

Queer Democracy

Desire, Dysphoria, and the Body Politic

Daniel D. Miller



“*Queer Democracy* stages a desperately needed intervention into Western political theory, which is going to have to get smarter about race, sex, gender, and religion if it hopes to offer a vision of justice in the midst of raging nationalisms. Exacting and inviting, rigorous yet clear, this is Daniel Miller at his best.”

Mary-Jane Rubenstein, *Professor of Religion, Core faculty in the Science and Society Program, Affiliated faculty in the Feminist, Gender, and Sexuality Studies Program, Wesleyan University*

“With so much theoretical sophistication, *Queer Democracy* responds to an enduring and urgent question: what differences does a democracy’s social body make for individual bodies who live in it? *Queer Democracy*’s response is smart and trans-formational. If you are a body living in a democracy, this response affects you. And after reading *Queer Democracy*, its response could become yours.”

William Robert, *Director of LGBTQ Studies, Associate Professor of Religion, Syracuse University*

“Social and political theorists have long understood ‘the body politic’ as a crucial metaphor, yet few have taken the metaphor as seriously as Daniel Miller does here, in an impressive work that runs from the Stoics to contemporary Christian nationalists. If social bodies are like actual bodies – marked not by their fixity, but by their ever-shifting morphology – then the social body is a queer body, and democracy is *queer democracy*.”

Samuel A. Chambers, *Professor of Political Theory and Political Economy, Department of Political Science, Johns Hopkins University*

“Miller’s *Queer Democracy* is compelling for how it bridges the divide between trans and queer theory with political theory. However, it will be of great appeal to non-specialists because of how Miller connects the metaphor of the body-political to contemporary iterations of populism and nationalism. There is no greater contemporary concern for American democracy than White Christian nationalism and its variants. And Miller is one of the few scholars able to capture the various elements of this political moment in a coherent theoretical frame. Miller’s analytical acumen enables him to reveal the ideological underpinnings of the religious and nationalistic forces at the center of American politics. This work is thus important for scholars working at the overlap of queer theory and political theory, but also any reader interested in understanding the passions, affects, and identities shaping the American public square today.”

Bradley Onishi, *Associate Professor, Department of Religious Studies, Skidmore College*



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QUEER DEMOCRACY

Queer Democracy undertakes an interdisciplinary critical investigation of the centuries-old metaphor of society as a body, drawing on queer and transgender accounts of embodiment as a constructive resource for reimagining politics and society.

Daniel Miller argues that this metaphor has consistently expressed a desire for social and political order, grounded in the social body's imagined normative shape or morphology. The consistent result, from the "concord" discourses of the pre-Christian Stoics, all the way through to contemporary nationalism and populism, has been the suppression of any dissent that would unmake the social body's presumed normativity. Miller argues that the conception of embodiment at the heart of the metaphor is a fantasy, and that negative social and political reactions to dissent represent visceral, dysphoric responses to its reshaping of the social body. He argues that social body's essential queerness, defined by fluidity and lack of a fixed morphology, spawns queer democracy, expressed through ongoing social and political practices that aim to extend liberty and equality to new social domains.

Queer Democracy articulates a new departure for the ongoing development of theoretical articulations linking queer and trans theory with political theory. It will appeal to both academic and non-academic readers engaged in research on political theory, populism, US religion, gender studies, and queer studies.

Daniel D. Miller is Associate Professor of Religion and Social Thought and Chair of the Department of Liberal Studies at Landmark College in Putney, VT. His research interests include religion, political theory and American politics, gender and embodiment, 20th-century continental philosophy, and theory and method in the study of religion.



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CONTENTS

<i>Preface</i>	<i>x</i>
<i>Acknowledgments</i>	<i>xiii</i>
Introduction	1
1 Dysphoric Desire: Fantasizing the Social Body	13
2 Traversing the Fantasy: Queer Democracy	53
3 Bedeviled by Nature: The Social Contract Tradition	83
4 Fantasies of Authenticity: Populism and Nationalism	133
5 American Dysphoria I: Christian Nationalism	166
6 American Dysphoria II: Civic Nationalism	213
Conclusion	255
<i>Index</i>	<i>259</i>

PREFACE

On Friday, January 20, 2017, I presented a Social Security Administration employee with the paperwork to change the gender marker on my daughter's Social Security record from "male" to "female." At the same moment, on a TV muted in the background, Donald Trump was being sworn in as the 45th president of the United States. Though this coincidence of timing was unintentional on my part, it effectively illustrates two series of events that have led up to the completion of *Queer Democracy*.

The first is my reason for sitting in the Social Security office that day. Assigned male at birth, my daughter, who was in second grade in January 2017, transitioned to live in accordance with her experienced gender of female when she was in kindergarten (in one of the bravest acts I have personally encountered). Occurring as it did at this young (but not at all atypical) age, her transition was social, not yet involving any medical interventions: she began the school year wearing dresses, informed us in November that she wanted to use she/her pronouns, the girls' restroom, and be referred to as a girl, and adopted a different name in April. As a professor trained, researching, and teaching in a critically and theoretically informed field, I have long been acquainted with the complexities of gender identity and have been familiar with queer theory. But with my daughter's transition and the imperative to support her and serve as an advocate in an often ignorant (at best) or deadly (at worst) world, the complex reality of gender identity became real, pressing, and urgent, while queer and trans theory were transformed into crucial personal resources for me, impacting both my personal and theoretical understanding in ways that were equally expected and unexpected.

Though I don't remember what first spurred me to take up the centuries-old metaphor of the "body politic," of society as a body, my daughter's ongoing experience of gender identity, the resulting embrace of my family and me within a new community of queer families, and my greater exposure to queer and trans theory led me to consider a theoretical question I hadn't before: what *kind* of body

has the “body politic” traditionally been imagined to be? From a trans-theoretical perspective, the answer was immediate: the body politic has been understood as a “normal” body, a body with a “normal” shape or morphology. And just as human bodies that depart from a perceived normal morphology often evoke visceral, negative discomfort and adverse reactions, so a social body, a body politic, that is not “normally” shaped evokes visceral, negative social and political reactions. It is here that trans theory makes its most significant theoretical contribution to the discussion that follows: *there is no morphologically normative body*. All bodies, including the social body, are queer, defined by shifting and fluid morphologies. The full richness of trans-theoretical reflections on embodiment is not only that it tells us something unique about trans embodiment, but that it reveals a broader truth about embodiment as such. As generations of trans activists can attest, the morphologically normative body is a fantasy that licenses the marginalization and disciplining of morphologically “abnormal” bodies. When applied to the social body, the fantasy of the morphologically normative body licenses social and political efforts to police (often literally) the social body to enforce a normative social order.

This is the central theoretical insight that has given shape to *Queer Democracy*. This is not a book about the history of political action undertaken by, and on behalf of, the LGBTQ+ community. While that is obviously an important topic about which excellent studies continue to appear (e.g., Clendinen and Nagourney 1999, Johnson 2006, Driskill 2011, Eaklor 2011, Mogul et al. 2012, Faderman 2015, Stryker 2017, Snorton 2017, New York Public Library 2019, Cervini 2020, Allen 2020), *Queer Democracy* draws on trans-theoretical insights about embodiment not as limited resources only for those who identify as queer, but as resources for theorizing social ontology, identity, and politics. Embracing the social body’s inherently queerness and morphological fluidity, “queer democracy” names all those social and political practices aimed at extending liberty and equality to broader and broader social spheres (of which political action by the LGBTQ+ community and its allies is a prime example).

Had it not been for the lessons I have learned from my daughter and the communities into which we have been woven as she continues her identity journey, I likely would never have availed myself to the theoretical resources I now view as being of central importance for political theory. If this represents a positive contribution to my project, Donald Trump’s 2016 election, officially ratified on that January day in 2017, represents the crucial second (and negative) contribution. As I say on more than one occasion in the discussion that follows (it bears repeating), this is not a book about the outcome of the 2016 US presidential election or the Trump administration (nor did its relevance end with the inauguration of President Joe Biden on January 20, 2021). The ideas I put forward would have been relevant had Trump never been elected, and they remain relevant now that he has been forced from office. For those who have long been aware of the populist and nationalist forces breaking the surface of American social and political life, and of the racism, xenophobia, misogyny, Islamophobia, trans- and homophobia, and

Christian exceptionalism that feed them, Trump's election was like a fever-dream become real. I wanted and needed to understand more fully the dynamics that had culminated in his election, which seemed farcical just a year and a half earlier, an understanding that the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body has provided. While the analysis that follows exceeds the bounds of a concern with Trump, then, his presidential candidacy and election were nonetheless the impetus for its production, just as the threat he posed to trans rights drove me to legally change my daughter's gender status while it was still possible to do so.

I do not intend the discussion that follows to be either doctrinaire or exclusivist. I readily acknowledge that queer and trans theory are not the only resources that challenge accounts of body normativity. Nor was Donald Trump's election the only social or political instigation for the following reflections. In that discussion, I follow specific paths to particular points, but others could reach these same points by following different paths. Likewise, my general focus on events and political developments in the US is not intended as an implicit statement about the priority or significance of the US, but reflects my own geopolitical context and the limited scope of my competence to effectively tackle the topics I address in other social or political contexts. All of which is to say that it is my fervent hope that *Queer Democracy* will become part of the polyphonic and fruitfully cacophonous discussions of such issues as populism, nationalism, democratic theory, queer theory, religion and politics, and the other unforeseen topics that open out of these.

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Finally, my thanks and admiration go out to all those fighting to advance queer democracy, often in unheralded ways and at great personal cost, every day. As I say in what follows, the democratic people, the *demos*, is emergent within the social, taking shape in unforeseen places and in myriad ways. Queer democracy is not about political parties, institutions, and procedures, first and foremost, but about ordinary people demanding liberty and equality. You are the heart of the *demos*.

INTRODUCTION

Two events proximate to the completion of this book, taking place in the spring and early summer of 2020, effectively illustrate the impetus for its writing. In the first, as state stay-at-home and social distancing orders instituted in response to the US Covid-19 pandemic wore on, protests demanding the reopening of businesses and economies arose in multiple US states. In Michigan, these protests took on a particularly intense form, when hundreds of protesters, mostly male and almost all White, occupied the state capitol building in Lansing, visibly and heavily armed with assault-style weapons and other firearms (Almasy and Riess 2020). Law enforcement responses to these actions were muted, to say the least. They resulted in few arrests, and there were virtually no violent confrontations between police and protesters. In response to the Michigan protests, President Donald Trump, who had previously made a number of dismissive, disparaging, and misogynistic remarks about Michigan's Democratic governor, Gretchen Whitmer, tweeted that "the Governor of Michigan should give a little, and put out the fire. These are very good people, but they are angry. They want their lives back again, safely! See them, talk to them, make a deal" (Liptak 2020).

Less than a month later, video emerged of Minneapolis, MN resident George Floyd, an African American man, lying face-down on the street, having been detained, handcuffed, and subdued by police, while a White police officer (Derek Chauvin) kneels on him, with his knee pressed against the back of his neck for nearly eight minutes (Carlisle 2020). Floyd can be heard screaming "please, I can't breathe!" while other White officers watch, until he falls silent (Sanchez and Sutton 2020). Following the release of the video, the mayor of Minneapolis said in a public news conference that the kind of hold employed on Floyd, which experts say can be deadly (Pane 2020), was against department policies (Sanchez and Sutton 2020). The four officers involved in the arrest were fired, the FBI

2 Introduction

launched an investigation into the incident, and Derek Chauvin was charged with manslaughter and third-degree murder (Carlisle 2020).¹

Coming in the weeks following the revelation of Ahmaud Arbery's execution at the hands of two White men in Georgia (Mahbubani 2020; Griffith 2020), the police shooting of Breonna Taylor following the execution of a "no-knock" search warrant in Louisville, KY (Costello and Duvall 2020), and video of a Amy Cooper, a White woman, calling the police on Christian Cooper (no relation), an African American birdwatcher in New York's Central Park, after he told her to leash her dog in accordance with Park rules (Griffith 2020; Vera 2020; Green 2020), the murder of George Floyd set off a wave of protests against police brutality and the routine police killings of unarmed Black Americans not only in Minneapolis, but across the country (indeed, around the world). In contrast to the Michigan protests, the response of law enforcement agencies around the country was anything but reserved or muted. Marking the contrast, for example, after having ignored thousands of mostly White protesters opposing the closure of public beaches less than a month earlier, protests of Floyd's murder in Huntington Beach, CA were declared an "unlawful assembly" violating bans on mass gatherings due to Covid-19 (Hamedy 2020). Around the country, police responded to protests, many of which were peaceful, with militaristic force. In marked contrast to his response to the White protesters occupying the Michigan capitol building a month earlier, President Trump responded to protests in Minneapolis by tweeting,

these THUGS are dishonoring the memory of Gregory Floyd, and I won't let that happen. Just spoke to Governor Tim Walz and told him that the Military is with him all the way. Any difficulty and we will assume control but, when the looting starts, the shooting starts. Thank you!

*(Sprunt 2020)*²

In the minds of many, the violent response to protests crystalized on June 1 in Washington, D.C., when Trump forcefully called for the imposition of "law and order" and threatened to mobilize the US military to put an end to protests. Clearly peaceful protesters were then forcibly removed from outside the White House so that Trump could walk across the street for a photo op in front of Washington's historical St. John's Episcopal Church (Liptak and Westwood 2020).

These paired events reveal a consistent disparity in police and political leaders' responses to protests. As media professor Jason Johnson (2020) evocatively sums up this disparity, "right-wing groups spit in the faces of police in regular gear in Michigan, while SWAT teams show up like Storm Troopers for chanting teens in Minneapolis" (Johnson 2020). This differential response is also captured in differing accounts offered by elected officials and in media reporting. White protesters, such as those in Michigan, are often described as "frustrated" with stay-at-home orders and as people eager to get back to work at shuttered businesses. Protests against police brutality, on the other hand, are often presented as always existing on the

verge of violence. When they do become violent, responsibility is often laid at the feet of protesters, with little acknowledgment of militarized and aggressive police forces' role in escalating the tensions of the situation. Local and state politicians also routinely attempt to externalize the rage expressed in such protests, blaming them on "outside agitators," even when evidence to the contrary emerges (Murphy et al. 2020).

Johnson (2020) also notes that, because they have an interest in drawing viewers/readers, media routinely focus on localized acts of vandalism and property damage, giving the impression that they are typical protest activities and that they are more widespread than they actually are. "Further," he notes, "much of the property damage attributed to protesters is often the result of police action or inaction in the face of lawful public behavior, something I've witnessed from Ferguson to the far-right protests in Charlottesville, Virginia." Additionally, typical (and racist) "they're burning their own community" narratives are simplistic, given that damage attributed to "protesters" is also caused by police, by "chaos agents," such as anarchists, who infiltrate the protests, and by regular criminals emboldened to act by police attention diverted elsewhere. Descriptions of protesters' actions as "reckless" or "self-defeating" persist, working to "minimize the extent of people's rage" (Dastagir 2020), thereby inoculating broader (White) society from the need to fully confront the events the spurred them. They also, by design, occlude the fact that "riots" represent "the actions of those who have exhausted every other way to be heard" (Dastagir 2020). Finally, application of the term "violence" to cover property damage has the effect of amplifying "property damage over the lost lives that sparked unrest to begin with" (Johnson 2020), a "ghoulishly misplaced" priority revealed not only in media accounts, but in Trump's implicit encouragement of the use of deadly force in protecting property.

Crucially, the patterns of uneven response and media coverage are not limited to these two examples, exemplifying persistent and ongoing patterns. As Johnson (2020) suggests,

police seldom use force or even present in force (protest shields, black helmets, etc.) when conservative or right-wing groups protest. When is the last time you saw a group of anti-abortion activists get tear-gassed? Yet with left-leaning groups, and especially groups of minorities, their protests are often met with shows of force.³

On one hand, accounting for the starkly different responses of elected officials, news media, and police to these different events is not difficult: they express patterns of longstanding and deeply ingrained systemic and structural racism, among other things, particularly in the case of law enforcement. And yet, such an answer is only a start, insofar as it opens myriad other questions: What, exactly, is racism? How does it operate? How should we understand the relation between racist social systems, institutions, or structures, on the one hand, and the

individuals shaped by them, on the other? Can or should racism be understood in terms of individually held beliefs and conscious animus, or in some other way? What is the relation between racism and other axes of social marginalization or exclusion?

The chapters that follow represent my response to these and other questions. Specifically, this project takes shape around three areas of inquiry. The first concerns the reflexive, almost autonomous, and seemingly natural quality of these disparate responses. For virtually any critical or analytical social observer, these differential responses were entirely predictable, typical, and, unfortunately, expected; indeed, it would have been surprising if responses to these events *had not* followed the pattern they did. In responding to these events as they do, elected officials, members of the media, and law enforcement are responding in the ways that have become most natural to them. We might say that such responses have become not only “second nature,” but more properly “first nature”. Any suggestion to those responding in these ways that they might or should have responded differently is experienced as counter-intuitive and non-sensical, running counter to common sense, and is therefore met with incredulity, hostility, or defensiveness.

Such reflections indicate that these responses are not the result of conscious calculation or deliberation, that they do not reflect the careful application of consciously held ideologies. Rather, they are the concrete expression of what I refer to as social and political *dispositions*, which structure and express social perceptions, affects, and practices. To describe them as playing a structuring role is to suggest that the explicit reasons or explanations for these disparate social and political responses to acts of protest and dissent are necessarily *post hoc* in nature, after-the-fact justifications of actions which arise as expressions of antecedent dispositions. Further, insofar as dispositions shape social and political perceptions, they rarely arise as objects of perception in their own right, so that individuals shaped by them are rarely aware of this shaping, while their *post hoc* justifications for practices or consciously held beliefs rarely correspond to an account of their actions articulated in terms of dispositions.

Informed by a dispositional account of these disparate responses, indeed, of a dispositional account of social and political perception, affect, and practice more generally, a second question follows: what *kind* of disposition is expressed in such responses? My answer is that such responses express a disposition to *proper social order*. “Proper” here is intended to carry significant normative force: such responses express and flow out of deep-seated dispositions concerning the way the social *ought to be* structured and the proper or appropriate roles and actions of the individuals and groups constitutive of it. Those individuals who stray from their proper places within the social, who fail to play their proper roles, disrupt the normative social order, eliciting visceral social and political reactions intended to put them back in their place. For reasons we will consider in much greater detail in Chapters 4–6, for many elected officials, members of the media, and

members of law enforcement, the phenomenon of hundreds of heavily armed White protesters occupying the Michigan state capitol building is simply less improper than hundreds or thousands of unarmed protesters of color and their allies holding peaceful protests. The latter are simply experienced or *felt* to be a much greater threat to proper social order than the former, before and quite apart from any subsequent reflection on or rationalization of the perceived differences between these groups.

Finally, a third question (really a pair of questions), again following from the first two, presents itself: if the divergent responses these acts of social and political protests express a disposition to proper social order, what, exactly, does “proper social order” entail? What else is involved, and how do we account for the interrelation of different dimensions of social order? To illustrate: looking over the mostly White, mostly male crowd of armed protesters in Michigan, a betting individual could feel confident wagering not only on their position regarding state-imposed shut-down orders, but on their political party affiliation, their general attitudes about undocumented immigrants, about sexual, gender, and religious minorities in the US, and their probable religious identity. Similar considerations hold for those actively involved in peaceful protests against police brutality in the wake of George Floyd’s murder. How do we account for this? The thesis advanced in the chapters that follow is that the structuring effect of the disposition to social order is not limited to a single dimension of social order, but, rather, a gestalt of social and political dimensions. The perception of proper social order involves normative intuitions about not only race, but also about gender, sexuality, religion, and a host of other social dimensions. Perception of proper social order is, we might say, a package deal, orienting multiple axes of shared social and political life. None of these dimensions are perceived or experienced in isolation from others, so that the perception of social order is comprehensive and totalizing.

A sustained and overarching argument in the chapters that follow is that the disposition to proper social order is effectively captured in what I will be calling the social-as-body metaphor, which is to say, in the idea that society as a whole can be understood as a kind of “body,” the healthy and functional operation of which requires its members’ proper ordering. The social-as-body metaphor has been a stock feature of Western social and political thought for centuries and, while it takes on specific concrete nuances depending on the historical period and context in which it finds articulation, it has consistently expressed a disposition to proper social order. I develop this point through a consideration of the body’s shape, or morphology: a properly ordered social body is one that has the proper shape, structured by members’ proper relation to each other.

This metaphor illuminates three issues related to the kinds of phenomena outlined above. First, it explains why a sense of proper social order is complex and multi-faceted: just as a properly ordered body is composed of many members in right relation, so a properly ordered society requires the appropriate relation of

its members, considered along numerous axes. Second, it helps to explain the visceral negative reaction to bodily members that are perceived to be “out of place,” thereby threatening the social order. Third, building from this, the metaphor also sheds light on the seeming naturalness of these negative reactions: a body with members out of place is literally dis-ordered, pathological, and must be put back into proper order.

The account of the social-as-body metaphor in the chapters that follow is substantively informed by queer, and specifically transgender, accounts of embodiment. Trans-theoretical accounts of embodiment illuminate what *kind of body* has traditionally been presupposed within the social-as-body metaphor. Even the brief consideration above reveals that the social-as-body metaphor, in its expression of the disposition to proper social order, has traditionally operated according to the logic of what I, following Talia Mae Bettcher (2009), refer to as the “natural attitude” of embodiment (103). On the logic of the natural attitude, bodies are defined by their *normative* morphology, a presupposition that is clearly expressed in the disposition to proper social order. Trans theory provides a critical resource for theorizing the social-as-body metaphor and the disposition to proper social order precisely because questions of body morphology and normativity have been central concerns within trans-theoretical reflection.

Building from the base of a trans-theoretical approach to the social-as-body metaphor and the disposition to proper social order, I argue in the chapters that follow that viscerally negative social and political reactions to the dis-ordered social body represent examples of *social dysphoria*. That is, they represent visceral, affective, non-rational responses to the social body’s perceived disorder aimed at reimposing its proper shape. But I also draw on trans-theoretical accounts of embodiment because they provide a critical resource for contesting the social body’s presumed morphological normativity. Trans theory’s crucial insight in this regard is that *all* bodies are fundamentally queer, defined by a fluid and shifting morphology. I argue that recognizing this point allows the social-as-body metaphor to be articulated in different terms, expressing a disposition not to the imposition of proper social order, but to the social body’s ongoing emergence in new forms with shifting morphologies, to the emergence of a social body which is no longer defined by a fixed, normative form.

This matters because, as I argue consistently in the chapters that follow, the social-as-body metaphor, grounded in the presumption of the social body’s normative morphology, has traditionally legitimized the suppression of any dissent that would unmake its presumed normativity. Reflecting this, the disposition to proper social order has consistently been fundamentally anti-democratic in its orientation, from the pre-Christian Stoic “concord” discourses to the nationalism and populism gripping the contemporary US. Reimagining the social-as-body metaphor in such a way as to allow for the expression of alternative social and political dispositions facilitates the articulation of what I call queer democracy.

Organization of the Book

Chapter 1 presents what might be considered the “nuts and bolts” of what follows in the rest of the book. I begin with a brief account of the social-as-body metaphor’s history and development. In doing so, I argue that it is a “dispositional metaphor” structuring social and political perceptions, affects, and practices, whether or not it is explicitly invoked within political discourse. I highlight how the metaphor has consistently expressed a disposition to proper social order and argue that it continues to shed light on social and political thought and practice up through the present. Drawing on queer and trans-theoretical accounts of embodiment, together with a critical analysis of the concept of gender dysphoria, I argue that the presumption of the morphologically normative body that has traditionally informed the metaphor is fantastical in nature, so that negative reactions to members of the social body who are perceived to be “out of place” are properly understood as socially dysphoric in nature. In the final section of the chapter, I carry these reflections on trans-theoretical accounts of embodiment further, arguing that they reveal the fundamental queerness and morphological fluidity that defines *all* bodies, including the social body, suggesting that these insights allow us to reimagine the social-as-body metaphor in such a way as to express alternative social and political dispositions that have their origin in an affirmation of the queer social body.

In Chapter 2, I continue the line of inquiry opened in the latter portions of the first chapter. Drawing on queer and trans-theoretical conceptions of embodiment as a constructive resource for normative political theory, I advance a model of “queer democracy.” Originating with the affirmation of the social body’s fundamental queerness and morphological fluidity, queer democracy expresses a disposition to the existing social body’s unmaking, with the aim of bringing a more expansively egalitarian social body into being. Taking shape around recognition that the democratic “people” (Gr. *demos*) is constitutively incomplete, queer democracy is expressed through the *demos*’s expansion via the extension of liberty and equality to new social domains. I contrast this vision of queer democracy with neoliberal managed democracy, which I argue defines contemporary American liberal democracy and expresses the fundamental disposition to social order in continuity with the traditional social-as-body metaphor.

Chapter 3 marks a shift in the book’s focus and is the first of four chapters that utilize the preceding discussions of the social-as-body metaphor and queer democracy as critical resources for the analysis of political theory and practice. In Chapter 3, this analysis focuses on the three classical social contract theories of Thomas Hobbes, John Locke, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau. All three explicitly invoke the social-as-body metaphor in their respective theories, and all three presuppose the morphologically normative social body. To a much greater extent than with Hobbes or Locke, elements of Rousseau’s political theory allow for the articulation of an alternative conception of the social body more consistent with

the vision of queer democracy. Ultimately, however, he undermines these dimensions of his theory, so that it expresses the traditional disposition to proper social order, albeit with greater ambiguity than we find in either Hobbes or Locke.

Chapter 4 turns to a consideration of contemporary populism in its articulation with nationalism. While both populism and nationalism can take different forms, my focus in this chapter is the majoritarian articulation of these movements presently on display not only in the US (my specific focus) but in other countries as well. I argue that populism takes shape around an exclusive sense of “the people” that contrasts decisively with the vision of the morphologically fluid *demos* at the heart of queer democracy. Within the populist imaginary, “the people” is not inclusive of all individuals within a polity but is limited to those who are perceived to possess the attributes of the *real* or *authentic* people. Populism is therefore inherently anti-pluralist in character, imagining the authentic people only in its opposition from all those who are excluded from it. Nationalism, while analytically distinguishable from populism, is nevertheless often articulated in populist terms. Within the context of increasingly pluralistic and diverse political states, nationalism draws a distinction between the totality of those living within the state and possessing citizenship, on the one hand, and those who are part of the *true* nation, on the other. In its articulation with populism, the members of the true national community and the authentic people perfectly overlap, leading to the advocacy for laws and policies aimed at the formal exclusion or subordination of those who are not perceived as belonging to the national community and efforts to preserve the social and political authority of those who are. I argue that the social-as-body metaphor provides a fruitful concept for the analysis of populism and nationalism, revealing both as contemporary expressions of the disposition to proper social order, representing dysphoric responses in opposition to queer democracy.

While the discussion of Chapter 4 is general in nature, aiming to highlight the formal features and articulation of contemporary majoritarian populism and nationalism, Chapter 5 turns to an examination of these phenomena within the contemporary US through a consideration of contemporary American Christian nationalism. Christian nationalism represents a form of populist nationalism that is supported to at least a moderate degree by more than half of the US population. Expressing the disposition to proper social order, Christian nationalists imagine the proper social body as hierarchical in nature, so that *real* Americans occupy positions of social and political authority, while all others occupy subordinate positions within the social body. This vision of the social body takes shape around an idealized conception of the prototypical real American as White, cisgender, heterosexual, Protestant, English-speaking, US-born, of northern European descent, and affirmative of patriarchy (if not male). The US’s changing demographic and ethnic profile threatens to unmake the proper social order imagined within Christian nationalism, giving rise to socially dysphoric attempts to reinforce or reimpose it, drawing on the institutions, procedures, and mechanisms of the US state to do so. The chapter’s final section examines these Christian nationalist

elements as represented in the administration of former President Donald Trump. With its aim of preserving a social order that privileges “real” Americans at the expense of all others, Christian nationalism, in a manner consistent with populist nationalism generally, represents a dysphoric rejection of queer democracy.

Chapter 6, the final chapter, examines an alternative expression of American nationalism, civic nationalism. Illustrating that nationalism is not limited to the political right, American civic nationalism takes shape around the idea that authentic American national identity is defined not by the ascriptive categories that figure within Christian nationalism, but by the ideals of the “American Creed,” such as liberty and equality. Advocating shared American identity as a necessary precondition for democracy, civic nationalism rejects “identity” or “movement politics,” arguing that it is divisive and fractures the commonality of American civic identity. Analyzing civic nationalism by considering one of its recent and well-publicized articulations, Mark Lilla’s *The Once and Future Liberal*, I argue that, despite its democratic pretensions, civic nationalism, like Christian nationalism, expresses a desire for proper social order and is actually anti-democratic in nature. By rejecting identity politics, it forecloses on the *demos*’s expansion, representing a dysphoric response to those with social or political identities that have no place within its normative vision of proper social order. As such, and despite its democratic aspirations, contemporary American civic nationalism is fundamentally anti-democratic in nature, which is perhaps most evident in the fact that many of civic nationalism’s targets of are the same as those of Christian nationalism.

Final Reflections

Some comments are in order regarding decisions about language in the chapters that follow. I have attempted to employ gender-neutral language, using they/them/their pronouns, even in the cases of singular antecedents, in cases where a gender-specific pronoun is not clearly indicated by context. However, I have not modified quotations in accordance with this convention, with the consequence that they (particularly those from older sources, such as Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau in Chapter 3) may contain gender-exclusive language (e.g., the use of “man” for “humankind”). I have attempted to highlight such cases with “[sic]” in the instances in which they occur. In the context of discussions of race and ethnicity, I have adopted the convention of capitalizing both “Black” and “White” (together with the related concept of “Whiteness”) and have modified quotations that do not follow this convention, for the sake of consistency. The move to capitalize Black is increasingly common, while there is more contention about the capitalization of White (and, of course, some style guides continue to capitalize neither). Explaining the editorial decision of the *Columbia Journalism Review* to capitalize “Black” but not white, Mike Laws (2020) writes, “*Black* is an ethnic designation; *white* merely describes the skin color of people who can, usually without much difficulty, trace their ethnic origins back to a handful of European

countries.” This description is painfully naïve. “White” and the related concept of Whiteness are emphatically *not* merely “descriptive” terms. On the contrary, determinations of who is and is not White have been historically variable (involving much more than simple appeal to ancestry in “a handful of European countries”) with tremendous social and political consequences. As Charles Mills (1997) suggests, while whiteness (with a lower-case “w”) may refer to “phenotype/genealogy,” Whiteness (with a capital “W”) represents a distinctive “political commitment” (126). As we shall see in Chapters 5 and 6 in particular, Whiteness is a defining ideological element of American nationalism and populism, playing a decisive role in conceptions of authentic American national identity. My aim in choosing to capitalize White is to capture the ideological, social, and political significance of White identity constructions, to capture White identity as a social and political commitment.

Finally, referring back to the contemporary events with which I opened this Introduction, I want to be clear that this is not a book about Donald Trump or the Trump administration, as I think the following chapters make clear. Nevertheless, had it not been for Trump and the outcome of the 2016 US presidential election, I do not think I would ever have pursued the questions it aims to address. As I suggested in the Preface, I certainly would not have been drawn to the resources and insights of queer and trans theory that are so central to the understanding of the social body and democracy in the discussion that follows. And, while I think the discussion that follows has direct relevance beyond the US context, recent social and political developments in the US weigh heavily enough in the background of the discussion that follows that I have limited most of the discussion to the US context.

Notes

- 1 Chauvin’s charges were subsequently upgraded to second-degree murder and the other officers were charged with aiding and abetting second-degree murder (Reyes 2020).
- 2 The president’s tweet was labelled with a warning by Twitter, which said it incited violence. Indeed, the phrase “when the looting starts, the shooting starts” echoed a phrase used by Miami police chief Walter Headley, in the context of racial unrest, in 1967. Headley had a long history of anti-Black bigotry, and his utterance of the phrase was a clear threat of violence against Black protesters (Sprunt 2020).
- 3 All of these points were reinforced with the tepid preparation and response of the Washington, D.C. Capitol Police in relation to the pro-Trump rally in Washington on January 6, 2021, which ultimately resulted in the deadly violent assault on the US Capitol building. The failure to anticipate and respond to the assault that led to the breaching of the Capitol building further highlights these dynamics of disparity. Indeed, the events of January 6, 2021 can be viewed as a symbolic culmination of these events.

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12 Introduction

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1

DYSPHORIC DESIRE

Fantasizing the Social Body

Introduction

What I call the “social-as-body” metaphor has served as a primary means for imagining society throughout Western history. This metaphor has consistently expressed a disposition to proper, almost always hierarchical, social and political order. This is evident in a crucial presupposition about embodiment underlying the metaphor, namely that bodies are naturally defined by a normative morphology, a proper shape, providing the ideal against which other expressions of embodiment are measured and evaluated. These themes of proper order and normative morphology are directly related: the body’s normative morphology requires that each of its members is in its proper place—the body’s organic unity depends on its members’ proper ordering. “Place” in this understanding is defined by both function and structural relation—bodily members can be said to be in their proper place only insofar as they play their prescribed role within the larger body and, in carrying out that role, stand in proper relation to other members. Applied to the social, then, this presupposition plays out in the presumption that the social body is also defined by a normative morphology, and that this normative morphology is maintained only as the social body’s members remain in their proper places, playing their proper social roles, and standing in proper relation to the social body’s other members.

It is important to appreciate the import of the term “proper,” which appears numerous times in this description and will occur many times more in the discussion that follows. Whenever applied to the body’s (flesh-and-blood or social) morphology, to members’ roles within the body, to social structures and practices, and so on, the term *proper* is intended to convey significant normative force. According to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, *proper* entered the English language

already reflecting a lengthy logical development from the French *propre* and Latin *proprius* (“one’s own, special, particular, peculiar”) (“Proper” 1991). Reflecting this, *proper* is intended to convey the meaning, “what it should be, or what is required; such as one ought to do” (“Proper” 1991) and, as an adjective, “as it ought to be, or as one ought to do” (“Properly” 1991). The body accords with its normative morphology only to the degree that it has the shape it *ought to have* and its members occupy their proper place to the extent that they remain where and as they *should be*, do as they *ought to do*. Location and function’s normative force is given in the fact that they become individual members of the body’s defining *properties*, their *sine qua non* or essence (“Property” 1991). Members exercise *propriety* to just the extent that they maintain their “proper state or condition” (“Propriety” 1991), occupying their required place and acting according to their defining role. When, by way of contrast, bodily members are “out of place,” failing to carry out their defining roles and to maintain the body’s defining structure, they are *improper*, acting *inappropriately* or with *impropriety*.

To reiterate, then, the social-as-body metaphor has consistently expressed a disposition to *proper* social and political order, with all the normative force implied in that term. Over the course of its development, two broad emphases, reflecting this “logic of the proper,” have remained consistent. The first and most obvious is the emphasis on the social body’s normative morphology, on its proper shape. The second is the existential danger posed to the social body by individual members that are out of place, failing to fulfill their proper role and/or disrupting the proper structural relation of the body’s members. The existential nature of the danger posed by bodily members that are out of place lends the social body’s morphology its experienced normative force. This normative force is concretely expressed in active efforts to maintain, enforce, and, if necessary, reimpose the social body’s proper shape, reflected in its members’ proper ordering. Such efforts represent dysphoric responses to a body perceived to have been rendered morphologically misshapen, grotesque, or monstrous.

A number of divergence themes flow together in the remainder of the chapter, and some orientation to that discussion is in order. This chapter introduces the social-as-body metaphor and the analytical framework that will orient the chapters that follow. The chapter begins with a brief history of the social-as-body metaphor in Western social and political thought.¹ Following this historical account, the chapter moves on to discuss the social-as-body metaphor’s specific nature *as* metaphor. What does it mean, for example, to describe the body as a *metaphor* for the social? In response to this question, I argue that the social-as-body metaphor is a “dispositional metaphor,” a metaphor structuring and expressing social perceptions, affects, and practices oriented around the maintenance of social and political order. Building on this, I next consider the question of what *kind* of body has been presupposed within the frame of the social-as-body metaphor. This is where I more fully discuss the notion of the body’s normative morphology and the dysphoric responses provoked by the impropriety of members of the body who are out of

place. My argument that dysphoria, a crucial concept for all that follows in this book, is an essentially social phenomenon is one of the key elements of this chapter. I appropriate this psychological term because it has to do, fundamentally, with questions of normative embodiment, as I illustrate with a discussion of gender dysphoria as outlined in the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual (DSM)*. I argue that the clinical conception of gender dysphoria reveals (albeit tacitly) its fundamentally social nature, with the consequence that its application to the social body represents a natural extension.

The chapter's final section introduces the theoretical orientation that structures the remainder of the book. Bringing together queer and trans-theoretical accounts of embodiment with Slavoj Žižek's theorization of political fantasy, I argue that the morphologically normative body imagined within the social-as-body metaphor is fantastical in nature. In contrast to the understanding of the body as defined by a proper shape, I argue that bodies, individual and social, are fundamentally queer, by which I mean that they are defined by a morphological fluidity, having no fixed or proper shape. In expressing the desire for the morphologically normative social body, the social-as-body metaphor has expressed a desire for an impossible object, highlighting the inherently non-rational nature of efforts to maintain or reassert its normative social and political order, hence their description as dysphoric.²

I conclude by arguing that recognizing embodiment's fundamentally queer nature allows us to reimagine the social body, embracing its morphological fluidity. It allows for the expression of alternative dispositions to those oriented to social and political order. Specifically, it allows for the expression of what I will call "queer democracy," originating in the social body's "monstrous (un)becoming" (Sullivan 2006, 560) and representing its productive unmaking with the aim of extending the democratic principles of liberty and equality to new social domains.

Historical Development of the Social-as-Body Metaphor

It would be difficult to overstate how pervasive the "society as corporate body" metaphor has been within Western social and political thought. As Margaret M. Mitchell (1993) notes,

the metaphor of the body for the political organism ... is very old, going back at least as far as the 5th and 4th centuries BCE ... The metaphor is also frequently attested in Greco-Roman literature well into the 2nd century CE, as also in Hellenic Jewish texts.

(158)

Of the social-as-body's various expressions, the Pauline formulation of the church as the "Body of Christ" plays a pivotal role. On the one hand, it carries the metaphor forward from its pre-Christian context, while on the other hand it provides the materials out of which the concept of the body politic will develop in the late medieval and early modern periods.

Paul and the “Body of Christ”

While Paul develops elements of this theme in several passages (see Dunn 1992, 147–148), the *locus classicus* for his discussion, and the passage which has had the greatest historical force, is in 1 Corinthians 12:12–26. Michelle V. Lee (2006) situates Paul’s 1 Cor. 12 discourse within the context of antique “concord speeches” (*homonoia*), which regularly employed the metaphor of the body to urge political and social unity (29), employed by Paul to combat factionalism within the Christian community in Corinth (Mitchell 1993, 160). Indeed, unity is a constant theme across Paul’s different discussions (Dunn 1992, 148, 154).

As Lee (2006) notes, Paul makes two central points in his opening: 1.) The one body is composed of many members and 2.) the many members constitute a single body (125): “Just as the body is one and has many members, and all the members of the body, though many, are one body, so it is with Christ” (1 Cor. 12:12, NRSV). In this formulation, Paul emphasizes both unity and diversity as constitutive features of the Christian community (125), and he extends his claim in the following verse (12:13), insisting that “that the Christians/Christ *are* one body in the Spirit [Gr. *Pneuma*]” (128–129).

As Mitchell (1993) notes, Paul’s deployment of the body metaphor to combat factionalism is “combined with an awareness of the political theory of the [body’s] mixed constitution” (160). Thus, “as it is, God arranged the members in the body, each one of them, as he chose” (1 Cor. 12:18, NRSV). The overall thrust of Paul’s argument in 1 Cor. 12:4–11 is therefore that “each person has his or her own individual gifts and roles to play, each of which in its own way benefits the community,” so that the Corinthian Christians are mutually interdependent (268). The effect is a divinely ordained hierarchy of social roles and functions (269), such that each individual can “achieve happiness no matter what one’s circumstances were” (Lee 2006, 137–138) precisely through the maintenance, rather than disruption of, the existing social order. Reflecting this, Paul emphasizes the need for the members of the Christian body to be satisfied with their assigned role, emphasizing the disruption to the body that would follow from a lack of such satisfaction (1 Cor. 12:19–25).

Of greater interest than the specifics of Paul’s argument, for our purposes, is just how typical of antique discourse it is. Stoic thought provides the background or context of Paul’s formulation (Lee 2006, 23), and Stoicism’s overall influence on this aspect of his thought is well established (see Dunn 1992; Mitchell 1993; Martin 1999; Lee 2006). Mitchell (1993) highlights that “Paul’s Christian version of the body image, the body of Christ, is an exact correlative of its Greco-Roman counterparts not only in its details, but also in its application” (268), representing a uniformity that extends “even to the details” of his argument, and that the metaphor’s application as an argument against social discord replays “one of the most common applications of the body metaphor for the state in antiquity” (159). Indeed, she notes that the latter represents “the most common *topos* in ancient

literature for unity” (161). In arguing for the body’s unity-in-complementarity to combat factionalism, Paul not only rehearses a commonplace of antique rhetoric, but even deploys the same technical language (268), and his argument that the body’s health is threatened by discord represents the very heart of the classical appeal to the rhetoric of the body in concord speeches (Lee 2006, 43).

Paul’s emphasis that the individual body parts’ ultimate oneness is granted through the Spirit (Gr. *pneuma*) also reflects Stoic ontology (Lee 2006, 131), insofar as *pneuma*, in Stoic thought, “is a kind of ‘stuff’ that is the agent of perception, motion, and life itself; it pervades other forms of stuff and, together with those other forms, constitutes the self” (Martin 1999, 21; see also 21–25). The Stoics typically conceived of *pneuma* as the material that holds together bodies composed of multiple parts (i.e., bodies of mixed constitution, as presupposed by Paul), joining those parts into a unified body (Lee 2006, 49–50). We could say, then, that Stoic “physics” provides the conceptual materials Paul utilizes to appeal for the church’s unity.

While Paul’s development of the church as the “body of Christ” is typical of antique thought in many regards, two contextual features require additional comment: the concept’s specifically political origins and its utility as a form of shared background knowledge. The image of the corporate body on which Paul draws so heavily is, fundamentally, an image of the political state (Lee 2006, 9), which was itself understood as an organic body (Dunn 1992 157, 160–161). The *homonoia* or concord speeches with which Paul’s presentation in 1 Cor. 12 has so much in common aim at ensuring unity and concord within the political state (Lee 2006, 29). Paul’s insistence on the corporate body’s hierarchical dimension also reflects a central emphasis in Greco-Roman conceptions of state and society (Martin 1999, 29). Martin situates Paul’s presentation within the fundamentally conservative political ideology he describes as “benevolent patriarchalism” (42), according to which the social disruption threatening the body comes as a threat to the maintenance of the social’s proper, which is to say hierarchical, structuring. The result is that conflict must be addressed by “reaffirming and solidifying the hierarchy of society” (40). This is why body parts’ mutuality does not represent an affirmation of equality but is grounded in a hierarchical structuring of the social that is viewed as fundamentally “natural” (see 41). Paul therefore develops his ecclesiology by utilizing a fundamentally political metaphor.

Paul’s appropriation of the social-as-body metaphor is also significant because it illustrates the degree to which the metaphor was already well established as a shared conception of the social. As Dunn (1992) states: “the fact that the physical body provided a model for organic unity was a major factor in the attractiveness and usefulness of the theme for Paul” (148). In his usage, Paul draws on a long and well-established rhetorical tradition (Martin 1999, 38), and is likely applying a “general principle of unity” that already possessed wide cultural acceptance within the Corinthian context (133–135). Martin (1999) argues persuasively that Paul’s deployment of this rhetoric represents his own participation in a well-established

rhetorical tradition and body of rhetorical knowledge (Martin 1999, 47–55). Paul appropriates *this* metaphor, then, because of its facility for communicating his points to his audience.

The Social Body Beyond the Church: Medieval Christendom

Paul's doctrine of the church as the body of Christ therefore carries forward a well-established, centuries-old social-as-body metaphor. But it also serves as the primary basis for the metaphor's ongoing life within later medieval social and political thought. To be sure, the metaphor's medieval development, particularly as it nears modernity, reflects the influence of multiple sources (Lewis 1954, 193; Canning 1996, 161; Wierda 1997, 28–30; Coleman 2011, 184). But, as Anton-Hermann Chroust (1947) writes, "the social thought of the Middle Ages ... proceeded from the principle of a single and uniform but articulate whole," and notes that it had "for its core the doctrine of the Church" (423), drawing specific attention to the particular Pauline passages in question (431, 443; see also Gierke 1987, 22; Wierda 1997, 28). The Pauline formulation therefore represents a crucial element of the shared Christian social ontology underlying diverse medieval formulations (Coleman 2011, 183).

While medieval thinkers, over the course of centuries, developed the social body idea in different ways, two primary themes of the social-as-body metaphor remain remarkably consistent: an emphasis on the social body's normative morphology, and an emphasis on the existential danger to that body when its members leave their proper places, failing to carry out their normative roles within the body as a whole. It is in this sense that Chroust (1947) is correct in suggesting that, their differences notwithstanding, different streams and sources of medieval thought concerning the social body flow in the same bed (427).

For our purposes, the most significant shift in the metaphor is not in its content, but in the scope of its articulation, from a specifically ecclesiastical conception to a clear and explicitly secular conception of the social itself as a "mystical body." Ernst Kantorowicz's (1957) historical account is of particular interest, suggesting that by the later medieval period, "the State showed increasingly a tendency to become a quasi-Church or a mystical corporation on a rational basis" (194). An appreciation of this shift requires an understanding of the corresponding, rather esoteric, shift in the "mystical body" (Lat. *corpus mysticum*) metaphor's referent.

Kantorowicz (1957) notes that by the early 14th century, *corpus mysticum* came to serve as a common appellation of the church, itself understood to include "Christian society as composed of all the faithful, past, future, and present, actual and potential" (194–195; see de Lubac 2007, 3). This usage, which may not seem all that remarkable, is in fact a novel development. There is no biblical basis for the description, so it marks a departure from the more limited Pauline notion of the church as "body of Christ" (Lat. *corpus Christi*) (Kantorowicz 1957, 195) and it is not attested in the Church Fathers or the works of the early medieval period

(de Lubac 2007, 4–6). In centuries prior, *corpus Christi* served as the nomenclature for Christian society, while *corpus mysticum* referred to the consecrated elements of the Eucharist (Kantorowicz 1957, 195–196; de Lubac 2007, 9). As insignificant as this shift may sound to the uninitiated, it represents a conceptual bridge to the formation of a secular conception of the social-as-body metaphor that retains its influence long past the medieval period.

Henri de Lubac (2007) offers a detailed genealogy of the conceptual shift in question. The single Latin word *corpus* (body) had multiple referents in the thought of the Western church, which stressed the interrelation of three different “bodies”: Jesus of Nazareth’s body, crucified by the Romans, the church as Paul’s “body of Christ,” and the Eucharistic elements described as Jesus’ “body” in the gospels (Matt. 26:26–29; Mark 14:22–25; Luke 22:14–20). The adjective “mystical” was applied to add clarity regarding these multiple “bodies,” referring specifically to the “body of Christ” offered in the Eucharistic elements (de Lubac 2007, 28–29). The term “sacrament,” in its technical ecclesiastical meaning, has its origins in the term used for “mystery”: the adjective “mystical” derives etymologically from the nous “mystery,” to which *both* the Latin terms *mysterium* and *sacramentum* correspond (45). Words associated with “mystery,” including *sacramentum*, in turn, retain the dual sense of being both “sign” and “secret” (46–47). The elements of the Eucharistic body were thus “mysteries” or “sacraments” serving as “signs” pointing to the death of Christ’s body on the cross and as demonstrating and enacting the church’s “secret” unity as the body of Christ through Eucharistic participation (see 13–17, 55–69). In this way, the three “bodies” were presented as distinct, yet inseparable.

Over time, the signification of the term *mystical* shifted from this technical sense in relation to the other two bodies of Christ (the church and Jesus crucified). Theologians and liturgists increasingly emphasized the identity of the Eucharistic body with Jesus of Nazareth’s crucified body, emphasizing the crucified Christ’s “real presence” in the Eucharistic elements, an emphasis that reached its fullest form in the doctrine of substantiation (Kantorowicz 1957, 196; see de Lubac 2007, 91–93). One result of this was the increasing identification of “the true body” of Christ (i.e., Jesus of Nazareth’s crucified body) with “the very same” body offered in the Eucharist (de Lubac 2007, 91), with the ultimate result that “the first two ‘bodies’ were molded into one” (95).

The identification of the Eucharistic body of Christ with the crucified Jesus’ “own body” corresponded to their common differentiation from the church as body of Christ (de Lubac 2007, 97–98). Over time, the church was increasingly described with the adjective “mystical,” to differentiate it from the “real” body of Christ offered in the Eucharist and on the cross (99, 106–107). This marks the shift in the meaning of *mystical* from its older, technical sense to something nearer a contemporary dictionary definition, according to which it means “spiritually allegorical or symbolic” in distinction from the “literal.” Thus,

it would become common to speak of ‘mystical body’ without any reference to the Eucharist, to the same extent that theories concerning the Church, whether in its visible form or in its hidden life, would develop outside the sacramental framework.

(114)

The same descriptor that had previously marked the inseparability-in-distinction of the three bodies of Christ now bifurcated them into “literal” or “real” bodies (i.e., the crucified body and the Eucharistic elements), on one hand, and the “mystical” body (i.e., the church), on the other.

This shift paves the way for the social-as-body metaphor’s expansion beyond its ecclesiastical application. While the terms “mystical body” and “body of Christ” come to function as interchangeable appellations for the church, the shift in the meaning of *mystical* foregrounds the specifically metaphorical nature of the church’s description as a body. Explicit comparisons with a human body serve the dual function of reinforcing the metaphor while simultaneously reinforcing its status as *metaphor*. Thus, “this mystical body would now be thought of not only in terms of the analogy with the natural human body, but *also in terms of the analogy with human society*” (de Lubac 2007, 114, emphasis added). These shifts mark the bridging of the traditional Pauline ecclesiastical formulation of the church as the body of Christ with the understanding of the social “body” beyond the church and, eventually, beyond Christendom. As Kantorowicz (1957) notes, this shift in usage “placed the Church as a body politic, or as a political and legal organism, on a level with the secular bodies politic which were then beginning to assert themselves as self-sufficient entities” (Kantorowicz 1957, 197). This marks a relativization (and, for Kantorowicz, a degradation) of the church, insofar as “the Church, which had been *the* mystical body of Christ, became *a* mystical body in its own right” (201).

The result, for Kantorowicz (1957), is that “the *corpus mysticum* proper came to be less and less mystical as time passed on, coming to mean simply the Church as a body politic or, by transference, *any body politic of the secular world*” (206; emphasis added). *Corpus mysticum* is thereby charged with “secular political contents,” “secularizing” the mystical body concept and transforming the church into a “mystical corporation,” a “Christian polity,” or a “corporation of Christ” (201–203). These conceptual shifts facilitate the social-as-body metaphor’s extension beyond a specifically ecclesiastical context, as when secular jurists appropriated the concepts of theology and canon law as resources for the development of “new ideologies for the nascent territorial and secular states” (Kantorowicz 1957, 207). Thus, in the 13th century, appeals to the *corpus republicae mysticum*, or “mystical body of the commonweal” appear, representing, again in Kantorowicz’s (1957) estimation, the “transferring to the secular commonweal some of the super-natural and transcendental values normally owned by the Church” (208; see Enlow 2001, 18). A significant influence in this development, from around the 14th century onward, is so-called “corporation theory” as a way of

thinking about secular kingdoms (Lewis 1954, 201–203; Burns 1988, 454), a “corporation” representing “at one and the same time a body composed of a plurality of human beings and an abstract unitary entity perceptible by the intellect” (Canning 1996, 172). This provides the context in which *corpus mysticum* came to have the specific juridical connotations of a “fictitious” or “juristic” person (Gierke 1987, 68; Burns 1988, 473–476; Canning 1996, 172–173; Wierda 1997, 31;), so that *corpus mysticum* was deployed synonymously with such secular juridical terms as *corpus fictum*, *corpus imaginatum*, *corpus repraesentatum*, and so on (Kantorowicz 1957, 209). By the 15th century, *corpus politicum* (“body politic”) and *corpus mysticum* were used interchangeably, with some political thinkers and jurists explicitly referring to 1 Cor. 12 in the context of the secular state (Kantorowicz 1957, 225; Gierke 1987, 10).

Both Kantorowicz and de Lubac view the social-as-body’s extra-ecclesial extension as a degeneration or banalization of a properly theological concept (e.g., de Lubac 2007, 85). Kantorowicz (1957), for example, writes, “while the lofty idea of the Church as *corpus mysticum cuius caput Christus* [‘the mystical body with Christ for its head’] was inflated with secular contents, corporational as well as legal, the secular state itself ... strove for its own exaltation and quasi-religious glorification” (207). This assessment is misplaced, insofar as it fails to register that Paul’s deployment of the social-as-body metaphor already represented a theological appropriation of a political metaphor. Recognizing this, the metaphor’s extra-ecclesial extension does not represent a secular appropriation of a *sui generis* theological category, but an ongoing appeal to a metaphor that retains remarkable continuity with ancient usage. Indeed, just as Paul appropriated the metaphor, at least in part, because it provided a shared conceptual background with his audience, the metaphor’s extra-ecclesial extension likely occurs for the same reason, indicating a broad social and ideological circulation. The social-as-body metaphor’s extension beyond its ecclesiastical context is nevertheless notable, insofar as the original Pauline appropriation of the metaphor had created the possibility that the metaphor would lose its facility as a social and political metaphor with the fading of the perception of society as a united “Christendom.” Its extension beyond a narrow ecclesiastical context ensured that this did not occur.

The social-as-body metaphor’s continuity over this period is clear, insofar as the dual themes we have emphasized throughout remain operative: an emphasis on the social body’s normative morphology and on the existential danger posed when its members are out of place, failing to carry out their proper social roles. When members are out of place, the social body is disfigured, and a disfigured body is a pathologically disordered body. The common social vision in this period is therefore of “an integrated and yet articulated social organism” (Chroust 1947, 424; Gierke 1987, 22). The existence of the whole is impossible without the parts of which it is composed (Chroust 1947, 434), so that the body’s members “communicate to each other and to the Whole the results of their operation” (Gierke 1987, 26).

A kingdom or polity remained, however, more than, or something other than, the sum of its parts. Thus,

the kingdom, quite apart from being a territorial entity, was identified with its members but was also distinct from them in that it possessed an abstract and perpetual aspect in the form of the *universitas* or ‘republic’ of the kingdom (*republica regni*).

(Canning 1996, 173; see Burns 1988, 473)

Within this framework, it remains the case that “the universal single social body ... always consists of parts and partial wholes which the universal whole not only *creates* but also dominates” (Chroust 1947, 445, emphasis added). The individual, as conceived within the social-as-body metaphor, is not modern liberalism’s abstract individual, but is conceived as a determinate individual only within the context of the social body as a totality (Lewis 1954, 193; Burns 1988, 474; Coleman 2011, 180–181). The social body’s structure determines its members’ proper social roles and these, in turn, define their individual identity or significance. Reflecting the logic of the proper, the individual’s essential identity is a function of their social role and their structural position vis-à-vis other members of the social. The social body is therefore hierarchically ordered and is organic in the sense that every member is “a mere *organ* or agent of the whole” (Chroust 1947, 447; Gierke 1987, 7).

In keeping with centuries-old conceptions, then, the social body’s integrated unity was not a matter of equalitarian complementarity between its members but was fundamentally hierarchical and unequalitarian in nature. Social hierarchies were taken as the natural order of things (Coleman 2011, 180), so that the medieval social body’s normative morphology was fundamentally pyramidal (see Wierda 1997, 33). Thus, “far from preaching a revolutionary equalitarianism, it [medieval political social and political thought] contented itself with stressing the duties that corresponded to each social station” (Lewis 1954, 196). Grounded in neo-Platonic metaphysics (Lewis 1954, 196) and a social ontology reflecting the extension of the *corpus mysticum* concept through the entirety of society, the politically instituted social order’s naturalness lay in its institution of a hierarchy of beings (Chroust 1947, 425, 442), assigning every social body member “his [*sic*] particular place and task within the superior [social] organism” (441). Applying the logic of the proper, then, we can say that the social body’s normative morphology was “proprietary” in nature, insofar as it required that “every part is perfectly fulfilling its *own proper functions*” (Gierke 1987, 26, emphasis added). Accordingly, the social body’s individual members “were conceived, not as arithmetically equal units, but as socially grouped and differentiated from each other” (Chroust 1947, 442; Gierke 1987, 28). Thus, it was taken for granted that society “should be organized along ‘natural’ class and functional lines” (Wierda 1997, 29). Despite affirming individuals’ spiritual equality, then, it is nevertheless true to say that medieval society was a society of normative “ranks and orders,” rather than a society of individuals (Lewis 1954, 198).

If the view of society as a hierarchically ordered organic body is obviously consonant with the social-as-body metaphor going back more than a thousand years, so too is the social body's *telos*. Concord (to borrow the Stoic term) or *tranquillitas* (as in medieval formulation—see Chroust 1947, 440; Gierke 1987, 26) remains the social body's end. Maintaining proper social order was a requirement of social harmony, necessitating the preservation of the “natural—instituted—order of things” (Chroust 1947, 425). Social harmony required every member of the social body “fulfilling its natural functions” (Chroust 1947, 440), marking another significant continuity with antique conceptions (Chroust 1947, 425, 440; Gierke 1987, 26; Enlow 2001, 6; Coleman 2011, 180). *Tranquillitas* reflected “a harmony and balance of contrasts and differences in rank, estate, profession, and general qualification” which could only be achieved via “a necessary stratification of an [*sic*] hierarchical society” (Chroust 1947, 442).

As Chroust (1947) suggests, the social body's unity is a consistent emphasis superimposed over this entire schema, representing “the foundation of everything and, hence, also the basis of all society and social existence” (429). In the medieval period this issue was tied up with larger questions regarding sovereignty (Coleman 2011, 180), retaining the antique and Christian focus on the social body's “head.” In the earlier part of the period, this takes a shape that is essentially continuous with preceding notions of the social body, insofar as the social body's (ecclesiastical or secular) unity is given in the singular individual of the pope or the king, respectively (Chroust 1947, 428, 447; Lewis 1954, 195; Burns 1988, 475; Enlow 2001, 4; Coleman 2011, 186–187).³ The locus of sovereignty shifts for some thinkers as the medieval period advances, so that notions gesturing toward popular sovereignty begin to arise (Lewis 1954, 202; Wierda 1997, 32; Enlow 2001, 18–23; Coleman 2011, 188).⁴

Beyond Christendom: The Modern State as Social Body

The emergence of the modern state form represents the culmination in the social-as-body metaphor. In the aftermath of the Thirty Years' War, argues Daniel Philpott (2001), “not only the ideal, but any substantive reality, of united Christendom was gone” (75). Following the Treaty of Westphalia (1648), which formalized a number of cultural and political trends underway at the time, what emerged in its place was an “anarchical ‘system’ of states—fighting, allying, trading, negotiating, making peace, without yielding or genuflecting to any higher power” (75). The significance of the treaty lies, in large measure, in its expression of the modern conception of political sovereignty as “supreme authority within a territory” (Philpott 2001, 16; Morris 2004, 198; see also Philpott 2011, 561).

As this suggests, the modern political state's emergence corresponds to a distinctively modern conception of territoriality. In contrast to the medieval model, according to which different polities shared a sense of commonality via their belonging to Christendom as a “single organism” (Philpott 2001, 77), the

emergence of the modern state system represents an atomization of the social, with its production of an international order of individual states, each of which represents a kind of world unto itself. Within this system, Philpott (2011) notes, “people are members of a political community ... by virtue of their residence within a set of geographical borders” (562). Geography therefore takes precedence over shared culture or perceived kinship. By way of contrast, medieval governance was not primarily territorial in nature (Philpott 2001, 78; Morris 2004, 197). Rather, in contrast to the modern state system, the various realms of Christendom were not separate, self-sufficient juridical domains, but presupposed a widely shared “normative world,” namely Christendom (Morris 2004, 197).

The shift to the conceptual terrain of the modern territorial state is accompanied by a pronounced concern with the question of political sovereignty (see Philpott 2001, 2011, 2016), which involves both “external” and “internal” dimensions. The former, which refers to “immunity from external interference” on the part of sovereign states, marks the modern state system’s “anarchical” nature (Philpott 2001, 18). As Scott Thomas (2005) notes, “a key aspect of the Westphalian settlement has come to be known as the nonintervention norm in international relations” (55).⁵ These conceptual and political shifts do not mark the social-as-body metaphor’s disappearance, but its further evolution. The sovereign state becomes the social body (Philpott 2001, 76), “an impersonal body politic that outlived and transcended the body of any of its rulers” (138). Representing a culmination of the trajectory of medieval corporatist political thought, the state emerges as “a corporate agent, distinct from the rulers, with a legally recognized personality” (Morris 2011, 554).

The internal dimension of state sovereignty corresponds to its external dimension (Philpott 2001, 18). The state’s internal territorial sovereignty is such that its authority applies to the population and resources within its borders (Diener and Hagan 2012, 7), involving “the right to command and correlatively, the right to be obeyed” (Philpott 2011, 561). While the scope of internal sovereignty may be limited in nature (Philpott 2001, 18–19), it nevertheless remains the case that sovereign power remains supreme or ultimate insofar as “it is the highest in a hierarchy of authorities” (Morris 2004, 199). As Philpott (2001) puts it, “in the chain of authority by which I look to a higher authority, who in turn looks to a higher one, the holder of sovereignty is highest” (16–17).

As this formulation makes evident, internal sovereignty’s constitution necessarily requires the subordination of all potential rivals to state authority within its territory. One of the chief historical rivals to secular, which is simply to say non-ecclesiastical, political authority was the Church. The establishment of the sovereign state system therefore required the church’s subordination to the state. As Philpott (2001) compellingly argues, Protestant theology, particularly Martin Luther’s thought, played a vital legitimating role in this process, with crucial effects on the development of internal sovereignty. Protestant iconoclasm led to the divestment of economic and social power from the Catholic Church to secular rulers, while Luther’s “Two

Kingdoms” theology insisted that, though all were to be subject to both political and ecclesiastical authority, only the former were to wield specifically political and economic power (105–107). The end result of this coincidence of Protestant theological and political aims was

a territorial state free from the temporal power of the pope, the emperor, and the entire Catholic Church, a territorial state whose ruler has appropriated Catholic Church lands and powers within its realm, assisted splinter churches in freeing themselves from Catholic authority, and defending these churches against the emperor—this was a state whose ruler would now be sovereign.
(107)

As John N. Figgis (1907) writes, “the unity and universality and essential rightness of the sovereign territorial State, and the denial of every extra-territorial or independent communal form of life, are Luther’s lasting contribution to politics” (91, qtd in Philpott 2016).⁶ The long-term result of these developments was the constitution of “religion” as privatized and, in an important sense, de-materialized, ultimately reducing it to “a set of moral and theological propositions” separable from “the virtues and practices embodied in the ecclesiastical community,” thereby rendering religion compatible with Europe’s emerging sovereign monarchies (Thomas 2005, 25). Thus, political and economic power were systematically stripped from the Church and consolidated under secular authority (i.e., non-ecclesiastical) state (Philpott 2001, 105–106).

Despite the shifts it undergoes in its transposition from Christendom to the political state, the social-as-body metaphor retains its two central, orienting themes with the emergence of the modern state system: the emphasis on the social body’s normative morphology and the existential danger posed when that body’s members are out of place. This is evident in the robust theories of political sovereignty that emerged following the breakdown of the sense of a shared participation in European Christendom (Philpott 2001, 143). This is clear in the thought of Jean Bodin, who produced the first systematic account of political sovereignty in Europe. Writing “in the midst of a generation-long civil war between Calvinists and Huguenots and the Catholic monarchy that tore France apart,” Bodin argued that only a sovereign state could provide the basis for a unified political body (566). This is particularly evident in Bodin’s insistence on sovereignty’s indivisibility (a notion that, while mistaken, was influential for both Hobbes and Rousseau, as we will see in Chapter 3) (see Bodin 1992, 49–50, 92, 104). As we shall see in the following chapters, the social-as-body metaphor, with its dual structuring themes, continues to find expression in modern and contemporary political thought and practice.

The Social-as-Body as Dispositional Metaphor

Valerio Fabbrizi’s (2018) suggestion that the emergence of the modern constitutional state following the French Revolution marks the end of appeals to the

social-as-body metaphor (16–17) contradicts my assertion of the metaphor's continued relevance. He writes, "the Hobbesian theory of absolute sovereignty is overturned by the liberal theory of democratic representative sovereignty, according to which laws are the product of a majoritarian and democratic legislative vote" (17). Therefore, he continues, "the idea of the body politic should now be replaced by the idea of a constitutional rule of law," according to which "constitutions become the product of the deliberation of a constituent assembly, representing the will of people, aimed at delimiting and controlling the sovereign power" (17).

It is certainly true that explicit appeals to the social-as-body do not figure prominently in contemporary political theory or practice. In this sense, Martin (1995) is correct when he contrasts contemporary political thinkers with their pre-modern forebears by suggesting that, for the former, the society-as-body metaphor is *only* a metaphor (15). Yet, as Žižek (1989) argues, "'Society as a corporate Body'," which is to say, "the corporatist vision of Society as an organic Whole, a social Body in which the different classes are like extremities, members each contributing to the Whole according to its function," remains, the "fundamental ideological fantasy" operative today (126). The social-as-body metaphor's central motifs are evident in his description: an emphasis on a morphologically normative social body, the health of which is a function of unity or harmony (i.e., concord or *tranquillitas*) that is threatened if its members are out of place, failing to play their proper social roles. This seems to open a theoretical gap between Fabbri's recognition that the social-as-body metaphor plays little to no explicit role within contemporary political theory or practice and Žižek's insistence that the metaphor represents modern politics' ideological basis. Fabbri and Žižek are both correct, and the way to bridge the gap separating them is to offer a fuller explication of the meaning of the social-as-body metaphor as a *metaphor* and of its operation within contemporary political thought and practice.

George Lakoff and Mark Johnson (2003) open a path for thinking through this issue in their well-known study of metaphor. They highlight a number of fallacies concerning metaphor, and while the fourth ("that rational thought is in no way shaped by the nature of our brains and bodies") is less germane to our concerns here, the first three they list are highly relevant, and worth quoting in full: "the first fallacy is that metaphor is a matter of words, not concepts. The second is that metaphor is based on similarity. The third is that all concepts are literal and that none can be metaphorical" (244). They argue that metaphor reflects not merely a way of speaking, but a form of conceptualization and reasoning as such, highlighting "the central role of metaphor in abstract thought" (245). In stating the issue this way, they do not mean that metaphor has fundamentally to do with ratiocination; rather, they assign metaphor a much more fundamental role, as a basic structuring dimension of human experience, arguing that our "conceptual system," which ordinarily forms the background that both renders our actions both possible and socially intelligible, is "fundamentally metaphorical in nature" (3).

Using the metaphor “argument is war,” they illustrate the significance of these reflections, noting,

It is important to see that we don't just *talk* about arguments in terms of war. We can actually win or lose arguments. We see the person we are arguing with as an opponent. We attack his positions and we defend our own. We gain and lose ground. We plan and use strategies. If we find a position indefensible, we can abandon it and take a new line of attack. Many of the things we *do* in arguing are partially structured by the concept of war. Though there is no physical battle, there is a verbal battle, and the structure of an argument—attack, defense, counterattack, etc.—reflects this. It is in this sense that the ARGUMENT IS WAR metaphor is one that we live by in this culture; it structures the actions we perform in arguing.

(Lakoff and Johnson 2003, 4)

These points deserve further comment.

First, “the essence of metaphor is understanding and experiencing one kind of thing in terms of another” (Lakoff and Johnson 2003, 5). That is (returning to their example), there is no pre-existing similarity between the activity (argument) and the metaphor through which it is articulated (war). As they state it, “it is not that arguments are a subspecies of war. Arguments and wars are different kinds of things ...” (5). The point of emphasis is that metaphor plays a significant, constituting role in experience, to such a degree that there is no sense in speaking of that which is “represented” by the metaphor in isolation or separation from it. Recognizing this point breaks down the distinction between the “literal” and the “metaphorical.” As they write (still discussing argument),

Our conventional ways of talking about arguments presuppose a metaphor we are hardly ever conscious of. The metaphor is not merely in the words we use—it is in our very concept of an argument. The language of argument is not poetic, or fanciful, or rhetorical; *it is literal*. We talk about arguments that way because we conceive of them that way—and we act according to the way we conceive of things.

(5, *emphasis added*)

The essential correctness of this point is evident when we consider that if, when arguing, we do not experience ourselves as conducting a verbal war, or battle, or a skirmish, we will likely insist that we are not arguing at all. Lakoff and Johnson therefore reverse the standard conceptualization of metaphor as merely linguistic in nature, suggesting that “metaphors as linguistic expressions are possible precisely because there are metaphors in a person's conceptual system” (6).

Drawing on Lakoff and Johnson's analysis, I am arguing that the social-as-body metaphor is conceptual (in their sense of this term) in nature, both structuring

and expressing perceptions, affects, and actions related to society's fundamental nature, deeply conditioning a sense of what society fundamentally *is*. Within this framework, describing the social-as-body metaphor as "metaphor" does not presuppose an opposition between the social's "literal" constitution and its "metaphorical" representation. Rather, in line with Lakoff and Johnson's account, the metaphor conceptually structures our sense of the social through its dual emphases on the social body's normative morphology and the threat to the morphology when members are out of place. Further, the social-as-body metaphor plays this structuring role even if social and political actors do not explicitly appeal to it, or even know of it. Returning to the disagreement between Fabbri's and Žižek's respective positions, then, we can see that Fabbri's insight is essentially correct at the level of explicit political discourse, while Žižek's is correct on a fundamental perceptual and affective level.

More remains to be said concerning the social-as-body metaphor's precise nature. For all its usefulness, Lakoff and Johnson's formulation, with its language of "concepts" can give the impression (which I believe to be mistaken) that metaphors operate on an abstract, mental, or psychological level. As I have already indicated, my argument is that the social-as-body metaphor operates on a more visceral, pre-reflective, affective level. Rather than concepts, the dual emphases at the heart of the social-as-body metaphor are better understood as "dispositions" structuring social perception, affect, and practice. I take this notion of dispositions from Pierre Bourdieu's (1990) well-known but complex notion of *habitus*, which names:

systems of durable, transposable dispositions, structured structures predisposed to function as structuring structures, that is, as principles which generate and organize practices and representations that can be objectively adapted to their outcomes without presupposing a conscious aiming at ends or an express mastery of operations necessary in order to attain them.

(53; see also 1977, 72)

Teasing apart this complex formulation will bring the social-as-body metaphor's ongoing operation into clearer focus.

Bourdieu develops his notion of *habitus* in an attempt to mediate between the structuralism of Lévi-Strauss and Louis Althusser, on the one hand, and Jean-Paul Sartre's radical voluntarism, on the other (Swartz 1998, 101; Robbins 2014, 43). More broadly, the concept represents Bourdieu's response to the much broader question,

how can one take into account *both* the observed regularities of social action, which most frequently are visible only to the social scientist who takes the time and effort to calculate them, and the experiential reality of free, purposeful, reasoning human actors who carry out their everyday actions practically, without full awareness of or conscious reflection on structures?

(Swartz 1998, 95)⁷

Bourdieu therefore formulates his theoretical intervention as seeking to overcome the “ruinous” divide between “subjectivism” and “objectivism” within the social sciences (Bourdieu 1990, 25).

Dispositions are therefore central to Bourdieu’s development of an account of agency that does not reduce to social or structural determinism. In speaking of “dispositions,” Bourdieu has in view the source of what he refers to as “practical,” “*doxic*,” “phenomenological,” or “primary” knowledge, which he presents as follows:

The knowledge we shall call *phenomenological* ... sets out to make explicit the truth of primary experience of the social world, i.e., all that is inscribed in the *familiarity* with the familiar environment, the unquestioning apprehension of the social world which, by definition, does not reflect on itself and excludes the question of the conditions of its own possibility.

(Bourdieu 1977, 3)

Several points about this description are worth noting.

First, what Bourdieu describes as “primary” knowledge of the social world is fundamentally practical in nature, meaning that it is not a matter conscious intent, explicit rational reflection, or discursive articulation. In describing dispositions as “structuring structures” (Bourdieu 1990, 53), then, Bourdieu is clear that dispositions name fundamental propensities to encounter the world, structuring the way it presents itself to us. Dispositions represent what Anthony Steinbock (2004) terms “cultural *a priori*s” (170).⁸ That is, dispositions are pre-given “essential structures” of our experience that “guide the ways in which we conceive of things, analyze them, regard or judge facts about our world” (171). These structures are *a priori* precisely insofar as they are not products of reason or the understanding or “objective” dimensions of experience, but are, on the contrary, the condition of possibility of objective appearing as such (170). Understood in these terms, dispositions “stylize” and typify “the very way of ‘seeing’ and the very reality seen” (172). Dispositions form the horizon against which and out of which our world is generated and are not themselves objects of reflective observation (i.e., Bourdieu’s critiques of “objectivism”). As Bourdieu (1977) writes, “the habitus could be considered a subjective but not individual system of internalized structures, schemes of perception, conception, and action common to all members of the same group or class and constituting the precondition for all objectification and apperception” (86). Dispositions constitute a fundamental orientation to the world, structuring the world *as* the world we experience, with all its qualitative force and, in so doing, constitute it as *our* world, the world in which we are most at home and to which we most definitively belong (i.e., with which we are most fundamentally “familiar,” to use Bourdieu’s term).⁹

Dispositions, as Bourdieu (1990) puts it, “generate and organize practices and representations that can be objectively adapted to their outcomes ...” (53), which

is to say that they not only structure the social world's givenness, but also our ongoing engagements in and with that world as given. As "structuring structures," dispositions structure responses to the social world in such a way that they tend to occur in regularized patterns. Dispositions guide and affect actions and responses in such a manner that, while social actors respond creatively and inventively in the world, some responses are effectively foreclosed (see Swartz 1998, 103). A disposition therefore represents "a way of being, a habitual state (especially of the body) and, in particular, a predisposition, tendency, propensity, or inclination" (Bourdieu 1977, 214n1). Dispositions, then, are such that we are "inclined" or "predisposed" to act or respond in particular ways and not in others. Such a formulation preserves a sense of agency without veering in the direction of subjectivist voluntarism.¹⁰

These considerations highlight more fully the complexity of an account of agency that is neither simply deterministic nor voluntaristic. Social actors act "freely," even if they do so with predictable regularity, precisely *because* they act habitually. That is, habitual actions are not experienced as "compelled" or determined insofar as they stem from internal (which is to say, internalized) dispositions. Habitual actions represent "the externalization of internality" (Bourdieu 1977, 72) rather than consciously chosen or calculated deliberations. Bourdieu's account of dispositions therefore provides his answer to the question of "how ... action [is] regulated; how ... action follow[s] regular statistical patterns without being the result of obedience to rules, norms, or conscious intention" (Swartz 1998, 95).

Such, then, is the nature of dispositions as structuring structures. But this is only half the story, insofar as they are also, in Bourdieu's (1990) formulation, "structured structures" (53). While dispositions represent a priori conditions constituting the world's givenness and our habitual responses to it, these a priori conditions are themselves historically and socially constituted. In more philosophical parlance, dispositions, as the condition of possibility for the world's intelligibility and our responses to it, have their own conditions of possibility in social life's concrete realities.¹¹ While dispositions represent the "externalization of internality," then, they also represent the "internalization of externality" (Bourdieu 1977, 72). They are, Bourdieu writes, "durably inculcated by objective conditions" (77), such that *habitus* is "the product of history" (82). As Swartz (1998) suggests, for Bourdieu "habitus is a 'structured structure' that derives from the class-specific experiences of socialization in family and peer groups" (102).

Habitus therefore "generates perceptions, aspirations, and practices that correspond to the structuring properties of earlier socialization" (Swartz 1998, 103). This is why dispositions may be described as internal or subjective, but not as individual (Bourdieu 1977, 86). On the contrary, they are generated by our membership in social collectivities that we do not choose and into which, borrowing a Heideggerian phrase, we are "thrown," with the effect that we are dispositionally constituted to act in ways that accord with the norms of those

groups. The effect is that “the system of dispositions” represents “a past which survives in the present and tends to perpetuate itself into the future by making itself present in practices structured according to its principles” (82). The dispositions that direct action originate within the social groups to which we belong, with the effect that as we act out those dispositions within the social, we perpetuate the *habitus* that first generated them. Social actions represent the externalization of previously internalized external structures, which drives a cycle of ongoing social reproduction. Thus, “objective structures are themselves products of historical practices and are constantly reproduced and transformed by historical practices whose productive principle is itself the product of structures which it consequently tends to reproduce” (83).

Combining these insights with Lakoff and Johnson’s account of metaphor, we can speak of “dispositional,” rather than conceptual, metaphors. That is, drawing on Bourdieu’s concept of disposition, we can see that metaphor operates on the dispositional level while at the same time, drawing on Lakoff and Johnson’s fundamental insight, we see that dispositions often take the form of metaphor. This account of “dispositional metaphors” yields a few central insights. Dispositional metaphors are not chosen, but, on the contrary, structure the fundamental experience of supra-individual collectivities which, in crucial respects, constitute individuality. These metaphors are not optional, representing the historically constituted a priori conditions of social perception, affect, and practice. As such, they are not elective and cannot be abandoned without forfeiting the social intelligibility of those perceptions, affects, and practices. To return to Lakoff and Johnson’s example of the “argument is war” metaphor, the metaphor’s fundamental nature is such that to set it aside is to set aside any meaningful concept of argument. In like manner, dispositional metaphors constitute the world’s givenness, structuring the range of possible responses to it and actions within it. Finally, such metaphors’ operations are not conditioned on conscious knowledge, adoption, articulation, or deliberation (indeed, their effective operation will generally depend upon their functioning as a presupposed horizon of intelligibility, rather than an object of explicit reflection). Drawing together these various threads, I am arguing that the social-as-body metaphor is dispositional in nature, and so represents a system of “durable, transposable dispositions, structured structures predisposed to function as structuring structures” as outlined by Bourdieu (1990, 53; see also 1977, 72).

In line with Bourdieu’s (1990) discussion, then, I am suggesting that the social-as-body metaphor plays the role of “generating and organizing practices and representations” within shared social and political life, and that it does so, as Bourdieu says, “*without presupposing a conscious aiming at ends*” (53, emphasis added). That is, the social-as-body metaphor continues to serve as a cultural a priori, a condition of possibility for collective social and political life. As dispositional in nature, the metaphor operates on what William Connolly (1999) calls the “visceral register,” a “register of subjectivity and intersubjectivity” of

“preconscious modes of intensity and thought-imbued feelings” (3, 176). It represents “gut-level” knowledge, Bourdieu’s primary knowledge, operating on a level anterior to, indeed as the condition of, explicit discursive rationality. It is what Brian Massumi (2015) refers to as a “thinking-feeling” that is not a mode of reflection, but its anterior condition, an “immediate understanding” that informs reflective or deliberative thought (94).

The social-as-body metaphor is not simply a matter of historical interest but continues to structure social and political life on a dispositional, affective level. It expresses a fundamental disposition to social order, almost inevitably hierarchical, in which all the social body’s members play their proper roles. Following the logic of the proper, these assigned roles define individual members’ places within the totality of the social body, constituting its normative morphology. In the following chapters, we will find that the social-as-body metaphor continues to structure social and political experience at the dispositional, visceral level, even in cases in which it is not explicitly invoked.

Indeed, there is a fundamental inconsistency between modern political theory’s explicit claims, on the one hand, and the social’s dispositional structuring, on the other. At the level of articulated political philosophy, the liberal emphasis on a society of “free and equal individuals” is certainly inconsistent with the naturalized social hierarchy of medieval appeals to society as *corpus mysticum*. At the dispositional level, however, the social-as-body metaphor, expressing itself in a visceral concern to maintain the social body’s normative morphology and a reaction against members out of place within it, is still discernible. Reflecting this point’s ongoing relevance, Catherine Holland (2001) notes that

rather than having been rendered inessential within politics, or banished altogether from it, the citizen’s body has come to figure more visibly and more powerfully than ever in the American political imagination over recent decades ... Foregrounding questions of race, gender, and sexuality, the so-called culture wars have placed the citizen’s body, yet again, at the very center of the nation’s political agenda.

(169)

It is precisely because the social-as-body metaphor continued to function at the dispositional level, rather than finding explicit political-theoretical articulation, that this inconsistency can stand without being experienced as contradictory—explicitly stated political or social values can obviously coexist with dispositions at odds with them. This marks one important dimension of Žižek’s (1989) assertion that the social-as-body metaphor represents a “fundamental ideological fantasy” (126). In affirming the metaphor’s “ideological” nature (we will come to its specifically fantastical nature shortly), I have in view the fact that dispositions are not constrained by logical consistency, retaining their operative force even when challenged on grounds of internal logic or coherence. That is, as the basis for the

meaning of the social itself, the dispositional social-as-body metaphor does not lend itself to “factual” or rational disconfirmation (see 99). That logical coherence and consistency with consciously held and articulated positions are insignificant to the social-as-body metaphor’s dispositional operation is one of the metaphor’s defining features in its ideological operation. Though they do not frame the issue in ideological terms, Lakoff and Johnson (2003) highlight this basic point when they note that the metaphors underlying fundamental social and cultural expression often do not cohere (23). While explicit invocations of the social-as-body metaphor or the “body politic” may therefore be rare, visceral reactions to disruptions of the social body’s normative morphology and to members out of place within it, remain fundamental to contemporary social and political experience. As we will see in the following chapters, the social-as-body metaphor continues to structure social and political perceptions, affects, and practices.

Social Body, Social Dysphoria

We have seen that the social-as-body metaphor operates on a pre-reflective, pre-discursive, dispositional level and that the body imagined within the metaphor is marked by two determinate features: a normative morphology and its preservation by ensuring that its members are not out of place. As both structuring structure and structured structure, the social-as-body metaphor dispositionally structures social and political perceptions, affects, and practices, on the one hand, and expresses socially shared conceptions of embodiment, on the other. The remainder of this chapter is focused on two issues. First, we will more closely consider the normative body imagined within the social-as-body metaphor, examining the conception of embodiment it presupposes to highlight its fundamentally fantastical character. Second, we will reimagine the body at the heart of the metaphor (and following from this, the metaphor itself), giving central place to a conception of the body as fundamentally queer, defined by a fluid and shifting morphology, lacking any normative shape. While there are a number of contemporary resources for reimagining the nature of embodiment, I want to draw specifically from the insights of transgender theory and experience.¹² In Rogers Brubaker’s words, “trans is good to think with” (Brubaker 2016, 71), insofar as trans theorists have long recognized that “bodies are screens” (Stone 2006, 229) directing social and political desire. Or, as Gayle Salamon (2010) sums up the issue, “a consideration of trans bodies might help us to understand how relations between the phantasmatic and the material can be embodied and lived” (2).

Trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC) bodies directly challenge normative conceptions of body morphology because their defining morphological feature is body members “out of place.”¹³ The dominant operative conception of embodiment is determined by what Talia Mae Bettcher (2009) describes as the “natural attitude” toward sex and gender, an attitude that posits bodies that are naturally dimorphic and presupposes that what is “natural” is normative. On this view,

“there are two naturally mutually exclusive, exhaustive, and invariant sexes, and membership within a sex is determined by genitalia,” which is to say, by body morphology (103).¹⁴ Accordingly, “gender presentation literally *signifies* sex,” and more specifically “genital status,” so that “there is a representational relation between gender presentation and sexed body” (105). Somewhat paradoxically, this relation is achieved negatively:

Clothing serves a “concealing” function. By “hiding” the body, the contrast between clothing and body is immediately implicated in the notions of *exposure* and *revelation*. This function is connected to taboos against nudity in public space and the demarcation of certain body parts as private. Yet it is precisely because genitalia are marked off as sexually private that they require available representations in public. If this is correct, the status of genitals as the “truth” flows from their required public concealment (which necessitates public signs).

(Bettcher 2009, 106)

There is a sense, then, in which the emphasis on normative body morphology is dissimulated, insofar as it is structured around the invisibility or concealment of genitalia which, precisely in that imposed invisibility, are powerfully present in every presentation of gender and the publicly shared understanding of morphologically normative embodiment.¹⁵

On the natural attitude, normal or natural sexed/gendered bodies are properly ordered, defined by members in their proper places: bodies with breasts have vaginas; bodies with penises do not have vulvas, and so on. Further, not only are individual sexed/gendered bodies’ members in their proper places, sexed/gendered bodies must themselves also be in *their* proper places within the social body, undertaking their proper social and sexual roles. This is the point at which sexuality, though analytically distinct from gender, nevertheless relates to gender and embodiment. Transphobia, fear of bodies that illegitimately cross (i.e., “trans”) the boundaries of normatively gendered embodiment, is intimately related to homophobia, the fear of bodies that fail to play their proper (which is to say heterosexual) role within the social body, even if they are normatively embodied. Thus, two “female” or two “male” bodies engaged in sex acts represent members of the social body that are fundamentally out of place, evoking visceral reactions, reactions which are only heightened if those acts occur between, say, a body with full breasts and a penis and a masculine body with a “front hole,” or between more than two bodies simultaneously, and so on.

As Salamon (2010) suggests, then, the TGNC body is *transgressive* precisely because it has no place within the social. The “sexually undecidable” body, like Aristotle’s “goat-stag,” “does not exist and is located nowhere.” She continues: “what secures the ontological primacy of place is precisely the fact that anything that is categorically undecidable cannot be located in any proper place. What

renders a thing or being impossible is literally that it *has no place*" (138–139). Within a social imaginary that defines normative embodiment only according to the logic of a binary bodily morphology, "sexual difference is genital difference is genital dimorphism" (138), so that TGNC bodies that cannot be placed within this binary *have no place at all*; they are fundamentally *out of place* within the social body.¹⁶

Such bodies can appear within the social only as monstrous or grotesque deformations, as modern manifestations of Aristotle's impossible goat-stag, as "living things of anomalous shape or structure ... fabulous creatures like the sphinx ... composed of strikingly incongruous parts" (Stryker 2006, 247). As Nikki Sullivan (2006) puts it, they are "transmogrifications," bodies that are "strange or grotesque," defined by "unnatural combinations," bodies "consisting of the dis-junction and interweaving of polyvalent elements that somehow resist unification into a singular and 'sensible' whole" (553, 561). Such bodies are "unnatural," in precisely the sense that they cannot be mapped onto the dimorphic grid posited within the natural attitude. There is no place within this social imaginary for bodies that are not morphologically normative or gender identities that transgress dimorphic norms of embodied gender. As Georgia Warnke (2009) argues, identities are contextual in nature and "create confusion" when they "overflow" their fixed contexts (33).

As Susan Stryker (2006) poignantly writes, the TGNC body

is an unnatural body ... It is flesh torn apart and sewn together again in a shape other than that in which it was born ... I find a deep affinity between myself as a transsexual woman and the monster in Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*. Like the monster, I am too often perceived as less than fully human due to the means of my embodiment.

(245)

TGNC bodies are literally bodies out of place, bodies that *have no place*. In the natural attitude, the truth of gender, indeed the truth of bodies, lies in normative morphology; TGNC bodies are deeply untrue. This is why, as Bettcher suggests, TGNC individuals are so often presented as deceivers (Bettcher 2009, 105, 2013; see also Halberstam 2004, 79–82).¹⁷

TGNC bodies are therefore *transgressive* precisely because they cross over (*trans*) the lines demarcating morphologically normative bodies; they are bodies defined by members out of place. Likewise, TGNC bodies provoke visceral social reactions because they are also out of place within the social body. Such bodies run afoul of the disposition to social order expressed in the social-as-body metaphor, subject to constant efforts to reimpose the social body's normative morphology and to return such transgressive members to their proper (which typically means invisible or nonexistent) places within it. Yet, in transgressing the social body's presumed normativity, TGNC bodies also play a revelatory role. As Sullivan (2006) suggests, "the trope of monstrous (un)becoming" can be deployed in

productive ways, rather than being rejected (560). It undermines the natural attitude's presumed truth with a deeper realization.

Far from transgressing natural embodiment, TGNC practices of embodiment serve as examples "of the many ambiguous and complex ways in which bodies are continually changed and changing" (Sullivan 2006, 553), bringing to light the fact that "all bodies are unnatural, created, formed, and transformed in and through modificatory processes and procedures of one sort or another" (558). TGNC bodies and reflections on bodies reveal that bodies are *always* monstrous, grotesque, transmogrified (see Richardson 2010, 10). Embodiment necessarily involves "transing," understood as the intentional crossing or transgressing of "previously categorically fixed territories" (Noble 2012, 46). As Stryker (2006) powerfully writes,

I who have dwelt in a form unmatched with my desire, I whose flesh has become an assemblage of incongruous anatomical parts, I who achieve the similitude of a natural body only through an unnatural process, I offer you this warning: the Nature you bedevil me with is a lie ... It is a fabrication that cloaks the groundlessness of the privilege you seek to maintain for yourself at my expense.

(247)

To encounter a TGNC body is therefore "to risk a revelation of the constructedness of the natural order" (254). TGNC bodies reveal that *all* bodies are unsettled; *all* bodies are perpetually in a state of flux or becoming; *all* bodies are "misshapen" or transmogrified; *all* bodies are, in a word, queer.

TGNC bodies do not depart from nature, they reveal that "natural" bodies are a myth. There is no natural, normative body, "no fixed, inherent, or essential body" (Richardson 2010, 9). TGNC bodies reveal what bodies always already are. It is not simply the case that TGNC bodies are queer, but that *all* bodies are always already queer, that embodiment itself is queer, defined by a fluid and unpredictable morphology. TGNC bodies' transgression lies not in their departure from a purportedly natural (and therefore normal) mode of embodiment, but in their revelation that there is no "natural" embodiment.

Considering again Salamon's (2010) insight that TGNC embodiment highlights the relation between "the phantasmatic and the material" (2), material TGNC embodiment reveals the fantastical nature of the normatively gendered body presupposed in the natural attitude structuring the social-as-body metaphor. This, in turn, brings us to the consideration of fantasy promised above. In this context, Žižek's (1989) account of fantasy is particularly illuminating.¹⁸ Rejecting what he describes as the "usual" definition of fantasy as "an imagined scenario presenting the realization of desire" (118), Žižek argues that fantasy is not about desire's fulfilment, but about its shaping and direction. As he puts it, "through fantasy, we learn 'how to desire'" (118). Stated in his preferred Lacanian theoretical idiom, the "big Other, the symbolic order itself is ... crossed-out by a

fundamental impossibility, structured around an impossible/traumatic kernel, around a central lack” (122). While this language can be arcane to the uninitiated, the big Other or symbolic order refers “to anything that contributes to the creation of our subjectivity” (Tyson 2014, 31), which is to say, to the social itself (therefore overlapping in significant measure with what Bourdieu develops under the rubric of *habitus*). Žižek’s point is that the social, which constitutes the subject, is never fully “closed” or fixed (Žižek 1989, 122).

This lack of closure is simultaneously good and bad news. The good news is that the symbolic order’s incompleteness is subjectivation’s condition of possibility, allowing the “breathing space” (Žižek 1989, 122) necessary for the subject to be constituted in ways that are not simply social predetermined.¹⁹ But this incompleteness is also bad news, because it is simultaneously subjectivation’s condition of impossibility: the same lack that allows the space for subjectivation means that subjectivation can never be completely attained, that the subject can never be fully constituted. So long as the symbolic order remains incomplete, so does subjectivity itself. Subjectivation remains, as it were, an ongoing task.

Fantasy occludes this incompleteness: “fantasy conceals the fact that the Other, the symbolic order, is structured around some traumatic impossibility, around something which cannot be symbolized” (Žižek 1989, 123). Fantasy is, then, “a scenario filling out the empty space of a fundamental impossibility, a screen masking a void” (126). Desire is fantastically directed toward the attainment of that which would bring about subjectivity’s full constitution. Yet, precisely because the symbolic order is incomplete, because the lack at the heart of subjectivity is constitutive, *there is no* object that can bring about such closure or completion. Yet fantasy nevertheless directs desire to this impossible object. In this process, “an empirical, positively given object becomes an object of desire ... it begins to contain some X, some unknown quality, something which is ‘in it more than it’ and makes it worthy of our desire” (119). That is, some element within the symbolic order, some determinate element of social or cultural life, is invested with a kind of superlative value, and is transformed into the missing or lacking object which will bring ultimate subjective completion, taking on the role of the *objet petit a*.²⁰ Fantasy directs desire toward the object invested with superlative value that will complete subjectivity. Fantasy masks that the lack at the heart of subjectivity is itself constitutive, rendering this operation impossible.

Žižek’s description of fantasy as a screen adds significance to Sandy Stone’s (2006) description of bodies as screens (229). Within the natural attitude, which underlies the dispositional social-as-body metaphor, a *particular kind* of body becomes the fantastical object of social desire. The White, cisgender, heterosexual body is invested with superlative value, becoming the normative screen onto which the social’s closure is projected (we shall consider this body’s additional features in Chapter 5). Thus, the social body is presented as an integral, organic totality, defined by a normative morphology, on the model of the fantastical body presupposed within the natural attitude.

Recognition of the morphologically normative body's social nature accompanies recognition of its fantastical nature. In discussing normative and non-normative embodiment, we are never discussing merely individual bodies, but are necessarily engaging with categories that are resolutely social. As Judith Butler (2004) notes, we are "regulated by gender," which "operates as a condition of cultural intelligibility for any person" (52). Or, as Cressida J. Heyes (2009) puts it, "none of us is at liberty to become any kind of person we want"; rather, "to align oneself with a particular identity formation is a necessarily intersubjective activity" (149). This social dimension reveals the fantasy of the morphologically normative body to be fundamentally *political*, which is why Salamon is correct to suggest a link between the material and the phantasmatic with regard to issues of embodiment.

The clinical psychological understanding of normatively and non-normatively gendered embodiment represents one of the cultural sites most clearly illustrating the links between materiality and fantasy, the individual and social dimensions of embodiment, and their entanglement of these issues with questions of normativity. These complex and shifting connections are on clear display in the changing conceptions of gendered embodiment articulated in the American Psychiatric Association's *DSM*, the guidebook for the diagnosis of mental health disorders utilized by professionals around the world. Following a lengthy period of debate, the fifth edition of the *DSM* (*DSM-V*) (APA 2013) replaced the diagnosis of "Gender Identity Disorder" (GID) with the diagnosis of "Gender Dysphoria" (451–459). This included replacement of the diagnosis of "Gender Identity Disorder of Childhood" (GIDC) with "Gender dysphoria in children."²¹ As a closer consideration of these changes reveals, they vividly register an emerging realization of the inherently social nature of embodiment, gender, and identity, a point which is relevant for reimagining the social-as-body metaphor.

DSM-V defines gender dysphoria as "a marked incongruence between one's experienced/expressed gender and assigned gender, of at least 6 months' duration," manifested in a requisite number of preferences and desires (APA 2013, 452–453). The mere presence of the diagnosis in the *DSM-V* can give the impression that gender dysphoria is an issue of individual psychology and embodiment (even if not pathology),²² but such an impression is mistaken. As clinically defined, gender dysphoria refers to "the distress that may accompany the incongruence between one's experienced or expressed gender and one's assigned gender" (APA 2013, 451). This psychological distress, which may be severe and potentially includes increased risk for suicidal ideation, suicide attempts, suicide, anxiety, impulse-control issues, and depression (APA 2013, 454, 458–459), "is the clinical problem, not identity per se" (APA 2013, 451). That is, gender identity that does not correspond to one's gender as assigned at birth is *not* defined as pathological; what *is* defined as pathological is the "distress" this non-correspondence may bring, expressed in the comorbid manifestations indicated.

While the *DSM* does not specify a treatment regimen for alleviating this distress, its remedy can be stated in a single word: transition (see WPATH 2012, 8–9).²³

The distress brought on by the incongruence of expressed gender identity with assigned gender is mitigated by rectifying that incongruence *in the direction of expressed or experienced gender identity*, whether by means of social transition, hormone therapies, surgical treatments, psychological counseling, or a combination of these. In other words, the distress that may accompany the experienced incongruence of gender identity and assigned gender is mitigated by transitioning to a gender expression that accords fully with one's experienced gender. The Gender Identity Disorders Work Group, tasked with researching and recommending changes related to the prior diagnosis of GID for *DSM-IV*, recognizes this point in its report, which states: "by definition, full social transitioning and legal sex/gender reassignment make the diagnostic criteria [for GID] no longer applicable" (Zucker et al. 2013, 910). This point is also reflected in the *DSM-V* discussion of gender dysphoria in children, which notes: "distress may not be manifest in *social environments supportive of the child's desire to live in the role of the other gender* and may emerge only if the desire is interfered with" (APA 2013, 455; emphasis added). Allowing full transition (social and/or medical) to one's experienced gender, including transition to a gender expression which does not lie on a male/female binary (APA 2013, 453), mitigates the psychological distress (i.e., gender dysphoria) arising from the incongruence of assigned gender with experienced gender.²⁴

Stated simply, if individuals experiencing gender dysphoria have access to the mental health, medical, and social resources for transition and social acceptance, there need not be any experience of distress related to incongruence between assigned and experienced gender (i.e., gender dysphoria). Crucially, to reiterate, the reduction of the incongruence between experienced gender and assigned gender is achieved by allowing and reinforcing gender nonconforming behaviors and identities, rather than repressing or interfering with them. As Zucker et al. (2013) note, support for gender transition involves "steps [that] support the behavior pattern that was incongruent with the natal sex" (910), an approach with "no parallel in any other psychiatric category" (911).

The diagnostic shifts represented in *DSM-V* and standards of care for gender dysphoria mark a growing recognition that gender dysphoria is a *social malady*, rather than a function of individual psychology and embodiment. This is registered in the shift in focus from "cross-gender"²⁵ behaviors in *DSM-IV* and *DSM-IV-TR* to gender *identities* that do not correspond to one's birth-assigned gender, and which may or may not correspond to a male/female binary, in *DSM-V*. This represents a significant break from earlier versions of the *DSM*, which were much more determined by the natural attitude of sex, gender, and embodiment. With this in view, it is telling that, as Karl Bryant (2006) points out, the diagnosis of GIDC had its origins in research of gender-variant boys in the 1960s, research that was, in large part, carried out in an effort to prevent them from growing into "homosexual, transvestite, or transsexual" adults (24). For critics of the GID and GIDC diagnoses, it is no coincidence that they first appear in *DSM-III*, which was also the first edition of the *DSM* to remove the diagnosis of homosexuality as a

mental health disorder. Finding clear continuity in these changes to the *DSM*, they argue that the inclusion of GID and GIDC in *DSM-III* provided a means of continued pathologizing of homosexuality in other terms (Bryant 2006, 24; Zucker et al. 2013, 907).²⁶

Whether or not one is fully persuaded by this line of reasoning, the conceptual links between trans- and homophobia, both grounded in the fantasy of the morphologically normative body, are on clear display in *DSM-III*, which identifies sexual arousal as a dimension of “gender role” (APA 1980, 261) and divides the category of “transsexualism” into four “subtypes” based on “prior sexual history” (“asexual,” “homosexual,” heterosexual,” and “unspecified”) (APA 1980, 262). The diagnostic criteria for GID in *DSM-IV* remains, fundamentally, about “wrong” bodies, about bodies that depart from normative standards, both in terms of individual morphology and of bodies that are out of place socially, transgressing normatively gendered behaviors. The result is a definition of gender-variant identity as inherently pathological (Vance et al., 2010).

In affirming the expression of variant gender identities, in emphasizing transition and recognizing that successful transition may obviate the need for any clinical diagnosis,²⁷ in expanding conceptions of gender identity beyond a male/female binary, and in removing specifications of sexual attraction from the diagnosis (Zucker et al. 2013, 907), current diagnostic standards and treatment practices mark a clear recognition that there is no “normal” gender embodiment, particularly when compared to previous editions of the *DSM*.²⁸ The changes to *DSM-V* are particularly noteworthy insofar as they reflect acceptance of the critique that the diagnoses of GID and GIDC in *DSM-III* and *DSM-IV* inappropriately focused on behaviors rather than identity (Bryant 2006, 24). As critics argued, the research and clinical work supporting the diagnoses “mistakenly recast a broad *social problem* in terms of individual pathology” (Bryant 2006, 29; emphasis added). These critics, then, explicitly highlight the mistake in understanding gendered embodiment and identity as matters of individual psychology and experience, rather than as fundamentally social phenomena.

Following on these considerations, we can see that if TGNC bodies have no proper place within the social due to their non-normativity, this is an issue about society, not TGNC individuals. Insofar as appeals to “natural” embodiment as normative are fantastical in nature, they express an active process of social normalization (Butler 2004, 41). Judgments about normative embodiment and the experience of dysphoria attached to non-normative embodiment are social in nature and cannot be reduced to issues of individual psychology. Viewed from within this frame, we can see that the changed diagnosis of gender dysphoria in *DSM-V* registers what Žižek (1989) describes as the “traversal” of the fantasy of morphologically normative embodiment, the “experience that there is nothing ‘behind’ it, and how fantasy masks precisely this ‘nothing’” (126).

This traversal, accomplished in the encounter with bodies that have no social place, is also vividly illustrated in the 2018 film *A Kid Like Jake*, directed by Silas Howard and based on Daniel Pearle's 2013 play of the same name (Pearle wrote the screenplay for the film version) (Pearle 2014). The film presents a number of issues arising from four-year-old Jake's "gender expansive" (so described by Judy, played in the film by Octavia Spencer) expression: the expression's changing dynamic as it becomes more publicly visible, the dilemma confronting Jake's parents about whether or not to leverage Jake's gender expression to help gain access to an elite preschool, the limits of their own acceptance of same-sex attraction, and so on. For our purposes, the film's most illuminating feature is that Jake rarely appears on screen and is seldom a scene's focus; indeed, in Pearle's play, Jake never appears on stage. At least one reviewer takes issue with the approach, suggesting that while such a "gimmick" is fitting for stage, the more "realistic" presentation of the film renders the decision not to focus on Jake the wrong "authorial choice" (Lapin 2018). Howard, who identifies as a trans man, however, acknowledges that the decision not to focus on Jake was initially counterintuitive, but explains the decision as "political," providing "a way for the audience to decide what Jake was or wasn't, to more show ... just how the societal pressure starts to take shape ..." (Howard 2018).

Jake's on-screen absence is more productive than Howard's critic allows. With Jake's absence, the film enacts the traversal of the fantasy of the normatively gendered body. Jake's absence vividly illustrates that Jake *has no place* within the social, thereby highlighting the disruption a TGNC body exercises on a social space constitutively structured around the natural attitude of normatively gendered bodies. And, as Howard's description of the decision not to place Jake in more scenes suggests, Jake's absence highlights just how little Jake's belonging within the social has to do with their own identity or volition. That is, Jake's lack of place, the lack of place for a TGNC individual whose embodiment is perceived as abnormal, *is not about Jake at all*. It is not Jake or Jake's non-normative embodiment that excludes them from social space; rather, it is a society constituted around the natural attitude toward embodiment, around the fantasy of the morphologically normative body. But, the recognition (by both the audience and Jake's parents) that this child who has no social place is also, simultaneously, their parents' child, reveals the missing fullness at the heart of the social itself. That is, it reveals that Jake's lack of place is not due to a missing dimension of Jake's embodiment, but to the fantastical fullness of normative embodiment that renders Jake socially impossible. In revealing the impossibility of Jake's place within the social, Jake reveals the social's fundamental incompleteness, thereby highlighting the fantastical nature of the normative body necessary for the full constitution of the social. And, in revealing the morphologically normative body's fantastical nature, Jake reveals embodiment's fundamental queerness.

The morphologically normative body, and the dysphoria that non-normative embodiment can engender, are both fundamentally social, rather than individual,

phenomena. The morphologically normative body is an object of fantasy, and dysphoria represents a visceral, affective effort to maintain that fantasy and to resist its traversal in the recognition of embodiment's inherent queerness. Insofar as the social-as-body metaphor transposes the fantastical understanding of individual bodies to the level of the social, we find the same fundamental dynamics at work. As we have seen, the social-as-body metaphor expresses a disposition to proper, hierarchical social and political order, to "concord" or *tranquilitas*, a disposition directed by the fantasy of the social body's normative morphology. When the social body's members are out of place, no longer playing their proper social role, the social body is transmogrified, revealing its queer and fluid morphology, threatening to reveal the morphologically normative social body's fantastical nature. Just as flesh-and-blood queer bodies provoke dysphoric social reactions, the emergent visibility of the queer social body provokes deep-seated, visceral, non-rational socially and politically dysphoric reactions aimed at preserving the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body, denying its fundamental queerness. Dysphoric responses to individual queer bodies and to the queer social body both express the same fantastical desire for morphologically normative embodiment.

Toward the Social Body's Unbecoming

The dispositions expressed in the social-as-body metaphor not only structure the social but are themselves structured by social conceptions of embodiment. In its structuring role, the social-as-body metaphor has been structured by the natural attitude of embodiment, according to which embodiment is a matter of normative morphology maintained through the assurance that the body's members remain in their proper places. Our consideration of TGNC bodies has revealed the morphologically normative body's fantastical nature underlying the natural attitude of embodiment. Such bodies reveal that there is no morphologically normative, proper body, that all bodies "trans" or cross morphological boundaries, all bodies are transmogrifications, that all bodies are fundamentally improper or queer. TGNC bodies therefore bring about a queering effect on embodiment by revealing embodiment's fundamental queerness. Appeal to the morphologically normative body is fantastical in precisely the sense that it seeks to mask or occlude this fundamental queerness. Given that social conceptions of embodiment structure the social-as-body metaphor, then, the fantastical nature of morphologically normative embodiment at the level of flesh-and-blood, material bodies reveals the shared political fantasy of the morphologically normative social body driving the social-as-body metaphor.

What becomes of the social-as-body metaphor in view of such considerations? We have seen that the metaphor has fundamentally structured Western thinking about the social for millennia and have suggested that it remains operative, the "fundamental ideological fantasy" (Žižek 1989, 126), at the

visceral, dispositional level up to the present (a point to be demonstrated in chapters to come). In suggesting that the social-as-body metaphor is fantastical, then, what is being claimed? As we seek to traverse the political fantasy, what is being set aside? I want to suggest that the metaphor's fantastical dimension lies not in the conception of the social as a body, but in the understanding of that body as morphologically normative, maintaining its proper shape only by ensuring that all its members remain their proper places within it. The revelation of the morphologically normative body's fantastical dimension, of embodiment's fundamental queerness, does not do away with the social-as-body metaphor (I am not sure this is possible); rather it queers or transmogrifies it. As Sullivan (2006) has suggested, "the trope of monstrous (un)becoming" (560) highlighted in reflections on TGNC embodiment can, rather than being resisted, serve as a constructive conceptual resource. Deployed as a political-theoretical resource, it allows for a counter-articulation of the social-as-body metaphor on an alternative dispositional register, one in which the social, as a body, consonant with flesh-and-blood bodies, is not morphologically fixed, but morphologically shifting and fluid. Far from finding "natural" expression in a morphologically fixed form, the social body is defined by ongoing practices of (un)becoming. "Thinking with trans" (see Brubaker 2016, 71) allows us to imagine the social as a different kind of body from that which has consistently been presupposed within the social-as-body metaphor.

The social-as-body metaphor, structured by the imagined morphologically normative body, has consistently expressed social and political dispositions to proper order, invariably giving rise to inegalitarian, hierarchical, and rigid social forms. Allowing the recognition of embodiment's fundamental queerness to inform the social-as-body metaphor, by way of contrast, facilitates the expression of alternative social and political dispositions. It allows for the imagination of the social as a queer or transmogrified body, bringing about what Butler (2004) calls the "divestiture" (48) of normative morphology with regard to the social. It allows for the expression of social and political desires for something other than order, concord, or *tranquilitas*. Specifically, as we will see in the following chapter, it allows for the expression of what we will call queer democracy, for dissensual political practice that productively unmakes the social body to disseminate liberty and equality to increasingly broad segments of the social. In contrast to dysphoric social and political responses to the queer social body's manifestations, queer democracy embraces that queerness and its constant (un)becoming to advance the inclusion of diverse and novel groups and individuals within the democratic people (Gr. *demos*). If efforts to counter the social body's queerness, to keep its morphology safely under wraps through the imposition of proper, hierarchical order, constitute dysphoric responses to the queer or transmogrified social body, queer democracy represents a euphoric embrace of that same queerness.

Notes

- 1 I do not mean to imply that the application of the body metaphor as a means of understanding or structuring the social has been limited to Western traditions of social and political thought. To explore cross-cultural conceptions of the social-as-body metaphor simply exceeds both my competence and the scope of this study, which focuses primarily on contemporary American politics.
- 2 “Non-rational” is not, here, equivalent to “irrational.” Dysphoria and dysphoric responses are explicable and operate according to a determinate logic, and so are not irrational. But they operate a visceral, affective register that is other than that of discursive reason, and so are non-rational.
- 3 The medieval period is marked, of course, by debates and contests of power concerning which of these loci is ultimately sovereign. But appeal to sovereignty, and the idea that it must be situated in a particular individual, is a common presumption in these debates (for a good, concise discussion of these debates, see Kilcullen 2014, 339–341). Regardless of where one stood on this issue, the fundamental maxim adumbrated by Chroust held true: “The body politic, like the body animal, always needed a *primum principium et movens*, for otherwise the organism would either fall apart or become completely paralyzed” (Chroust 1947, 447).
- 4 One effect of the emphasis that the parts were constitutive of the social whole is that the will of the sovereign ruler was never absolute, even in earlier periods, but normatively constrained (Burns 1988, 454–464; Canning 1996, 162–167) and that the social body’s “members” were recognized as having rights and social value (Chroust 1947, 444, 450; Lewis 1954, 195). In addition to the discussion here, we will also have occasion to consider evolving understandings of sovereignty in greater detail in Chapter 3.
- 5 This nonintervention norm was first articulated in decidedly religious terms, under the principle *cuius regio, eius religio*, “the ruler determines the religion of his realm.” External sovereignty was such that states would not interfere with one another on the basis of religious belief, effectively establishing the principle of religious pluralism between states (Thomas 2005, 55; Philpott 2001, 81). It is important to clarify that religious pluralism in this context does not signify a recognition of religious pluralism *within* the states in question. What emerged following the Westphalian settlement was a system of confessional states, not religiously diverse liberal pluralist states in a contemporary sense. Over time, the principle of non-intervention expanded beyond concerns related to religious affiliation.
- 6 As Philpott (2001) suggests, these shifts produced significant real-world political effects, insofar as Protestant polities most enthusiastically embraced the imposition of secular sovereignty to assert social order, a pattern which was later “internationalized” in the emerging European system of states (143–144).
- 7 Richard Jenkins situates Bourdieu’s theory as a response to the “‘structure-action’ problem,” which he describes as “perhaps the most persistent issue in social theory” (Jenkins 2014, 48).
- 8 While Steinbock’s focus is not Bourdieu, but the development of what he terms “generative phenomenology,” his phenomenological account is marked by a great deal of continuity with Bourdieu’s theory of *habitus*. While space does not permit a fuller development of this point here, I hope to explore the relation of their thought more fully in the future. For Steinbock’s fullest account of generative phenomenology, see Steinbock 1995; for my own application of generative phenomenology to political theory and social ontology, see Miller 2016.
- 9 I have developed this point elsewhere, drawing on the generative phenomenological concept of the “homeworld.” See Miller 2016, 165–177.
- 10 While Bourdieu eschews appeal to the concept of “habit” understood as “a mechanistic assembly or preformed program” (Bourdieu 1977, 218n47), his description of

- dispositions as “habitual states” does demonstrate the proximity of the concept to that of habit (Swartz 1998, 115).
- 11 I owe my understanding of this notion of conditioned conditions of possibility to the related ideas of Jacques Derrida’s “quasi-transcendentals” and Ernesto Laclau’s “weak transcendentalism” (which is itself dependent on Derrida’s notion). For Laclau’s development of “weak transcendentalism,” see Laclau 2002, 386 and Butler and Laclau 2004, 342. For his part, Derrida does not develop the theme of quasi-transcendentalism systematically. Rather, he develops the theme of transcendental conditions of possibility that are themselves historically or empirically conditioned in a number of his signature themes and concepts. The particular theme I have found most helpful is that of iterability, or non-identical repetition. For Derrida’s most sustained treatments of this topic, see Derrida 1973, 1988a, 1988b, 1988c.
 - 12 Other thinkers I have found particularly useful for thinking through issues of embodiment include Mazis 2002 and 2008; , Haraway 2006; Boesl and Keller 2009; Alaimo 2010; Bennett 2010; Coole and Frost 2010; and Frost 2016.
 - 13 I use “trans and gender nonconforming” as an umbrella term intended to encompass multiple identities and forms of embodiment. My uses of “transgender” and “trans” should be understood in the same way. The term “trans*” (pronounced “trans star”) is often used to signal an awareness of the diversity of TGNC communities. I have opted not to use this term simply to avoid confusion, since the texts I cite typically do not use it. For a useful discussion of issues of nomenclature and definition, see Simmons and White 2014.
 - 14 In contemporary usage, “sex” and “gender” are analytically separable. “Sex” generally refers to the sex assigned to an individual at birth, and typically refers to biological, genetic, and physiological characteristics. “Gender,” on the other hand, relates to the social roles and behaviors adopted by individuals, usually in conformity with cultural conceptions of masculinity and femininity. Sex has traditionally been understood to determine gender, while gender expression has traditionally been understood to reveal something about “biological sex.” This is reflected in the assignment of a gender to infants based on sex characteristics. While trans theory, as well as current medical and mental health practice, recognize the gender identity may not align with assigned sex, what Bettcher calls the “natural attitude” presupposes their identity, which is why she deploys the terms “sex” and “gender” as she does.
 - 15 While the presumption that gender is normatively tied to bodily “sex” is socially prevalent, Bettcher’s points highlight that the linkage between sex and gender has fundamentally to do with body morphology, rather than karyotype or hormone levels (Bettcher 2009, 106). This is why, for example, the assignment of gender at birth is usually undertaken on the basis of visible morphological characteristics. Numerous authors highlight the difficulties that arise in attempting to ground a dimorphic conception of gender in biological sex. See, for example, Fausto-Sterling 2000 and Warnke 2009, 28–31.
 - 16 There is, of course, no single “TGNC body,” and no single way that such bodies are socially situated. In his discussion of TGNC identity, Brubaker (2016) highlights three social models: the “trans of migration,” which involves the aim of modifying the body in such a way as to fully transition to one or another binary gender identity, the “trans of between,” which involves an androgynous identity that finds its place in neither of the binary gender identities, and the “trans of beyond,” which involves “positioning oneself in a space that is *not* defined with reference to established categories” (72–73). For additional discussion, see Richard Ekins and Dave King’s (2006) discussion of the “transcending” conception of TGNC identity (181–220). At first glance, it might seem that the TGNC bodies in view above would only be those occupying the latter two positions noted by Brubaker; “stealth” TGNC bodies or TGNC bodies that “pass” as either male or female would seemingly not disrupt the dimorphic gender imaginary.

Yet this would be a simplistic response. Within the dimorphic, transphobic social imaginary, there is no greater threat than TGNC bodies, particularly the bodies of trans women, that *can* pass as morphologically normative. Such bodies represent a material disconfirmation of both dimorphic conceptions of gender, and traditional patterns of gender hierarchy (see Serano 2016b, 15–20). As Heath Fogg Davis (2017) suggests, *all* TGNC experience challenges the fundamental logic of “sex immutability,” thereby threatening a transphobic social imaginary (63). Judith Halberstam (2004) further reinforces the point I am making here in her excellent analysis of the 1999 film *Boys Don’t Cry* (based on the true story of Brandon Teena). As she suggests, within the film the character Brandon Teena poses an excessive threat precisely *because* he “passes” as male, even to the point of performing sexually, while “outside” the film, the film experienced success with audiences because Teena was able to play an effective masculine role. On both levels, the ability of a TGNC body to pass, its indiscernibility from supposedly “real” male bodies, is the source of threat (see 83–92).

- 17 This reality is well illustrated in TGNC individuals’ common experience of being asked, often by total strangers, whether or not they have had “the surgery,” by which is meant, of course, “bottom” or genital reassignment surgery (Bettcher 2009, 106).
- 18 Žižek’s primary contribution here and in the discussion that follows is his account of political fantasy, which he develops early in his career; I have mixed feelings, at best, regarding his subsequent works. In addition to Žižek 1989, 1994 and 1996 are valuable resources for his theory of political fantasy. For an account of concerns about the overall quality of Žižek’s work with which I very much agree, see Gilbert 2007. While I also have reservations about Lacanian psychoanalytic theory’s scope and range of application, I have found Žižek’s Lacanian approach extremely illuminating as a means of understanding the idea of the social body.
- 19 The consistency of this point with the Bourdieu’s account of *habitus* and the phenomenological account of political subjectivity I have developed elsewhere (see Miller 2016) further highlights the possibility of employing Žižek’s account of fantasy without committing to his Lacanian approach in its entirety.
- 20 The *objet petit a* is the “object small *a*,” where the “*a*” is the first letter of the French *autre*, or “other.” The object “small other” corresponds to the “big Other,” which is the symbolic order. The idea is that the “big Other” is that which influences our subjectivation but, due to its inherent incompleteness, also forecloses on the full accomplishment of that subjectivation. The object of desire becomes the “small other” that stands in, as it were, for the constitutive incompleteness of the “big Other.”
- 21 The diagnosis of GID first appeared in the third edition of the *DSM* (*DSM-III*) (APA 1980, 261–266) and was included in the fourth edition (*DSM-IV*) (APA 1994, 532–538) and fourth edition text revision (*DSM-IV-TR*) (APA 2000, 576–582).
- 22 There was a great deal of controversy surrounding updates to the diagnosis of Gender Identity Disorder in the *DSM-V*, with numerous calls for its elimination or reform (Bryant 2006, 23 highlights several sources for these). The APA Gender Identity Disorders sub-work group, tasked with examining the diagnosis and recommending changes for *DSM-V*, conducted an international survey of advocacy, community, and professional groups supportive of TGNC rights, and found that a majority believed the diagnosis of GID should be removed entirely from the updated version of the *DSM* (Vance et al. 2010, 5). Among those arguing for the inclusion of the diagnosis, the primary reasons given included the assurance of health care reimbursement, legal advocacy, and broadening social acceptance of TGNC individuals (5–6). As the authors of the survey note, “a persistent theme in the short answers both for and against the inclusion of GID in the *DSM-V* was the necessity of changing the criteria and language of the diagnosis if it is to remain in the manual” (7). A majority of respondents held the opinion that aspects of the GID diagnosis were ultimately harmful to TGNC individuals (10).

- 23 I use the term “transition” broadly, to refer to a process of active identity affirmation. As the WPATH *Standards of Care* (2012) notes, not all TGNC individuals experience such affirmation in terms of “transition,” “because they never fully embraced the gender role they were assigned at birth or because they actualize their gender identity, role, and expression in a way that does not involve a change from one gender role to another” (9).
- 24 Discussion of transition as it relates to gender dysphoric youth requires a comment on the controversy surrounding Kenneth Zucker. While Zucker chaired the Gender Disorders Work Group in the run-up to the publication of the *DSM-V*, served as editor of *Archives of Sexual Behavior* (a position he continues to hold), helped write the “standards of care” guidelines for the World Professional Association for Transgender Health, and led Toronto’s Child Youth and Family Gender Identity Clinic (GIC), affiliated with the Centre for Addiction and Mental Health (CAMH), for decades (Singal 2016), he has also become a hugely polarizing and controversial figure in recent years. Zucker and the clinic had faced criticism that they practiced a form of conversion therapy related to gender identity in young children and youth, leading to an external review of their practices in 2015 (see Hayes 2018; Canadian Press 2018). The review found that the clinic “focused on intensive assessment and treatment, despite current practice favoring ‘watchful waiting,’ and the education and support of parents in accepting their child’s gender expression” (Hayes 2018). In other words, Zucker and the clinic did not adopt the increasingly common “gender-affirmative” approach which “focuses on identifying young transgender children and helping them socially transition,” instead adopting the position that “in many cases, it was preferable to first ‘help children feel comfortable in their own bodies,’” in the belief that “gender dysphoria will likely resolve itself with time” (Singal 2016). Zucker, who was not consulted in the external review (Hayes 2018), acknowledges that “the clinic actively tried to encourage young patients to accept their biological sex in a bid to ‘reduce a child’s gender dysphoria,’” but vociferously denies the equation of such a practice with conversion therapy (the independent reviewers stated that they were unable to ascertain whether the clinic’s practices amounted to conversion therapy) (Canadian Press 2018; Hayes 2018). He was fired the same day the report was released and publicly posted on the CAMH website, and the GIC was shut down permanently (Singal 2016; Hayes 2018). Zucker’s firing was hugely controversial. While many activists in the transgender community, including Rainbow Health Ontario, celebrated the move, more than 500 clinicians and researchers signed a petition in his defense (Hayes 2018). To add to the controversy and confusion, Zucker later entered into a non-confidential settlement with CAMH, receiving an apology for his firing, stating that “the review was intended to identify best practices and how to best serve children and adolescents with gender dysphoria—not to examine the behavior and practices of Dr. Zucker,” and also paying Zucker \$500,000 (Hayes 2018). While Zucker, who continues to maintain a private practice, has touted the settlement as vindication, CAMH still stands by its decision to close down the clinic, affirming the belief that a “modernizing approach to delivering services to youth better supports diverse patients through best practice and timely care” (Hayes 2018).

It should be clear from my support for gender identity transition and the discussion that follows that I firmly support a “gender-affirmative” approach to helping children and youth with gender dysphoria, and hold that such an approach is, in fact, more consistent with the publications published by Zucker and others cited in this chapter. I agree with trans activist Julia Serano’s (2016a) position that the more conservative approach of Zucker and the clinic reflect adherence to an increasingly discredited account of “desistence” as it relates to gender dysphoria in children and youth (see Tannehill 2017). In citing publications authored by Zucker, then, I emphatically do not endorse his apparent preferences for the clinical treatment of gender dysphoria in children and youth.

- 25 *DSM-III* and *DSM-IV* presuppose a male/female gender binary, so that gender non-conforming behaviors are, by definition, “cross-gender” in nature.
- 26 While I find this line of reasoning persuasive, Zucker and Spitzer 2005 and Bryant 2006 argue that this explanation for the inclusion of GID and GIDC in *DSM-III* is reductive.
- 27 Despite this, because insurers may not cover hormone treatments, mental health care, or medical procedures in the absence of a gender dysphoria diagnosis, the clinical diagnosis is often maintained in practice.
- 28 While I stand by this interpretation, this should not give too sanguine an impression regarding contemporary clinical practice. There are still numerous mental health professionals and health care providers that are ignorant of, or actively resist abiding by, the contemporary diagnostic criteria for gender dysphoria and standards of care of TGNC individuals.

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2

TRAVERSING THE FANTASY

Queer Democracy

Introduction

One might be excused for suggesting that the social-as-body metaphor is of historical interest, with little contemporary relevance for political theory. As noted in the previous chapter, Valerio Fabbrizi (2018) argues that the emergence of the modern constitutional state following the French Revolution marks the end appeals to the society-as-body metaphor (16–17). Thus, “the Hobbesian theory of absolute sovereignty is overturned by the liberal theory of democratic representative sovereignty, according to which laws are the product of a majoritarian and democratic legislative vote” (17). He concludes his reflections by insinuating a fundamental opposition to the concept of the body politic, writing: “the idea of the body politic should now be replaced by the idea of a constitutional rule of law,” according to which “constitutions become the product of the deliberation of a constituent assembly, representing the will of people, aimed at delimiting the controlling the sovereign power” (17).

As Fabbrizi’s reflections suggest, the question that imposes itself at this point is the degree to which the social-as-body metaphor continues to hold with the emergence of modern democratic forms (we will consider the question of Hobbes, together with Locke and Rousseau, in the next chapter). Claude Lefort’s (1988) well-known reflections on the “democratic revolution” highlight this issue. Lefort’s theoretical program pivots around the significance of the overturning of the Ancien Régime, an event which is not, in his view, merely structural or institutional, but represents “a mutation of the symbolic order” itself (16).¹ The Ancien Régime, as he outlines it, is structured around the contours of the social-as-body metaphor we have been considering. Thus, he suggests, under such a regime, “power was embodied in the person of the prince,” who served as

the ultimate guarantor of the unity of the social order (17). While this need not imply that the prince held unlimited power (such conceptions of power had already been widely challenged by the end of the medieval period) (Burns 1988, 470; Wierda 1997, 32; Coleman 2011, 188–189), the prince did serve the role of “mediator between mortals and gods or, as political activity became secularized and laicized, between mortals and the transcendental agencies represented by a sovereign Justice and a sovereign Reason” (Lefort 1988, 17). Insofar as power was embodied in the prince, then, “it ... gave society a body” such that, as we have seen already, “the hierarchy of its members, the distinction between ranks and orders appeared to rest upon an unconditional basis” (17). In keeping with the well-instituted operation of the social-as-body metaphor, the prince was the social body’s head, directing it, ordering it, and maintaining its normative morphology.

The democratic revolution represents a fundamental shift from this understanding. Lefort (1988) develops this point in his well-known conception of the “empty place of power” structuring democracy (17). On this formulation, democracy marks a form of “disincorporation” (17) by which “democratic society is instituted as a *society without a body*, as a society which undermines the representation of an organic totality” (18, emphasis added). In contrast to the fixed, hierarchical structure implicit in the traditional society-as-body metaphor, democracy represents a society “which, in its very form, welcomes and preserves indeterminacy ...” (16). For Lefort, democracy names a reality that cannot be “reduced to a system of institutions” (14).

Fabrizzi and Lefort’s reflections give the impression that the social-as-body metaphor no longer provides a useful resource for thinking the nature of the political in relation to contemporary discussions of democracy. Yet this is only true if we understand the metaphor in explicit, discursive terms. That is, it is correct to say that it is now rare to find reflections on democratic and political practice that explicitly invoke the social-as-body metaphor. Understood in these terms, Martin (1999) is correct in noting that the identification of the social with a body is merely metaphorical (15).

The situation is very different, however, if we understand the social-as-body metaphor to be dispositional in nature, as outlined in the previous chapter. As I suggested there, the social-as-body metaphor expresses a disposition to proper order, structuring social perceptions, affects, and practices toward the maintenance of the morphologically normative social body. Recalling Bourdieu’s (1977) designation of a disposition as “a way of being, a habitual state ... and, in particular, a predisposition, tendency, propensity, or inclination” (Bourdieu 1977, 214n1), it will become clear that the social-as-body metaphor still captures the dispositions structuring our contemporary democratic system. Confronted with the social body’s fundamental queerness and its constant morphological “(un)becoming” (Sullivan 2006, 560), contemporary democratic institutions and practices, despite their nominal concern for the rule (Gr. *kratos*) of the people (Gr. *demos*), too often represent dysphoric mechanisms for reigning in unruly members of the social body.²

By way of contrast, I present an alternative political ontology, a divergent imagining of the social body that embraces its queer, morphological fluidity. This political ontology finds expression in another democratic articulation, “queer democracy,” which takes shape in dissensual social and political practices that mark the productive unmaking of the existing social body with the aim of extending the democratic principles of liberty and equality to new social domains. In this way, queer democracy embraces the *demos*’s constitutive incompleteness and its ongoing, novel expansion.

The Normative Social Body and Contemporary Democracy

Neoliberalism and Managed Democracy

Thinking in terms of Robert Dahl’s (1989) distinction between “substantive” and procedural/institutional conceptions of democracy (116, 163), Lefort’s conception of democracy as a social-ontological revolution clearly represents a substantive conception. Despite this, he is not naïve about democracy’s prospects. On the contrary, he postulates an intimate relation between democracy, structured around the empty place of power, and totalitarianism. Totalitarianism, democracy’s other, constantly haunts democracy, always lurking nearby as an unseen danger. Thus, in response to the indeterminacies of a democratic social structuring,

we see the development of the fantasy of the People-As-One, the beginnings of a quest for a substantial identity, for a social body which is welded to its head, for an embodying power, for a state free from division.

(Lefort 1988, 20, 1986, 305)

Totalitarianism is driven by the fantasy (in Žižek’s sense) of the “People-as-One,” embodied in “the omniscient, omnipotent, benevolent other, the militant, the leader, the Egocrat” (Lefort 1986, 300).³

Another reason for democracy’s proximity to social forms and practices that would undermine it, at the more concrete level of contemporary practice and political theory, is that *democracy* is itself a slippery term. As Wendy Brown (2015) notes,

in the popular imaginary, “democracy” stands for everything from free elections to free markets, from protests against dictators to law and order, from the centrality of rights to the stability of states, from the voice of the assembled multitude to the protection of individuality and the wrong of dicta imposed by crowds.

(19)

This popular imaginary includes most democratic political theory, within which the virtual reduction of democracy to a formal imposition of majority rule

decided by elections is so common as to be almost taken for granted. For example, David Held (2006) points out that such a view runs “from Plato to Schumpeter,” and highlights Friedrich Hayek as a particularly noteworthy illustration (203; see Hayek 1960, 1976), while Ricardo Blaug and John Schwarzmantel (2001), in the Introduction to their anthology of democratic theory, highlight the widespread sense in which democracy is understood in these terms (14).

Understood in such decidedly procedural/institutional terms, democracy is subject to its own further transformation, which Sheldon Wolin (2008) has examined under the rubric of “inverted totalitarianism,” which is not derived from classical totalitarianism (xxi). In contrast to the classical totalitarianism theorized by Lefort, inverted totalitarianism is not contemporary liberal democracy’s other; rather, it is its defining form. And while inverted totalitarianism also differs from classical totalitarianism in that the social-as-body metaphor is not explicitly articulated, we shall see that it continues to operate at the dispositional level, so that the “managed democracy” that emerges represents a dysphoric response aimed at regulating the *demos*, thereby ensuring the social body’s proper order and normative morphology.

Wolin (2008) argues that capitalism is inverted totalitarianism’s “reigning ideology” (47). Thus, it “gains its dynamic by combining with other forms of power ... and most notably by encouraging a symbiotic relationship between traditional government and the system of ‘private’ governance represented by the modern business corporation” (xxi). Recognizing that the modern corporation “marked the emergence of private power on a scale and in numbers hitherto unknown, the concentration of private power unconnected to a citizen body,” then, Wolin argues that inverted totalitarianism represents “the coming-of-age of corporate power” (xxi-xxii).

Wolin here highlights the corporatization or marketization at the heart of contemporary liberal democratic regimes, which represents a fundamental shift in social ontology as profound and far-reaching as that outlined by Lefort. Brown (2015) develops these points in great detail in her examination of neoliberalism’s influence on contemporary democratic regimes.⁴ If capitalism is inverted totalitarianism’s reigning ideology, neoliberalism is the reigning ideology within contemporary capitalism itself, representing “the rationality through which capitalism finally swallows humanity” (44). As she argues, while neoliberalism “is most commonly understood as enacting an ensemble of economic policies in accord with its root principle of affirming free markets” (28), it is more than a theory of markets or capitalism. Rather, neoliberalism represents “a peculiar form of reason that configures *all aspects* of existence in economic terms” (17, emphasis added). Neoliberalism therefore operates as an “order of normative reason” (30) structuring the social, extending the marked model “to all domains and activities—even where money is not an issue—and configure[ing] human beings exhaustively as market actors, only and everywhere as *homo oeconomicus*” (31). The social-ontological implications of this formulation cannot be overstated: “within neoliberal rationality, human capital

is our 'is' and our 'ought' ... *all* domains are markets, and we are everywhere presumed to be market actors" (36, emphasis added). To constitute human beings a *homo oeconomicus* is to universally reduce the aim of life to "enhancing portfolio value in all domains" (33). As she sums up the issue, "the normative reign of *homo oeconomicus* in every sphere means that there are no motivations, drives, or aspirations apart from economic ones, that there is nothing to being human apart from 'mere life'" (44). This universal marketization has profound implications for the state and democratic politics. Economic growth becomes government's sole end and legitimation, with the effect that "democratic state commitments to equality, liberty, inclusion, and constitutionalism are now subordinate to the project of economic growth, competitive positioning, and capital enhancement" (26). Echoing Wolin's points regarding state-corporation symbiosis, "the state's table of purposes and priorities has become indistinguishable from that of modern firms ..." (27).

The implications and transformations of political practice following from this are thoroughgoing. "*Homo oeconomicus* approaches everything as a market and knows only market conduct; it cannot think public purposes or common problems in a distinctly political way," with the effect that "the very idea of a people, a demos asserting its collective political sovereignty" disappears (Brown 2015, 39). Neoliberalism is therefore fundamentally anti-democratic, insofar as it "generates a condition of politics absent democratic institutions that would support a democratic public and all that such a public represents at its best" (39). Concerns for justice dissipate, such that "the guarantee of equality through the rule of law and participation in popular sovereignty is replaced with a market formulation of winners and losers," so that "liberty itself is narrowed to market conduct" (41). Neoliberalism transforms the entire terrain of the political, so that opponents exercising political power are figured as "the enemy" precisely insofar as it disrupts the extension of the economic to all social and political domains. "This open hostility to the political in turn curtails the promise of the modern liberal democratic state to ensure inclusion, equality, and freedom as dimensions of popular sovereignty" (42).

Neoliberalism is inverted totalitarianism's ideology, while Wolin's "managed democracy" is the effect of the neoliberalization Brown analyzes. Wolin's (2008) discussion of the processes underlying managed democracy fleshes out Brown's discussion in concrete, practical terms. As suggested a moment ago, society's neoliberal transformation is fundamentally anti-democratic in nature. What marks this as an "inversion," in Wolin's sense, is precisely that these anti-democratic tendencies are produced within a system that claims to be democratic (46). Indeed, inverted totalitarianism "trumpets democracy worldwide." What it advances as managed democracy, however, is a form of democracy "centered on containing electoral politics: it is cool, even hostile toward social democracy beyond promoting literacy, job training, and other essentials for a society struggling to survive in the global economy. Managed democracy is democracy

systematized.” Managed democracy therefore names a complex technology for managing democracy without appearing to suppress it (47).

Echoing Brown, Wolin (2008) notes that democracy’s management is attained through the marginalization of the citizenry, which is an effect of social corporatizing and marketizing (131). As consumers and human capital, citizens are redefined as “respondents rather than actors, as objects of manipulation rather than as autonomous” (132). On a neoliberal logic, then, “the political has been managerialized,” so that “politics and elections as well as the operation of governmental departments and agencies now are routinely considered a managerial rather than a political skill” (135). This managerialization yields the anti-democratic consequence of excluding the public “from a deliberative role in each and all of the major preserves of modern power” (134).

The state-corporation union is such that the state’s regulatory function diminishes while the “private” sector increasingly takes on roles traditionally assigned to the state, so that “‘privatization’ becomes normal and state action in defiance of corporate wishes is an aberration” (Wolin 2008, 136). This privatization is central to democracy’s management, insofar as it diminishes the scope for political and democratic participation (136). In line with Brown’s analysis, Wolin highlights an “antipolitical culture of competition” that takes root, such that any concern with “the care of common arrangements, of practices in which, potentially, all could share in deciding the uses of power while bearing responsibility for their consequences” dissipates (138).

Operating in line with neoliberalism as a social logic, managed democracy “is the application of managerial skills to the basic democratic political institutions of popular elections” (Wolin 2008, 140), so that any substantive conception of democratic practices is hollowed out and replaced with empty institutions and procedures. Neoliberalism thereby disseminates a culture “that taught consumers to welcome change and private pleasures while accepting political passivity” (xxiii). Within this structure, popular elections, far from representing democratic life’s *sine qua non*, operate as the means of its management. Thus, “the citizenry is reduced to an electorate,” such that what little political action is undertaken by citizens is limited to regularly scheduled elections which are, themselves, transformed into “complex productions” that “require constant supervision rather than continuing popular participation” (140). Managed democracy is therefore structured around “molding the support of citizens without allowing them to rule” (142), having replaced democratic participation with elections. By way of contrast, Wolin argues that a “truly democratic” polity would be one in which elections would be only one means of democratic legitimation (147–148).

Inverted totalitarianism “thrives on a politically demotivated society” because it enables the management of the “‘active’ electorate” (Wolin 2008, 64). This is on display with the popular will’s construction and manipulation in the opinion surveys around which contemporary elections take shape. Similar dynamics occur with the news media’s commercialization, which reduces political argument to

easy-to-digest, transient, consumer-friendly soundbites. The myriad effects of this include the reduction of political choice (Crouch 2004, 46–47) and the creation of a “semipermanent spectating class” consigned to observing the actions of pre-established political elites (Green 2009, 4). The overall effect

is to accentuate what separates citizens, to plant suspicions and thereby further promote demobilization by making it more difficult to form coherent majorities around common beliefs. At the same time, the dicing of the public into ever more refined categories renders their constituent members more easily manipulable: cheaply reproduced in “focus groups,” their conclusions are represented as political reality. The respondents, for their part, are not obligated to act on their opinions: giving an opinion entails no political responsibility.

(Wolin 2008, 59–60)

Such mechanisms reduce democracy or, better, the “democratic” options presented in elections, to a matter of branding (60). Those few candidates who will ever appear before voters represent carefully managed and selected brands, while the citizenry “lacks effective power to control or set the terms of actual elections, including the regulation of campaign finance, television ads, and debate formats” (149). Freedom itself is therefore marketized, representing only “comportment with a market instrumental rationality that radically constrains both choices and ambitions” (Brown 2015, 41). The effect is that “the identification of democracy largely with voting ... [runs] the risk that legitimization can become automatic, tantamount to a slippery slope ending in Tocqueville’s submissive citizenry” (Wolin 2008, 148).

Governmentality and the Neoliberal Social Body’s Normative Morphology

Inverted totalitarianism’s social structure, as neoliberal rationality’s political expression, seems to disrupt the social-as-body metaphor’s dispositional logic, as is evident in the contrast Wolin drawn between inverted and classical totalitarianism. He sums up classical totalitarianism in a manner consonant with Lefort’s formulation: “it is the attempt to realize an ideological, idealized conception of a society as a systematically ordered whole, where the ‘parts’ ... are premeditatedly, even forcibly if necessary, coordinated to support and further the purposes of the regime” (Wolin 2008, 46). In setting up the contrast between classical and inverted totalitarianism, then, Wolin seems to present inverted totalitarianism as having broken with the social-as-body metaphor and its presumption of the social body’s normative morphology.

Brown’s (2015) discussion of neoliberalism and governmentality sheds further light on these considerations. She begins with the concept of political rationality,

which she borrows from Michel Foucault, noting that, first and foremost, “political rationality does not originate from the state, although it circulates through the state, organizes it, and conditions its actions” (118). There is no question here, as in a classically totalitarian model, of a top-down imposition of order, of a “head” structuring the body for its support, nor is there a sense that this structuring is organized around an explicitly formulated or articulated political program. On the contrary, a political rationality “brings into being the subjects and orders that it may be seen only to organize or rule” (115). In other words, reigning political rationalities produce political subjects, including those who govern; as Wolin suggests, “the leader is not the architect of the system, but its product” (Wolin 2008, 44).

These complex dynamics fall under the nomenclature of “governmentality,” which represents the “primary administrative form” within neoliberal political rationality (Brown 2015, 122). As Brown summarizes the key points, “governance signifies a transformation from governing through hierarchically organized command and control—in corporations, states, and nonprofit agencies alike—to governing that is networked, integrated, cooperative, partnered, disseminated, and at least partly self-organized” (123). Governance therefore “signifies a specific mode of governing that is evacuated of agents and institutionalized in processes, norms, and practices” (124); echoing Wolin, she suggests that, within this political rationality, the political is reconfigured as “a field of management or administration” (127).

The social and political terrain of neoliberal rationality and its attendant governmentality would appear to be very different from that structured by the social-as-body metaphor. Certainly, explicit appeals to the properly ordered “body politic” do not figure prominently within the order of neoliberal managed democracy, particularly with the fading of classical political or democratic concerns highlighted by both Wolin and Brown. And the emphasis on non-hierarchical, dispersed, and decentralized forms seems to be at odds with emphases on social concord achieved through the maintenance of a properly ordered social body, itself maintained by ensuring that bodies take their proper places within the social. A closer consideration of neoliberalism’s operative “structuring structures” (Bourdieu 1990, 53), however, reveals how misleading such an impression is.

Once again recalling that the social-as-body metaphor operates on the dispositional register, rather than at the level of explicit discourse or formal reflection, it is instructive to remind ourselves that “disposition” designates “a way of being, a habitual state ... and, in particular, a predisposition, tendency, propensity, or inclination” (Bourdieu 1977, 214n1). In its structuring role, the social-as-body metaphor operates at the level of Connolly’s (1999) “visceral register” (3), predisposing those within the social to act and react in regulated ways. Crucially, this does not require a “master agent” enforcing the social’s body-constitution, but accounts for the regulated structuring of the social in the absence of any such agency. It thereby accounts for the fact, registered in both Wolin and Brown, that the individuals who emerge as the “head” within the structure of neoliberal managed democracy are themselves *effects* of that structure.

Brown's detailed analysis of neoliberal governmentality highlights the social-as-body metaphor's ongoing analytical utility and is therefore worth considering at some length. Neoliberal governmentality's structuring operation is such that the agents it shapes experience their own imposed configuration and their places within the social as normal or even optimal. A relatively stable and fixed social morphology gains normative operative force precisely insofar as neoliberal subjects are predisposed to *experience it* as simply given or, indeed, as an expression of their own socio-political desire. As Brown (2015) states the issue: "neoliberalism governs as sophisticated common sense" (35). Likewise, neoliberal subjects are predisposed to feel threatened, often at an existential level, and to react viscerally, when other socio-political subjects disrupt that "commonsense" social-morphological norm. The metaphor therefore continues to effectively communicate the structuring socio-political dynamics operative within neoliberal managed democracy at the dispositional level, regardless of a lack of explicit appeal to the concept of the social body. On the visceral, dispositional level, the social is still experienced as a morphologically normative social body, structured around members occupying their proper places, and playing their proper roles, within it.

Advanced capitalism's structuring effects provide the defining contours of the morphologically normative neoliberal social body. Reflecting her emphasis on the transformation of individuals into capital, Brown (2015) notes that "both persons and states are expected to comport themselves in ways that maximize their capital value in the present and enhance their future value" (22). Within this universalizing reduction to capital, she highlights several elements of neoliberal rationality that determine the social body's normative morphology. "First," she writes, "we are human capital not just for ourselves, but also for the firm, state, or postnational constellation of which we are members," with the effect that we, as human capital, are at "persistent risk of failure, redundancy and abandonment" (37). This vulnerability highlights the centrality of competitive positioning and value appreciation as defining features differentiating the order of *homo oeconomicus* from that of classical economics (33). Competition, rather than exchange, becomes the essence of the market, such that everything becomes a zero-sum game (36). The proper, normative role of members of the social body is to unquestioningly exist in this state, to experience it as normal, obvious, or even optimal. Neoliberal capitalist logic expresses no end or *telos* beyond its own continued instantiation. A crucial component of the neoliberal social body's normative morphology is therefore members' acceptance of their own social expendability as necessary for its overall health, "health" here representing nothing beyond neoliberalism's nihilistic repetition of capitalization.⁵ Second, and very much following from this, "inequality, not equality, is the medium and relation of competing capitals ... equality ceases to be our presumed natural relation with one another" (38). Inequality "becomes normative" and, following from this, "labor disappears as a category, as does its collective form, class, taking with it the analytic basis for alienation, exploitation, and association among laborers" (38).

According to neoliberal capitalism's zero-sum logic, there *must be* economic "losers" if there are to be "winners."

The normalizing of inequality and social stratifications is such that they are neither experienced nor avowed *as* stratifications (see Brown 2015, 129). As justice ceases to play a critical political role (40), such stratifications' morphologically normative force is evident in the fact that they cease to register as questions of justice, instead being experienced as "natural," and therefore normative, features of the social body itself. Reflecting the naturalization of its morphological normativity, the social body's structuring order is presented as apolitical or "postideological," so that any social or political contestation of that order is presented as unnecessarily antagonistic and "politicized" (see 130). This normalized morphology is such that any attempts to disrupt it or place it in question threaten it with "monstrous (un) becoming" (Sullivan 2006, 560), provoking dysphoric responses in an effort to maintain it.

Brown's (2015) discussion of "responsibilization" vividly illustrates these points. Referring to the "moral burdening" accruing to those instances of human capitalization at the low end of social, political, and economic stratification, "responsibilization signals a *regime* in which the singular human capacity for responsibility is deployed to constitute and govern subjects and through which their conduct is organized and measured, remaking and reorienting them for a neoliberal order" (132–133). Thus, the neoliberal devolution of centralized power combines with responsibilization to produce "an order in which the social *effects* of power—constructed and governed subjects—appear as morally burdened agents" (134). The neoliberal subject is thereby "doubly responsibilized":

it is expected to fend for itself (and blamed for its failure to thrive) *and* expected to act for the well-being of the economy [which is to say, the social body in its neoliberal form] ... Responsibilized individuals are required to provide for themselves in the context of powers and contingencies radically limiting their ability to do so.

(134)

The responsibilization process also takes on decidedly racial nuances. Theologian Miguel A. De La Torre (2019) captures this point perfectly when he describes lower- and middle-class Whites as "dreaming upward and blaming downward" (57). He highlights the fact that, when confronted with such issues as downward mobility, economic insecurity, wage stagnation, and so on, White Americans, "rather than focusing on the actual causes of their downward mobility ... redirect their wrath to those outside the realm of Whiteness" (52). Thus, while real wages have only increased for the wealthiest (White) Americans over the past 40 years, the White middle class "became some of the fiercest defenders of those profiting from their losses" (55). On this logic,

the failure for economic growth to occur in all strata of the population is not the fault of the top 1 percent; it is the fault of those who live outside of Whiteness. Blame—like manure—flows downhill. The reasons offered by Fox News for white financial stress and distress are those “illegals” taking our jobs and welfare queens living off public assistance.

(56)

Thus, “blaming downward offers a tangible reason for their predicament, as well as an object upon which to unleash their fury. Blaming downward explains financial failures while masking the institutionalized biases of the downwardly mobile middle classes” (87).

Responsibilization, whatever its form, serves to maintain the social body’s normative morphology. Individuals’ or groups’ contestation of their social position or of the neoliberal social structure’s normativity, placing them out of place within the social body, represents an impropriety that threatens to disfigure or transmogrify it. Such wayward members of the social body fail to take responsibility for themselves and, more crucially, to accept their own position within the social as necessary for the political (which is to say economic) well-being of the whole. Any individual who veers from this program, who is out of place within the social body, “risks impoverishment and loss of esteem and creditworthiness at the least, survival at the extreme” (Brown 2015, 22).

Such judgments, representing the visceral, dysphoric response elicited by threats to the social body’s normative morphology, legitimize efforts to discipline the social body’s wayward members in an effort to maintain and reassert its normative morphology. As Wolin (2008) writes, “managed democracy requires a process by which ‘extreme’ views are filtered and control rests with a favored guardian group, the ‘right people’ who have been preselected” not by conquerors, but by managed democracy’s neoliberal system itself (142).⁶ To this end, the ideal of an active and engaged electorate is replaced with the “consumer sovereignty” and “shareholder democracy” (65) necessary for the maintenance of proper social order, ensuring that “expectations—those accompanying an investment or a contract, for example—will not be upset by destabilizing developments, such as erratic fiscal policies, widespread social unrest, or popular demands ...” (143).

Advanced capitalism’s dynamics are again central for imposing and maintaining the neoliberal social body’s normative morphology. Insofar as the universal reduction to capital renders security and well-being tenuous and inherently contingent, capitalism itself is a primary source of potential social instability (Wolin 2008, 143). Yet this programmed instability further serves managed democracy’s needs: “when citizens are insecure and at the same time driven by competitive aspirations, they yearn for political stability rather than civic engagement, protection rather than political involvement” (239). The normative neoliberal social order’s imposition thereby produces the dispositions necessary for its ongoing perpetuation. Within this overarching structure, governance disavows the

circulation of power (Brown 2015, 130), with publicly legitimated state intervention limited to acts undertaken to aid the economy (40), occluding the fact that within neoliberal governance, the state/corporate hybrid represents one of the most invasive socio-political systems in history (Wolin 2008, 137).

All the foregoing is, of course, dissimulated within managed democracy's practices, procedures, and institutions. As Wolin (2008) notes, "inverted totalitarianism disclaims its identity," so that "democratic myths that have become detached from democratic practice may prove useful" (52). The democratic myths to which Wolin appeals are ubiquitous in political discourse: equality and liberty, "one person, one vote," majority rule, and so on. Within the American context we further specify mythical elements that accrue to the broadly democratic ideal: the attainability of the "American Dream," America as the world's defining meritocracy, the world's oldest and most fully developed democracy, and so on. Such myths are so pervasive that "to liken American democracy to a dictatorship, our constitutional system to a totalitarian one, is to invite outrage tempered by disbelief" (42).⁷

These pervasive myths also work to occlude the social-as-body metaphor's structuring role. As we saw in the previous chapter, because the social-as-body metaphor operates at the dispositional level, its structuring and shaping of actual social and political life coincides with explicit, discursively articulated legitimations of social and political life (such as the American myths noted above) with which it is fundamentally incompatible, without eliciting an experience of contradiction on the part of socio-political subjects. Indeed, this marks the social-as-body metaphor's specifically ideological dimension. In practice, modern democratic social and political life is carried out by agents who are predisposed to act according to the logic expressed in the social-as-body metaphor, thereby reinforcing the social body's normative morphology, even if they would reject any explicit social or political articulation of the metaphor.

The social-as-body metaphor therefore continues to structure the social within contemporary managed democracy. In a manner entirely consistent with the antique and medieval conceptions of the social body, the neoliberal social body's concord or *tranquillitas* requires the maintenance of its normative morphology, in which all its members remain in their proper places. In keeping with this consistent pattern, the neoliberal social body's normative morphology remains hierarchical, involving a range of stratifications and inequalities essential for its operation. Within neoliberal managed democracy, proper order is preserved precisely, and only, insofar as social agents' constitution as human capital, economic growth as the state's sole legitimate end, and citizens' constitution as *homo oeconomicus* are not called into question. The neoliberal social body's normative morphology requires that neoliberal governance not be disrupted. Any disruption of that governance, any contestation of the social body's normative stratifications and inequalities, threatens to transmogrify the "natural" neoliberal body into something grotesque. This is why, lack of explicit appeals to the social body notwithstanding, Catherine Holland (2001) is correct in noting that

rather than having been rendered inessential within politics, or banished altogether from it, the citizen's body has come to figure more visibly and more powerfully than ever in the American political imagination over recent decades Foregrounding questions of race, gender, and sexuality, the so-called culture wars have placed the citizen's body, yet again, at the very center of the nation's political agenda.

(169)

Expressing the social-as-body metaphor's logic, the neoliberal social body requires that all such wayward bodies be put back into their proper places.

To challenge inequalities and stratifications on the bases of gender identity, sexuality, race, economic status, or any of the myriad other possible axes of contestation is to threaten the social body with monstrous (un)becoming, to threaten its transformation into something "unnatural." As with all threats to normative embodiment, these provoke visceral, dysphoric responses that serve to maintain and reinforce the social body's normative morphology. The management of potentially unruly democratic forces is crucial to this process: democracy can be practiced only to the extent that it can be managed in such a way as to preserve the social body's stratified and inequalitarian morphology.

As we have seen, however, neoliberal managed democracy presents itself as a paragon system of democratic action and participation. Its management mechanisms must therefore be such as to manage and direct social agents without explicit anti-democratic repression. The dysphoric responses to the normative social body's disruption must not appear within the social as the dysphoric responses they are. Just as the social-as-body metaphor operates at the dispositional level, then, the mechanisms enforcing and reimposing the neoliberal social body's normative morphology operate in complex ways below or behind explicitly discursive or reflective political and social reasoning. The normativity, the very "normalness," of the subjectivities constituted within the context of neoliberalism is a crucial component of this operation. Neoliberal political rationality represents a cultural *a priori* shaping social agents' affective experience, predisposing them to act in such a manner as to preserve it.⁸ Once again drawing on Bourdieu's formulation, neoliberal political rationality represents "a way of being, a habitual state (especially of the body) and, in particular, a predisposition, tendency, propensity, or inclination" (Bourdieu 1977, 214n1). Neoliberal rationality constitutes contemporary democratic subjects' internal dispositions, which are then "externalized" in the form of their "free" actions, which in turn reinforce the neoliberal political rationality from which they originated (see Bourdieu 1977, 72).

The legion examples of this are remarkable precisely because so many present themselves as unremarkable, neutral descriptions of political or social fact: voter suppression laws that masquerade as protections of democracy from the threat of rampant voter fraud; a system of campaign contribution "regulations" that ensure candidates who spend the most are virtually guaranteed political victories

(Koerth-Baker 2018);⁹ complex party rules for participation in debates and appearance on public ballots, serving the obvious interests of entrenched political elites; endless coverage in 24-hour news cycles by companies that trade in, and are judged as, entertainment (see Crouch 2004, 46–50); endless polling about candidates’ “electability,” a measure which becomes self-fulfilling, a perfect example of elites’ use of polling to direct political energy and shape elections ahead of the fact, often in the name of an imagined “moderate” electorate (see Klein 2015; Levitz 2017); adding a decidedly gendered dimension to the former, female candidates for office must also contend with “likeability” measures as well, an amorphous notion that is almost never applied to male candidates (to say nothing of the virtual invisibility of political candidates who do not conform to a dominant cis-heteronormative paradigm); dismissal of anyone who dares to challenge entrenched racial privilege as “playing the race card” or “politicizing identity”; dismissals of challenges to economic inequality as “socialism” or “class warfare”; dismissals of grassroots activism on the grounds that it is not “civil” and, explicitly, that it is disorderly; and on and on.¹⁰

Wolin (2008) effectively highlights such mechanisms, writing

the political role of corporate power, the corruption of the political and representative processes by the lobbying industry, the expansion of executive power at the expense of constitutional limitations, and the degradation of political dialogue promoted by the media *are* the basics of the system, not excrescences upon it.

(287)

That is, the very structures, processes, and actors that are often decried, on all sides, as inimical to democracy are actually central to its management. Managed democracy is therefore not a departure from democracy as a “legitimate” state form, but enacts its essential logic, insofar as statist democracy is fundamentally concerned with counting, which is to say, with offering an account of members’ proper places within the morphologically normative social body (see Rancière 2010, 33) and ensuring that they do not get out of place.¹¹ As a state form, then, democracy necessarily operates according to the logic of what Jacques Rancière (2010) calls the “police principle”:

The essence of the police lies in a partition of the sensible that is characterized by the absence of void and of supplement: society here is made up of groups tied to specific modes of doing, to places in which these occupations are exercised, and to modes of being corresponding to these occupations and these places. In this matching of functions, places, and ways of being, there is no place for any void. It is this exclusion of what “is not” that constitutes the police-principle at the core of statist practices.

(36)

As this description makes clear, managed democracy, as contemporary liberal democracy's de facto state form, has fundamentally to do with maintaining the morphologically normative social body. The concord of the social depends upon ensuring that bodies that constitute it are in their proper places, playing their proper roles. Members that threaten to transmogrify the social body provoke socially and politically dysphoric responses.

None of these responses is articulated with the explicit invocation of the social body or the "body politic," or the preservation of an inegalitarian, stratified society. On the contrary, of course, all such responses are couched in terms of freedom, liberty, the defense of democracy, and so on. Yet the effort to enact and enforce the neoliberal social body's normative morphology and to police its members is evident. Such efforts' visceral, automatic, and reactionary nature marks their pre-reflexive, dysphoric dimension. At the most fundamental level, the management of democracy represents a constellation of dysphoric responses to any of the social body's members who threaten to enact its monstrous (un)becoming.

Queer Democracy

Notwithstanding the lack of explicit invocations of the social body, we can see that contemporary neoliberal managed democracy expresses the traditional social-as-body metaphor's logic, operating at the dispositional level. It is a concrete manifestation of the disposition to proper social order expressed in the social-as-body metaphor, structuring social perceptions, affects, and practices in such a way as to instantiate the morphologically normative neoliberal social body. As we saw in the previous chapter, however, the morphologically normative social body is fantastical; it is an impossible object, directing political desire away from recognition of the social body's queerness. Social and political actions directed toward imposing and maintaining the social body's proper shape mask the reality that monstrous (un)becoming is not something that befalls a social (or flesh-and-blood) body defined by an otherwise "natural," fixed morphology, but that, on the contrary, the social body is always defined by (un)becoming. The social body is always "transing" (Noble 2012, 46) or transmogrifying, defined by a fluid morphology without fixed form. All appeals to morphologically normative embodiment are therefore fantastical precisely because they mask the impossibility and unnaturalness of any morphologically normative embodiment. In expressing the "natural attitude" (Bettcher 2009, 103) of embodiment underwriting the traditional social-as-body metaphor, managed democracy therefore represents a contemporary example that Žižek (1989) identifies as the "fundamental ideological fantasy" (126). In managed democracy's specific case, this fantasy is expressed in efforts to manage, direct, or contain the *demos*'s force.

In highlighting contemporary managed democracy's fantastical dimension, I am not romanticizing some past "golden age" in which democracy was *not* fantastical in nature. The fantastical desire to manage the *demos* has consistently marked

modern democracy, as it did democracy's classical Athenian expression. As John Dunn (2005) points out, modern democracy's emergence was marked by two very different conceptions of democracy, which he terms "equality" and "egoism." He notes that egoism (a.k.a. "the English doctrine of the economists") was essentially "aristocratic in substance," focusing on the extension of rights to the (potential) exclusion of equality of condition (124, 125), and that the equalitarians found themselves "heavily out-spent and out-voted" (126), with the effect that any substantively equalitarian vision of democracy was effectively quashed with the eventual constitutional and institutional structures that won the day.

Such considerations are clearly relevant in considering the US context, given that the American framers, whom Wolin (2008) describes as "steadfast critics of democracy," "treated as axiomatic that a modern political system had to make concessions to democratic sentiments without conceding governance to 'the people'" (155; see also Deneen 2018, 162). Reinforcing the traditional concern for proper social order expressed in the social-as-body metaphor, the American framers shared the centuries-old position that democracy was "inherently prone to disorder," and so must be carefully constrained (xx). Within this context, he also notes that "the fate of democracy is to have entered the modern world at the same moment as capitalism ..." (269; see Brown 2015, 205), while Dunn argues that "the market economy is the most powerful mechanism for dismantling equality that humans have ever fashioned" (Dunn 2005, 137). The result has been the emergence of a "democratic" society in the US that is "uncomfortable with every surviving vestige of explicit privilege, but remarkably blithe in face of the most vertiginous economic gulfs, and comprehensively reconciled to the most obtrusive privileges of wealth as such" (Dunn 2005, 127), all of which fuel contemporary managed democracy.

Modern democracy has consistently sought to constrain the "rule of the people," seeking to maintain order through the management of the *demos*, ensuring that an unruly *demos* does not threaten the social body's normative morphology. Consonant with antique and medieval articulations of the social body, inequality, hierarchy, and social stratification have been central features within modern democracy, providing the schema for the social body's proper shape. When examined in terms of the social-as-body metaphor's dispositional structuring, modern democracy's emergence hardly seems like the "mutation of the symbolic order" celebrated by Lefort (1988, 16) but, on the contrary, the Ancien Régime's continuation.

As we saw in the previous chapter, however, in addition to playing a structuring role within the social, the social-as-body metaphor is also a "structured structure" (see Bourdieu 1990, 53). That is, the social-as-body metaphor not only structures the social but is itself socially conditioned and shaped (see Bourdieu 1977, 72). While the social-as-body metaphor has been articulated in terms of the natural attitude of embodiment and morphology, we saw in the previous chapter that a consideration of trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC) embodiment

calls the natural attitude into question, revealing embodiment's fundamental queerness. This recognition, in turn, allows for a queer reimagining of the social-as-body metaphor itself, opening the possibility of articulating the social body in such a way that (un)becoming serves as a constructive conceptual resource for social and political imagining, rather than an obstacle to be overcome or denied. The queering of the social-as-body metaphor allows for the social body's articulation on an alternative dispositional register, one in which the social body is not morphologically fixed but shifting and fluid. "Thinking with trans" (Brubaker 2016, 71) in this way offers a potent means of imagining a queer, transmogrified social body, one which is not governed by a normatively hierarchical, unequal, and stratified morphology.

Despite its very real historical shortcomings and limitations, the concept of democracy harbors within itself this queering, equalitarian promise. It continues to harbor the revolutionary potential to which Lefort appeals, its polyvalence opening it to new articulations. As Brown (2015) notes, "the term 'democracy' contains nothing beyond the principle that the demos rules," with the effect that "'democracy' signifies the aspiration that the people, and not something else, order and regulate their common life through ruling themselves together" (202). The very same notions at the heart of modern democracy (e.g., "liberty, equality, and fraternity") that mask neoliberal manage democracy *also* serve as the basis for new imaginings of what democracy could be.

Women, racial and religious minorities, slave descendants, new immigrants, queers, not to mention the poor and working classes, have seized on the universalism and abstraction of liberal democratic personhood to insist on belonging to the category of "man" (when they did not), to stretch liberal meanings of equality (to make them substantive, not only formal), and to press outward on freedom as well (to make it bear on controlling conditions of existence, not mere choice within existing conditions).

(206)

While the promise of appeals to popular sovereignty was constantly tempered and betrayed in a thousand ways, that promise "nevertheless forced episodic reckonings with the operation of wealth and other privileges in organizing common life" (207). What Dunn identifies as the equalitarian strain in modern democracy has never disappeared entirely.

While it may therefore be true that democracy names a state form virtually as soon as it (re)emerges in the modern period (Dunn 2005, 130), it also speaks with a radically equalitarian and plural resonance that cannot be reduced to such a form. Appealing again to Dahl's (1989) distinction, substantive conceptions of democracy continue to exercise a political force (see 116, 163). Jacques Derrida (2003) effectively highlights this point with his notion of the "democracy to come," suggesting that no matter how "cynical" appeal to a concept such as

modern democracy may be, it nevertheless harbors an “invincible promise” (114). “Democracy to come” therefore names “the incompletion and essential delay, the self-inadequation of every present and presentable democracy” (Derrida 2005, 38).

Neoliberal managed democracy’s actually-existing forms, practices, procedures, and institutions do not exhaust democracy’s promise and potential. On the contrary, even the most strident critiques of existing democracy may be undertaken “in the name of democracy, of a democracy to come,” of a democracy that always remains outstanding, enlivening such critique (Derrida 1997, 104, see also 2005, 89). As Derrida (2005) emphatically suggests,

the expression “democracy to come” does indeed translate or call for a militant and interminable political critique. A weapon aimed at the enemies of democracy, it protests against all naïveté and every political abuse, every rhetoric that would present as a present or existing democracy, as a *de facto* democracy, what remains inadequate to the democratic demand, whether nearby or far away, at home or somewhere else in the world, anywhere that a discourse on human rights and on democracy remains little more than an obscene alibi so long as it tolerates the terrible plight of so many millions of human beings suffering from malnutrition, disease, and humiliation, grossly deprived not only of bread and water but of equality or freedom, dispossessed of the rights of all, of everyone, of anyone.

(86)

Derrida’s notion of the democracy to come is consonant with what Margaret Canovan (1999) describes as democracy’s “redemptive face.” In contrast to its “pragmatic face,” which has to do with the institutions and procedures necessary for democracy’s functioning in large, complex, and pluralistic polities, democracy’s redemptive face highlights that it is also “a repository of the aspirations characteristic of modern politics,” a “faith in secular redemption,” and “the promise of a better world through action by the sovereign people” (11).

The concept of democracy, then, opens itself to an alternative articulation of the *demos*’s rule vis-à-vis that of contemporary neoliberal managed democracy, one representing the “divestiture” (Butler 2004, 48) of the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body and the embrace of the social body’s inherent queerness. Within this alternative articulation, which I am calling queer democracy, the *demos*’s rule cannot be reduced to the institutional or procedural forms of the contemporary liberal democratic state, precisely insofar as these are fundamentally implicated with neoliberal managed democracy and the fantastical conception of the morphologically normative social body.¹²

Within a queerly democratic imaginary, the *demos* is better understood as an ongoing process than as a substance or social object, and democracy as a form of dissensual social and political practice, rather than a determinate set of institutions or procedures. Laying hold of the redemptive promise that continues to resonate

in the notion of the rule (*kratos*) of the *demos*, queer democracy takes shape in ongoing dissensual practice undertaken to extend the democratic principles of liberty and equality to new social domains. As imagined within queer democracy, belonging within the *demos* is not limited to a privileged subset of society, but encompasses the totality of political subjects (see Brown 2015, 202), so that the *demos* is, in principle, coextensive with the social. Thus, expressing the social body's fundamental queerness and morphological fluidity, the *demos* itself has no fixed or final constitution, no normative morphology, but is constitutively incomplete, queer, transmogrified.

The significance of viewing the *demos* as the totality of political subjects is given in the fact that political subjectivity is itself a political achievement, performatively enacted through dissent, rather than a fixed attribute. Reflecting the social body's (un)becoming, queerly democratic practice productively unmakes its existing morphology, enacting a negation of the presently existing social and political order, imagining in its place a new social body inaugurated in such practice (see Honig 2009, 44). In so doing, queer democracy, which expresses the demand for a place within the *demos* on the part of those who presently have no place within it, transmogrifies the *demos* itself.

A consideration of the dynamics of political recognition and legitimacy illustrates queer democracy's performance of political subjectivity and the *demos*'s accompanying transmogrification. On a conventional understanding, the legitimacy of political subjects is the condition for recognizing the demands they level through dissensual social or political action. That is, we recognize the legitimacy of those demands because we register the legitimacy of the political subjects leveling them. Within a predominantly liberal framework, the legitimacy registered in political demands is typically articulated in terms of rights or liberties: the political subjects leveling demands possessed legitimate rights or liberties that were previously not recognized or otherwise denied. The failure to recognize these rights or liberties is rectified when the subjects leveling them are permitted to participate in the *demos*'s political life.

What is most pertinent in this understanding, for our purposes, is its pre-supposed political ontology. While dissenting political subjects' rights or liberties were in some way curtailed or denied, unduly excluding them from the *demos*'s political life, these political subjects were nonetheless already present, though unrecognized, within the social body. The legitimacy of their political demands is therefore a function of their political subjectivity: as rights- or liberty-possessing political subjects, their exclusion from political participation in the *demos* was illegitimate, which is remedied through political recognition. Understood in this way, the recognition of these subjects has no ontological effect on the *demos* itself. As legitimate political subjects, those leveling political demands were always already a legitimate part of the *demos*—they were just prevented from participating fully within it. Their exclusion therefore represents a failure to recognize the *demos*'s true or authentic shape. This is the logic of the fully inclusive *demos*: given

enough time, we can in principle come to recognize all legitimate political subjects, bringing the full contours of the *demos* into view. The *demos* itself therefore possesses a normative morphology which, even if not fully visible at a present moment, nonetheless acts as a final cause guiding both political recognition and dissent.¹³

This understanding of political legitimacy and recognition continues to express, however tacitly, the social-as-body metaphor, structured around a conception of the *demos*'s normative morphology. The basis for the recognition of political demands' legitimacy is their perceived congruence with a morphologically normative social body. Practices and demands that threaten to unmake the social body or the *demos* itself will be dismissed as illegitimate for precisely that reason. The vision of the fully inclusive *demos*, whether that vision be progressive (i.e., it is believed that there are legitimate political subjects currently barred from full participation in the *demos*) or conservative (i.e., it is believed that the *demos* already includes all legitimate political subjects), remains dispositionally structured by the morphological normativity that has traditionally been expressed by the social-as-body-metaphor.

The performative account of political subjectivity that informs queer democracy presupposes a very different logic of legitimacy and recognition. Rather than legitimacy conferring recognition, recognition confers legitimacy. The rights and liberties demanded of the *demos* in queerly democratic action emerge as legitimate, politically and socially intelligible demands only to the degree they are recognized as such. Political subjects' legitimacy and social intelligibility, the basis for their inclusion in the *demos*'s political life, is dependent upon their political and social recognition.¹⁴ Crucially, this recognition therefore marks the emergence of *new* political subjects within the social, subjects who cannot be said to pre-exist the queerly democratic practices in which they participate. The emergence of demanding subjects therefore represents, in Jacques Rancière's (2010) words, "the political invention of the Other or the *heteron* ... which continually produces 'newcomers'" within the social (59). This marks a very different ontological terrain to that presupposed in the conventional understanding, one according to which the *demos* is an event emergent within the social (see Miller 2016, 210–217), rather than an entity with a fixed, normative shape.¹⁵

The emergent nature of political subjects and their demands is such that it is impossible to foresee or anticipate where or when they will arise; dissent bubbles up within the social in incalculable and unpredictable ways. Every incorporation of novel political subjects into the *demos* therefore changes its constitution, so that it becomes something other than what it previously was. Novel political subjects' incorporation within the *demos* neither affirms nor expresses its preexisting, normative morphology, but instead represents the *demos*'s productive unmaking and transfiguration, resulting in its reemergence in a morphologically new form. As Bonnie Honig (2009) notes,

each new inclusion [within the *demos*] comes with disturbance and possibly transformation for those people and rights that are already in [the *demos*], as well as for the antecedent rules that aspire to govern or subsume all new cases and events.

(49)¹⁶

As she sums up the issue, “each new right inaugurates a new world” (53). This is why democracy, as the *demos*’s rule (*kratos*), is always, as Derrida says, to come: the *demos*’s constitutive incompleteness is such that democracy can never simply be said to have “arrived” or been enacted. Rather, the *demos*’s morphology is fundamentally fluid and shifting, preventing its emergence in any final, fixed form.

This understanding highlights the fantastical dimension of the conventional understanding of political recognition and inclusion, with its presupposition of the *demos*’s morphological normativity. Within the queer democratic frame, the *demos* is constitutively incomplete, and can have no fixed or final morphology. Every leveling of political demands marks an effort to constructively unmake the *demos*’s normative morphology, while every instance of political recognition marks its transfiguration, remaking it into something other than it was before. Political subjectivity’s emergent and open-ended nature, forged in queerly democratic practice, is also such that there can be no *telos* or final form to the *demos*. There is, for example, no morphologically normative *demos* asymptotically approached through novel political subjects’ recognition. Rather, recognizing the morphologically normative *demos*’s impossibility allows us to traverse the fantasy of the *demos*’s proper shape, instead highlighting its irreducible queerness and morphological fluidity.

Queer democracy, enacted in dissensual social and political practice, expresses the *demos*’s constant unmaking, taking shape around its ongoing expansion and the maintenance of its own (un)becoming as an anticipation of the unforeseeable emergence of novel political subjects (e.g., Critchley 2007, 112). The *demos* originates in the fundamentally queer social body and is, in its ongoing expansion, coincident with it in principle. Structured as it is around the expansion of liberty and equality to ever-wider social spheres, queer democracy cannot be reduced to “majority rule,” nor can it be reduced to determinate institutions or procedures. On the contrary, queer democracy involves what Honig describes as the “remainders” produced within democracy as a state form (e.g., Honig 2009, 120), its “unchosen, unarticulated, or minoritized alternatives—different forms of life, identities, solidarities, sexes or genders, alternative categories of justice, unfamiliar tempos” (16).¹⁷

Queer democracy takes shape around those whose identities lack intelligibility within the social body as presently constituted. So understood, the *demos* “has no allotted place within the system” (Wolin 2008, 249), which is to say, within democracy as a state form. If we are to speak of the *demos*’s rule (*kratos*), then, the locus of this “rule” must lie elsewhere than the mechanisms of the state.¹⁸

Because there is no “outside” to the state (see Critchley 2007, 112) and because the transmogrifying *demos* has no social place within the state, queerly democratic social and political practice, in its *unmaking* of the social body, *makes* a place where none is given, creating a distance from the state within the state itself (92, 113). Breaking with the binary logic of “inside” and “outside,” the *demos* so understood represents the “principle of heterogeneity” inhering within democracy as a state form (Rancière 2010, 53).¹⁹

In its break from the natural attitude of embodiment that has structured the social-as-body metaphor, queerly democratic social and political practice is necessarily an-archic, insofar as it calls into question the founding logic of Western political theory that the power to rule (*arkhe*) has fundamentally to do with natural dispositions to rule and to be ruled, respectively (Rancière 2010, 30). Queer democracy therefore represents “a rupture in the logic of the *arkhe*” (31) and the presumed normativity of the “natural.”²⁰ Indeed, as Rancière notes, Plato rejects democracy precisely on the grounds that it represents an “unnatural” social order (49–50; see also Rancière 2006, 35–36). The queer *demos* is Aristotle’s goat-stag in social form: an unnatural body that simply *cannot be* within the context of contemporary neoliberal managed democracy. A queerly democratic social body is monstrous, grotesque, transmogrified. It is a body marked by “strange or grotesque transformations” and “unnatural combinations,” “a body that consists of the dis-junction and interweaving of polyvalent elements that somehow resist unification into a singular and ‘sensible’ whole” (Sullivan 2006, 553, 561). Once again applying Stryker’s description, the queerly democratic social body “is an unnatural body ... It is flesh torn apart and sewn together again in a shape other than that in which it was born” (Stryker 2006, 245).

And yet, just as TGNC bodies represent the traversal of the fantasy of morphologically normative embodiment, queerly democratic practice points the way to traversing the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body. Queer democracy’s transmogrification of the social body reveals its fundamental queerness. Like all bodies, the social body is inherently grotesque or monstrous (see Richardson 2010, 10). Shaped by the visceral sense of this queerness, queer democracy expresses political dispositions counter to the disposition to proper order traditionally expressed in the social-as-body metaphor. Queerly democratic practice flows from “transed” dispositions (see Noble 2012, 46), dispositions toward fluid morphology, driven by the affirmation of the queer social body. The “deformation” of the social enacted with dissensual democratic practice (Critchley 2007, 117) therefore reflects the fact that all bodies, including the social body, “are unnatural, created, formed, and transformed in and through modificatory processes and procedures of one sort or another” (Sullivan 2006, 558).

As the discussion of political recognition makes clear, queer democracy embodies a complex social ontology, revealed in the question that continues to persist despite the discussion to this point: *what, exactly, is queer democracy?* In large measure, we have been concerned to define queer democracy negatively

through its differentiation from neoliberal managed democracy. And herein lies the key to understanding its ontology: precisely insofar as queer democracy emerges unforeseeably in the unmaking of the existing social body, precisely insofar as it represents the *negation* of the presently existing social and political order, it takes shape through an apophatic modality.²¹ Traditionally identified with theological discourse, a number of contemporary thinkers (Derrida 1992, 1995, 2007; Keller 2010; Faber 2010; Hughes 2010) have argued persuasively that apophatic discourse speaks with multiple voices, at least some of which escape the gravitational pull of theology. Rather than understanding it as a specifically theological form, apophaticism is better understood as a discursive form forced upon us “in every discourse that seems to return in a regular and insistent manner to [the] rhetoric of *negative determination*, endlessly multiplying the defenses and the apophatic warnings” (Derrida 1992, 74, emphasis added; see also Hughes 2010, 353). Apophaticism therefore represents a formal structure open to “universalizing translation” (Derrida 1995, 63) beyond theological discourse. We are thrown into apophatic discourse, as a form of negative determination, in those instances in which “negativity ought to absolutely rarify discourse” (Derrida 1992, 84), but in which we are still required to speak. We are thrown into apophatic discourse when we name that which “‘is’ not and does not say what ‘is,’” when we are thrown into discourses that take the form “this, which is called X ... ‘is’ neither this nor that ...” (74).

As a negation of the existing social and political order, queer democracy draws us into precisely such discourse, as we have seen. Insofar as the *demos* is constitutively incomplete, emergent, and perpetually outstanding, it *is* not in any determinate sense. In stating that it cannot be reduced to a state form, to existing institutions, procedures, and so on, that the emergent *demos* necessarily exceeds the scope of the democratic people in any given moment, in insisting that the *demos* is better understood as a process than as a social or political object, discourse about queer democracy is necessarily pressed into negative determination. Again, applying Derrida’s (1992) reflections on apophaticism to our discussion, queer democracy “calls for another syntax” than the predication marking a more objectivist social ontology.

Queer democracy’s emergent *demos* has no fixed essence to which we can point for its ultimate confirmation. Yet this point should not lead to undo mystification or concerns that the *demos* somehow lacks reality or force. Insofar as queer democracy involves the *constructive* unmaking of the social body, its positive force lies in its negation and the affirmation of the social body’s (un)becoming, which is the positive condition of possibility for the queerly democratic expansion of liberty and equality to broader social spheres and the *demos*’s substantive expansion. It is the condition of possibility, to reiterate, for *making* a place within the social for those with no place.

As the “principle of heterogeneity” within state democracy (Rancière 2010, 53), as the “political invention of the Other or *heteron*” (59), the queerly

democratic *demos* is literally nonsensical when considered from within the frame of any actually-existing democratic state form, such as neoliberal managed democracy, insofar as it emerges only through the unmaking of the “sense” of the social itself. Queer democracy is inherently dis-ordering, hence its provocation of dysphoric responses aimed at reimposing social order. And these visceral, dysphoric responses serve to warn us away from an understanding of apophaticism as an abstract phenomenon, insofar as they illustrate the necessarily concrete nature of the social body’s (un)becoming.

Rather than asking what queer democracy *is*, it is better to ask where it *occurs* within the social. Thus, the loci toward which socially dysphoric responses are directed alert us to queer democracy’s concrete inbreaking within the social. The backlash against efforts at voter mobilization and voting access, against movements such as the #MeToo movement and Black Lives Matter, the fear and rage directed toward protests for racial justice, and judicial and legislative efforts to curtail, halt, or roll back the gains of the LGBTQ+ community, to name just a few, all mark determinate, concrete sites at which the existing social body is being unmade, concrete instantiations of a disposition for queerly democratic social embodiment. It is precisely the queer *demos*’s lack of intelligibility within the existing social body that provokes distinctly non-rational, dysphoric responses, responses that make evident the “ontological shudder” (Mills 1997, 86) instigated by these very concrete phenomena. But this lack of intelligibility, this breakdown of the sense of the social, is simultaneously the positive condition for the emergence of a more expansive *demos*. Borrowing the phrasing of Alexander G. Weheliye (2014), the “zones of indistinction” that occur in the unmaking of the social body represent the “deformations of freedom” necessary for the *demos*’s ongoing emergence (2). The negation of the existing order is the condition of possibility for the invention of “hitherto unavailable genres of the human” (24) that emerge through queerly democratic practice.

Finally, it is also worth reemphasizing the effect that affirming the queer social body has on all those who participate in the emergent *demos*. The *demos*’s changing identity, through its ongoing emergence and expansion, is such that the concrete identities of all its members, which is to say, the concrete identities of all who affirm and participate in the social body’s fundamental queerness, are also changed. In this regard, queer democracy and the *demos*’s emergence are not significant solely for those who have been excluded from it. Rather, those who *have* been counted as legitimate members of the *demos*, but who nevertheless affirm the queer social body and the emergent *demos*, are also affected by queer democracy’s ontological shudder, which constructively reconfigures their own identities. Cishet white men who strive with the LGBTQ+ community for their gains embody a fundamentally different political and social identity from those who dysphorically oppose that community; men who join with the #MeToo movement in working to dismantle sexist and misogynist social structures embody a fundamentally different political and social identity than those who

dysphorically oppose such efforts; white people who participate in the efforts of people of color to undo the legacies and institutions of White supremacy and White privilege embody a fundamentally different political and social identity than those who dysphorically work to preserve what Mills (1997) theorizes as the “racial contract” that has structured American society since its founding. While we could multiply such examples, the point is that queer democracy is not “just” about those who have not had a place within the *demos*, but is also about the ontological transformation of those who have. So understood, it is clear that even seemingly fixed and assured social and political identities are in flux, illustrating Roland Faber’s (2010) point that “everything has an apophatic aspect” (212).

Conclusion

As we saw in the previous chapter, the social-as-body metaphor has traditionally been structured by the natural attitude of embodiment, according to which bodies are defined by a morphology granted normative status due to its purported naturalness and maintained only by assuring that none of their members are out of place. Recognizing Lakoff and Johnson’s (2003) insight that “we act according to the way we conceive of things” (suitably modified to emphasize the affective, dispositional nature of “conception”) (5), the social-as-body metaphor has typically legitimized the constitution of a hierarchical and stratified social body. As we have seen in this chapter, the disposition to social and political order expressed in the desire for the morphologically normative social body is not limited to the past but continues to operate in the present. The institutions, procedures, and governance within neoliberal managed democracy serve the end of enforcing the social body’s normative morphology by reigning in the *demos*, while simultaneously presenting this imposition of order as the organic expression of democratic freedom and equality.

Trans theoretical reflections on embodiment reveal the natural attitude and invocations of morphologically normative embodiment to be fantastical expressions of the desire for a proper order that has never existed. Rather than expressing natural, normative morphologies, bodies are irreducibly queer, taking shape as ongoing expressions of fluidity and morphological (un)becoming; bodies are always transmogrified assemblages. This sense of queer embodiment structures an alternative articulation of the social-as-body metaphor. Generating dispositions counter to that of proper social and political order, this alternative takes shape around a vision of the queer *demos*, of the *demos* as fluid, marked by its continual productive unmaking, involved in ongoing transmogrifying processes. These dispositions express themselves in queerly democratic practices, which represent a form of social body modification, unmaking the social body and allowing it to emerge anew, with a new morphology, through the ongoing extension of liberty and equality to new social spheres.

Returning to Lefort's (1988) reflections, we can see that queer democracy represents the constitution of a society "which undermines the representation of an organic totality" and which "welcomes and preserves indeterminacy" (16, 18). However, contra Lefort, it does not represent a form of "disincorporation" or the institution of a "society without a body" (17, 18). Queer democracy is an expression of queer social embodiment, not embodiment's absence or dissolution. The disposition toward social and political order, expressed in the desire for a morphologically normative social body, runs deep, however, and the queer social body's enactment, like all queer bodies, provokes dysphoric responses, as we shall see in future chapters.

Notes

- 1 It is clear, of course, that in his discussion, Lefort focuses on the context of the French Revolution and the specifically French conceptions of monarchy and society that preceded it. Nevertheless, he highlights issues with broader applicability to our theme of the social body.
- 2 Here and throughout my discussion of democracy, I will use the Greek *demos* rather than the English "people." I adopt this convention for a number of reasons, one of which is that it allows for greater clarity when comparing the *demos* as I understand it from the "people" as articulated in contemporary populism and nationalism, which are the focus of Chapters 4–6.
- 3 We will revisit Lefort's formulation of the democracy and totalitarianism in Chapter 4.
- 4 As she notes, while Wolin does not employ the term "neoliberalism" in his discussion, this is essentially what he has in view with his treatment of these issues (Brown 2015, 29).
- 5 The backlash against restrictions on social gatherings and interactions during the 2020 Covid-19 pandemic in the US provides a chilling illustration of this logic at work. This was particularly evident in the argument that those most likely to die if exposed to the virus should be willing to do so for the sake of the economy (see Beckett 2020).
- 6 Wolin's reference to "conquerors" reflects the publication of his book in the immediate aftermath of the Iraq War.
- 7 Mark Lilla's (2017) advocacy of American civic nationalist identity, the focus of Chapter 6, represents a telling example of this outrage.
- 8 The concept of cultural *a priori*s is introduced in Chapter 1.
- 9 While Maggie Koerth-Baker is correct to note that the fundraising success of winning political candidates cannot be translated into a straightforward assertion that fundraising alone is responsible for electoral victory, it nevertheless remains the case that political candidates who do not successfully fundraise can be virtually assured of political defeat.
- 10 As the discussions in Chapters 5 and 6 demonstrate, these management mechanisms are deployed by both the political right and left.
- 11 Jacques Derrida also offers some complex reflections on the theme of counting or calculation in relation to democracy that bear on this issue (see Derrida 2005, 28–31).
- 12 The discussion that follows both draws from and builds upon my earlier work on social ontology and radical democratic political theory, which I developed in more technical detail in Miller 2016, chapters 4 and 5. While the discussion that follows is not simply a repetition of my earlier work, and departs from it in some respects, I nevertheless understand my discussion of queer democracy to be continuous with it.
- 13 Jürgen Habermas's conception of toleration and social inclusion illustrates this point. On the one hand, he elaborates a complex and nuanced account of recognition and political inclusion, insisting that the recognition of individuals possessing rights also

require “a politics of recognition that protects the integrity of the individual in the life contexts in which his or her identity is formed.” Such recognition is required because individual identity is achieved only intersubjectively (Habermas 1998, 208). Such a formulation could be developed in such a way as to register the constitutively incompleteness of the *demos*, as I am proposing. Yet this is not the direction taken by Habermas. On the contrary, he presupposes legitimacy’s priority over recognition, which makes it possible, on his account, to determine the *demos*’s proper contours. Thus, writing under the presupposition of a legitimate (as he understands that term) constitutional order, “once the corresponding prejudices against people of color, homosexuals, or women are overcome, no components of ‘otherness’ remain to which a justified rejection that was generally recognized as legitimate could refer” (Habermas 2008, 259; emphasis added). What this suggests is that, even if full inclusion with the *demos* is a goal which can only be asymptotically approached (a notion that would certainly be consistent with Habermas’s thought more generally), efforts at inclusion or toleration are nevertheless guided by a determinate understanding of the fully inclusive *demos*’s morphological contours.

- 14 It is important to note two points with regard to this process: 1.) as a general politico-ontological process, it is not inherently progressive or democratic, and 2.) it is a more intuitive idea than it may at first seem. Both of these points were vividly illustrated in President Donald Trump’s refusal to unequivocally condemn violent White nationalist activists in the aftermath of the “Unite the Right” rally in Charlottesville, VA in 2017. In the aftermath of the violence, Trump infamously insisted that there were “very fine people” on both sides of the rally (Keneally 2017; Politico 2017). As observers on both the left and the right, including the “alt-right,” recognized, Trump’s statement legitimized the White nationalists’ actions in Charlottesville, granting a measure of political legitimacy to American White nationalism more broadly. The widely shared intuitive sense of the significance of Trump’s recognition of White nationalist activists reflects the operation of this process.
- 15 Benjamín Ardití (2014) advances a similar conception of “the people,” also drawing on Rancière. While he is addressing the phenomenon of populism, his formulation is more consistent with my formulation of the *demos* than with populism’s anti-pluralist articulation of “the people.” We will revisit these and related considerations in Chapters 4–6.
- 16 I would simply add that such transformation is not only possible but represents a necessity at the level of social ontology.
- 17 To argue that queer democracy cannot be *reduced to* determinate institutions or procedures is not to suggest that such institutions and procedures are not necessary for its concrete functioning. Returning to Canovan’s (1999) discussion, I agree with her that democracy requires *both* redemptive *and* pragmatic dimensions. As she suggests, democracy, in its pragmatic dimension, “is essentially a way of coping peacefully with conflicting interests and views under conditions of mass mobilization and mass communication” (10), which necessitates “multi-party systems, free elections, pressure groups, lobbying and the rest of the elaborate battery of institutions and practices by which we distinguish democracy from other modern polities” (11). I have also found Nadia Urbinati’s work informative for these points (see especially Urbinati 2006, chs. 5–6 and 2014, ch. 3). While institutions and procedures, even purportedly “democratic” institutions and procedures, cannot ensure the preservation of queerly democratic practice and the *demos*’s ongoing expansion, there can be no queerly democratic practice without institutions and procedures. They are necessary, but certainly not sufficient, conditions for queer democracy. If I have focused more on democracy’s redemptive dimension in the preceding discussion, this is because democracy’s managers lean heavily on its pragmatic requirements as a legitimation for the fundamentally anti-democratic articulation of managed democracy. Correcting this requires, perhaps, an over-emphasis on democracy’s redemptive dimension.

- 18 This is not to suggest that dissensual practice will not take place at the level of state institutions and procedures, but that such practice will never be exhausted by, or fully embodied within, such institutions and procedures. On this point, it is useful to consider the points Honig (2009) makes in response to Seyla Benhabib's accusations that her position is "antistatist" (134–137).
- 19 We will again encounter this question of the *demos's* rule (*kratos*) in discussing the relation of popular sovereignty, queer democracy, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau's thought in the next chapter.
- 20 Laclau and Mouffe (2001) have essentially the same dynamic in view when they insist that "the logic of democracy is not a logic of the positivity of the social," but that it is an essentially "subversive moment" (188).
- 21 For a fuller development of the concepts of apophaticism and alterity informing this discussion, see Miller 2016, 235–249.

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3

BEDEVILED BY NATURE

The Social Contract Tradition

Introduction

The classical social contract theories of Thomas Hobbes, John Locke, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau offer a fascinating study in the social-as-body's pertinence and development. In marked historical continuity, their respective political theories all explicitly appeal to the metaphor of the body politic. At the same time, however, their appeal to the metaphor takes on a distinctively modern tone, applying to the state, rather than a culturally unified Christendom (see Philpott 2001, 76). As we noted in Chapter 1, the shift to the conceptual terrain of the modern territorial state is accompanied by a pronounced concern with the question of political sovereignty (see Philpott 2001, 2011, 2016), a concern that figures prominently in Hobbes's and Rousseau's respective accounts of the social body.

Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau all locate the social body's originary constitution in individuals' entrance into the social contract, a conception that would have been unintelligible within the normative framework of Christendom, in which European Christians were understood as *de facto* members of the social body. Within this changed cultural framework, the political sovereignty wielded by states became the socially unifying basis constituting the social body (Philpott 2011, 566), evident in social contract theorists' appeal to it. Christendom's breakdown was accompanied by a breakdown in governance relying on a broadly expressed cultural unity, opening the way for the imposition of political sovereignty as a distinctly territorial form of governance. States came to be defined by fixed and clearly demarcated borders, within which rulers exercised supreme authority (16, 561; Morris 2004, 198) over both the resident population and territorial resources (Diener and Hagan 2012, 7), a conception of authority granting a historically new significance to geography (Morris 2004, 197).

In Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau, then, we encounter novelty in continuity. The social-as-body metaphor is central to all three thinkers' political theories, but the metaphor is deployed on a different conceptual and historical terrain than in prior periods. As we shall see, their theories also differ in the degree to which they register the possibility of a queer social body taking shape through the *demos*'s queerly democratic expansion, thereby traversing the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body.

In the discussion that follows, I argue that Rousseau's social contract model holds the greatest promise for the recognition of the queer social body and the advancement of queer democracy, though it ultimately falls short of this potential. It must be noted at the outset, however, that all three theories, despite their apparent human universalism, fail to countenance the possibility that the full scope of humanity participates, or is even capable of participating, in the social contract or the social body it enacts. This point has been developed forcefully in the thought of Charles W. Mills (1997), who demonstrates convincingly that the social contract is upheld by what he terms the "racial contract," with the effect that only White Europeans emerge as truly capable of entering into the social contract and properly belonging to the social body, and Alexander G. Weheliye (2014), who argues that the concept of "the human" at the basis of modern European Enlightenment thought has been limited to White Europeans as well.¹ Taken together, such insights vividly demonstrate that the social body that emerges in these thinkers, whatever respective nuances may be present, is a normatively White European social body, and I will note specific dimensions related to this normative conception of the social body in the discussion that follows.

Thomas Hobbes: *Leviathan* and the Normative Social Body

The social-as-body metaphor figures prominently in Hobbes's political theory. As we have seen in previous chapters, the dispositions expressed in his appeal to the social-as-body metaphor are as significant as the mere fact of that appeal. In discussing Hobbes, it is helpful to first highlight some of his most notable appeals to the metaphor. Following this, we will consider his account of the social body's origin, the basis for its unity, and his clear expression of the disposition to proper social and political order as the basis of his appeal to the metaphor.

The Social-as-Body Metaphor in Hobbes

Hobbes (1996) appeals to the social-as-body metaphor from the first page of *Leviathan*'s Introduction, writing that the "Art of man [*sic*]" is capable of imitating divine creation in the production an "Artificial Animal." Yet, he continues,

Art goes ... further, imitating that Rational and most excellent work of Nature, Man [*sic*]. For by Art is created that great LEVIATHAN called a

COMMONWEALTH, or STATE, (in Latin CIVITAS), which is but an Artificial Man [*sic*]; though of greater stature and strength than the Natural, for whose protection and defense it was intended.

(9)

The social contract is the means of creating this body, an act analogous to a divine fiat “by which the parts of this Body Politic were first made, set together, and united ...” (9–10). Just as God knit together the human body in Psalm 139, those entering into the social contract knit together the social body.

Hobbes (1996) reiterates elements of this description, and adds others, in *Leviathan*’s well-known seventeenth chapter. There, he writes that the “Common-Wealth, in Latin CIVITAS” is “the Multitude ... united in one Person;” the body politic is “a real Unity of them all, in one and the same Person,” constituting the “LEVIATHAN” as the “Mortal God, to which we owe under the Immortal God, our peace and defense” (120). The person of the sovereign provides the social body’s unitive force. Thus, those contracting to institute the commonwealth “confer all their power and strength upon one Man [*sic*], or upon one Assembly of men [*sic*], that may reduce all their Wills, by plurality of voices, unto one Will” (120), this one individual or assembly bearing the title of sovereign (121). The sovereign, as “the Person of the Commonwealth,” is also the “person Commanding,” the “*Persona Civitas*” (183). The appointed sovereign “bear(s) their Person” (120) and is the artificial body’s “soul,” giving life and motion to the whole (9).

We are well advised to take at face value Hobbes’s (1996) language of the social body as a “real unity” borne in the person of the sovereign. Throughout *Leviathan*, particularly in its early pages, he rails against the use of metaphor in philosophy (see 25–26, 35, 36, 52). From his perspective, then, the commonwealth as a corporate body, unified by the sovereign, is irreducible to “mere” metaphor.² This point is vividly illustrated in *Leviathan*’s famous frontispiece, with the clear image of the commonwealth, in the person of the sovereign, wielding both political authority (in the image of the sword) and ecclesiastical authority (in the image of the bishop’s crozier), simultaneously composed by and lending unity to the commonwealth’s individual members (Bredenkamp 2007, 30–33).

Hobbes’s (1996) appeal to the social-as-body metaphor and its presumed normativity are both evident in his account of the commonwealth’s institution and maintenance. Given that the sovereign serves as the commonwealth’s unifying force, bearing its person in their own individual person, any challenge to the sovereign is a pathological malformation threatening the social body, resembling “the disease of a natural body, which proceed(s) from a Defectuous Procreation” (222). The presupposition of the social body’s proper shape is rendered explicit in Hobbes’s description this malady of the social body:

to what Disease in the Natural Body of man [*sic*], I may exactly compare this irregularity of a Commonwealth, I know not. But I have seen a man, that had another man growing out of his side, with a head, arms, breast, and stomach of his own: If he had had another man growing out of his other side, the comparison [with models of mixed government] might then have been exact.

(228)

A social body in which the sovereign is challenged is a body disordered, a body whose members are out place, rendering it grotesque, monstrous, and fundamentally unnatural.

Escaping the State of Nature and the Origin of the Social Body

Despite his insistence on the social body's artificiality, "nature" nevertheless looms large in Hobbes's (1996) account. In contrast to such a grotesque departure from nature, the morphologically normative social body naturally takes its proper shape in the exit from the state of nature and entrance into the social contract. He (in) famously defines the state of nature as a "war of every man [*sic*] against every man [*sic*]" (87, 88).³ This enmity owes to people's relative equality in the state of nature (86–87) and to the radical liberty they all possess as individuals. Reflecting his positivist account of law, the state of nature is fundamentally lawless, and for this reason, amoral:

the Desires, and other Passions of man [*sic*], are in themselves no Sin. No more are the Actions, that proceed from those Passions, till they know a Law that forbids them ... Nothing can be Unjust. The notions of Right and Wrong, Justice and Injustice have there no place.

(89, 90)

Individuals in the state of nature therefore possess the right of nature, which is to say, "the Liberty each man [*sic*] hath, to use his own power, as he will himself, for the preservation of his own Nature," a right extending to "every thing; even to another's body" (91).

The state of nature, then, is a state marked by unconstrained individual liberty. The paradox that arises within this state is, of course, the cancelling effect such unchecked liberty actually has on freedom. As Hobbes (1996) puts it, "there can be no security" within the state of nature (91): "men live without other security, than what their own strength, and their own invention shall furnish them withal" (89). The radical liberty of all, in perpetual competition and conflict, plays a cancelling role that renders life, in Hobbes's best-known formulation, "solitary, poor, brutish, and short" (89). The paradox, then, is that within the state of nature, humans are precluded from living out the full time "which Nature

ordinarily alloweth” (91). Individuals’ exercise of *natural* liberty contravenes nature, rendering their lives *unnaturally* brief.

The delimitation of natural liberty through entrance into the social contract offers the way to salvation from this pitiable state. The dire realities within the state of nature lead Hobbes (1996) to formulate what he terms the “general rule of Reason” aimed at self-preservation: “that every man [*sic*], ought to endeavor Peace, as far as he has hope of obtaining it” with the aim of preserving life, though they retain recourse to self-defense and war if need be (92). With an invocation of natural law, then, Hobbes defines the “Fundamental Law of Nature” as seeking and following peace (92). To this fundamental law he adds a second, which makes clear that such preservation can only be achieved through the delimitation of natural liberty:

that a man [*sic*] be willing, when others are so too, as far forth, as for Peace, and defense of himself he shall think it necessary, to lay down this right to all things; and be contented with so much liberty against other men [*sic*], as he would allow other men [*sic*] against himself.

(92)

This “laying down,” representing a transfer of right to another, “is that which men [*sic*] call CONTRACT” (94).

Hobbes appeals to natural law, then, as the basis for the social body’s constitution via entry into the social contract. Law’s centrality in the social body’s constitution is not limited to natural law, however, as Hobbes (1996) makes clear through the pivotal role he assigns to civil law in maintaining the social body’s unity. Civil and natural law are not opposed but, rather, “the Law of Nature, and the Civil Law, contain each other, and are of equal extent” (185). Thus, the civil law is “part of the Dictates of Nature” and “obedience to the Civil Law is also part of the Law of Nature” (185). Civil law’s sole end, in keeping with the precepts of natural law, is natural liberty’s restraint, “without which there cannot possibly be any Peace” (185). Civil laws are the commands to which all members of the commonwealth are subject (183), representing “the measure of Good and Evil actions,” “the public Conscience” (223).

The Unity of the Social Body and the Will of the Sovereign

Law is central to both the origin and maintenance of the social body, insofar as its delimitation of liberty provides the condition of possibility for its constitution. This is why the sovereign’s power, as “sole Legislator” (Hobbes 1996, 184), is so foundational to Hobbes’s thought. The social contract’s maintenance cannot be entrusted solely to those who enter into it, insofar as, in the state of nature, there can be no assurance of compliance: “the bonds of words are too weak to bridle men’s [*sic*] ambition, avarice, anger, and other Passions, without the fear of some

coercive Power” (Hobbes 1996, 96). Those entering into the social contract, then, do not simply set aside natural right, but transfer it to another. Individuals’ natural right is transferred to a third party, as it were, who stands apart from, and exercises authority over, all parties subject to the social contract. The contrast is therefore only protected from avoidance by “a common Power set over” all parties, “with right and force sufficient to compel performance” to its dictates (96). Thus, the natural state of war persists until people are under “a common Power to keep them in awe” (88).

In transferring right to the sovereign, those entering into the social contract are agreeing upon a designated lawgiver in the person of the sovereign (Hobbes 1996, 89), and this ceding of sovereignty cannot be revoked (122). The sovereign is the sole measure of the law: as the origin of civil law, they are not subject to it because it is not possible “for any person to be bound to himself [*sic*]” (184) and they are the law’s sole interpreter (190). In their role as over-awing power ensuring the maintenance of the social contract, the sovereign is also the law’s executor and enforcer. Thus it is that there can be no hope of individuals maintaining the social contract, and therefore the commonwealth, without “Fear of some evil consequence upon the rupture” (93), which “evil consequence” is enacted by the sovereign. The sovereign therefore possesses “right and force sufficient to compel performance” (96), a right possessed inherently, not through subjects’ largesse (214): in laying aside their natural right to punish those who oppose them, that right naturally goes to the sovereign, so that it “was not given, but left to him [*sic*], and to him [*sic*] only” (214).

Granting disciplinary authority to the sovereign constitutes the sovereign as the commonwealth’s sole representative. This representative role is significant, insofar as it ensures that the commonwealth is a “real Unity of them all, in one and the same Person” (Hobbes 1996, 120), rather than a mere conglomeration of individuals maintained simply through brute force. The commonwealth’s institution in the social contract confers on the sovereign “all the Rights, and Faculties of him [*sic*], or them” who take on sovereign power, with the result that the sovereign is granted “the Right to Present the Person of them all, (that is to say, to be their Representative)” (121). Because the sovereign is the rightful representative of all who enter into the social contract, the sovereign’s legislation, interpretation, and execution of the law are simultaneously also the legislation, interpretation, and execution of the law by all within the commonwealth. Thus,

every one, as well he [*sic*] that Voted for it, as he [*sic*] that Voted against it, shall Authorize all the Actions and Judgements, of that Man [*sic*], or Assembly of men [*sic*], in the same manner as if they were his [*sic*] own.

(121)

Insofar as the sovereign’s actions are, in their representative function, the actions of all, sovereignty operates as the basis for the social body’s unity and proper order.

In stressing this point, however, it is important not to misinterpret Hobbes. While he writes (1996) that those who have freely entered into the social contract are consenting “to stand by what the major part should ordain” (123), his account of the social body’s “real unity” bears much greater ontological weight than this majoritarian language might otherwise indicate. Illustrating this point, he writes, “the Commonwealth is no Person, nor has capacity to do anything, but by the Representative, (that is, the Sovereign;) ...” (184). As the people’s representative, the sovereign does not simply stand in for them in their absence, but actually constitutes them as the people of the commonwealth. The sovereign is the source of the social body’s unity because the sovereign is itself an indivisible unity (129–134):

a Multitude of men [*sic*], are made *One* Person, when they are by one man [*sic*], or one Person, Represented ... *For it is the Unity of the Representer, not the Unity of the Represented, that maketh the [corporate] Person One.*
(114, *emphasis added*)

Will is the sovereign’s defining attribute and, through its expression in law, the unitive basis of both the sovereign and the commonwealth. Thus, in insisting that the social body is a “real unity,” Hobbes (1996) also insists that, in conferring power to the sovereign, the plurality of individual wills are “reduced to” the single will of the sovereign (120). This unification of will owes to the people’s participation in the sovereign as constituting representative. Thus, the multitude under the sovereign’s authority are “many Authors, of every thing their Representative saith, or doth in their name; Every man [*sic*] giving their common Representer, Authority from himself [*sic*] in particular; and owning all the actions the Representer doth” (114). Legal command is therefore not merely the sovereign’s command but, through the sovereign, that of the unified social body as a whole, so that all who are subject to sovereign authority “are bound ... to Own, and be reputed Author of all, that he [*sic*] that already is their Sovereign, shall do, and judge fit to be done” (122). Thus it is that the sovereign bears in their person the person of the commonwealth as a whole (120), so that Hobbes sometimes refers to the sovereign and the commonwealth interchangeably, as when the sovereign, as “the Person of the Commonwealth” is also the “person Commanding,” the “*Persona Civitas*” (183).

Dissent and the Monstrous Social Body

There can be no legitimate place for dissent on Hobbes’s account of the social body. Given the constitutive role of the sovereign’s person and will on the body politic, the legitimacy of their acts and commands cannot be contested. Given Hobbes’s social ontology,

it follows, that whatsoever he [*sic*] [the sovereign] doth, it can be no injury to any of his [*sic*] Subjects; nor ought he [*sic*] to be by any of them accused of

Injustice. For he [*sic*] that doth any thing by authority from another, doth therein no injury to him [*sic*] by whose authority he [*sic*] acteth; But by this Institution of a Commonwealth, every particular man [*sic*] is Author of all the Sovereign doth; and consequently he [*sic*] that complaineth of injury from his [*sic*] Sovereign, complaineth of that whereof he [*sic*] himself is Author.

(Hobbes 1996, 124)

Thus, while the sovereign may commit “iniquity,” it is nevertheless impossible for the sovereign to commit injustice (124).

While the sovereign must be accountable to God (Hobbes 1996, 224, 231), then, Hobbes is clear that political sovereignty is absolute and beyond human contestation. He dismisses objections that this model of absolute sovereignty lacks a sufficient rational basis by responding that such objections owe to “interest,” not reason, and come from those in need of proper instruction regarding the nature of sovereignty and the commonwealth (232–233). Explicitly appealing to “concord” as a justification, he argues that “the Obedience, (and consequently the Concord of the people)” is vital to the social body’s proper ordering, without which the commonwealth will ultimately be destroyed (234). Such disobedience represents an “intestine disorder” (221) threatening the social body from within.

These points highlight the causal relation between dissent, understood as any challenge to unified sovereignty, and the “Defectuous Procreation” (Hobbes 1996, 222), the transmogrified body, outlined above. With this formulation, Hobbes gives clear voice to the traditional disposition to proper social order expressed in the social-as-body metaphor. The maintenance of the social body’s normative morphology requires the exercise of indivisible sovereignty backed by the threat of violence. Hobbes’s dysphoric repulsion when confronted with a body, flesh-and-blood or social, whose members are out of their “proper” places highlights the continuity of his invocation of the social-as-body metaphor with the pattern outlined in the first chapter.

Locke: Majority Rule, Natural Law, and the Normative Social Body

Locke, like Hobbes, makes explicit appeal to the social-as-body metaphor, with both significant parallels and differences. In an obvious parallel, Locke’s social body is the commonwealth formed when individuals leave the state of nature by entering into the social contract. He routinely appeals to the social-as-body metaphor as a means of understanding the constitution and the unity that arise from the social contract, though, unlike Hobbes before him or Rousseau after, he does not explicitly appeal to the concept of sovereignty in his formulation (Morris 2011, 551). This reflects his relatively greater emphasis on reason, particularly natural law, which remains a “black box” in his political theory. Locke also rejects authoritarianism like that advanced by Hobbes and places much greater, and more explicit, emphasis on notions of the people and popular consent,

thereby allowing greater positive scope for political dissent in his theory. In the final analysis, however, he remains beholden to the notion of the social body's normative morphology, deviation from which can only represent a grotesque deformation.

The Social-as-Body Metaphor in Locke

The first chapter suggested that the social-as-body metaphor operates on a dispositional level and that the relation between metaphor and disposition is reciprocal in nature: metaphors express dispositions, but those same dispositions are also shaped by metaphors. In Hobbes's appeal to the social-as-body metaphor, we encounter a case of the former: his appeal to the morphologically normative social body clearly expresses his political disposition to unity and sovereign authority. In Locke's application of the metaphor, we encounter the converse: his appeal to the normative social body forecloses on the radical potential of dispositions otherwise expressed in his political theory. Although his appeal to popular consent and the power of the people would appear to lead to an affirmation of the social body's fundamental queerness, expressed in queerly democratic practice, this trajectory in his political theory is undermined by a countervailing tendency in his thought, evident in his appeal to a morphologically normative social body. The result is a formulation that remains grounded in the fantasy of the morphologically normative body, the fantastical nature of which is revealed in the people's paradoxical constitution.

The People, the Centrality of Dissent, and the Queer Social Body?

In a statement marked by formal similarities to Hobbes, Locke (1988) writes that individuals divest themselves of their natural liberty and "put on the bonds of civil society" by "agreeing with other Men [*sic*] to joyn and unite into a Community, for their comfortable, safe, and peaceable living one amongst another, in a secure Enjoyment of their Properties, and a greater Security against any that are not of it" (331). When "any number of Men [*sic*]" have consented to form such a community, "they are thereby presently incorporated, and make *one Body Politick*" (331), the end of which is "the Preservation of their Property" (351). The consent grounding this community is radically individual in nature (337): "*Every Man* [*sic*]" is "*naturally free*," bound to the community only through "his own Consent" (347). Every individual must give consent, even if this is only tacit in nature (347–348), and if individuals wish to withdraw their consent, they may leave the present government's jurisdiction and institute a new social contract "*in vacuis locis*" (349).⁴ Locke therefore holds (no matter how contrived the means) that individuals are not subject to the state simply by virtue of birth under its authority, but only by granting individual consent (344–345). Simple subjection to the government's authority suffices only to render one a "subject," and not a full "member" of

society, the latter being determined only via consent (349). Individuals' consent also does not obligate their posterity but applies only to them as individuals (346). There is a sense, then, in which the state must constantly be renewed through the giving of consent and retains its authority only so long as this is granted, a position which stands in marked contrast to Hobbes's insistence that, once sovereignty is granted, the commonwealth, in the person of the sovereign, stands beyond all contestation in perpetuity.

Even though those in the state of nature are nominally governed by the Law of Nature, individuals lack the means for preserving their property, necessitating the political community's institution. Locke (1988) highlights three elements missing within the state of nature: 1.) civil law, 2.) an impartial judge to interpret the law's demands, and 3.) an executive to implement and enforce the law (351). Thus it is that, in entering into the social contract, individuals "take Sanctuary under the establish'd Laws of Government, and therein seek *the preservation of their Property*" (352). In another point that is largely consistent with Hobbes, by entering into political community, individuals set aside their natural liberty and give up the power to punish those who commit crimes against them (352–353).

The commonwealth's constitution redresses the lack within the state of nature. The "*Legislative Power*," the founding of which represents the "first and fundamental Positive Law of all Commonwealths" (Locke 1988, 355), has as its highest end the commonwealth's preservation (355–356). Formed by "a positive voluntary Grant and Institution" (363) from society, it is "*the supreme power of the Common-wealth*" (356). The consent to transfer authority to the Legislative is neither irrevocable nor absolute, in contrast to the transfer of sovereign power in Hobbes. The Legislative acts only in trust on the part of those who grant it authority (356, 381), and so the scope of its authority cannot be arbitrary. On the contrary, its authority is limited to "the publick good" (357), shall be "employed for their good, and the preservation of their Property" (381), and "can have no other *end or measure* ... but to preserve the Members of that Society in their Lives, Liberty, and Possessions" (382). If the Legislative's members are not permanent, but must be appointed periodically, this appointment must come from the people choosing representatives (370).⁵

Locke (1988) is clear that the Legislative is the source of civil law and, in contrast to Hobbes, he separates legislative and executive power.⁶ While the Legislative need not be constantly in session, the laws stand perpetually in need of execution, so that "'tis necessary there should be a *Power always in being*, which should see to the *Execution* of the Laws that are made, and remain in force" (365). Thus, the executive power, together with what Locke terms the "Federative Power" (365), is distinct from, but subordinate to, the Legislative Power (366–367).

The political community's formation also provides for an "impartial judge to interpret the demands of law." In contrast to Montesquieu's later development (1989), Locke does not distinguish a judiciary power from those of the Legislative

and executive. As Alex Tuckness (2016) points out, the reason is that, while Locke “is not opposed to having distinct institutions called courts,” it remains the case that “he does not see interpretation as a distinct function of power.” On the contrary, it is a primary responsibility of the executive, in executing the laws promulgated by the Legislative, to interpret them (Tuckness 2016; see Locke 1988, 324–325). We will revisit this interpretive role below. For the moment it suffices to note that, with this formulation, the commonwealth’s constitution grants all three elements lacking in the state of nature.

Locke (1988) insists that the Legislative is only “a fiduciary Power” holding the people’s trust, such that, should it act contrary to that trust, “there remains still *in the People a Supreme Power* to remove or *alter the Legislative*” in response (367). Should those in power act contrary to law, they become tyrannical (400), and those wronged are free to seek legal recourse against them and, should this be denied, it is lawful to resist the government’s unlawful acts (403). If the government’s illegal acts “have extended to the Majority of the People” or “seem to threaten all” in their lives and liberty, then, Locke suggests, “how they will be hindered from resisting illegal force, used against them, I cannot tell” (404–405). To those who fear this outcome, he suggests that this situation only arises when the government has utterly failed in its mission to seek the people’s good (405).

This situation gestures toward those instances when the people fully exercise their power to alter the Legislative. Locke (1988) notes a number of ways in which the government can “dissolve from within” (407–411), such as exceeding its authority in the passage of laws, imposing laws not promulgated by the Legislative, the executive’s prevention of the Legislative assembly, altering elections without popular consent, placing the people under foreign power, and the executive’s failure to enforce the laws. In all such cases, the people are free, when the government is dissolved, to provide a “new Legislative, differing from the other, by the change of Persons, or Form, or both as they shall find it most for their safety and good” (411). But Locke is equally clear that the people are not obliged to wait until the government dissolves “from within” (407) but can actively move to dissolve the government “when the Legislative, or the Prince, either of them act contrary to their Trust” (412).

When the government, in the form of either the Legislative or the Executive, breaches its trust, by taking away or destroying the individuals’ property, it forfeits the power that has been granted to it, and that power “devolves to the People” (Locke 1988, 412–413). In response to the objection that such a doctrine “lays a *ferment* for frequent *Rebellion*” (414), Locke advances several related counter-responses. Most notably, he responds with the argument that, far from licensing frequent rebellion, the doctrine of “a Power in the People of providing for their safety a-new by a new Legislative” is, in fact, “*the best fence against Rebellion*, and the probablest means to hinder it” (415). He argues that, in either dissolving the government through improper acts or in violating the people’s trust, the *government* has, in fact, taken on the status of “rebel” standing in violation of the law

(415–416). In such a case, the government exercises mere “Force without Authority,” thereby reintroducing a state of war against the people (416). Denying the people this right therefore, in Locke’s estimation, amounts to declaring that “honest Men [*sic*] may not oppose Robbers or Pirates, because they may occasion disorder or bloodshed” (417). Given that government’s end is “the good of Mankind [*sic*],” it is better that the people be free to resist tyranny than that they “should be expos’d to the boundless will of Tyranny” (417).

The Normative Social Body and the Constitution of the Demos

This insistence on the people’s authority to modify the Legislative gestures toward a recognition of the validity of social and political dissent and, following from this, of the queerness and fluidity of the social body, lacking a fixed and normative morphology. This is not, however, what we find in Locke’s explicit invocation of the social-as-body metaphor. On the contrary, he appeals to the morphologically normative body, the unity of which is assured only to the extent that its members remain in their proper places, the propriety of which are ensured by majority rule. The result is a theoretical articulation marked by striking parallels to Hobbes’s own account of the social body. In particular, he advances a similarly paradoxical account of the people’s constitution vis-à-vis that of the commonwealth. His appeals to natural law do not mitigate his theoretical difficulties at this point, but ultimately highlight the fantastical nature of the body to which he appeals.

As we have seen, Locke (1988) presents the commonwealth’s constitution as the formation of “*one Body Politick*.” But he immediately goes on to describe this single social body as one “wherein the *Majority* have a Right to act and conclude as the rest” (331). He goes into no detail concerning the nature of the body to which he appeals, but it is clear that he operates within the “natural attitude” of embodiment (Bettcher 2009, 103), presupposing a body with a fixed, natural morphology, the naturalness of which confers normative force; indeed, he does not need to address its morphology explicitly precisely because he presupposes morphological normativity to be “natural.” This is significant because the social body’s presupposed morphological normativity provides him with a legitimation for adopting the principle of majority rule:

when any number of Men [*sic*] have, by the consent of every individual, made a *Community*, they have thereby made that *Community* one Body, with a Power to Act as one Body, which is only by the will and determination of the *majority*.
(331)

It is necessary, Locke insists, that “one body” be able to move “one way,” which is impossible if every individual body member wills differently (331–332). Thus,

it is necessary the Body should move that way whither the greater force carries it, which is the *consent of the majority*: or else it is impossible it should act or continue one Body, *one Community*, which the consent of every individual that united into it, agreed that it should; and so every one is bound by that consent to be concluded by the *majority*.

(332)

In Locke's (1988) development, the social contract's legitimacy depends upon this notion of majority rule, which is to say that it hangs on his appeal to the social body's unity. Were it not the case that entrance into the social contract constituted consent "to submit to the determination of the *majority*, and to be concluded by it," then "this *original Compact*, whereby he [*sic*] with others incorporates into *one Society*, would signifie nothing, and be no Compact," leaving individuals in the state of nature (332). While every individual must consent to participate in the social contract, which is to say in the social body, such consent is consent to majority rule (347).

As we saw in the previous chapter, queerly democratic practice cannot be reduced to majority rule or, following from this, institutions and procedures intended to aggregate the majority's will. This element of Locke's thought, then, is fundamentally anti-democratic in nature, in the sense outlined in the previous chapter. Locke's (1988) articulation of majority rule leaves no room for dissent: within the social body context, "the *act of the Majority* passes for the act of the whole" (332). "Where the *majority* cannot conclude the rest," by way of contrast, "there they cannot act as one Body, and consequently will be immediately dissolved again" (333). Dissent, insofar as it threatens the social body's morphological unity, threatens its dissolution. In Locke, then, we once again encounter the disposition to proper political and social order, expressed in the social-as-body metaphor.

The expression of the majority will is civil law, and Locke's (1988) thought again parallels Hobbes's in its insistence that civil law is the unitive force constituting the social body. We have seen that the "first and fundamental Positive Law of all Commonwealths" is the institution of the Legislative (355), and we have also seen that Locke differs from Hobbes insofar as individuals' transfer of the rights to the Legislative is not irrevocable. Yet, while he insists that "the *Community* may be said ... to be *always the Supream Power*," Locke goes on to insist that "this Power of the People can never take place till the Government be dissolved" (367). As long as the government remains in place, the Legislative, rather than the people, is "*the supream [sic] Power of the Common-wealth*," and in case this were not a clear enough statement, Locke goes on to describe the Legislative as "sacred and unalterable in the hands where the Community have once placed it" (356). Once the majority of the social body's members have invested the Legislative with its representative power, it becomes "sacred and unalterable," so long as it fulfills the trust placed within it.

We will return to the issues involved in determining whether the government has, in fact, forfeited its trust. For the moment, it is instructive to look more closely at the Legislative in its specifically representative role vis-à-vis the people of the Commonwealth. The paradoxical nature of representation in Locke (1988), as in Hobbes, is that the people can only take shape once its “first and fundamental law” has constituted the commonwealth. That is, the representative constitutes the people that are supposed to have constituted it. Locke writes,

’tis in their *Legislative*, that the Members of a Commonwealth are united, and combined together into one coherent living Body. This is the *Soul that gives Form, Life, and Unity* to the Commonwealth ... For the *Essence and Union of the Society* consist[s] in having one Will.

(407)

Prior to the commonwealth’s constitution, which gains the spark of life only with the people’s constitution of the Legislative, there *is no* unified society to constitute it. This formulation’s thoroughgoing and paradoxical character is given in the fact that “when the *Legislative* is broken, or *dissolved*, Dissolution and Death” of the social body follow (407), with the effect that “the People become a confused Multitude, without Order or Connexion” (411). Thus, Locke simultaneously insists that the people does not act as supreme authority unless the government is dissolved, *and* that the government’s dissolution simultaneously dissolves the people itself into a monstrous and grotesque mass. There is, in Locke’s theory, no social body before the will of the people, but there is no people apart from the unified social body. It is therefore unclear how, with the government’s dissolution (for whatever reason) “supream authority” *can* devolve to the people.

This fundamental theoretical difficulty is compounded by additional procedural and theoretical mechanisms regulating dissent in Locke’s (1988) account. He counters the concern that allowing resistance to government commands “will unhinge and overturn all Politics, and instead of Government and Order, leave nothing but Anarchy and Confusion” (401) by arguing that only unlawful commands, which necessarily exceed the government’s legitimate authority, may be opposed. Further, the first recourse in such cases is not the exercise of force, but “Appeal to the Law” (403). Resistance beyond this is only legitimate in those instances (rare in his estimation) in which the unlawful damages cannot be “repaired” via such legal appeal.

At first blush, this formulation appears straightforward enough and is consistent with Locke’s account of the people’s ultimate authority and the government’s dissolution: should the government’s lawless acts extend far enough and affect enough individuals, the Legislative, and those powers subordinate to it, are effectively dissolved. But Locke’s failure to account for the fact, so well-illustrated by Jacques Derrida (2002), that adjudications of law are never simple “applications,” but extensions or delimitations, representing substantive modifications of

the law itself, undercuts this seemingly straightforward account. When we recall that, for Locke, legal interpretation is not a separate power from the Legislative and executive, but an extension of them, this theoretical point's implications become more stark. Dissent is only legitimate when it is undertaken in the face of the government's lawlessness, but it remains solely in the government's purview to legislate, apply, *and* interpret the law. Locke's deference to the Legislative's supreme and sacred authority, then, effectively reduces legitimate popular dissent to nothing.

Locke's (1988) attempts to address the complexities arising from the issue of legal interpretation highlight his theoretical muddle on this point. He acknowledges the importance of the question of "*who shall be Judge*, whether the Prince or Legislative act contrary to their Trust" (426–427). Applying his "fiduciary" logic, he insists that "*the People shall be Judge*; for who shall be *Judge* whether is Trustee or Deputy acts well, and according to the Trust reposed in him, but he who deposes him ..." (427)? In support of this point, he poses the following question, intended to be rhetorical: "if this be reasonable in particular Cases of Private Men [*sic*], why should it be otherwise in that of the greatest moment ...?" (427).

It is immediately evident, however, that this question fails to make Locke's desired point because, on his own terms, this is a patently false analogy. As we have seen, he appeals to the people's ultimate authority, but the people lack authority so long as the government is constituted, during which time the Legislative and its deputies retain ultimate authority. Likewise, representation's paradoxical nature again comes into play: reminiscent the account of sovereignty and representation in Hobbes, Locke argues that the commonwealth's judgments *are* its individual members' judgments, insofar as the Legislative acts as their representative (325). There is, then, clear reason why what holds in the case of private individuals *cannot* hold in the case of the people vis-à-vis the government. The difficulty in arguing that "the Body of *People*" is the "proper *Umpire*" between "a Prince and some of the People, in a matter where the Law is silent" (427) is that the constitution of the "body of the People" is itself an effect of the government, as we have seen. That is, to reiterate, without the government, there *is no* people. In appealing to the "body of the people," then, Locke mysteriously invokes another "body" in addition to the social body, the indivisible unity of which he has insisted upon throughout (such was the import of his appeal to majority rule). His consistent insistence on the social body's unity, and therefore its normative morphology, is undone by his appeal here to the impossible, and so fantastical, "Body of the People."

Natural Law: Locke's Black Box

Locke's consistent appeal to the people's authority is therefore undercut by his equally consistent appeal to the social body's normative morphological order, embodied in the Legislative and its deputies. These dueling affirmations lead to the theoretical tangles outlined above. Locke also grounds his account in a

conception of natural law, which casts a rationalist veneer over his theory, potentially providing a way out of the theoretical morass we have been discussing. That is, if the social body's constitution in the form of the commonwealth outlined by Locke represents not *merely* an expression of a majority of individuals' will, but of a deeper rationality, then it becomes possible that his theory's paradoxes and contradictions are, if not eliminated, then at least significantly attenuated in their potential force and effect. As we shall see, as attractive as this possibility may be, his appeal to natural law ultimately does nothing to mitigate the force of these difficulties.

For Locke (1988), in contrast to Hobbes, the radical liberty possessed in the state of nature cannot properly be understood as a state of lawlessness. Rather, the state of nature is a "*State of perfect Freedom*," but only "within the bounds of the Law of Nature" (269), so that the state of liberty is not "*a State of License*" (270). It is evident to reason, "which is that Law," that "being all equal and independent, no one ought to harm another in his Life, Health, Liberty, or Possessions" (271). The execution of this universal law, which Locke also describes as "Reason" (271) and "the Will of God" (358), lies in every individual's hands (271), with the rights of punishment and reparation that implies (273–275). The state of nature is therefore not properly equivalent to a state of war (as in Hobbes), but becomes so only when individuals transgress the Law of Nature's demands, harming others (278–281).

Herein lies the reason for exiting the state of nature and forming the commonwealth. While all individuals stand under the Law of Nature, the fact that each is the executive of that law creates the "Inconvenience" that "where Men [*sic*] may be Judges in their own Case," it is "easily to be imagined, that he [*sic*] who was so unjust as to do his [*sic*] Brother an Injury, will scarce be so just as to condemn himself for it" (Locke 1988, 276). Thus, to escape the state of war, "wherein there is no appeal but to Heaven," is "one great *reason of Mens* [*sic*] *putting themselves into Society* and quitting the state of nature" (282). As we have seen, it is in the commonwealth's formation that individuals set aside their natural right and transfer it to the "hands of the Community" (324). And it is here, as we have also seen, that the society becomes "one Body," united by "a common establish'd Law and Judicature to appeal to" (324).

It is important to recognize that, for Locke (1988), there is a crucial sense in which the commonwealth's formation is not so much an escape from the state of nature as its ratification. Individuals' natural, God-given inclination is to form "Society" (318), which comes naturally to humankind (352). Further, within the society of the commonwealth, civil law, its unifying feature, is itself an expression of the Law of Nature (357–358). And while the commonwealth's formation is necessary for escaping the state of war, the state of war is not synonymous with the state of nature but is a corruption of it. The commonwealth's formation therefore represents a restoration of the order that properly holds in the state of nature. Reflecting this, the Law of Nature binds, and is the measure of, the

commonwealth's legislative actions. Thus, "the Obligations of the Law of Nature, cease not in Society, but only in many Cases are drawn closer," so that "the Law of Nature stands as an Eternal Rule to all Men [*sic*], *Legislators* as well as others" (358).

As Peter Laslett (1988) suggests, then, "the objective existence of a body of natural law is an essential presupposition" of Locke's political theory (82). His appeal to the Law of Nature grounds the commonwealth's constitution in a deeper (or higher) God-given rationality. As such, hesitations concerning reliance on majority rule, about the commonwealth's essential interest in seeking the common good, and so on, can be laid to rest: of course there will be instances of tyranny and misconduct on the part of the Legislative and its deputies, but we can, Locke would seem to suggest, safely assume that these will be rare, exceptions that prove the dictates of the Law of Nature continue to hold. Indeed, Locke asserts that the Law of Nature in which civil law is grounded is even more "intelligible and plain to a rational Creature" than the civil law itself (Locke 1988, 275), with the implication that civil law's meaning and binding force are themselves fully intelligible and rational. It is impossible to examine this appeal to the Law of Nature without concluding it is intended as a refuge against the paradoxes and concerns that otherwise mar his account.

Yet the ease of this appeal to the Law of Nature is precisely what undercuts its persuasive force. Locke never specifies exactly what Law of Nature's content actually *is*. As Laslett (1988) notes, "*Two Treatises* relies heavily upon natural law, but the term ... is never analyzed there" (85). He also notes that the "easy confidence" evident in Locke's appeal to natural law in his political theory contrasts sharply with his "skepticism about natural law and about reason itself" and his rejection of innate knowledge in his earlier *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (81, 89; see Locke 1996). Illustrating this point, in a single passage, Locke (1988) appeals to natural law's self-evident nature but immediately insists that "it would be beside my present purpose, to enter here into the particulars of the Law of Nature, or its *measures of punishment*" (275). The result, as John W. Yolton (1993) notes, is that "the specific information or injunctions prescribed by that law" are unspecified, with the effect that "this feature of that law would seem to give Locke license to use it to support whatever claims he wishes to make" (123).

The function of natural law in Locke's political theory is to provide a rationalistic veneer to his political philosophy, in principle obviating the risk to liberty and equality inherent in concepts such as majority rule, supreme legislative authority, and the delimitation of dissent. But natural law represents a black box in his theory: its precise content and mechanisms remain hidden, so it is essentially impossible to evaluate his appeal to it, heightening some of the complexities it is presumably intended to address. For example, by leaving natural law's specific content or demands unspecified, Locke clears the ground for those interpreting and implementing the law to defend its every use as an expression of natural law dictates. Likewise, its vacuity also renders appeals to it essentially meaningless, so that it in no way attenuates the force of the contradictory and paradoxical elements of Locke's thought we have considered above.

Body Determines Dispositions in Locke

The social-as-body metaphor both expresses and shapes political dispositions. Reflecting the former of these relations, Hobbes's disposition to proper social and political order finds natural expression in his appeal to the morphologically normative body. We find something different in Locke. Given his insistence on individuals' consent as the basis of political life, together with his emphasis on individual liberty, his invocations of the morphologically normative social body, which are in many essential respects identical to that of Hobbes, is surprising. Like Hobbes, he argues that a social body that is dis-ordered, a body whose members are out of place, is rendered grotesque or monstrous, no longer recognizable as a body at all. While one might reasonably expect to find a central role for political dissent in Locke's political theory, then, we ultimately look in vain for such a role, instead finding that his appeal to the morphologically normative social body undermines this element of his thought.

In Hobbes, then, we find an example in which the social-as-body metaphor expresses his political dispositions, whereas in Locke we find an example in which the social-as-body metaphor effectively delimits the political dispositions that can effectively be expressed within his political theory. In his political theory we encounter intimations of the social body's queerness and fluid morphology, as with his appeal to a "body of the people" that overflows the bounds of the social body's morphological normativity and the people's right to unmake the government, allowing for the commonwealth's emergence in a new form. Ultimately, however, the queer impulses of Locke's theory are dysphorically repressed, falling back to an appeal to the maintenance of the social body's proper shape, grounded in Legislative will. The result is a paradoxical and convoluted theory, one that gestures toward the queer social body's promise but fails to reach it.

Rousseau and the Denatured Social Body

Rousseau's political thought is the most complex of the three social contract theorists considered in this chapter, combining Hobbes's emphasis on the classical concept of sovereignty with Locke's concern for the people's central role in the state. For Rousseau, as Morris (2011) notes, "the sovereign is and can only be the people" (551). It is no simple matter to combine these two theoretical emphases, as reflected in what can be termed, borrowing a phrase from Cas Mudde (2017), a "vulgar Rousseauian argument" (33) according to which Rousseau's combination results in a theory that is inherently totalitarian in nature, a sentiment famously captured in Jacob Talmon's (1968) now-classic account of "totalitarian democracy." On this reading, we encounter in Rousseau yet another appeal to the morphologically normative social body, expressing a political disposition antithetical to queer democracy.

And yet, Rousseau's thought also opens itself up to a very different reading, according to which his account of popular sovereignty, and more importantly of the people at its heart, allows for a much more fluid and dynamic conception of the social body than we find in either Locke or Hobbes. His thought, albeit at times at odds with itself, expresses a disposition toward the constitutively incomplete *demos* outlined in the previous chapter, expressed in an account of the social body that is *not* the properly ordered, morphologically normative body of either Locke or Hobbes. In contrast to these thinkers, he appeals to the queer social body that takes shape through queerly democratic practice. As we will also see, however, he nevertheless fails to fully embrace the queer body to which his theory so energetically gestures.

Totalitarian Democracy and the Normative Social Body?

Morris (2011) notes, "Rousseau ... thinks [consistent with Hobbes] of sovereign power as indivisible, inalienable, and absolute" (551, see also Gourevitch 1997, xxiv). Rousseau differs markedly from Hobbes, however, in his attribution of sovereignty to the people, which is expressed in the "general will," with the effect that "the sovereign state cannot act against the members of the will" (551). This sovereign will, in turn, represents the basis for the social body's unity, expressing a variant of the representation paradox we have seen in both Hobbes and Locke.

Rousseau (1997b) repeatedly strikes Hobbesean chords when writing about sovereignty. Like Hobbes, he makes explicit appeal to the social-as-body metaphor to defend the inalienable (57–58) and indivisible (58–59, 111) nature of sovereignty, so much so that he rejects the possibility of representation with regard to sovereignty (57, 114). The social contract marks the movement out of the state of nature and the constitution of a single body, as each individual's transfer of "*his [sic] person and his [sic] full power*" under the sovereign constitutes "each member ... an indivisible part of the whole" (50). The resulting association produces "a moral and collective body" and grants the social body "its unity, its common *self*, its life and its will" (50). Like Hobbes, then, Rousseau identifies this single, indivisible social body with sovereignty as such (52), so that the resulting "public person" is the "*Republic*," "*body politic*," "*Sovereign*," or "*Power*" (50–51, emphasis in original).

While entry into the social contract constitutes the body, however, it does not ensure its preservation (Rousseau 1997b, 66). Only a state ruled by laws warrants the name "republic," representing a unified social body (67), highlighting the need for law to give "motion and will" to the body (66). Further, insofar as the "principle of political life" resides in sovereign authority, the state can only be maintained through the Legislative Power (109). This indivisible sovereign power at the heart of the state ensures the social body's normative morphological integrity. Sounding thoroughly Hobbesean, Rousseau argues that the transition from the state of nature and the political state's constitution grants the social body "absolute power" over all its members (61), so that the state, as a "moral person"

constituted by its members, requires the sovereign as a “universal coercive force” moving and arranging each “in the manner most conformable to the whole” (61). In another Hobbesean vein, the sovereign itself cannot be placed under an “inviolable law” (52), nor can it be placed under any other superior authority, insofar as it operates as the “coercive force” maintaining the social body’s morphological integrity. A social body that is *not* ordered by indivisible sovereign power is monstrous, grotesque, or deformed: those who would divide sovereignty “turn the Sovereign into a being that is *fantastical* and *formed of disparate pieces*,” which would be like creating a person “out of several bodies, one of which had eyes, another arms, another feet, and nothing else” (58, emphasis added).

These points highlight the clear parallels between Hobbes’s and Rousseau’s accounts of sovereignty in relation to the morphologically normative social body. Where Rousseau most obviously differs from Hobbes, adopting a position closer to Locke’s, is in his unambiguous location of sovereign authority within the people. Gourevitch (1997) sums up Rousseau’s concern thus, writing that

the theme of the Social Contract is popular sovereignty, and every issue and argument which Rousseau takes up in the course of the work seeks either to strengthen the case for it, or to ward off possible challenges to it.

(xxiii)

While the individuals comprising the state are unambiguously placed under the sovereign’s “absolute power,” for example, Rousseau (1997b) is clear that the sovereign itself is constituted by the individuals who comprise it (52), the “associates” that constitute the state, defined as “the *people*” (51). It is the people that possess the legislative authority central to the social body’s maintenance and preservation. The “legislative power” is the only force exercised by the sovereign, so that it acts solely and “by means of the laws,” and so only when the sovereign people is assembled (110). Rousseau famously presses this point, insisting that the people’s sovereign authority is immediate, such that “the instant a People gives itself Representatives, it ceases to be free; it ceases to be” (115). The people in its entirety is tasked with enacting legislation affecting the state as a whole (67), out of the conviction that all those subject to law ought also to be its authors (68).

In another point of conceptual proximity with Locke and distance from Hobbes, Rousseau (1997b) distinguishes between the people as legislating sovereign and the executive power. These two powers are complementary: the people’s sovereign authority represents the heart of the state, while the executive power is its brain (109). The legislative and executive powers correspond respectively to the people as sovereign, on the one hand, and the government, on the other, and Rousseau is clear that the latter is merely the sovereign people’s “agent or minister,” tasked with communicating between “the State and the Sovereign” (82). Within this division of labor, the Legislative Power is the will of the state, while the executive is its power.

Highlighting the primacy of popular sovereignty in his thought, Rousseau (1997b) consistently emphasizes the sovereign people's priority over the government: while the people are constituted by the social contract (49), the government is constituted by the sovereign's legislative act (118), so that not even the government is above the people in terms of authority (116). Thus, the people must retain force sufficient to contain the government (84), and the government's jurisdiction ends, with the suspension of executive power, with the legitimate assembly of the people (112). If need be, the government can be sacrificed to the people (86), and the sovereign people retain the right to determine whether to retain the government in its present form and/or with its present administration (120).

A tension naturally arises between Rousseau's assertion that sovereignty is indivisible, inalienable, and so on, and his insistence that sovereignty resides in the plurality of the people. We have seen that, while Locke does not explicitly appeal to the classical notion of sovereignty, he nonetheless grapples with the potential *disunity* implicit in appeal to the people, working through the imposition of various theoretical mechanisms to ensure the commonwealth's ultimate unity. Rousseau's attempt to negotiate these tensions lies in his famously complex notion of the general will.

On one reading, Rousseau's general will leads to a conception of sovereignty vis-à-vis citizens that can hardly be considered an improvement over Hobbes, a concern voiced in Talmon's (1968) articulation of what he sees as Rousseau's theory of totalitarian democracy (38–49), a perspective which has remained influential (Gourevitch 1997, xxxix; Inston 2012, 197n38). As Nicholas Dent (1992) sums up this issue, Rousseau's critics have long felt his formulation of the general will sacrifices individual citizens' freedom and will (188). In a related vein, contemporary discussions of populism often involve appeals to Rousseau's general will (Mudde 2004; Plattner 2010; Mudde and Kaltwasser 2013, 2017; Rooduijn 2014; Heinisch and Mazzoleni 2017; Sorensen 2017; Huber and Schimpf 2017; Skenderovic 2017). While next section's discussion demonstrates that such a reading is simplistic and can rightly be described as "vulgar" (Mudde 2017, 33; see also Müller 2016, 25), its ongoing influence nevertheless highlights the usefulness of considering it more closely.

The people's sovereignty is exercised in the general will (Rousseau 1997b, 57), a necessary concept, given Rousseau's insistence on sovereignty's indivisible and inalienable nature. For the people's legislative will to legitimately apply to all, it "must issue from all" (62), which requires that the people's will be general, in the sense that it is "the will of the body of the people" as a whole, rather than that of only a segment of it (58). The general will therefore appears to follow logically from the idea of the people as a unified social body: "so long as several men [*sic*] united consider themselves a single body, they have but a single will" with "common preservation" and "the general welfare" (121).

Such formulations, taken in isolation, give the impression that Rousseau's general will is essentially a restatement of Locke's majority rule, and there are

indeed instances where Rousseau (1997b) gives the impression that the general will is equivalent to majority opinion (see 123, 124, 125). Such appearances notwithstanding, however, Rousseau distinguishes between the general will and what he calls “the will of all,” understood as “a sum of particular wills” (60).

Rousseau’s distinction between the general will and the will of all has proven troubling and difficult for interpreters because it seems to allow little place for the particular will, the will of individuals qua individuals. Stated in terms developed in the previous chapter, Rousseau’s account of the general will, in its relation to the sovereign, morphologically normative social body, seems to leave no legitimate place for queerly democratic practices. For example, in yet another echo of Hobbes, Rousseau (1997b) insists that the general will cannot err. Highlighting the general will’s non-equivalence with simple majority will, he argues that the general will is “always upright and always tends to the public utility,” while “the people’s deliberations” are *not* always upright and do *not* always tend to the public utility; in the latter instance, the people can “*appear* to want” something bad (59, emphasis added). In such instances, dissenting individuals’ wills must be brought in line with the general will: the general will is the “constant will” of all members of the state, such that when an opinion contrary to our own carries the day, it is evidence not of the fallibility of the general will, but of our own failure to properly discern it. An individual will out of line with the general will is one which is mistaken, representing that individual’s failure to properly know itself as a constituent member of the social body. If, in such an instance, my particular will had prevailed, “*I would have done something other than what I willed,*” with the seemingly paradoxical result that “*I would not have been free*” (124, emphasis added).

The complexity of the relation between general will and individual will owes to the fact that, while Rousseau shares Locke’s insistence on the people’s authority, he does not simply appeal to the principle of majority in doing so. In developing his account of popular sovereignty, he insists that the general will *is* the will of the individual *even if the individual opposes it*, that is, even if the individual’s particular will stands in opposition to the general will. This introduces a version of the same constitutional paradox we have encountered in Hobbes and Locke: the social body, once constituted by the people, is itself the basis for determining the very identity and will of the people that constituted it. Rousseau (1997b) clearly highlights this relation of state to people, writing that those constituting the state “*assume the name people*” (51, former emphasis added), with the clear implication that the people takes shape as an effect of the state’s constitution. For Rousseau, then, the sovereign people’s will (i.e., the general will) determines the wills of the individuals who constitute the people, even if they are unaware of it. In a manner reminiscent of both Hobbes and Locke, then, the sovereign will *is* the will of the individuals within the state.

Given the similarity of Rousseau’s thought to Hobbes’s on this point, it is not difficult to account for the strikingly Hobbesian tone of central elements of his

theory. For example, Rousseau (1997b) argues that the state's constitution involves the "total alienation" of each individual and "all of his [*sic*] rights" to the community as the fundamental condition of equality (50). So it is that each of us place ourselves "under the supreme direction of the general will" and receive one another as "indivisible parts" of the whole (50). Part of what it means to be placed under the supreme direction of the general will, of what it means to be an indivisible part of the whole, is that any particular individual's will is "really" the general will, even if they themselves are not aware of it, having alienated their individual authority to the sovereign people.

The general will's end or goal is the people's freedom and equality (78). Yet Rousseau's (1997b) formulation of the general will in relation to the people sounds decidedly inequitable. While he insists that the people subject to the laws ought also to be their author, he also writes that a "blind multitude" "rarely knows what is good for it" and is therefore often ignorant of *what* it wills. Thus, the people "always wills the good," but "does not always see it," with the result that individuals "see the good they reject," while the people "wills the good it does not see." The solution to this difficulty? Individuals must be "*obligated to conform their wills to their reason*," while the people "must be taught to *know what it wills*" (68, emphases added). This coercive need explains why the social body requires both will *and* power, in the form of the executive (82). So it is that, in one of Rousseau's most complex and controversial formulations, individuals refusing to abide by the general will "shall be *constrained to do so* by the entire body," such that they "*shall be forced to be free*" (53, emphases added). The people's retroactive constitution as an effect of the general will explains, following a logic very similar to what we have seen in Hobbes, why such coercion is not presented as a straightforward denial of freedom. The transfer of sovereignty to the people, which only speaks in the form of the general will, is such that the sovereign will actually *constitutes* individuals' "true" will, whether or not they themselves recognize or experience it.

On such a reading, Talmon's (1968) interpretation of Rousseau as a proto-totalitarian theorist is understandable. Rousseau's general will is, on his interpretation, "something like a mathematical truth or a Platonic idea. It has objective existence of its own, whether perceived or not. It has nevertheless to be discovered by the human mind" (41). The general will is not, strictly speaking, something reflecting the sovereign people's will, so much as an objective reality recognized by the people: "there is such a thing as an objective general will, whether willed or not willed by anybody" (43).

On this interpretation, Rousseau's appeal to the general will not only hearkens to Hobbes's political theory, but also suggests a great deal of commonality with Locke's natural law appeal. Consistent with this, Talmon (1968) argues that "Rousseau's sovereign is the externalized general will, and ... stands for essentially the same as the natural harmonious order" (43). The general will's objective nature provides the legitimate reason behind "forcing" individuals to be free:

freedom is the capacity of ridding oneself of considerations, interests, preferences, and prejudices, whether personal or collective, which obscure the objectively true and good, which, if I am true to my true nature, I am bound to will. What applies to the individual applies equally to the people. Man [*sic*] and people have to be brought to choose freedom and, if necessary, to be forced to be free.

(42)

Thus, “if the people does not will it [the general will], it must be made to will it, for the general will is latent in the people’s will” (43).

Talmon (1968) detects a deep contradiction in Rousseau’s thought on this point between, on the one hand, his insistence on popular sovereignty’s inviolability and, on the other hand, his “physiocratic” interest on unanimity, social order, and harmony (44, 45, 46). Rousseau, he writes, “could never decide what he wanted, to release human nature or to moralize it by breaking it; to be alone or a part of human company” (38). In the end, Talmon does not think Rousseau left this issue unresolved; rather, he sacrificed the individual to the collective. Thus,

it is not the self-expression of the individual, the deployment of his particular faculties and the realization of his own and unique mode of existence, that is the final aim, but the loss of the individual in the collective entity by taking on its colour and principle of existence.

(42)

Caught in the “agony” of the tension between private impulse and “the duties of civilized society,” and barring “a return to the untroubled state of nature,” the only options are “a complete self-abandonment to the element impulses or to ‘denature (*denature*) man [*sic*]’ altogether” (39). Too much a thinker of his age for his own good, Rousseau’s “original postulates” were “unity and unanimity” (44), which could come only through the sacrifice of the individual to collective political life.

The “expectation of unanimity,” argues Talmon (1968), brings with it “the implication of dictatorship” (46), highlighting the blind spot at the very center of Rousseau’s political thought: “in the pre-democratic age Rousseau could not realize that the originally deliberative creation of men [*sic*] could become transformed into a Leviathan, which might crush its own makers” (47). The people, expressing itself in the general will, stands “in place of the Physiocratic enlightened despot,” the natural consequence of Rousseau’s appeal to sovereignty’s indivisibility (45, 46). In seeming confirmation of this assessment, Rousseau (1997b) insists that the social body’s creation requires “transforming each individual who by himself [*sic*] is a perfect and solitary whole into part of a larger whole from which that individual would as it were receive his [*sic*] life and his [*sic*] being” (69). Legislation attains its highest possible “pitch of perfection” only when “the force acquired by the whole is equal or superior to the sum of the natural forces of all the individuals,” so that “each Citizen is nothing and can do nothing except with all the others” (69).

Rousseau (1997b) further develops this point concerning perfection in a manner that seems to lend credence to the totalitarian interpretation of his thought, arguing that such perfection is so unnatural that instituting a people is tantamount to “changing human nature” (69). The work of legislation therefore requires “an undertaking beyond human force,” but possesses an authority “that is nil” to do so (70). This nullity of executive force gives rise to the need for an additional office, one that is neither that of sovereign nor executive, one that “gives the republic its constitution” while nevertheless having “no place within its constitution” (69). This is the office Rousseau outlines in his discussion of “the Lawgiver,” a required supplement to the people, a “superior intelligence” aware of individual passions but subject to none of them (68). The Lawgiver lacks recourse to either force or reasoning and must therefore appeal to authority of another kind. (71). It is thus that the Lawgiver must place the people’s decisions “in the mouth of the immortals” to raise them above “vulgar men” (71). For Talmon (1968) this is evidence that “the whole aim of political life is really to educate and prepare men [*sic*] to will the general will without any sense of constraint” (42). The license given to the Lawgiver, in their wisdom surpassing that of the “vulgar” masses, to “rally by divine authority those whom human prudence could not move” (71) does, indeed, seem to overflow all sense of constraint. On the totalitarian reading then, Rousseau not only insists on the “perfection” that comes through political unanimity, but enforces the imposition of such unanimity through dependence on the lawgiver.

Rousseau’s Queer Social Body

Considerations like these certainly seem to lend substantial weight to the totalitarian reading of Rousseau’s political theory. As I have suggested, however, the foregoing fails to register its full complexity and texture. Attending to these textures opens a very different reading, offering the theoretical resources for a different account of the social body more in keeping with the vision cast in the previous chapter. On this reading, dissent plays a central role in the general will’s constitution, thereby representing the expression of a morphologically fluid, queer social body with no normative, predetermined shape. What emerges is a recognition of the social body as fundamentally unnatural, marking a stark departure from the natural attitude of embodiment operative in both Hobbes and Locke.

Denaturing the Social Body

Denaturing Nature and the Political Order

Talmon’s treatment of the role of nature in Rousseau’s thought provides a useful point for entering into this discussion. On the one hand, he attributes to

Rousseau the essentially Lockean notion that society's institution through the social contract is an expression of individuals' natural sociality (see Locke 1988, 352), hence his argument that the general will is an instantiation of "the natural harmonious order" (Talmon 1968, 43), presenting Rousseau as a kind of natural law theorist. At the same time, however, Talmon argues that this imposition of pre-existing natural order represents a fundamental denial of the natural subjectivity of the individuals who constitute the state. The "denaturing" undertaken in Rousseau's theory amounts to a denial of "the self-expression of the individual, the deployment of his particular faculties and realization of his own and unique mode of existence" as the "final aim" of social life (42), and of "an essential concomitant of democracy, namely, diversity of views and interests" (44). On this account, Rousseau denies the natural self-expression of the individuals who compose the social body by imposing the harmony of nature on the social order.

Talmon's reading is instructively right and wrong simultaneously. Rousseau *does* reject the notion that the final aim of social life is individual expression. While will's centrality in Rousseau's theory certainly marks him as a species of voluntarist, he is not, ultimately, an individualist. He also articulates a need to "denature" individuals by emphasizing the need to overcome the particularity of individual will (see Riley 2006, 140).⁷ But attention to Rousseau's treatment of natural law reveals a marked departure from the Lockean notion that the state's formation is a fundamentally natural act, contra Talmon, casting the entirety of his political theory in a completely different light.

We gain a clearer view of Rousseau's understanding of natural law by briefly considering his earlier *Discourse on the Origin of Inequality* (Rousseau 2011). There, his political thought starts with a marked critique of the understanding of natural law in his competitors' theories (Inston 2012, 19). He undertakes his investigation of natural law "less in the hope of resolving the question than with the intention of clarifying it and of reducing it to its true state" (40). He then proceeds to reveal the "true state" of natural law appeals to be conceptually vacuous and theoretically self-serving.

He first highlights natural law theorists' insistence that "the principles of this science must be deduced from this very nature of man [*sic*], from man's [*sic*] constitution and nature" (Rousseau 2011, 41). Given the supposed ubiquity of sources for knowledge of natural law (i.e., all human beings), Rousseau expresses mock "surprise and a sense of outrage" at the lack of agreement as to what, precisely, natural law's contents might be (41). Despite the purported universality of a natural law accessible to all rational beings, competing definitions of natural law are, in fact, "in perpetual contradiction with one another," agreeing only that "it is impossible to understand the law of nature and consequently to obey it without being a great reasoner and a profound metaphysician" (41). Indeed, knowledge of natural law proves not to be "natural" at all:

all those definitions that are found in books have, over and above a lack of uniformity, the added fault of being drawn from several branches of knowledge that men *do not naturally have*, and from advantages the idea of which they cannot conceive *until after having left the state of nature*.

(41, *emphases added*)

This lack of intelligibility concerning natural law is such that, while “the philosophers who have examined the foundations of society have all felt the necessity of returning to the state of nature,” the fact is that “none of them has reached it” (45). Appeals to natural law amount to little more than a retroactive projection of contemporary concerns, “transferr[ing] to the state of nature the ideas they themselves acquired in society” (46). Borrowing Patrick Riley’s (2006) statement of the issue, natural law formulations are, for Rousseau, “scarcely natural” at all (143).

Political philosophers (and Rousseau explicitly references the thought of Locke and Hobbes among his examples) routinely seek political life’s foundations in the state of nature and appeals to natural law but fail to find it. In a particularly telling statement, Rousseau (2011) notes that these thinkers failed to consider what he sees as the most likely explanation for these theoretical lacunae: “it did not even occur to most of our philosophers to doubt that the state of nature had existed” at all (46). In his view, such appeals’ theoretical function is to legitimize whatever principles the theorists in question *already* value as foundational for society:

writers begin by seeking the rules on which, for the common utility, it would be appropriate for men to agree among themselves; and then they give the name *natural law* to the collection of these rules, with no other proof than the good that presumably would result from their universal observance.

(41)

Appeals to society’s foundations in “natural law” therefore represent theorists’ retrojection of their privileged principles of social foundation into a mythical past as an act of legitimation, thereby providing “a very convenient way to compose definitions and explain the nature of things by virtually arbitrary views of what is seemly” (41).

And yet, while Rousseau rejects the intelligibility of appeals to the state of nature, he does not simply jettison it from his political theory, instead adopting the language of the exit from the state of nature with entrance into the social contract and the political state’s constitution. This raises an obvious question: what role does such appeal play in his political theory, given its alleged political vacuity? Rousseau (2011) refers to this as a “*hypothetical history* of governments” and suggests that it provides “an instructive lesson for man [*sic*] in every respect” (43, *emphasis added*), inviting us to consider in what sense this is the case.

As Kevin Inston (2010) suggests, Rousseau’s critique of natural law appeals and the state of nature represents an assertion of “the impossibility of final and

objective social grounds" (19). *This*, rather than his rejection of liberal individualism, marks the fundamental site of "denaturing" in Rousseau's theory. "The image of nature does not offer a model to be imitated by the social contract, but reveals society's inherent contingency, its lack of *natural* justification" (Inston 2012, 21; emphasis added). Theorists' retroactive imposition of arguments for society's foundation into the state of nature highlight, for Rousseau, that "we reflect on society's grounding only once its absence appears through the conflicts caused by human interaction" (22). Indeed, the mythical nature of appeals to natural law and the state of nature reveal for Rousseau (2011) that sociability itself is not natural (contra Locke) (42); if it were, it would not be so difficult to achieve, and neither the political state nor its institutions and positive laws would be necessary.

The vices that make social institutions necessary are the same ones that make their abuses inevitable Any government that always operated in conformity with the purpose for which it was founded without being corrupted or altered, would have been needlessly instituted.

(87)

While natural law theories "naturalized society," then, Rousseau's theory "de-naturalizes" it" (Inston 2012, 26). There is no natural or objective foundation to political society that can assure its proper role or function. And yet, crucially, as Inston also notes, this heightens, rather than eliminates, the question of social foundations (19). The theoretical value of state-of-nature appeals lies in the "negativity of nature," rather than in any positive content to nature or natural law: The subtraction of any positive social content from nature heightens its difference from society, serving to highlight social and political forms' utter contingency (26). The only natural commonality underlying and grounding human society is precisely the *lack* of any natural ground (125). Political society's basis resides in a tensive relationship between similarity and difference: "the desire for association starts with an awareness of difference and that awareness leads us to apprehend what we share in common: a need for social order to protect our freedom" (125). This lends sense to Rousseau's (1997b) assertion that society is necessary precisely *because of* the conflict of particular interests, on the one hand, but that "what these different interests have in common is what forms the social bond," on the other (57). As Inston (2012) sums up the issue, "the contract's identity as a source of order only makes sense because of the permanent threat of disorder subtending it" (125).

Rousseau's "ontological weakening" of natural law therefore does not simply eliminate it from consideration or invalidate its theoretical value; on the contrary, it becomes an "absent presence haunting all attempts to make legitimate positive laws" (Inston 2012, 20). The question of social grounds remains—demands regarding the legitimacy of political institutions, procedures, and positive laws will

be leveled, and responses must be given. But “nature’s” emptiness reveals that any such justifications necessarily remain contingent; they are never fixed or fully assured (21). Acknowledgment of this contingency represents neither political nihilism nor an abdication of political responsibility. On the contrary, it heightens political responsibility, insofar as the responsibility for justifying such institutions and practices cannot be fobbed off to nature but lies squarely at the feet of those who constitute, participate in, and perpetuate those political regimes (20):

the lack of objective standards does not undermine morality and politics ... but rather inaugurates it. Because of that lack, we have to decide how to devise and implement laws which foster our safe and free existence; we have to reconstruct the pre-reflexive natural principles politically.

(23)

The lack of the state’s natural foundations denatures not only its institutions and practices but reveals the contingent and shifting nature of the people constituting the state as well. If there is no law regulating either human nature or the political order, both are rendered contingent. Thus, Rousseau (2011) insists on the “immense space that separates” the “natural state” from the “civil state” (90). “The human race of one age,” he suggests,

is not the human race of another age The soul and human passions are imperceptibly altered and, as it were, *change their nature* ... in the long run, our needs and our pleasures change their objects ... with the original man [*sic*] gradually disappearing, society no longer offers to the eyes of the wise man [*sic*] anything but an assemblage of *artificial men* [*sic*] and *factitious passions* which are the work of all these new relations and have *no true foundation* in nature.

(90, *emphases added*)

In the *Geneva Manuscript*, Rousseau (1997a) explicitly states that “there is no natural and general society among men [*sic*].” He goes on, however, to situate political society’s origin precisely in this lack of natural society: “by means of new associations, let us correct, if possible, the lack of a general association” (159). In discussing the transition from the state of nature to society, then, Rousseau explicitly grounds the latter in a process of de-naturing, insisting that “humankind would perish if it did not change its way of being” (Rousseau 1997b, 49).

Yet, as Inston (2010) suggests, this dual contingency of humanity and society, their lack of objective grounds, is paradoxically the ground of political freedom: “the negativity of nature supplies the affirmative condition of our freedom to reject the present moment and its determination of social truth and reconstruct it in line with current aspirations and demands” (36). The state of nature and natural law become an “empty place” grounding the social, with the effect that “society, stripped of necessary content, can always be imagined and arranged in

ways that go beyond given reality” (36). Talmon is therefore correct to suggest the significance of denaturing in Rousseau’s thought. His mistake lies in his failure to realize just how thorough and pervasive this denaturing is, calling into question even the social foundations which he himself continues to take for granted.

Denaturing Will

Talmon overlooks the presence in Rousseau’s thought of *both* an insistence on individual freedom *and* the state’s legitimation in the expression of the general will, thereby understanding Rousseau to simply subsume the former in the latter. As Rousseau (1997b) insists, however, civil association is “the most voluntary act in the world” (123) and individual acts are “deprived of morality” if they are not voluntary (45). As Riley (2006) suggests, then, the individual’s freedom actually becomes the starting point for untangling Rousseau’s political theory, specifically regarding the general will. As he puts it, “had Rousseau not been centrally concerned with freedom—above all with the voluntariness of morally legitimate human actions—some of his political thought’s structural features would be (literally) unaccountable” (124; see also 148).

Individuals’ voluntary entrance into social life is one such structural feature. Rousseau (1997b) insists that, left to their own devices, individuals’ natural inclination is to exercise their freedom in conformity with their particular wills, which direct action only toward their own advantage (see 87), which is why any emphasis on freedom runs the risk of falling prey to “deceit and manipulation” (Inston 2012, 36). This explains why, for Rousseau, appeals to reason and law alone are insufficient: such appeals’ necessity is proof that they are, in themselves, insufficient to govern or redirect the passions directing individual wills (Riley 2006, 143). The general will that governs shared political life therefore runs counter to the natural inclinations governing individual wills, confronting us with a significant difficulty in explaining the possibility of individuals’ voluntary entrance into shared social life. Indeed, this difficulty is such that Rousseau describes it as “squaring the circle” (124).

For Rousseau, the will’s congruence “with *shaping and becoming*” (Inston 2012, 144) makes this “squaring” possible. With his concept of the general will, Rousseau is *not* appealing to nature or natural law. Indeed, Riley (2006) notes Rousseau’s “radical doubts about the real existence of any universal” (140), including a natural law to guide will’s exercise. As a result, Rousseau’s will operates apart from any conception of “objective ends” (127), so that reason lacks inherent causative force in relation to the will, in contrast, for example, to Kant’s conception of will (139). Individuals must be “de-natured” to will the general will, rather than merely their individual particular wills, but this de-naturing cannot be based on anything universal or objective; it is not an operation of reason alone. The general will then, is “nonnatural ... artificially produced (over time)” (115).

Rousseau (1997b) argues that political life is not governed by reason or the passions alone, but by the “union of will and understanding” (68). Social life is possible because the will is malleable and individual passions can be shaped in new directions. But this shaping does not occur naturally or automatically: as Riley (2006) sums up the issue,

in the end, for Rousseau, no *moral universelle*—not a Christian one based on universal charity, not a Diderotian one grounded in passion-silencing reason, not a Kantian one resting on reason-ordained “objective ends”—can help in the transformation of natural men into denatured citizens.

(144)

Civic education is the means for shaping the will. Rousseau “wanted to endow human beings with a will, a really efficacious ‘power’ of choosing, which can then be subjected to the generalizing influence of civic education” (146). Will and understanding are united through the process of civic education, so that the general will emerges as a “collective will,” simultaneously “constructed *and* voluntary” (Inston 2012, 127, emphasis added).

Given Rousseau’s simultaneous insistence on the need to overcome the particularities of the individual will and his rejection of the notion of a universal to guide all wills, the “general” of the general will marks a position between the particular and universal (Riley 2006, 126, 134, 142). The general will is “neither merely ‘private’ nor simply ‘rational,’” but is “general rather than universal” (145), constituting a shared standpoint which must be attained (140). Individuals must be “de-natured” in such a way that their combined willing may be “*made* general,” thereby “generalizing” the will (130–131).⁸

Rousseau’s thought here is complex, and Riley (2006) notes that the “relation of will to authority—of autonomy to educative ‘shaping,’” is “one of the most difficult problems in Rousseau” (132). The generalizing of will takes shape via social and political processes of identification and agreement, whereby new political identities are constructed (Inston 2012, 127). In keeping with the recognition that will is not effectively directed through reason alone, these processes require what Rousseau (1997a) describes as the formation of “new sentiments” (159). Inston develops this point through an elaboration of Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe’s account of hegemonic articulation, which involves “the linking together of different identities and political forces into a common project and as the building of new social orders from dispersed elements” (127). The overlap of Rousseau’s political theory with Laclau and Mouffe’s should not be surprising (see Laclau 2000, 55), given that both theories are fundamentally concerned with the formation of shared “generality” on a social terrain where the individual actors share no natural or metaphysical grounding (i.e., no *moral universelle* or “objective ends”). On such a terrain, the central task is the performative construction of a commonality that does not preexist its own construction, a commonality which must be attained absent “objective ends.”⁹

“For Rousseau and Laclau,” Inston (2010) suggests, “the universal ... lacks any necessary content, symbolizing the absent fullness of society” (126). The only common feature of those entering into the social contract is their shared *lack* of any pre-given commonality. As with Rousseau’s appeal to the absent state of nature, however, this lack of pre-given commonality is theoretically productive. Those entering into the social contract must construct a common basis for society precisely *because* no such commonality pre-exists that construction. The theoretical concept of political articulation draws on this same principle, which is fundamental to the queerly democratic practice outlined in the previous chapter (see also Miller 2016, 185–195, 199–234). The political demands leveled by individuals or groups are demands for what they currently lack, and therefore represent appeals to a fullness of political identity they do not currently possess—were this not the case, they would have no need to level such demands in the first place (see Miller 2018, 3–5). Political demands therefore do not express a “fullness” of political agency, but a productive absence at its heart. They are claims to what is currently “missing” from the political subjects who emerge through the project of leveling them. This is why the leveling of such demands necessarily amounts to an unmaking of the social body: they contest shared political and social life’s purported fullness and adequacy, revealing the occlusions, exclusions, and denials around which it takes shape. Equivalential articulation names the process whereby the missing “something” that would complete the political or social identity of a particular individual or group (i.e., the object of political demand) is articulated as being equivalent to the “something” demanded by other individuals or groups, thereby forging a shared or, in Riley’s (2006) terms, “general,” socio-political identity out of particular individuals and groups.

Rousseau’s conception of the general will represents an example of equivalential articulation *avant la lettre*. While there are no universals, no objective ends, which determine the contours of social or political identity, the political is nevertheless constituted around a “contingent universality.” This has to do with the names signifying political identity’s missing fullness to which political demands lay claim (Miller 2019, 46). These signifiers are “universal” in the sense that virtually all political actors appeal to them, and they are familiar to us for precisely this reason (examples include “freedom,” “equality,” “rights,” “justice,” etc.). But they are also contingent insofar as they are “empty,” lacking universally shared meaning, significance, or social referents. They are, then, contingently universal insofar as they enjoy virtually universal appeal among political actors, while the only reason they enjoy such appeal is that these diverse actors do not assign them the same meanings. Such contingent signifiers therefore operate universally only because divergent social actors “fill” them in different ways, rendering their meaning and socio-political force variable and contingent. Successful equivalential articulation occurs when a particular way of “filling in” a universal signifier is, again borrowing Riley’s phrase, “generalized,” constituting a particular individual or group’s interest(s) as *equivalent* to other individuals’ or

groups' interests, resulting in the emergence of a common political identity, defined by a new "common sense" (Laclau and Mouffe 2001, 183–184; Miller 2019, 4–5), Rousseau's (1997a) "new sentiments" (159).

As Inston (2012) suggests, then, "like Laclau's contingent universal" the general will "has 'no necessary body and necessary content'" (129; Laclau 1996, 35), as illustrated in Rousseau's (1997b) insistence that the general will's end, goal, or object is the common good (57), an empty signifier if ever there was one. The general will "names the missing unity around which divergent beings converge, supplementing it with decisions about how to build society" (Inston 2012, 129). That is, the general will, insofar as it expresses the "common good," emerges as the effect of the political will's equivalential articulation. It is a "generalized particular" (126), a "generalization" of will that emerges only as broader and broader segments of social and political society actively identify with it *as* the good they all share in common.

Far from representing an appeal to natural law or Platonic truth, then, the general will emerges as a political task. Highlighting the centrality of will and affect (i.e., "sentiment") in Rousseau's thought, individuals "become socialized only by *identifying with* social institutions and forms" (Inston 2012, 135) in the absence of any pre-given identity around which the social takes shape or pre-given content of the common good. The general will's grant of legitimacy to political society holds only if individuals *freely* acknowledge the general will *as* general, which depends upon the will's malleability. Laclau's notion of "investment" highlights this identification as simultaneously free and affectively driven, insofar as socio-political identities take shape as divergent individuals and groups come to be actively "invested in" the equivalentially articulated names given to the missing fullness of their political subjectivity (Laclau 2000, 81; 2004, 287). As Inston (2010) puts it, "for the contract to work, we have to change our 'way of being' voluntarily, to commit ourselves actively and passionately to the principles of freedom and equality" (135). Rousseau (1997b) expresses this point when he identifies the "fundamental problem" addressed by the social contract as the need for "a form of association" that will provide the common force needed to protect individuals but which will *also* ensure that individuals, by "uniting with all," simultaneously obey only themselves and "remain as free as before" (49–50). Identification with the equivalentially articulated common good therefore forms the basis for the "new sentiments" necessary for social life (Rousseau 1997a, 159). We can state this dynamic of identification and will formation in terms Bourdieu's dynamic of internalization and externalization, outlined in Chapter 1. Identification constitutes an example of internalized political articulation shaping political subjectivity, which is then expressed as the "externalization" of will (see Bourdieu 1977, 72).

Once appeal to a pre-existing natural law or state of nature is abandoned, then, Rousseau's general will emerges *not* as the expression of a fixed natural or Platonic form, but as a purely contingent effect of political articulation. As a generalized effect of equivalential articulation marking a domain between the particular and the

universal, the general will is such that the “always incomplete separation of the general from the particular leaves the former susceptible to being challenged and modified by the latter” (Inston 2012, 130; see Rousseau 1997b, 60). As Rousseau (1997b) suggests,

while it is not impossible that a particular will agree with the general will on some point, it is in any event impossible for this agreement to be lasting and constant; for the particular will tends, by its nature, to partiality, and general will to equality.

(57)

This highlights the undecidable relation between general and particular (Inston 2012, 130).

The general will’s contingency is such that the order constituted by the social contract can never be total because it can never be final or complete. Insofar as entry into the social contract is spurred by the lack of commonality, political disagreement serves as the basis for shared political life (Inston 2012, 128–129). This, combined with the undecidability of general and particular, ensures that any social or political unity expressed in the general will is necessarily temporary in nature (Inston 2012, 131). The social body’s constitution around the general will is therefore never an accomplished fact, but an ongoing, continuous process. As Steven Affeldt (1999) points out, then, “will, for Rousseau, is essentially an act of willing and therefore cannot ‘be equated with or ensured by any concrete embodiment in established laws’” (306). As Rousseau (1990) suggests, “today’s law should not be an act of yesterday’s general will, but of today’s, and we have engaged ourselves to do not what everyone has willed, but what everyone now wills” (103). As Inston (2012) suggests, then, “only a continuous act of willing conditions the state’s legitimacy” (131). Any other conception, in Rousseau’s mind, undermines the people’s sovereignty (Rousseau 1990, 103).

Rousseau’s formulation of the general will as contingent and inherently incomplete obviously resonates with the account of queer democracy and the *demos*’s constitutive incompleteness outlined in the previous chapter. To recall, we saw that the *demos* is constitutively incomplete, insofar as actors with novel political identities emerge within the social in contingent and unforeseeable forms, leveling demands for inclusion within the *demos*. When those actors’ demands are recognized as legitimate and they gain a place within the *demos*, its constitution is necessarily changed. Further, the leveling of such demands necessarily unmakes the social body, contesting the normativity of its current morphology, revealing that the *demos*’s “rule” (Gr. *kratos*) lies in this productive unmaking and subsequent emergence of a social body with a novel morphology. Queer democracy, then, names a political practice expressing a dispositional affirmation of the ongoing contestation of the *demos*’s identity at any given time, with a view to expanding the principles of freedom and equality to increasingly expansive social

and political spheres. Relating these points to Rousseau's theory, we can now see that the *demos's* expansion in this way concomitantly requires the general will's expansion.

Given the resonances of Rousseau's theory with queer democracy, it is appropriate to think of the general will as the "will of the *demos*." Inston (2012) highlights these points well. Because the general will is always the will as generalized, and is therefore marked by the undecidability of general and particular, its formulation at any given moment is continually open to contestation. The general will "remains forever haunted by the particular interests ... from which it differentiates itself to acquire universal representation" so that, as noted above, the general will continually remains open to challenge and modification by particular interests. Because the general will is never an accomplished fact or a mute objective body within social and political life (contra Tolman), it necessarily remains open to novel reformulations (130). Like the *demos*, the general will is itself constitutively incomplete, paradoxically always outstanding, "remaining infinitely open to being willed otherwise" (131). If we understand queerly democratic practice as an expression of "will," then the general will's emergent nature goes hand in hand with that of the *demos*, representing, paradoxically, the expression of the socially inexpressible and revealing the social body's fundamental queerness.

The understanding of the general will as the will of the constitutively incomplete, morphologically queer *demos* helps to account for some of Rousseau's more problematic formulations regarding both the people and its expression of the general will. His insistence on the people's unrepresentable nature offers one such example. Taken at face value, this assertion seems a patent misstatement, given that the executive surely plays a representative role, at least in the minimal sense of representing the *demos* in the law's actual execution. If, however, the *demos* and the general will are performative in nature, political *tasks* forever in-process, rather than accomplished social facts, the *demos's* unrepresentable nature is clearer, registering the recognition that while institutions, structures, and procedures for governance (i.e., government) are necessary (i.e., they represent Canovan's (1999) "pragmatic face" of democracy) (11), the *demos* cannot be *reduced* to those institutions, structures, and procedures. The emergent *demos* can never simply be coextensive with the mechanisms of state.

The understanding of the general will as an emergent, constitutively incomplete effect of political contestation can also help to shed light on Rousseau's (1997b) language of individuals being "forced to be free" (53), one of the most contentious elements of his thought. His suggestion that those entering into the social contract transfer their "person and full power" to the sovereign people should be read as a claim about the "sentiments" or dispositions of those entering into the contract, rather than a description of subordination or subjugation. Indeed, the latter position makes little sense, given the constitutively incomplete nature of the *demos* and the general will, which require thinking the *demos's* sovereignty in terms other than that of efficacious will (a point we will revisit below).

The situation is very different, however, if we take Rousseau's statement about enforced freedom as a statement about disposition or sentiment. Agreement to submit to the *demos's* sovereign authority, given its constitutive incompleteness, represents an affirmation of its nature *as* incomplete. That is, such agreement represents an affirmation of the *demos's* and social body's continual unmaking through ongoing queerly democratic practices; it represents a dispositional affirmation of the queer, morphologically fluid social body and the *demos's* open-ended emergence. To be "forced to be free" is to enter into the contingency that defines the *demos's* becoming and the general will's expression, with all the unforeseeable consequences this necessarily implies.

Rousseau's theory involves an irreducible moral dimension at this point, keyed to affect and disposition, which should not be overlooked. In keeping with his insistence on the malleability of will and sentiment, Rousseau argues that upon entering into the social contract, it becomes possible for individuals to identify with society as a whole (Wootton 2011, xxii) and, through this identification, to become dispositionally oriented to the general will. Upon entering into society, then, what Rousseau calls *amour de soi*, "love of self," is transformed into *amour propre*, or "self-love." *Amour de soi*, which simply "directs us to the enjoyment of our proper goods" (Dent 1992, 35) and represents "a healthy instinct for self-preservation, neither moral nor immoral, but necessary" (Wootton 2011, xxi), becomes *amour propre* when the "goods" we seek come necessarily to involve interaction with others (Dent 1992, 35). Dent (1992) suggests that *amour propre* "directs us to secure for ourselves recognition from others and a standing in society in which we are honored as significant beings ..." (35). So understood, *amour propre* has no inherent moral status (Inston 2012, 64).¹⁰

Amour propre, however, often transforms into political vice, having to do with "seeing what is good and valuable for oneself in terms of others' lack of these things, in terms of others being of little or no account in comparison with oneself" (Dent 1992, 34), in which case it is appropriately translated as "egoism," "vanity," "pride," "self-aggrandizement," and so on. In such cases, *amour propre* becomes "a corrupt, competitive desire to seem better than others, to be envied" (Wootton 2011, xxi). The direction of individual will, then, can be generalized, identifying with the common good, so that others are perceived "as a source of care and support from whom one can readily expect recognition and to whom one can then equally readily grant it" (Dent 1992, 35). But it can also be "particularized," in which case the individual seeks their own good in a manner "not tied by sentiment or obligation to others in any way" (Dent 1992, 187).

To reiterate, there is nothing natural or automatic about the cultivation and maintenance of such dispositions and moral orientations; they are, on the contrary, effects of denaturing. Rousseau's point is that individuals must be "forced to be general" in their willing (Riley 2006, 125–126). That is, if Rousseau never abandons his insistence that participation within the *demos* must be voluntary, he also recognizes that the dispositional commitment to such participation, insofar as

it requires active identification with the emergent general will, comes neither naturally nor easily. The undecidability of general and particular is such that we can easily mistake our narrow interests for those expressed in the general will. Nonetheless, by remaining dispositionally oriented to participation in the *demos*'s ongoing emergence, we *submit ourselves* to the general will's authority—we place ourselves, freely, under the strictures of actively seeking (i.e., willing) the common good and identifying with it, even at the cost of our own identity's unmaking. By being “forced” to remain affected by the constitutive incompleteness of the *demos* and general will, by committing ourselves, via that ongoing participation, to the transcendence of our own particular will, *even when unrecognized as such*, we are “forced” to act according to the freedom to which we remain dispositionally oriented. Precisely insofar as the *demos*'s contours are never fixed and the general will is never an accomplished fact, our participation within the *demos*, *particularly* when we dissent, represents an ongoing recognition that *there is no other authority upon which we can lean* beyond our own (and others') free participation. This dispositional reading preserves Rousseau's consistent emphasis on individual freedom which, if occluded, as in the authoritarian or populist reading, renders his whole theory incoherent.

This is why Rousseau (1997b) is correct to suggest that “if my particular opinion had prevailed, I would have done something other than what I willed, and it is then that I would not have been free” (124). The undecidability of the general will and my particular will always remain, so that I may mistake the latter for the former. Indeed, the situation may be more complex than this: given that the general will's formation is always ongoing, there *may be no* correct answer to the question as to whether or not my particular will corresponds with the general will. Determining the boundary between general and particular is not simply a matter of reasoning or epistemology, but of affective disposition as well. As Inston (2010) suggests, “we can *never be sure* that the general will is truly general or just a particular masquerading as general” (132). Our desire for the social body's queerly democratic unmaking can easily morph into a disposition to preserve a social order that benefits us at others' expense. The combination of generality and will is therefore such that the general will necessarily expresses a kind of “split personality” (131). Thus, Rousseau (1997b) correctly highlights the legitimate possibility that “when the opinion contrary to my own prevails, it proves nothing more than that I made a mistake and took to be the general will what was not” (124). If the general will is constitutively incomplete, emerging only through processes of political contestation and identification, it can be true, as Rousseau suggests, *both* that the general will is “always upright and always tends to the public utility” *and* that “the people's deliberations” are not (59). It is only on the presumption that the general will represents a Platonic reality as suggested by Talmon that such a formulation poses a theoretical difficulty.

The individual will's de-naturing does not involve its abolition, as suggested by populist or totalitarian readings of Rousseau's theory, but its transformation, and

concomitantly that of individuals' acts of willing, so that the individual will does not devolve into the vice of crass egoism or individualism. Achieving this moral aim is not a matter of "thinking" differently or acting against one's will, but of fundamentally transforming the will through the shaping of "sentiment," or what we have been calling disposition. As Gourevitch (1997) suggests, "to unite wills, the passion to be counted on is love, specifically the form of love which Rousseau calls *amour propre*, suitably generalized to make the common good and hence the general will an object of true attachment" (xxii).

The Queerly Sovereign *Demos*

Rousseau's account of the general will's contingency and the people's constitution as an ongoing political task provides the theoretical resources for imagining the social body in a way that disrupts the fantasy of its morphological normativity. It gestures toward the recognition of a queer, morphologically fluid social body that is always coming to be, a body marked by a productive "(un)becoming" (Sullivan 2006, 560), a body the vibrancy of which owes to the fact that it *has no* normative, proper shape. Yet, in his explicit invocations of the social body, this is not what we find in Rousseau. Instead, we encounter in his theory another dysphoric response to the morphologically non-normative social body that threatens to undermine the otherwise revolutionary force of his thought. Despite his skepticism concerning appeals to nature, when it comes to thinking the social body, Rousseau remains, once more borrowing Stryker's (2006) telling word, "bedeviled" by it (247). He remains resolutely beholden to the natural attitude of embodiment, according to which any transmogrification of the social body can only elicit a dysphoric response. The proximate source of this dysphoria is his insistence, with Hobbes, on sovereign indivisibility and the argument that any division of sovereignty produces a monstrous or grotesque social body.

Rousseau runs the risk of succumbing to the same fate as Locke, whose theory's potential as a resource for queer democracy is effectively foreclosed by his appeal to a morphologically normative social body. It would be an overstatement to suggest that reconciling the queerly democratic impulses in Rousseau's theory with his dysphoric response to the morphologically non-normative social body is simple. Nonetheless, there remain within his theory the conceptual resources for thinking the concept of the "sovereign people" in a way that affirms the social body's fundamental queerness. If it is not clear that Rousseau himself would countenance such a reimagining of his political theory, it nevertheless builds on resources internal to it.

As a starting point in this reformulation, I propose that Rousseau's insistence on sovereignty's indivisibility not be taken as a statement about the ordering of the people, but as a gesture toward a distinction between the people as sovereign and the government as executive. Both his warnings concerning sovereignty's division and his insistence on its inalienability have to do with the danger of

ceding the people's sovereignty to the government or, stated in the terms of the previous chapter, of democracy's reduction to its pragmatic dimension, to the institutional and procedural forms and mechanisms intended to enable its practice. Such a reading builds from Rousseau's formulation of government's legitimate role, on the one hand, and the dangers of contemporary neoliberal managed democracy (outlined in the previous chapter), on the other.

We have seen that Rousseau not only distinguishes between the people as sovereign and the government as executive, but also maintains the subordination of the latter to the former, repeatedly reaffirming the sovereign people's right to suspend or reconfigure the government. Government's legitimate role is to serve as an agent of the people, executing the general will and acting, somewhat paradoxically, as "an intermediate body" between subjects and sovereign (Rousseau 1997b, 83). In addition to playing this intermediary role, the government ideally also serves the educative role Riley (2006) identifies as central for the general will's shaping and production (126).

In developing these points, I am revisiting Rousseau's discussion of the "law-giver," reformulating it and combining it with what he says about government's role. Victor Gourevitch (1997) describes the concept of the lawgiver as "one of the high points—and one of the stumbling blocks" of Rousseau's thought (xxii), while Dent (1992) notes that "the figure, or function, of the 'legislator' in Rousseau's political theory strikes many people as one of its most curious, and unconvincing, elements" (144). The lawgiver fills a theoretical lacuna in Rousseau's thought, essentially having to do with questions of political legitimacy. Law, which serves as the basis of political life, is legitimate only so long as it expresses the people's general will, so that, again, those subject to the law are also its author (Rousseau 1997b, 68). This formulation sounds straightforward enough, but actually opens up significant theoretical questions.

The general will's emergence from the "blind multitude" (Rousseau 1997b, 68) of individuals requires, as we have seen, the shaping of particular wills so that they can take on a "generalized" form. The state and its institutions play a crucial role in shaping the sentiments necessary for this process, with the obvious consequence that the general will's emergence requires, as its antecedent, the structures necessary for its formation. At the same time, however, the people, expressing the general will, are to serve as the state's foundation. Rousseau (1997b) directly states the paradoxical conclusion that follows from these observations:

for a nascent people to be capable of appreciating sound maxims of politics and of following fundamental rules of reason of State, *the effect would have to become the cause*, the social spirit which is to be the work of the institution would have to preside over the institution itself, and men [*sic*] would have to be prior to laws what they ought to become by means of them.

(71, *emphasis added*)

If the state and its institutions are simultaneously the general will's cause and effect, so to speak, how can legislative and governmental processes ever come into being without sacrificing their legitimacy? Rousseau's answer is, through the lawgiver, who appears in his political theory to resolve these difficulties. The lawgiver is tasked with educating and shaping the multitude into the *demos*, seeking to enact the general will. Their role is to denature individuals so that will can be generalized in the pursuit of the common good.

Even if we recognize the theoretical need to which Rousseau's (1997b) law-giver responds, its problematically *ad hoc* and idealized nature is evident, as when he describes the lawgiver as a "superior intelligence" who "saw all of man's [*sic*] passions and experienced none of them, who had no relation to our nature yet knew it thoroughly, whose happiness was independent of us and who was nevertheless willing to care for ours" (68). As this formulation clearly illustrates, Rousseau's formulation of the lawgiver seems not to be informed by his own insight concerning the "hypothetical" nature of civil society's pre-history, thereby falling prey to mythologizing of which he is otherwise critical. In actual fact, of course, any sense of contemporary individuals "choosing" or contracting to enter civil society can only have, at best, a hypothetical, heuristic sense.¹¹ In reality, we are all, to borrow a Heideggerian phrase, "thrown" into political society (see Heidegger 1962, 174). It pre-exists us—we do not "choose" it, nor is it clear, given the ubiquity of the modern state and its authority, where we could reasonably go to escape it.¹²

This situation of "throwness" is precisely what heightens questions of political legitimacy, and it is here, insofar as it seeks to provide an account of political legitimacy, that a reformulated articulation of the lawgiver concept can still be of positive theoretical value. The aim here is to configure Rousseau's lawgiver not as a *deus ex machina* used to explain society's hypothetical origins, but as a means of testing the legitimacy of the actual states in which individuals find themselves. Rousseau's account is clearly insufficient as it stands, but his formulation does make two contributions to such a configuration: first, what Riley (2006) identifies as the lawgiver's educative *function* (126) and, second, the lawgiver's *institutional*, rather than individual, nature.

The first of these features is straightforward enough: it is the lawgiver who brings about the individual's transformation "into part of a larger whole from which that individual would as it were receive his life and his being" (Rousseau 1997b, 69). Regarding the second of these points, while Rousseau typically envisions the lawgiver as an individual person, he also locates the theoretical need for the lawgiver as arising from a consideration of how to account for the legitimacy of the state's institutions that shape the *demos* if that very legitimacy can arise only from the sovereign people itself (see 71).

With these dual emphases, we once again encounter Rousseau's anticipation of key developments in contemporary theory, in this case Bourdieu's concept of *habitus*. In reformulated terms, the lawgiver does not name an individual at

society's origins, but the complex of structures shaping the social and political dispositions of those existing within them who, in turn, also modify those existing structures. The structures in question here are the gestalt of existing political institutions, procedures, practices, and so on (essentially everything Canovan identifies as comprising democracy's pragmatic dimension), that orient and organize contemporary civic and political life, into which all those subject to political authority necessarily find themselves thrown. So understood, the lawgiver does not name an individual, but the actually existing constellation of political "structuring structures" that shape the social and political dispositions of those who find themselves always-already enmeshed within them.

Insofar as questions of origins and foundings enter into this formulation at all, they do so only with a mythical-poetic force. Rousseau (1997b) suggests that the lawgiver, in order to "rally without violence and to persuade without convincing," appeals to a "sublime reason which rises beyond the reach of vulgar men" by placing their decisions "in the mouth of the immortals, in order to rally by divine authority those whom human prudence could not move" (71). While "sublime" and "transcendent" appeals no longer tend to claim immortal or divine authority, we nevertheless encounter their contemporary analog in appeals to various national founding myths (such as, in the US context, those of a unified populace, of the "Founding Fathers," of the "intent of the framers," etc.), intended to justify and legitimate the existing gestalt of political structures and institutions.¹³ With the exception of particularly rarefied discourses, the aim of such appeals is not a factual or empirical recounting of the state's origins, but legitimation of this gestalt that transcends the vicissitudes, complexities, contingencies, and contradictions of their actual formation and ongoing operation.¹⁴

While the lawgiver, understood in these terms, clearly extends beyond the government narrowly conceived, it also encompasses it. Given Rousseau's clear position on the government's limited authority vis-à-vis the people, the lawgiver clearly cannot have the thoroughgoing and unchecked authority presupposed in the authoritarian reading of Rousseau. On the contrary, the lawgiver's legitimate role lies in shaping civic and political dispositions to the common good expressed in the general will, to produce political subjects with a *predisposition* to the common good. However, given the emergent nature of the *demos* and the general will, and therefore of the common good itself, this gestalt is, at any given historical moment, necessarily provisional in nature, standing in need of its own ongoing and continual modification. To this point, it is telling that Rousseau (1997b) also highlights the lawgiver's provisional nature, suggesting that it is displaced with the coming "maturity of the people" (73). While this certainly should not be understood as a utopian vision along the lines of the "withering of the state," it nevertheless highlights that the *demos*'s expansion through queerly democratic practice and the concomitant shift in the general will's constitution represent its "maturation" (a fitting term as long as it isn't taken in a teleological sense) beyond the bounds of any currently-existing gestalt of political institutions, practices, and procedures, necessitating their reconfiguration.

This is where the lawgiver's other dimension, in relation to the concept of *habitus*, comes into view. The gestalt of existing political institutions and practices structuring social and political life is simultaneously structured by the *demos*'s continual unmaking of the social body. The *demos*'s "continuous act of willing," expressed in queerly democratic practices, has a reciprocal structuring effect on the political gestalt. That is, as the *demos*'s constitution changes, as the people "matures" through the extension of liberty and equality to more expansive social spheres, producing concomitant shifts in social and political dispositions, elements of the existing gestalt of political institutions, legal frameworks, electoral practices, political debate, practices of judicial review, and so on, are called into question and reformulated in myriad ways, reflecting the social body's fluid morphology.

This is the framework through which we should reconsider Rousseau's critique of "divided sovereignty." If we take queerly democratic practice and the *demos*'s continual willing as expressions of its sovereignty, then sovereignty is "divided" precisely to the extent that the government and its structuring gestalt are resistant to, or actively operate to displace, the *demos*'s restructuring, which is to say, to the extent that they express a political disposition to the maintenance of a social and political order that has attained normative status. This is exactly what we confront in the regulation of the *demos* under neoliberal managed democracy's inverted totalitarianism, outlined in the previous chapter. The management of the *demos*, the effective foreclosing of queerly democratic practice, represents a dysphoric response to an improper social body and the effort to impose a normative morphology on it. This is the sense in which Rousseau's (1997b) insistence that "the instant a People gives itself Representatives, it ceases to be free; it ceases to be" (115) can be rendered meaningful, rather than hopelessly hyperbolic or contradictory. Once the queer *demos* is effectively supplanted by those institutions, structures, practices, and individuals intended to serve it, it is lost. Such is the cost when the *demos*'s "rule" (Gr. *kratos*) is reduced to the institutional management of the contemporary democratic state.

While this articulation of popular sovereignty is consonant with Rousseau's overall thought in many regards, drawing as it does upon elements of his own theory, it also reveals some of the fissures in his thought, points at which he also articulates positions at odds with such a formulation. He does not speak with a single voice concerning sovereignty's indivisibility, the unruly *demos*, and the conception of social embodiment that follows from it. He argues, for example, that only formal assemblies of the people at the fixed dates determined by the magistrates are legitimate (Rousseau 1997b, 111). Given the *demos*'s constitutive incompleteness, however, the *demos*'s assembly cannot be institutionally determined in this manner. On the contrary, there is an undecidable relationship between the "assembly of the people," understood in institutional terms, and queerly democratic practice. This is because such practice can never, by its very nature, be viewed as "legitimate," insofar as it unmakes the social body and existing norms of legitimacy. If the state, as "moral and collective body," is indeed made up of

“as many members of the assembly as *have voices*” (50; emphasis added), then the “assembly of the people” can never be institutionally fixed and differentiated from socially and politically transmogrifying practices, because such practices aim to expand the scope of those who “have voices.”

Given Rousseau’s theoretical polyvalence, then, how can we understand popular sovereignty? Sovereignty should be understood as the *demos*’s free, ongoing emergence within the social. Like the *demos* that exercises it, sovereignty should not be understood as the nomination of a determinate socio-political possession or capacity, but as an ongoing process. If the *demos* has no fixed social or political referent, then “sovereignty,” as one of its attributes, must also be understood as lacking a fixed, determinate referent (Inston 2012, 127). Sovereignty, so understood, is always, to borrow Derrida’s well-worn formulation, “to-come” (see Derrida 2001, 67; Miller 2016, 178–179). This is the import of Rousseau’s (1990) acknowledgment that although sovereignty “is one of the most important propositions in the whole matter of political right,” it nevertheless “has only an abstract and collective existence” (87).

What, then, of the social body? How does such a conception of popular sovereignty inform the social-as-body metaphor? Rousseau clearly presents us, to a degree that simply does not apply to either Hobbes or Locke, with the theoretical resources for affirming the social body’s fundamental queerness, expressed in the morphological fluidity of its continual (un)becoming. Yet, if this is Rousseau’s theoretical promise, it is clear that he fails to fully deliver on it. In the end, his insistence on sovereignty’s indivisibility is expressed in a vision of the social body that ultimately betrays the theoretical dynamism of other elements of his thought. Beholden as he remains to the conception of a morphologically natural, and therefore normative, social body, his theory continues to register a dysphoric desire for the maintenance of proper social and political order. This dysphoric dimension of his theory is arguably what licenses the vulgar or totalitarian reading of this thought. Taken as a whole, then, his political theory represents a queer account of the social body that disavows its own queerness. Had he allowed his practical awareness of the necessary transmogrification of the *demos* and the general will to affect his theoretical appeal to the social body, he might have acknowledged its fundamental queerness, bringing his theory out of the closet.

Conclusion

Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau vividly illustrate the transposition defining the social-as-body metaphor in the transition to the modern period. While Hobbes’s appeal to the metaphor straddles the line between medieval thought, with its emphasis on the political leader as the locus of social embodiment, and modern thought, where the political state becomes the site of embodiment, the shift to this latter understanding is evident in Locke and Rousseau. For all three thinkers, the role of law takes center stage, particularly in the cases of Locke and Rousseau,

whose rejection of Hobbes's authoritarianism raises questions of legislative legitimacy that do not arise in Hobbes's theory. This shift to a focus on law, particularly in the latter two thinkers, transforms the conception of will in line with the emergence of the concept of political sovereignty that arises with the modern political state. In these classical social contract thinkers, then, we encounter both continuity and change in the invocation of the social-as-body metaphor.

Arguably the most significant point of continuity between their invocation of the social-as-body metaphor and those that have come before is that all three thinkers' understanding of the metaphor continues to be structured by the natural attitude of embodiment, taking for granted a body morphology the naturalness of which grants it normative force. The taken-for-granted nature of this understanding of embodiment is given in the fact that none of the three articulate it explicitly, instead simply presupposing it in their appeals to the social-as-body metaphor. This is somewhat ironic, given that, for all three thinkers, political society is ultimately conventional or artificial in nature. To say that the social body is conventional (i.e., based on social and political convention) is to say that it is contingent, seemingly undermining appeals to the presupposed naturalness of any determinate shape to the social body, opening the way for a recognition of the social body's fundamental queerness and morphological fluidity.

As we have seen, this is not what we find in Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau. For Hobbes and Locke, this insight is forestalled by their respective appeals to natural law (the quintessential expression of the supposition that nature conveys normativity), each of which is unconvincing in its own way. In Hobbes's case, what he identifies as laws of nature seem more akin to basic prudential social principles, and his invocation of them to give force to the dictates of civil law is at odds with his otherwise positivistic conception of both law and morality. In Locke's case, not only is his appeal to natural law seemingly inconsistent with other areas of his philosophical thought, but natural law remains so ill-defined and vague that, again drawing on Yolton's (1993) description, it "would seem to give Locke license to use it to support whatever claims he wishes to make" (123). For his part, Rousseau goes much further toward a recognition of the full implications of the social body's morphological contingency. In the end, however, his invocation of the social body's morphological normativity undermines his theory's full significance for reimagining the social body's nature. In the final analysis, all three thinkers remain "bedeviled" by nature (Stryker 2006, 247), both in their continued appeals to natural law (Hobbes and Locke) and their presupposition of the body's "natural" morphology (Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau).

In their respective refusals of the full implications of the social body's contingency and fluidity, Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau's political theories continue to express the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body. To recall once again, Žižek (1989) argues that the social-as-body metaphor, with its emphasis on the social body's proper shape, works to direct political and social desire in such a way as to mask the social's "fundamental impossibility" (122).

This impossibility or contingency is evident in what Honig (2009), following Connolly (1993, 1995, 2002), refers to as the “paradox of politics” (12–39). While she develops this point with specific reference to Rousseau, it applies equally well to Hobbes and Locke. The paradox of politics has to do with the state’s lack of natural or rational foundations that would lend it legitimacy. The paradox is evident in the common structure of representation found in all three thinkers, according to which the state’s formation finds its legitimate origin in the decision of those subject to its authority, but it is only after its establishment that the body that can legitimately undertake such a founding is properly constituted. An effect of the state’s foundation is therefore posited as the antecedent condition for its legitimacy. This paradox reveals the social’s irreducible contingency and the social body’s queer and morphologically fluid nature. In failing to fully register this paradox, however, Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau remain caught within the political fantasy of the morphologically normative social body, which operates to occlude the social body’s ongoing (un)becoming. While Rousseau, in particular, goes some way toward traversing that fantasy and imagining the social body differently, even he ultimately stops short of recognizing the fantasy for what it is, despite his rejection of natural law.

With their failure to traverse the political fantasy of the morphologically normative social body, the theories of Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau continue to express dispositions to proper social and political order which run counter to queer democracy. The queer *demos* that productively unmakes the social body through the extension of liberty and equality to broader and broader social domains remains a threat that must be effectively constrained, even in Rousseau’s account, which otherwise offers rich resources for an account of queer democracy. Recognition of political society’s conventional nature represents an opportunity to traverse the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body and to undertake practices of queer democracy that express a dispositional affirmation of the queer, morphologically fluid social body. Missing this opportunity, the theories of Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau instead register as dysphoric responses to the queer social body, aiming to impose and reinforce proper social order.

Notes

- 1 Mills (1997) argues, persuasively, in my view, that “White” as a racial category comes into being with the articulation of classical social contract theory, which itself overlaps with European “exploration,” colonialism, and settler colonialism (63–64). A constitutive feature of the economics of European “exploration” and expansion, of course, was also the European enslavement of non-Europeans, further highlighting the racial dimension of classical social contract thought (see Horne 2018 and 2020). Thus, the racial identity of those capable of entering into the social contract is established only in contrast with those who are incapable of so entering, with the effect that “the *Racial Contract* is ... the truth of the *social contract*” (Mills 1997, 64). This argument is strengthened with a consideration of the construction of White identity in the context of American settler colonialism, which is so central to Locke’s thought (see note 4

- below). As Gerald Horne (2018) suggests, colonial settlement of the Americas and the need to draw distinctions between both non-White slaves and indigenous populations led to the construction of a common White European identity capable of overcoming European class and religious divisions (13, 24, 151, 190; see also Dahl 2018, 10).
- 2 It is worth reiterating at this point that, in the account of its relation to dispositions, the concept of metaphor outlined in Chapter 1 and developed in preceding chapters is also irreducible to “mere” metaphor, understood in contrast to the “literal.”
 - 3 The racialized nature of Hobbes’s social contract theory is apparent in his discussion of the state of nature. Responding to the objection that there was never actually a time in which the generalized state of war he postulates occurred, he suggests that “I believe it was never generally so, over all the world: but there are many places, where they live so now,” giving the “savage people in many places of *America*” as his example (Hobbes 1996, 89). As Mills (1997) suggests, then, “a nonwhite people, indeed the very non-white people upon whose land his fellow Europeans were then encroaching, is his only real-life example of people in a state of nature” (65; see also Nichols 2005). He goes on to note that “the phrasing and terminology of Hobbes’s characterization may well have been derived directly from the writings of contemporaries about settlement in the Americas” (65), linking the development of his social contract theory directly to settler colonialism in the Americas (on settler colonialism, see Johnston and Lawson 2005; Veracini 2010, 2015; Hixson 2013; Mamdani 2015; Dahl 2018).
 - 4 Locke’s appeal to unoccupied space highlights the substantive racism in his account, insofar as it inscribes the logic of settler colonialism and the erasure of indigenous populations at the heart of his thought. As Jimmy Casas Klausen (2007) and Adam Dahl (2018, 54–55) suggest, the cogency of Locke’s theory of consent requires the concept of *terra nullius*, of land that is legally and conceptually “unoccupied” despite the presence of indigenous populations. The “empty places” to which Locke appeals were not, of course, literally empty—their European occupation required the active dispossession of indigenous populations, a dispossession legitimized by an active perception of “emptiness” and disavowal of the land’s prior occupation (Veracini 2010, 82; Dahl 2018, 4, 55) and by the “indigenization” of dispossessing colonists (Veracini 2010, 77–78, 2015, 38; Hixson 2013, 11–12). Indeed, this presupposition of unoccupied space, combined with Locke’s (1988) well-known argument that land becomes property only when “mixed” with human labor (287–289), serves as one of the pre-eminent justifications for settler colonialism in the Americas and beyond (see Mills 1997, 67–68; Dahl 2018, 132–133).
 - 5 In keeping with his allowance for “mixed” constitutions, Locke does not require that all members of the Legislative must be elected. See Tuckness 2016 for this point.
 - 6 This separation of powers does not deny the possible overlap of institutional roles (e.g., Parliament and monarch) (Tuckness 2016).
 - 7 Talmon’s naively liberal individualism is open to critique from several philosophical and theoretical perspectives. For a trenchant recent critique of liberal individualism focused specifically on political and ethical subjectivity, see Krause 2015.
 - 8 With its discussion of the need to denature the will and actively construct the general will, Rousseau’s articulation of his own social contract theory would seem to avoid the racializing tendencies evident in Hobbes and Locke. However, as Mills (1997) points out, the need for humans to be transformed into fully moral agents stands in contrast to his vision of the uncorrupted savage, so that “the praise for nonwhite savages is a limited paternalistic praise, tantamount to admiration for healthy animals, in way to be taken to imply their equality, let alone superiority, to the civilized Europeans of the ideal polity” outlined in *The Social Contract* (69). Human perfectibility, attained within the ideal political state, is not open to all humans.
 - 9 Recognition of the lack of “objective ends” forms the starting point for Laclau’s whole political theory. See Laclau 1996, vii–viii.

- 10 Dent (1992) notes that this is a minority interpretation of Rousseau's account of *amour propre*.
- 11 John Rawls's formulation of the "original position" as a thought experiment for determining a just society's contours probably remains the best contemporary example of the application of social contract principles in a heuristic sense (see Rawls 1999, 102–168; 2001, 14–18; 2005, 22–28). In keeping with Kantian dimension of so much of his thought, it is also worth noting that Kant is unambiguous in his own insistence that the social contract should not be understood as a historical fact (see Kant 1991, 79), but is, rather a practical idea of reason (Reiss 1991, 27–28). However, despite the fact that "the historical dimension of contractarianism had apparently vanished altogether" from European thought, Kant is very clear that only White Europeans qualify as "persons" in his contractarian thought (Mills 1997, 69–72; see also Eze 1995).
- 12 I have already noted the problematic nature of Locke's appeal to "open areas" on the globe. Additionally, as Morris (2011) notes, there is virtually nowhere on the planet where one can reasonably go and *not* be under the jurisdiction of a state (544–545).
- 13 Bonnie Honig (2009), in a trenchant critique of Jürgen Habermas, offers a telling and informative analysis of a particularly naïve appeal of this kind (33–34). We will consider another in Chapter 6.
- 14 It is obviously true that scholars and others with a significant historical focus *do* approach issues related to the founders and the founding period as a factual question. But it is important to recognize that technical scholarly and historical treatments are not typical of appeals to the "Founding Fathers," and so on.

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4

FANTASIES OF AUTHENTICITY

Populism and Nationalism

Introduction

The focus in this chapter is what we might term (for reasons outlined below) “majoritarian populism.” Context matters when considering populism, particularly in relation to democracy and established state systems. Our focus will be the breed of populism currently on display in places like western Europe and, the particular focus of the next chapter, the United States. Within these contexts, populism is not defined by a marginalized or historically oppressed group demanding political participation and representation in a system from which they have been excluded. On the contrary, populism in these contexts, countries with established democratic institutions and procedures and increasingly pluralistic populations, is a phenomenon reflecting the interests of those who have historically represented a majority of the population and who have wielded the greatest social and political authority.

Similar considerations hold for nationalism which, as we shall see, is conceptually and practically related to populism in numerous ways. While nationalism can, and has, taken the form of calls for regional autonomy and the devolution of political authority in some of these countries, the breed of nationalism here is that which is currently most visible on the right, which seeks to ground contemporary civic identity in an idealized narrative of the nation’s historical (whether real or imagined) identity. When articulated with majoritarian populism, nationalism serves to maintain the social and political authority of those recognized to be part of the historical nation by subsuming civic identity with national identity.

In the forms we are considering, nationalism, populism, and their articulation together in the form of populist nationalism, express a disposition toward the morphologically normative social body’s imposition and maintenance, a social

body in which the “authentic” people, who are also “real” members of the national community, exercise social and political authority, while the social body’s other members occupy subordinate positions and roles. While the social body metaphor will arise in our consideration of populism and nationalism, it is usually implicit. That is, in contrast to the classical social contract theorists considered in the previous chapter, contemporary nationalists and populists do not typically make explicit appeal to the metaphor of the morphologically normative social body in an effort to legitimize their movements. As we saw in the first chapter, however, the social-as-body metaphor has fundamentally to do with a disposition to establishing and maintaining a normative, hierarchical social order. As we saw there, the social-as-body metaphor highlights and gives name to such social and political dispositions, whether or not it is explicitly invoked in defense of a particular social structure. The metaphor also allows us to highlight the visceral, affective reaction when the normative social order is disrupted or called into question, revealing the social body’s fundamental queerness.

Capturing this emphasis, the forms of nationalism and populism we examine represent dysphoric responses to the unmaking of the social body’s proper order brought about by demographic and economic changes, as well as queerly political practice on the part of novel social groups’ members and those who have been historically marginalized. Within the populist and nationalist imaginary, consonant with traditional expressions of the social-as-body metaphor, the social body’s transmogrification can only be improper, representing a pathologically grotesque malformation that must be remedied. Redress of the social body’s transmogrification takes form in socially dysphoric reactions aimed at (re)imposing and maintaining its normative morphology by putting the social body’s unruly members back in their “proper” place. Populist and nationalist reactions are dysphoric not only in the sense that they seek to reassert the social body’s normative morphology, but also in the sense that they reveal its fantastical nature. The social body’s transmogrification draws attention to its morphological contingency, revealing its fundamentally queer and morphologically fluid nature. Drawing again on Žižek’s (1989) discussion of political fantasy, populism and nationalism express a desire for a fantastical social body, an impossible social body, a social body that *never was* (118). The morphologically normative social body toward which populism and nationalism strive is a fantasy.

Populism

What is populism, what are the mechanisms through which it operates and takes shape within the social, and what is its relation to democracy, and specifically to the queer democracy introduced in Chapter 2? While no broad consensus has emerged on all of these questions, Sandra Vergari (2017) highlights three main approaches to understanding populism: as an ideology, as a discursive political style, and as a political strategy (241). As her discussion indicates, there can be

significant overlap between these different approaches, and in the discussion that follows I will elaborate populism as a combination of the three: it represents what Cas Mudde and Rovira Kaltwasser (2017) describes as a “thin-centered ideology” (21) or, perhaps better, what John B. Judis (2016) describes as a “political logic,” understood as “a way of thinking about politics” (14), rather than a distinct political regime in its own right (Urbinati 2014, 149). Yet this logical articulation around “the people” remains largely formal taken in the abstract and must be filled out discursively in such a way as to specify the people’s specific nature and identity, an awareness of which will necessarily bring us to a consideration of populism as a strategy for gaining and maintaining political power. As Nadia Urbinati convincingly demonstrates, populism should be understood contextually as a “within-state-power” (2018, 572), with the discursive articulation of the people serving as a means of attaining and maintaining state power (2014, 128–129). An overarching theme emerging from a consideration of populism is that it is best conceived as an active process of identity formation, rather than a static social phenomenon.

“The People”: The Logic and Discourse of Populism

What Jan-Werner Müller (2016) describes as populism’s “inner logic” (10) most obviously takes shape around claims concerning “the people” (Lat. *populus*) and the bifurcation of social and political space into the “two homogeneous and antagonistic camps” of “the pure people,” on the one hand, and the “corrupt elite,” on the other (Mudde and Kaltwasser 2017, 6).¹ But this formulation remains formal and essentially empty given its key terms’ generality: “the people” is so ambiguous as to offer little of theoretical value without further elaboration (Canovan 2005, 1–3), while anti-elitist appeals are common to politicians of virtually every stripe, populist or not (Müller 2016, 22).

This generality must be supplemented by more precise discursive articulations of the populist people. As Margaret Canovan (2005) points out, the people appears to have two broad, seemingly contradictory senses: the whole polity or a particular segment of the population (65), such that populist leaders seek “to mobilize the people as excluded part in the name of the people as sovereign whole” (65). It is impossible, of course, for any empirical social body to correspond to this conception, a point reflected in theorists’ descriptions of the populist people as an “illusion” (Müller 2016, 28), a “fantasy” (3), a “fiction” (Canovan 2005, 130ff.), a “myth” (132ff.), and so forth. Such descriptions, however, are misleading. While it is certainly true that the populist people is not what might be referred to as a “natural kind,” it does, nevertheless, take on a concrete socio-political reality. Invocations of the people provoke identification with it, so that it retroactively constitutes the very reality of which such invocations are made (see Arditì 2014, 95–96). As with any group identity, then, the populist people’s objectivity is a function of the shared group identity of those who identify with it.

As Richard Jenkins (2014) sums up this general principle, “what is real is a shared sense of ‘groupness,’ of group membership” (9). As he also notes, “the minimal reality of a group is that its members know that it exists and that they belong to it” (13). Borrowing Louis Althusser’s language, the people to which populists appeal includes those who recognize themselves in the populists’ invocation (see Althusser 2008, 309–310). Populist leaders “summon ... up the authority of the people-as-whole” to mobilize the identification of “the excluded people-as-part,” thereby lending a redemptive force to populist appeals (Canovan, 2005, 89, 90, 122).

As Jenkins (2014) suggests, “identity” is best understood “as a process—*identification*—not a ‘thing’; it is not something that one can *have*, or not, it is something that one *does*” (6). Thus, the populist people exists only to the extent that “members know that it exists and that they belong to it” and behave in a manner that conforms with this knowledge, thereby “realizing” its reality (13). While Jenkins’s account of this process applies to group identity generally, it certainly applies to the populist people. But group identity’s dependence on individual identification only represents half the dynamic of social identity. As Jenkins also notes, “identity is never unilateral” (44). Rather, individuals expressing an identification “seek to ‘be’—*and to be ‘seen to be’*—‘something’ or ‘somebody,’ to successfully assume particular identities” (44, *emphasis added*). The populist people’s constitution is therefore a function of a reciprocal recognition dynamic, involving both individuals’ and groups’ recognition of themselves as members of the populist people, and other members’ recognition of that self-recognition’s legitimacy, in turn.

In this process, groups generate “prototypes,” idealized representations of the stereotypes and normative tendencies embodied in group members (Theiss-Morse 2009, 72–73). This sense of group prototypicality, what Jenkins (2014) terms the “public-image” generated by the group (44), becomes the basis for what Steph Lawler (2014) calls “self-impersonation” (118), which occurs when individuals identify with the ideal group member prototype, actively working to bring themselves into conformity with it. Through this process, the individual copies an “imagined original” (121), shaping their individual identity in conformity with prototypical group identity, their “self-image” in conformity with the group’s “public-image” (Jenkins 2014, 44). This identity performance is “convincing” (Lawler 2014, 122) to just the degree that individuals conform to the prototype sufficiently to be recognized as group members. We must take care not to be misled by the language of performance, copying, impersonation, and so on; the process of identification is not a matter of calculation or deceptive artifice. There is no “true” or “authentic” individual self pre-existing these performances of prototypicality. Rather, the performance of group identity is self-identity’s basis (121); individual identity always emerges in the complex interplay of self-image and public image. Thus, suggests Lawler, “to be a person *is* to be a mask” (120, *emphasis added*).

These general processes of identity formation are integral to the populist people's constitution. Those whose performance of individual identity is recognized as most fully corresponding to the prototypicality of group members are recognized as true or authentic members of the populist people. This process of identity formation and recognition occurs at the dispositional level—the projection of idealized group prototypicality and its internalization by individuals is one of the “structuring structures” shaping individual dispositions and affects. This is why language of cognition, belief, even, indeed, recognition, can be misleading. Certainly, identification with the populist people involves cognition, appeal to facts, statements of belief, and so on. But, as Michael Freeden (2013) notes, “ideologies are also forms of contestation over the political mobilization of emotion” (1). Identification processes operate on what William Connolly (1999) calls the “visceral register” (3). The notion of “interests” illustrates this point. While it may be intuitive to suggest that individuals identify with the populist people because it serves their objective interests to do so, Jenkins (2014) notes that identification and interests are co-constituting, such that “how I identify myself has a bearing on how I identify my interests” (8). The populist people's objectivity consists of individuals' and groups' *felt sense* of belonging within it which, in turn, shapes their cognition, belief, and interests in conformity with the prototypicality of the populist people's identity. The populist people is therefore not a static empirical reality, but is actively, and only, constituted via these ongoing processes of identification and recognition.

The dynamics of prototypicality and identification in the populist people's constitution are such that it is not only anti-elitist, but is also defined by broader anti-out-group bias (Krämer 2017, 405). The stronger a group's shared sense of identity and the firmer its boundaries, the more fixed and robust its idealized conception of members becomes (Theiss-Morse 2009, 92). This means, in the case of populism, that one of the populist people's defining features is its purity, so that populism involves “the sanctification of the unity and homogeneity of the people versus any part of it” (Urbinati 2014, 151). This is why the populist people is never inclusive of the entire populace; rather, populism is “is a politics not of inclusion but primarily of exclusion” (147). As Müller (2016) sums up the issue, “in addition to being anti-elitist, populists are always antipluralist: they claim that they, and only they, represent the people” (20), so that “for a political actor or movement to be populist, it must claim that a part of the people is the people” (22).

Populism's logic of exclusionary constitution is not unique, effectively mirroring the dynamics Alexander G. Weheliye (2014) has uncovered in the constitution of the Western Enlightenment's “Man” as equivalent to White Europeans. Consistent with Canovan's account of the way in which a part of the populace is mobilized through appeal to the “people-as-whole,” Weheliye articulates the ways in which White European hegemony has been maintained through authoritative appeal through identification as “Man.” As he writes, “Man represents the western configuration of the human as synonymous with the heteromasculine, white, propertied,

and liberal subject that renders all those who do not conform to these characteristics as exploitable nonhumans, literal legal no-bodies" (135). "Man," in this formulation, is not universally inclusive, but is in fact only constituted through the exclusion of those human bodies that are not recognized as conforming to the prototype of Man. Likewise, all those within the populace not recognized as conforming to the prototype of the real or authentic populist people are excluded from membership, despite the apparently universal scope of the category.

This active "expulsion of pluralism" (Urbinati 2014, 137) is also what makes it difficult for individuals to modify the prototypical image of the populist people. Any perceived deviation from group prototypicality leads to individuals being positioned outside the populist people. Thus, the degree to which populist identity operates as a structuring structure shaping individual identity is much greater than the extent to which it can also be shaped by differences in individual identity among its members.

Media's role is also crucial in the populist people's constitution. Benjamin Krämer (2017) highlights broader and narrower senses in which news media, in particular, can be termed populist. "Media populism" in the broad sense involves the ways in which media that does not seek to advance a populist agenda (indeed, that may harbor an anti-populist agenda) nevertheless "fosters and sustains populist worldviews" (406). A case in point is such media's attempt to counter elitism by "routinely reporting negative incidents involving elites" (407), an effort that is not aimed at promoting populism and which is, in fact, centrally important for countering managed democracy. However, such reporting, particularly through incessant repetition, has the unintended consequence of fueling the populist claim that the entire political system is elitist, opposed to the populist people's interests. The presumed immediacy of social media and the internet can also feed populism's anti-elitism. This occurs when media utilizing these platforms, which present themselves as operating in a "pluralist and deliberative mode" (e.g., by allowing for viewer/subscriber comments), nevertheless confirm populists' anti-elitist sentiments by failing to be responsive to viewers'/consumers' feedback (408). Populist actors also deliberately employ strategies and styles that "trigger" journalistic coverage, thereby placing non-populist media in a double-bind: if they do not take the bait, they face accusations of elitism and bias, but if they do take the bait, their coverage normalizes populist identities and discourses (408–410). Such normalization is vital for populist movements, effectively amplifying and lending coherence to the idealization of the populist people. Related to this, media coverage also serves to give the impression that populist identification is much more widespread than it might in fact be (Bail 2015, 10), thereby helping to "mainstream" such identification.

In providing a platform for populism's articulation and dissemination, then, non- or anti-populist media lends increased social, objective reality to the populist people, sedimenting and helping to expand populist identification. But non-populist media also feeds the anti-pluralism that drives populism through negative coverage of "deviant behavior by members of out-groups" (Krämer 2017, 410)

against which the homogeneous populist people takes shape. As Krämer suggests, “such coverage seems to confirm the view that the characters of ‘the people’ and the out-group are fundamentally incompatible” (410). Negative out-group coverage thereby amplifies the emotions driving populist identification (Bail 2015, 136), not only lending social reality to the populist people, but presenting it as the homogeneous, non-plural mass populists imagine it to be.

Media can also be populist in a narrower sense, expressly aiming to aid populist movements and spur populist identification. While all types of media may be put in the position of “spread[ing] information about incidents that can be used as evidence of populist worldviews,” narrowly populist media takes this further, framing such incidents “in ways that emphasize anti-elite and anti-out-group perspectives,” cultivating “truly populist frameworks” of interpretation and experience (Krämer 2017, 411). But populist media’s most obvious role is to serve as a stand-in for populist leaders by “selecting and interpreting issues from a distinct populist perspective” (414). This process of selection, publication, and media amplification further aids in processes of prototypicality and interest selection, further lending added social reality to the populist people such media support.

Populist logic bifurcates social and political space into two camps: the populist people, discursively articulated as homogeneous and pure, and all of those who are not part of the populist people. Consideration of the populist people naturally raises the question of its relation to democracy, with its concern for the *demos*. For various reasons, many theorists view populism as consistent with democracy, which is also how many populists present their own movements (Canovan 1999, 2). As Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) suggest, assessment of such claims requires a working definition of democracy, which is a tricky proposition, as we have seen (80). For their part, they employ a minimalist definition of democracy as “the combination of popular sovereignty and majority rule; nothing more, nothing less,” arguing on the basis of this definition that populism is “essentially democratic,” inconsistent with liberal democracy, but not democracy *per se* (80–81). Highlighting such considerations, Müller (2016) notes that, for some democratic theorists, populism stands as a corrective to “liberal technocracy” (8). Populism will appear to many as the apotheosis of participatory democracy, given its emphasis on the “will of the people” (Urbinati 2018, 571, 2014, 131), its appeal to the majority principle (Urbinati 2014, 141), and its claim to be “government by the people” (Urbinati 2018, 572).

However, the minimalist definition of democracy proposed by Mudde and Kaltwasser, on which the compatibility of populism and democracy depends, is insufficient when compared to the model of queer democracy outlined in Chapter 2. First, as we saw there, queer democracy cannot be reduced to majority rule. More substantively, populism’s incompatibility with queer democracy lies in two fundamentally irreconcilable senses of “the people.” While the populist people is structured around an exclusive, anti-pluralist, and fixed conception of its reality or authenticity, the queerly democratic *demos* is defined by its

fluidity and constitutive incompleteness. The queer *demos* is inherently polymorphous and heterogeneous, the very antithesis of “purity.” With this distinction in view, it is clear that populism and queer democracy are fundamentally incompatible, expressing divergent political logics.

Populist Strategy and Governance

Even accepting populism’s fundamentally anti-democratic nature, which will come into clearer focus as we move forward, the similarities between the two illustrate that they exist in tense conceptual and practical proximity to one another. Both clearly entail a dimension of popular involvement and agitation (as Urbinati makes clear, popular movements are not populist by default—see 2018, 573), and both articulate what could be described as anti-elitist positions, if by “elitism” we include many of managed democracy’s features. Populism and queer democracy both “allude ... to the idea of self-government of the people, i.e., a political system in which the people rule” (Mudde and Kaltwasser 2017, 80). Such parallels lead many theorists to emphasize populism and democracy’s proximity-in-non-identity. So, for example, Benjamin Arditi (who is more sympathetic to the idea of democracy and populism’s compatibility) describes populism as democracy’s “internal periphery” (Arditi 2007, 60, 2014, 102), Margaret Canovan described populism as the “shadow” cast by democracy (Canovan 1999, 3; see also Arditi 2007, 49), Urbinati (2018) describes populism as a “*within-state-power* phenomenon” that arises within established democratic systems (572), and Claude Lefort theorizes authoritarianism as an ever-present danger attendant to democracy (Lefort 1988, 13–20; see also Arditi 2007, 60).²

Canovan’s (1999) theorization of democracy’s “pragmatic” and “redemptive” faces illuminates how populism inhabits democracy as its shadow or internal periphery, existing in a parasitic relationship with it. Democracy, in its pragmatic dimension, has to do with how to get things done in the context of large, complex, and pluralistic polities. Thus, “democracy is essentially a way of coping peacefully with conflicting interests and views under conditions of mass mobilization and mass communication” (10), which requires institutions and procedures such as “multi-party systems, free elections, pressure groups, lobbying and the rest of the elaborate battery of institutions and practices by which we distinguish democracy from other modern polities” (11). More than such institutions and procedures, however, democracy is also, simultaneously, “a repository of the aspirations characteristic of modern politics,” a “faith in secular redemption” and “the promise of a better world through action by the sovereign people” (11). This redemptive face of democracy is vital because “pragmatism without the redemptive impulse is a recipe for corruption” (11).

Democracy’s pragmatic and redemptive faces are therefore opposed but interdependent, such that populism emerges in the “gap” between them (Canovan 1999, 9). If populism thrives in the invariable gap between

democracy's redemptive promise and its pragmatic performance (12), then managed democracy's corrupted ground is all the more fertile for populism's emergence. A functioning democracy's legitimate pragmatic elements can devolve into the excesses outlined in our earlier discussion of neoliberal managed democracy, so that they can no longer be understood as legitimately serving the *demos*. When this occurs, the ground is prepared for either queer democracy or populism's emergence. As Canovan writes: "it really is the case that people who can manage to believe in the possibility of collective action and to unite behind it can exercise more power than if they give up and concentrate on their private affairs" (13), and this belief is ultimately necessary for both populism *and* queer democracy.

In Chapter 2 we examined the contours of a queerly dissensual democratic response to the devolution into managed democracy. Here, a consideration of populism's operative governing strategies stands in marked contrast, highlighting its fundamentally anti-democratic contours. Nadia Urbinati alerts us not to succumb to the view that populism is unconcerned with questions of governance and the exercise of political authority, highlighting that attention to such issues is central to understanding populism as a prevalent and pervasive political phenomenon. As noted previously, she argues that populism must be recognized as the "within-state power" it is, seeking state power and the occupation of state institutions (Urbinati 2018, 572). While populist discourse presents populism as an organic expression of the populist people outside or beyond the pale of the political state, it embodies, in fact, "a deeply statist vocation" (Urbinati 2014, 152). As she suggests, while populism might be an effective democratizing force within a non-democratic context, it is fundamentally anti-democratic when considered in the context of established democracies such as the US.

The notion of majority rule brings these points into clearer focus. One of Urbinati's (2018) most significant theoretical contributions is her attention to the imposition of "extreme majoritarianism" as one of populism's defining characteristics as a "ruling power" (572). While democracy, as a governing system, takes root with "the interpretation of the people and majority rule" (572), populist majoritarianism stands opposed to the mechanisms of constitutional, representative democracy, insofar as the latter presupposes a plurality of social interests and actors (572–573). Populism's "main and recognizable character" as a state power is "hostility against liberalism and the principles of constitutional democracy, from minority rights, division of powers, and pluriparty system" (Urbinati 2014, 129).

While an element of populists' claim to legitimacy lies in their appeal to the democratic principle of majority rule (Urbinati 2018, 575), populism actually represents a "majoritarian regime" (Urbinati 2014, 138) which has effectively reduced political opposition to a "meaningless entity" (139). This represents a procedural and institutional manifestation of the anti-pluralism forming populism's conceptual heart. Populist governance transforms majority rule

into “the rule of majority” (139), replacing a pragmatic principle of opinion aggregation to majoritarian identification with the authentic people (Urbinati 2014, 159). This majoritarianism is marked by social “verticalization” and polarization (131). Translated into the forms and language of representative democracy, “populism wants to make the entire people into one large party or identify it with one vision and one leader [verticalization], while the minority is no longer honored as partisan-friend but treated as partisan enemy [polarization]” (143, 165).

This anti-pluralist majoritarianism is articulated together with populism’s overriding anti-elitist discourse, so that populism’s “trademark distrust of elites” becomes a mechanism for overrid[ing] institutional constraints on their [populists’] actions (Arditi 2007, 59). Effectively highlighting Canovan’s pragmatic dimension of democracy, Urbinati (2014) suggests that, premised as it is on the existence of irreducible pluralism, contemporary democracy represents “an organization that is meant to diffuse, control, and break rather than concentrate and exalt power.” (9)

Democracy’s procedures and institutions not only generate agreement and the aggregation of majority views, but “*also* disputation, disagreement, and opposition, in a word, pluralism” (165). Populists therefore “scourge ... intermediary institutions like political parties and parliaments” (8) in the name of “reclaiming the democratic authority of ordinary citizens against the elites” (11), marking the reclamation of power by “ordinary people” (133). Populist governance thereby enacts the “centralization of power, weakening of checks and balances, strengthening of the executive, disregard of political oppositions, and transformation of election in a plebiscite of the leader” (129).

While both populism and queer democracy may oppose “elites,” particularly in the context of contemporary neoliberal managed democracy, populist anti-elitism also encompasses any members of out-groups who are not recognized as having a place within the populist people, marking a decisive break from the logic and practice of queer democracy. Populist governance therefore involves a repudiation of “dissent, minority views, and the dispersion of power” which are presupposed in representational democratic procedures and institutions (Urbinati 2014, 133). Majority rule is thereby transformed into the deciding populist majority’s domination (Urbinati 2018, 580), inevitably undermining protections for minorities and individual liberties. It is crucial to recognize that according to populist logic, members of both the political majority and the minority may be citizens, but both cannot be part of the legitimate or authentic people (Urbinati 2014, 147). Premised on “the right of the majority against any minority,” populist politics is therefore articulated around opposition between the populist people and all who oppose it whether they be fellow citizens or not (151). Reflecting its parasitic relationship with democracy, then, democratic institutions and procedures become the means of concentrating populist power and authority, rather than means of dispersing and distributing it (159, 160). Populists therefore aim to

not only make use of, but to conquer, democracy's representative institutions (Urbinati 2018, 273).

Populist majoritarianism also reflects a distinctive perspective on the idea of political representation and leadership. Populists' rejection and bypassing of established institutions and procedures for democratic practice not only reflects their anti-pluralism, but also their rejection of established practices for representation. Populist governance is premised on the direct discernment and fundamental correctness of the "will of the people," with no need for traditional representational means of "detecting, affirming, and managing" that will (Urbinati 2014, 135, 2018, 576). Existing representational procedures and institutions disrupt the immediate access to the people's undivided will presupposed within populism, insofar as such procedures and institutions presuppose both pluralistic political contestation (Urbinati 2014, 136) and a mediated distance between represented and representative. As Arditì (2007) suggests, the very concept of representation "makes no sense" unless one remembers that a gap exists between these "two tiers" (63).

The logic of representation also fundamentally counters claims to the populist people's presumed homogeneity because the representative is not simply an extension or reflection of the will of those represented. As Arditì (2007) notes, representation's "re-" does involve a certain "repetition" of those represented in the representative, so that "the people" return through a substitute" (63–64). However, he goes on to note that "that which returns is not an unaltered sameness, a mere expression of pre-constituted identities and interests" (64). That is, representation is not a one-way process moving from those represented to representative but modifies the identities of *both* parties. As Laclau (2007) suggests, "representation is a two-way process: a movement from represented to representative, and a correlative one from representative to represented" insofar as "the function of the representative is not simply to transmit the will of those he represents, but to give credibility to that will in a milieu different from the one in which it was originally constituted" (158). While the concept of representation contains the idea of making the will or desire of those represented "present again" through the representative, it also involves a correlative, transformative shift in the opposite direction, through which the representative's actions and identity retroactively affect the identity of those represented who authorize them. The effort to enact the will of those represented, to speak and act on their behalf, invariably involves the transformation of that will—yet, to the extent that those represented continue to recognize the representative as *their* representative, this has a kind of rebound effect, modifying the identity of those represented.³ As Laclau also notes, this process is not an aberration or breakdown in representation, but is "inherent in *any* process of representation" (158).⁴

Applied to populism's specific case, the representational task of "rendering present" the populist people's will "introduces a *differential element* that modifies the absent presence of 'the people'" (Arditì 2007, 64; emphasis added). In other

words, representation's very concept and operation highlight the impossibility of the populist people's presumed homogeneity. It is no surprise, then, that populist governance eschews formal representational structures and practices in favor of an ideal of immediacy, such that representative institutions and procedures forfeit any normative value (Urbinati 2014, 159). Populist governance promises a "more genuine identification of the represented with the representatives" (136), dismissing all power divisions and representational forms felt to widen a gap between the populist people and its representative (149). Populism is therefore a literal "politics of immediacy" (150), one that eschews any institutions and procedures thought to mediate the relation between the populist people and their authentic representative.

These considerations serve to highlight the political leader's significance within populism, the dynamics of which are effectively illuminated in Urbinati's concept of political verticalization. Consistent with the rejection of a representational logic, the populist leader is not recognized as the populist people's mere representative, but as its prototypical embodiment and, even further, as the embodiment of the popular will itself (Urbinati 2014, 153; Krämer 2017, 405), rendering visible the people's invisible sovereignty (Urbinati 2018, 277). This "politics of personalization" necessarily undermines electoral practices and processes, insofar as these can only hinder the authentic people's (non)representation in their leader (Urbinati 2014, 153).

Political personalization further highlights the media's role in relation to populism. Arditì (2007) identifies political personalization as an element of what he terms "audience democracy," an important part of the context in which populism emerges (51, 68). Within audience democracy, politicians participate in "political marketing," enabling them to bypass traditional structures of party authority to establish "personal legitimacy" through direct appeal to the electorate, with the result that "personal *trust* becomes an important criterion for electoral options" (51–52). Within this framework, voter behavior increasingly indicates the preference for a particular person, rather than a party platform or a political ideology. This development within general democratic practice holds out the promise of "securing a virtual immediacy" between voters and candidates that "seems attuned to the populist claim to a direct appeal to the people and its fascination with leaders who enjoy supra-partisan legitimacy" (51).

Audience democracy therefore aids the political personalization and verticalization manifest in populist governance, transforming the character of elections. While elections within democratic systems simultaneously "separate and link citizens and government" (Urbinati 2018, 576), populism aims to close the gap between them. Thus, elections within a populist polity become "a plebiscite for celebrating the leader" (577). Leaders are invested, rather than elected, insofar as elections are transformed into exercises in the leader's acclamation as the populist people's authentic expression (Arditì 2007, 65; Urbinati 2014, 160). Populism is, then, a *pars-pro-toto* (a "part for the whole") project, in which the individual leader is an expression of the whole populist people (Urbinati 2018, 573).

Political verticalization and personalization come together in support for a strong leader who can personify the people's interests (578).

This conception of political leadership highlights the fantastical nature of populist governance. While populist logic and discourse direct political desire toward the opposition of elites, the populist leader's elevated status reveals populist governance is not, in practice, anti-elitist after all. Rather, as Müller (2016) suggests, "populists ... are fine with elites as long as they are the elites leading the people" (30). Populist leaders know, he suggests, that they are, in fact, part of "the elite," as do their supporters. "What matters," however, "is their promise that as a *proper* elite, they will not betray the people's trust and will in fact faithfully execute the people's unambiguously articulated political agenda" (30, emphasis added). In practice, populism therefore represents "a strategic politics of *elite transformation* and authority creation" (Urbinati 2014, 157, emphasis added).

Populism's "participatory imaginary" (Arditi 2007, 60) is also fantastical, directing political desire through a vision of "the [populist] people as a political actor that asserts its sovereign authority by remaining in a permanent state of mobilization" (Urbinati 2014, 166). In actual practice, however, the personalization, verticalization, and extreme majoritarianism that define populist governance transform the populist people into a "reactive mass of followers" (157), breeding a "militant kind of passivity" (153), as reflected within the logic of populist elections. This follows naturally from the vision of the leader as the immediate expression of the populist people's will, highlighting the authoritarian tendency within populist governance (Lefort 1986, 299–300). Because the leader is the populist people's expression, the leader's dictates necessarily express the people's will, so that the extreme majoritarianism of populist governance can paradoxically find expression in a single individual's acts. As the populist people's effective incarnation, then, the populist leader is always already authorized to act *a priori* (Arditi 2007, 83). In the end, "populists can get away with undemocratic behavior ... as long as their actions are perceived to represent the will of the people" (53). Thus "the populist representative is in fact a leader who wants people's faith and emotional identification with no question of accountability" (Urbinati 2018, 577). Going even further, the logic of populist leadership is such that the leader is *entitled* to such faith.

Yet, finally, the presumed immediacy of populist leader and populist people is also fantastical in nature. To reiterate Laclau's (2007) point, *all* representational forms involve the retroactive constitution of those represented in the person(s) of their representative(s), despite the former's logical priority (158). Effective representation is therefore contingent on the successful interpellation of those represented (Arditi 2007, 64) and on this interpellation occurring below their awareness (and often even below that of their representatives). Audience democracy's promise of immediacy therefore deserves the qualifier "virtual" (51), because it veils the gap between represented and representative (68), masking the mediation that continues to take place, producing an impression of immediacy that is impossible in practice. Thus,

“mediations remain in place, denser than ever and ubiquitous as the mass media take over from the party press and propaganda sections,” with the effect that “the media provide a semblance or simulacrum of immediacy that gives momentum to a mode of representation characterized by the ‘as if’ of *virtual immediacy*” (68).

Contemporary media allow for the masking of representation’s “re-” more effectively than at any time in the past. The populist leader is not the populist people’s immediate embodiment. On the contrary, they constitute the populist people through a complex recursive process. Precisely to the degree that their representational status is occluded, that their appeals are perceived to be direct, rather than mediated, populist leaders position themselves as the populist people’s authentic prototypes, retroactively defining their identity while simultaneously lending increased social reality to the populist people through its continued recognition of itself in them. Through this recursive process, the populist leader becomes the embodiment of the “public-image” that shapes individual members’ “self-images.” The populist people is therefore more an expression of the populist leader than the leader is an expression of the populist people.

Conditions of Populist Emergence

Populism may be an attendant danger necessarily accompanying democracy, but more remains to be said concerning its conditions of emergence. As a general point, many of the contextual factors supporting populism’s emergence are not unique to it, but foster a broader range of popular movements, including practices and expressions of queer democracy, that do not metastasize into populism (see Urbinati 2014, 150). Many of these factors boil down to a crisis of democratic legitimacy, on the one hand, and of representation, on the other. Some of these elements have already come into view in our earlier discussion, while others will be readily familiar to any observer of contemporary society and politics.

We have already considered the media’s role under the rubric of audience democracy and examined some of the ways in which even non- or explicitly anti-populist media can cultivate populism. In a related vein, we also recall the role of polling within neoliberal managed democracy (we have only to think of ubiquitous polls concerning candidates’ “electability” and voters’ levels of “enthusiasm” for political candidates) as another salient dimension of audience democracy that feeds the “personalization of politics” evident in populism. To these familiar social and political realities we can add the increasing economic inequality in the US. As Urbinati (2014) suggests, an economically bifurcated society feeds political polarization, diminishing the possibility for political compromise (139–141). The result of such polarization is “broken social equilibrium” (141), which fertilizes the ground for populism’s emergence.

Canovan’s discussion of democracy’s two faces also draws our attention back to the earlier discussion of managed democracy. As Ardit (2007) suggests, “populism is a response to an asymmetry brought on by an excess (of pragmatism) and a

deficit (of redemption)” (46). In a description that very much fits within the context of managed democracy, he highlights the danger that arises when the “semblance of impersonal institutional virtue” is undermined by “the shadier deals concocted regularly by the political and economic elites in the name of systematic stability” (78). It is clear that central features of neoliberal managed democracy represent not only a pragmatic excess at the cost of democracy’s redemptive face, but that this is exacerbated by a pathologizing of the institutions and procedures constituting democracy in its pragmatic dimension.

These social and political developments represent a shared context for the emergence of both queer democracy and populism. The key ingredient for populism’s emergence, as opposed to queer democracy’s expressions, is the cultivation and maintenance of a clear sense of crisis or threat confronting the *real* populist people. Cultivation of this sense of crisis and the concomitant *feeling* that the populist people are in crisis is more important than whether or not it has any empirical basis (Miller 2019, 232–233). Recalling Jenkins’s (2014) point that identification and interests are mutually constituting (8), a carefully cultivated sense of crisis becomes the threat, the positive interest, driving identification with the populist people. The active process of fostering and capitalizing on this felt sense of crisis is also crucially important. Illustrating this point, Urbinati (2014) identifies the process of “conquering people’s consent to a narrative” as a central populist mechanism (156), Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) note that populists “spare no effort in creating a *sense of crisis*” (106), and Arditì (2007) suggests that populism takes shape around a “redemptive script” incorporating crisis language (63). The populist crisis narrative is not abstract but is typically marked by appeals to injustices done to the populist people (Krämer 2017, 411). Thus, populism

constructs a crisis of identity and the traditional way of living (in terms of national culture, gender, family, etc.), a crisis of justice (where the in-group is treated unfairly by the elite and in contrast to purported privileges for out-groups) and ultimately a crisis of representation.

(413)

And, of course, media coverage and repetition feed this sense of crisis, whether intentionally or not. The mere fact of media coverage adds a sense of reality to the crisis, while its ubiquity and repetition exaggerates the existing scope of identification with the crisis narrative.

Hahl et al. (2018), discussing populist perceptions of leaders’ legitimacy or authenticity, offer an insightful analysis that sheds further light on the sense of crisis around which populism takes shape, as well as what differentiates this sense of crisis from that which might motivate popular action expressed through queerly democratic practice.⁵ The populist sense of crisis involves legitimacy, emerging from a constituency’s perception that its “interests are not being served by a political establishment that purports to represent it fairly” (3). They highlight

two conditions under which such a crisis can emerge: 1.) when groups experience a “representational crisis,” in which the political establishment “does not appear to govern on their behalf” and, 2.) a “power-devaluation crisis” in which the political establishment “favor[s] new social groups over established groups” (3).

A representational crisis “occurs when established political leaders claim to govern on behalf of all citizens but in fact are believed to pursue their own interests or that of an incumbent social category” (Hahl et al. 2018, 7). The perception of such a crisis is obviously widespread within the contemporary US and, as our discussion of managed democracy made clear, there is, unfortunately, ample evidence of its accuracy. The representational crisis has the potential to spur myriad popular responses, particularly insofar as established political leaders’ non-representative character is perceived (or experienced) as favoring a historically privileged group, one that “has enjoyed more rights or resources in the past” (7). When the representational crisis spurs popular action aimed at remedying this through the extension of rights and resources to marginalized parts of society, it represents an example of queerly democratic practice, marked by the productive unmaking of the social body to extend the *demos* to include those who previously had no place within it.

A “power-devaluation crisis,” by way of contrast, provokes a distinctly populist response. A power-devaluation crisis involves three groups: 1.) a political establishment, 2.) an incumbent group “who sees itself as the ‘real people’,” and 3.) a “group of erstwhile outsiders who are rising and whom the incumbent groups views as being unfairly favored by the establishment” (8). In an important sense, the power-devaluation crisis is the reverse of the representational crisis. Here the driving issue is a privileged group’s *loss* of dominant or favored status and its displacement via *increasingly broad* social and political representation.⁶ The perceived crisis lies not in a lack of representation, but in its expansion at the cost of the dominant group’s privilege, highlighting the populist people’s distinctively anti-democratic and anti-pluralist constitution. The response to a power-devaluation crisis is to seek the preservation of the populist people’s social and political authority by maintaining its anti-pluralist identity.

In addition to vividly illustrating the queer *demos* and the populist people’s different respective logics, a power-devaluation crisis also illustrates why Urbinati’s insights concerning populist majoritarianism should not be understood solely in a quantitative, numerical sense. That is, populist governance, insofar as it involves the effort to preserve the “authentic” populist people’s authority or power against those who demand increased political participation and representation, may *not* involve a numerical majority, strictly speaking. So long as the privileged group maintains its effective hold on the mechanisms of social and political power, the same dynamics of extreme majoritarianism remain operative, whether or not the populist people actually represents a numerical majority.⁷ This also further highlights why the out-groups against whom the populist people defines itself include not only “elites,” but all those who are not recognized as belonging within the populist people.⁸

The Fantastical Populist Social Body

The populist conception of the people reflects what we have been calling the “natural attitude” (Bettcher 2009, 103) of embodiment, expressing a political disposition toward a morphologically normative, properly ordered social body. As Urbinati (2014) notes, “in most European languages, except for English, the terms *popolo*, *peuple*, and *Volk* designate an organic, collective entity, a *single body* with a collective name and meaning that has one will and is not separated into multiple units” (161, latter emphasis added). As Krämer (2017) suggests, then, populism imagines the properly ordered society in terms of a *Volkskörper*, a “body of the people” (412). The populist social body is, once again, the morphologically normative social body. In populism’s case, the social body’s normative morphology is one in which the authentic people exercise political power and authority, while all the body’s members who are not recognized as belonging to the people occupy their proper, subordinate places in the service of this social order. As this suggests, the social body is normatively hierarchical in nature, and when non-members of the populist people contest their subordination within it, they transmogrify it, revealing its fundamental queerness and, risking to unmake the social body, displacing those recognized as the populist people’s *real* members. On the natural attitude, nature confers morphological normativity, so that a social body whose members are out of their proper place is unnatural, grotesque, and pathologically malformed. Such disfigurement provokes dysphoric responses on the part of those recognized as properly belonging to the *authentic* people, taking the form of populist efforts to re-impose the social body’s proper structure.

Again highlighting Arditì’s (2014) description of populism as democracy’s internal periphery (102), populism’s parasitical relationship with democracy is evident in the way populists mask the dysphoric nature of their response to the social body’s transmogrification through appeals to the “will of the people” and their appropriation of existing democratic representational mechanisms. But the insurmountable distance that nevertheless separates populism and queer democracy is given in the fact that the populist people is fundamentally incompatible with the constitutively incomplete *demos*. Populism and queer democracy express very different dispositions toward social embodiment. In contrast to the social body’s normative morphology grounded in the populist people’s exclusive and anti-pluralist nature, queer democracy expresses a disposition toward the *demos*’s unmaking and expansion, a disposition oriented by a queer social body with no normative structure.

Lefort’s (1986) well-known theorization of the democratic people as constituting an “empty” place of power (279) captures the logic of the queerly democratic *demos*. As he suggests, “democracy combines these two apparently contradictory principles: on the one hand, power emanates from the people; on the other, it is the power of nobody. And democracy thrives on this contradiction” (279). The *demos* is the central figure of authority within the democratic imaginary, but it “remains indeterminate” (304). This serves as an appropriate description of the

demos's rule (*kratos*) as understood within queer democracy: in contrast to the populist people's rule, the *demos's* rule is paradoxical, taking shape not through the exercise of authority defined by its fixed and regulated identity, but by its non-identity, its openness and incompleteness (see the discussion of the queerly sovereign *demos* in the previous chapter). The *demos* takes shape as *demos* only as the principles of liberty and equality are extended throughout social space, which extension simultaneously unmakes its identity as constituted within in any defined period or locus. Queer democracy, then, embodies and enacts the contradiction Lefort identifies, expressing a fundamentally anti-populist political logic.

But Lefort's analysis also alerts us to the fact that the *demos's* constitutive incompleteness, the source of queer democracy's vibrancy, also marks its point of existential threat. Populists, disposed to the properly ordered, hierarchical, morphologically normative social body, will find the contradiction of the non-identitarian *demos's* rule intolerable, leading to efforts to resolve it. For Lefort, the resolution of this contradiction takes form in totalitarianism. On his analysis, totalitarianism enacts the same social and political logic as populism (as reflected clearly in populist governance's authoritarian tendency), emerging as an ever-present threat accompanying democracy and expressing a disposition toward the maintenance of the social body's proper structure. In contrast to the *demos's* emptiness defining democracy, expressing an affirmation of the queer social body, totalitarianism's foundation is "the presentation of the People-as-One" (297) and the attempt to secure society's "bodily integrity" (298). Reflecting populism's *pars-pro-toto* nature (Urbinate 2018, 573), Lefort also suggests that the totalitarian social body "breaks down into the image of a whole and a part that stands for the whole" (300), with the "Egocrat" leader as the head that represents the whole (299).

Lefort (1986) therefore vividly highlights populism's disposition to morphologically normative embodiment. But he also notes that the "image of the People-as-One" operates "on the level of fantasy" (304). Once again recalling Žižek's argument that political fantasy's role is to direct political desire, we can see that appeal to the *Volkskörper* expresses a desire for an impossible social body. The morphologically normative social body was never the authentic, natural, or organic expression of "the people" imagined within populism. It was always, on the contrary, a political effect, only ever imperfectly enacted through the suppression of the social body's members who threatened to transmogrify it and reveal its inherent queerness, which renders any normative morphology impossible. The social and political changes that populists experience as "unjust" (Krämer 2017, 411) are experienced as such precisely because they render the social body as grotesque or monstrous, morphologically fluid. They reveal, again hearkening back to Stryker's (2006) language, that the morphological normative social body with which populist desire "bedevils" us is a lie (247). Power-devaluation represents a crisis precisely because the transmogrified, queer social body becomes visible, provoking populism as a dysphoric response to the inevitable failure to achieve the authentic populist people's normative embodiment.

Populism and Nationalism

The *authentic* or *real* populist people's identifying features can take any number of forms and need not be nationalist in character. As Krämer (2017) suggests, however, within contemporary populist movements "the definition of 'the people' as *ethnos* has almost superseded all other social categories, such as social class and other descriptions of society and its antagonisms" (412). The populist people, then, is often equated with "the nation," so that populism takes a nationalistic form.

Nation and State

To understand the significance of articulating the populist people in terms of nation, it is necessary to distinguish the concept of nation from that of country or state. While concepts such as nations, peoples, and states are commonly conflated (Diener and Hagan 2012, 45–46), state and nation express two divergent conceptions of territoriality, marked by two different modes of identification. The failure to adequately distinguish between nation and state muddles otherwise informative analyses, such as Michael Billig's influential *Banal Nationalism* (1995), while appreciation of their conceptual distinction sheds more light on populism's specifically nationalist articulations.

The state is an inescapable fact of contemporary life. As Christopher Morris (2004) notes, States have "swept the world," both conceptually and literally (206), so that "today virtually the entire land mass of the globe is the territory of one state or another" (Morris 2011, 544). Richard Bellamy (2008) highlights the virtual impossibility of *not* living in a state within the present global order, such that, in this sense, it is almost impossible to be "stateless" (53; see Morris 2011, 545).⁹ The state's ubiquity and taken-for-grantedness, however, occludes the reality that the contemporary state system, the only political system to have become truly global in scope (Philpott 2011, 564), is distinctly modern, representing a marked departure from prior historical forms of socio-political organization (Morris 2011, 545).

State and nation express, among other things, fundamentally different practices of territoriality, a term which here refers to a twofold process involving "the division of land between social entities and assigning specific meanings to the resultant places" (Diener and Hagen 2012, 59). Noting that territoriality "results from historical contexts, practical needs, and geopolitical contingencies" (6), Alexander C. Diener and Joshua Hagen advance a constructivist conception of territoriality (67), according to which a defined territory is less a fixed object than the outcome of active and always ongoing bordering practices. Such practices change over time, and modern bordering practices express a distinctively geographical form of territoriality. Stated succinctly, within the state, geographical location takes precedence over shared culture or perceived kinship. As Philpott (2011) notes, within the state system, "people are members of a political

community ... [only] by virtue of their residence within a set of geographical borders" (562). The state concept therefore presupposes no commonality among its inhabitants other than their shared habitation of its geographic territory. The subjection to the state's exercise of authority (i.e., sovereignty) on the part of all those inhabiting its geographical territory, taken in isolation from other considerations of shared identity, grants a historically new significance to geography (Morris 2004, 197). This distinctively modern conception of the state became internationally formalized with the 1648 Treaty of Westphalia and was eventually "exported" globally through colonization and former colonies' subsequent attainment of independence, setting it on the trajectory of perceived inevitability that marks the concept today.¹⁰

This territorial form's distinctiveness comes into clearer focus when compared to the nation's very different territoriality. Within the national form, in contrast to that of the state, the social has priority over legal, political, or territorial relations (Grosby 2005, 27). As Morris (2004) notes, "a nation is a society whose members are linked by sentiments of solidarity and self-conscious identity based on a number of other bonds (e.g. history, territory, culture, race, 'ethnicity,' language, religion, customs)" (205). In distinction from the state as a "legal and political relation," then, the nation is a "cultural community" (Grosby 2005, 22). Reflecting this distinction, "a group of humans will constitute a nation in this sense in so far as the members share certain properties and in so far as they are conscious of this shared condition" (Morris 2004, 205, see Morris 2011, 547).

Whereas geographic territory takes precedence over shared culture or perceived kinship in the state concept, in the concept of the nation these latter categories take precedence over geographic territory. Thus, "the term 'nation' implies the continuation over time of a relatively uniform territorial culture" (Grosby 2005, 20). In contrast to the state, then, "the boundaries of a territory are never merely geographical; they indicate the spatial limit to many of those traditions that are passed from one generation to the next." Grosby continues: "the individuals who dwell within a territory do not merely interact with one another; they participate in territorially bounded traditions" (47). Within the concept of the nation, then, the significance of geographical territory is a function of shared identity, not its basis, as with the state.

The connection of identity and place comes into view with a consideration of the English word "nation," derived from the Latin noun *natio*, itself derived from the verb *nasci*, "to be born from," a term that also relates to the Latin derivation *nativus*. As these linguistic considerations highlight, "nation" reflects a dual sense of origins, having to do both with place of origin (one's "native" place) and lines of birth or descent (as in "nativity"). Thus, "while familial descent ... is different from territorial descent, these two forms of kinship are neither mutually exclusive nor historically demarcated" within the nation (Grosby 2005, 44). National belonging is therefore a matter of "descent in the territory of the nation *and* descent from parents who are members of the nation" (13, emphasis added).

Two additional points about these dual lines of descent deserve further mention. First, national members' shared identification is not strictly empirical or factual, but is a matter of perception (Grosby 2005, 13). As Grosby (2005) notes, although "both ethnic group and nation are often perceived as being 'natural' relations" insofar as one is typically born into them, this kinship conception also incorporates "other cultural traditions, such as language and religion, as boundaries of the social relation" (14). The nation therefore involves a "collective self-consciousness of actual *and imagined* duration" (11, emphasis added) and "a real or fictive claim to common ancestry" (Fenton 2006, 195). Thus, while there is a sense in which the nation is an "objective" reality, insofar as it pre-exists individual members who are born into it (Grosby 2005, 29), its ongoing existence requires individuals' continued identification with it. It relies on "the renewed acknowledgement" of generations of its members, with the effect that the nations' identities can change over time (30).

This shared identification is the basis for national territoriality: the national territory is the territory *of the nation*. That is, the nation's geographical boundedness is given through the association of the nation's members with a particular territory—their shared identification defines the territory as distinctly *theirs*. Articulating these elements together, Grosby defines the nation as "a community of kinship [real or imagined], specifically a bounded, territorially extensive, temporally deep community of nativity" (Grosby 2005, 14). Belief's role is again central to the nation's territoriality: a nation is "a territorially formed 'people' that is *believed to have* existed over time" (11, emphasis added).

These very different conceptions of territoriality demonstrate why there is generally not a one-to-one correspondence between nations and states. While Morris (2004) correctly notes: "since the entire land mass of the globe is now the territory of some state, we do not find any nation that does not overlap with a state" (205–206), it also remains the case that state territoriality "often does not succeed in defining membership so as to correspond with the identity of a 'people' or 'nation'" (Philpott 2011, 562). The common term "nation-state" is therefore best reserved for those examples of political states with a single nation, or favoring a particular nation, while most states are best described as multinational states (see Morris 2011, 547). To these considerations we can add those cases in which nations are divided among multiple political states (e.g., the Kurds) or those nations that are denied the status of belonging to any state (e.g., the Palestinians or Rohingya). It is also possible to imagine states that develop a strong enough and pervasively shared sense of civic identity to represent a kind of "civic nation," as in idealized presentations of shared French republican identity or the mythology of the U.S. as a cultural "melting pot" (we will consider a version of American civic nationalism in Chapter 6).¹¹ "Nationalism," as we will be using the term, is the normative conflation of the political state's mechanisms and structures with a shared national identity, the basis of which lies elsewhere than in the politically or legally constituted state.

Nation and People

As Grosby's (2005) description of the nation as "a territorially formed 'people'" (11) makes clear, if the populist people is not automatically and universally identified with the nation, the linkage between the two is nevertheless common, and for good conceptual reasons. As Steve Fenton (2006) demonstrates, the concepts of people, race, and nation have traditionally overlapped theoretically, historically, and ideologically (192), as has already come into view to some extent. The existence of both the nation and the populist people depends on active identification and recognition, and those who identify with the nation, and who are recognized as belonging to it, are often identified as "the people."

The category of race enters into the analysis at this point, insofar as it has operated as one of the central conceptual linkages between the concepts of nation and people. In its concrete operation, what Fenton (2006) calls "the national story" has "all the potential functioning in a manner parallel to racial exclusiveness," such that an affirmation of the nation can be viewed as a devaluation of all who are not recognized as belonging to it (193). The concepts of race, nation, and people have continued to tangle and coalesce across historical changes in meaning and application. For example, an early meaning of race was "tribe, nation, or people regarded as of common stock" (194), the meanings of race and nation "converged on the sense of 'a people'" in pre-modern usage (201), and the concept of race later came to have a "biologized" meaning, coming to refer to "a world hierarchy of peoples and types" (194). Taken in this more modern, and likely more familiar, sense, race and nation have often been used to define one another (194, 201), while both terms have also been related to that of people: the Latin *natio* "has the general sense of breed, stock, kind species, race as well as a more specific sense of 'a race of people, a nation, *people*'" (194, emphasis added). Summing up these points, then, "nation and race have *both* had, and to some extent retain, this sense of 'breed' *or people* united by common descent" (194, latter emphasis added). The overlapping senses of race, nation, and people help clarify why the authentic populist people's identification so often contains significant racial and ethnic dimensions, as well as why nationalism is so often and easily expressed as *ethnonationalism*. Our awareness of these connections is heightened with the recognition of the nineteenth and early part of the twentieth centuries as "an extremely lively period for the racialization of society, politics, and the world order," so that racial hierarchy "was a matter of both ideology and political domination," as evidenced in Victorian practices of empire and colonization (196).

These conceptual entanglements persist into the contemporary period, despite discursive shifts in the definition and application of race. Expressing a biologized conception of race, Victorian appeals to racialized conceptions of the nation or the people reflect what Ali Rattansi (2007) calls "strong" conceptions of race and racism, defined as "the belief that separate, distinct, biologically defined races exist; that they can be hierarchically ordered on the basis of innate, and thus

unalterable, superior and inferior characteristics and abilities; and that hostility is natural between the races" (95). By way of contrast, many contemporary populists and nationalists do not appeal to conceptions of biological race and may, in fact, explicitly reject them. The result is that accusations of racism leveled against nationalists and populists are typically rejected on the grounds that they are not making claims about race, but about "ethnic national culture" (3). Implicit in such rejections of racism is the presumption that, without appeal to biological notions of race, the conceptual overlap of nation, race, and people no longer holds. Were this the case, ethnonationalist conceptions of the populist people would have to do with issues of shared culture or kinship, but not race, and would therefore not represent examples of racism.

This presumption is fallacious. First, as we have already seen in Fenton's analysis, the conceptual linkages of race, nation, and people pre-date specifically or narrowly biologized racial conceptions and the "hard" racism Rattansi describes. Further, and second, even with the articulation of explicitly biological racial conceptions, the concept of race continued to incorporate more than *mere* biology, containing both biological *and* cultural dimensions (Grosby 2005, 7). Third, and most significantly, the "cultural differences" to which contemporary populists and nationalists typically appeal continue to presuppose a natural immutability of national or popular cultural identity (Rattansi 2005, 104). Appeals to people or nation often draw upon stereotypes "that blur any distinction between culture and biology" (105), effectively transferring the presumed immutability of biological race to the domain of cultural identity. This shift highlights how many populist and nationalist movements continue to express a form of "cultural racism" without any explicit appeal to biological conceptions of race (105).

As these points suggest, stereotyping represents a crucial component in the construction of racial identity and of group prototypicality more generally (Theiss-Morse 2009, 72). Despite its likely familiarity as a concept, then, stereotyping deserves further comment. Stereotypes help to fill out the meaning or affective load that attach to prototypical group members. Whether positive or negative (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 64), stereotypes provide a means of both social categorization and explanation. Regarding the former, stereotypes are totalizing in scope, insofar as they define characteristics ascribed to *all* group members and distinguish them fundamentally from members of other groups; likewise, individual distinctions between group members are rendered null, such that any group member becomes functionally interchangeable with all others for purposes of social categorization and explanation (see Gottschalk and Greenberg 2019, 80). But they are also taken to determine the behavior of those to whom they are applied, so that they play an important role in social explanation. That is, "individuals identified with *group X* do/think/believe *Y* because *all* members of *group X* are defined by (fill in the blank stereotypical feature)." Such explanation can be reduced to tautological form: all *group X* members do/think/believe *Y* because they are members of *group X*. Through stereotyping, group membership becomes a self-legitimizing social explanation.

Racial stereotypes represent the “everyday constructions and perceptions of [racial] group difference” (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 23) that justify a racially hierarchical social ordering. It is especially important to recognize two points about stereotypes’ fulfilment of this legitimizing function. The first is that “individuals do not create the meanings attached to politically relevant categories but instead accept or reject existing stereotypes” (69). That is, racial stereotypes are not “filled in” by individuals and then applied, but rather structure and express individuals’ social perceptions, affects, and practices. As Walter Lippmann stated the issue early in the 20th century,

for the most part we do not first see, and then define, we define first and then see. In the great blooming, buzzing confusion of the outer world we pick out what our culture has already defined for us, and we tend to perceive that which we have picked out in the form stereotyped for us by our culture.
(Lippman 1922, 81; *qtd in Masuoka and Junn 2013, 69*)

Thus, “individuals not only develop stereotypes from their personal experiences but also report those meanings as they are defined by society” (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 70).

The second important point is that the content of specific stereotypes is grounded in existing racial hierarchies. Thus, while stereotype content can be both positive or negative, “location in the racial hierarchy corresponds with the valence and intensity of stereotypical traits associated with groups” (64), so that “individuals in racial groups of lower position will be perceived to hold relatively more deficient characteristics and negative traits than those places higher in the hierarchy” (65). In concrete practice, then, specific stereotypes’ contents will reflect existing racial hierarchies, thereby justifying and reinforcing the very hierarchies that give rise to them, closing the circuit of a viciously circular logic.

With appeal to cultural stereotypes, then we have ample reason to affirm with Fenton (2006) that “a ‘new racism’ predicated on an exclusivist cultural imagination functions in much the same way as an ‘old racism’” (198) within contemporary populism and nationalism. He also alerts us to the ways in which such developments and transpositions operate within contemporary accounts of people, state, and nation. If the twentieth and twenty-first centuries have been marked by a growing awareness of political states’ multi-ethnic constitution, a conception of “tacit majorities” within them has nevertheless remained. To use the example of the United States,

Anglo-Saxon was a preferred category of ‘race’ as was Protestant of religion. If ‘the American people’ was not precisely conceived as mono-ethnic, White, Anglo-Saxon and Protestant [nevertheless] stood for a norm from which others were a deviation.

(198)

The upshot of this is the simultaneous operation of “an acknowledgement of a multiracial population,” on the one hand, with “an equation of a dominant population with ‘the nation’,” on the other (198). Thus, “a particular ethno-racial and cultural category is imagined as the nation” even in the pluralistic context of the state (198).

Given these complexities, it becomes clearer why nationalism and populism are often articulated together and why, additionally, racial conceptions of both nation and people are so prevalent. But they also highlight further the significance of the conceptual distinction between nation and state for analyzing conceptions of national identity. Fenton’s reference to the “the American people” as White, Anglo-Saxon, and Protestant (an issue we will explore in much greater detail in the next chapter) illustrates this point. Recognition that all US citizens share a legal civic identity, for example, in no way forecloses on the possibility that a distinction may nonetheless be drawn between the totality of US citizens and a subset of those citizens who represent *real* Americans, understood in a narrower nationalistic sense.¹² It is possible (indeed common) to hold that not all US citizens (i.e., those who share legal civic identity) are *real* Americans (i.e., share national identity).

Jenkins’s (2014) distinction between virtual and nominal identification is helpful in clarifying this distinction. Nominal identity has to do with an identity’s “name,” while virtual identity has to do with its “experience” (46). Within this framework, “the name [nominal identity] can stay the same—‘X’—while what it means in everyday life to be an ‘X’ [virtual identity] can change dramatically” (46). This dynamic is evident in the common and colloquial use of “American” as a descriptor. Applied to the state/nation distinction, “American” may nominally apply to all who are recognized as sharing in civic or political identity (i.e., citizenship). Virtually, however, there will be a sense for many that not all members of the US state are *true* or *authentic* Americans in a nationalist sense. This observation also relates to Jenkins’s emphasis on the mutuality of social identification and recognition: it does not matter if all who participate in American civic identity claim to be “real” Americans on that basis if sufficient numbers of people distinguish (whether knowingly or not) between civic identity, on the one hand, and a narrower conception of American national identity, on the other.

Nationalist Identification

Given the complex and amorphous discursive relations of nation, state, race, and people, Bart Bonikowski (2016) is correct in suggesting that nationalism represents “a pervasive cognitive and affective orientation rather than a coherent ideology” (428). Nationalism, he suggests, is best understood as a form of practice reflecting a particular set of dispositions that are “relational, intersubjective, morally and affectively laden, and largely taken for granted” (429). Nationalism is an ongoing “performance of identity-work” (Edgell et al. 2019, 5) expressed in

“routinized forms of talk, and ritualized symbolic practices” (Bonikowski 2016, 429) that together express and reinforce the “constitutive norms,” the “rules,” both formal and informal, that define group membership (Schildkraut 2014, 446). These norms “infuse group symbols with emotional potency and meaning,” thereby amplifying feelings of national solidarity and even sacralizing the nation itself (Bonikowski 2016, 434). Taken together, such practices represent “a performance of cultural affinities” that define membership in the nation (Edgell et al. 2019, 6). Disposition and action are mutually reinforcing, so that nationalism, understood as “a discursive and cognitive frame,” serves as the means through which “people understand the world, navigate social interactions, engage in coordinated action, and make political claims” (430). Stated in the language of Chapter 1, nationalism structures individual and group social perceptions, affects, and practices.

The nation, like the populist people, maintains its existence only to the degree that people continue to actively identify with it. This is reflected in Bonikowski’s (2016) emphasis on practice, which works to generate “a taken-for-granted belief in the natural status of the nation-state as an object of identification” (430). While I would differentiate between nation and state, for the reasons outlined above, Bonikowski’s emphasis on identification’s role is informative. Theiss-Morse (2009) suggests that “national identity is based on people’s belief that a national community exists and that the people within the national community share certain characteristics” (5), while Benjamin De Cleen (2017) notes that the perception of nation as community engenders the sense that all the nation’s members are part of an organic whole (344). Recognition of identification’s role in the nation’s ongoing constitution and identification’s grounding in practice allows for an appreciation of nationalism’s operational scope, ranging from a discourse deployed by political elites, on the one hand, to “more tacit” dimensions, “expressed in habituated modes of thought, speech, and behavior that take for granted the nation’s cultural and political primary,” on the other (Bonikowski 2016, 431).

This broad operational range highlights nationalism’s non-exceptional nature. While disruptive events, explicit struggles over national identity, and acts of ritual membership renewal may bring nationalism into clear relief, these all reflect the latent mechanisms that are always at work maintaining nationalist identification, typically below the level of explicit awareness (Bonikowski 2016, 429–432). Thus, nationalism is “actively institutionalized in daily practice” (432), rendering it typical or, borrowing Billig’s (1995) memorable term, “banal.” Nationalism’s banalization involves constant, subtle reminders through speech, symbolic rituals, engagement with national institutions, and consumption practices, that reinforce one’s socialization into the nation, naturalizing the belief that “the world is (and should be) divided into identifiable nations” (Bonikowski 2016, 432, 433).

Dispositional language is appropriately applied to nationalism in its banal dimensions insofar as, precisely because it is banal, explicit deployment of nationalist frames only occurs “sporadically” (Bonikowski 2016, 435). As we have

seen, nationalism's normal functioning operates below the surface, at the dispositional level structuring social and political perceptions, affects, and practices. One of nationalist identity's defining dispositional, structuring dimensions is an emphasis on the nation's "internal homogeneity" and its perceived "fundamental distinctiveness" from other nations, a perception simultaneously expressed and reinforced "through frequent interactions with linguistic and culturally similar individuals" coupled with only infrequent contact with "culturally distant others" (432–433). Such everyday encounters engender a sense of national homogeneity that takes the form of ethnic and cultural purity, often leading to xenophobia (433, 434). Nationalism's practical and routinized nature illustrates why perceived national homogeneity represents an effect of identification with the nation, and therefore a social or political achievement, rather than the expression of a fixed, primordial identity. The ubiquitous, everyday nature of the practices that both reinforce and express nationalism highlight Billig's (1995) point that "nationalism, far from being an intermittent mood in established nations, is the endemic condition" (with the caveat, again, of the need for a clearer analytical distinction between nation and state) (432).

Given such observations, it becomes clear why those "who are acutely threatened by rapid cultural and economic changes" are most likely to be responsive to nationalist political appeals (Bonikowski 2016, 433). Theiss-Morse's conception of prototypicality is again enlightening in this context: those who most fully identify with the idealized national prototype are most likely to resist cultural or economic changes that result in a society that is perceived to depart from that prototypical vision. This why nationalist appeals, like populist appeals, are aided by power-devaluation crises, in which those whose possession of social and political authority on the basis recognized national membership perceive the diminishment of that authority by social and political gains on the part of those who do not fit the ideal of national belonging.

Idealized conceptions of national belonging and the desire to maintain social and political authority play out in very concrete ways. Those who hold restrictive views of national belonging are associated with a range of exclusionary policy preferences, such as "stronger anti-immigrant attitudes ... negative sentiments toward ethnic minorities ... and cultural protectionism" (Bonikowski 2016, 438). High levels of pride in national cultural heritage also correlate with ethnocultural understandings of national identity (439), while perceptions of national superiority correlate with "bellicose foreign policy ... authoritarian attitudes ... prejudice against minorities ... hostility toward immigrants ... opposition to supra-national institutions ... and voter apathy" (439). The nation's perceived homogeneity therefore leads to the adoption of concrete policies and positions aimed at preserving that homogeneity and the social and political authority of the *real* nation's members, even within the pluralistic state.

The significance of the nation's perceived homogeneity should not, however, distract from the reality and significance of competing national identity conceptions. Normative conceptions of national identity are the effects of social and

political contestation—just as there is never only one conception of the authentic people's identity, there is never a single operative conception of what the nation truly is. Not only will many experience a distinction between *real* Americans and those who are only nominally American via civic identity, for example, but there will also be *competing accounts* of what a “real” American is. As Bonikowski (2016) puts it, there exists “extensive within-country heterogeneity” regarding understandings of the nation's boundaries (437). Even “nationalism in settled times” is marked by “multiple [competing] conceptions of national membership” (437). Indeed, were this not the case, the social and political developments spurring power-devaluation crises could never come into being.

As a form of group identity (Schildkraut 2014, 443), then, national identity emerges from among competing conceptions of national membership (Bonikowski 2016, 437). The “winners” in the contest of national identities are, of course, those national identity expressions that succeed in winning the greatest degree of individual and group identification. Success in this regard is largely an effect of a particular national identity conception's overall coherence, which is a function of the symbolic boundaries within which it takes shape, boundaries which Penny Edgell et al. (2019) describe as “a way of packaging shared cultural affiliations and identities” (5). To our recognition that neither populism nor nationalism reflect coherent ideologies we can now add that their effective constitution and maintenance depend on the “coherent packaging” of the cultural affinities around which they take shape (2), with different conceptions of national identity expressing divergent “cultural styles” (18).

The Populist/Nationalist Social Body

Nationalism and populism are analytically distinct phenomena, and distinct examples of each can be cited. As we have seen, however, their similarities and conceptual overlap are extensive enough that we should expect to find them articulated together. This occurs when the ideal prototypes of people and nation converge (as do, concomitantly, the out-groups against which these prototypes are defined—see De Cleen 2017, 349), so that only the populist people are also recognized as the nation's true members. Populist politics' verticalization and personalization also take on a nationalist form when the populist leader is recognized as expressing the identity not only of the people, but of the nation as well (Urbinati 2018, 578). Urbinati (2014) also highlights “the incorporation of the people in modern state sovereignty and its identification with the nation” (161; see De Cleen 2017, 344), suggesting populism and nationalism's ready convergence in a political style seeking state power (128). De Cleen (2017) suggests that “the people-as-underdog is a sub-group of the ethnic-culturally defined nation” (349), illustrating that nationalism can be driven by the same power-devaluation crises that motivate populism. Thus, following this logic, “the people-as-underdog” can refer to the majority or power-wielding minority who

perceives its displacement, and therefore pits itself against “migrants and other national(ist) out-groups” (349). In such a formulation, the pluralist, multi-culturalist society represents an existential threat to both people and nation. As this makes clear, exclusivist nationalism and populism both express an anti-pluralist disposition, so that in their coincidence those perceived to threaten the populist people include the same individuals and out-groups who are perceived to threaten the nation’s integrity (350).

Like populism, nationalism may trend in a broadly democratic direction when it arises in a non-democratic context, or when the “nation” in question corresponds to a historically marginalized or oppressed population. The nationalism on which we are primarily focused (a US example of which is next chapter’s focus), by way of contrast, arises within the context of established democratic systems and, arising from power-devaluation crises, is aimed at preserving historically privileged populations’ social and political authority. When it takes a populist form, this nationalist orientation expresses the same anti-democratic desire for the normative social body as populism—with populism and nationalism’s coincidence, the national body *is* the populist *Volkskörper*. When articulated with populism, such a nationalist form is marked by the same distance-in-proximity to democracy and defined by the same anti-democratic, majoritarian governance strategies. Finally, with its concern for attaining state power, populism naturally lends itself to a distinctively nationalist articulation, given nationalists’ insistent on the coincidence of nation and state.

Like populism, nationalism expresses a disposition to the proper, hierarchical ordering of both society and the state. The state itself, in its idealized coincidence with the nation, is imagined as having a normative morphology, according to which those who belong to the authentic nation exercise political and social authority, while the proper places of those who do not, including those with only nominal civic identity, are subordinate to them. And, like populism, nationalism represents a dysphoric reaction to any unmaking of this normative social order, to this imagined social body’s transmogrification. Articulated together, nationalist populism (or populist nationalism) therefore represents a virulent, “doubly dysphoric” response to morphologically fluid social bodies, such as those increasingly evident in complex, pluralistic countries.

But nationalism also shares populism’s fantastical nature. Like populism, it expresses a political desire for an impossible social body. As we have seen, the nation emerges only as the contingent result of social and political contests and its ongoing existence remains dependent on individuals’ and groups’ identification with it. As with populism, then, the social and political changes that unmake the national body’s imagined normative morphology reveal its fundamental queerness. They reveal that *every* social body is queer, morphologically fluid and grotesque in its articulations. If nationalist populism, then, is doubly dysphoric, the political desire it expresses is also doubly fantastical in nature.

Notes

- 1 In the discussion that follows, we will be contrasting the operative conceptions of “the people” in populism and queer democracy. For the sake of clarity, I will generally refer to the latter as the *demos*, and will typically specify “the populist people” or “the people” when referring to the concept as it operates within populism. Additionally, and in line with our practice in prior chapters, insofar as “the people” is a collective, it operates grammatically as a singular noun, which is reflected in generally awkward English-language locutions (e.g., “the people is ...”).
- 2 Lefort’s expressed concern in authoritarianism in relation to democracy, not populism *per se*. As we will see below, however, the two emerge as essentially symmetrical social movements once populist patterns of governance come into view.
- 3 Achen and Bartels (2016) offer an empirical grounding to these theoretical considerations, putting forward a compelling case that individuals’ political and policy beliefs are often an *effect* of the platforms of the political parties with which they identify (i.e., with the political parties that represent them). See, in particular, Chapters 9–10.
- 4 Highlighting the general nature of this point about representation, we considered similar points in our discussions of representation in Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau in the previous chapter.
- 5 As the title of their article suggests, their specific focus is why populists are willing to support “lying demagogues.” This specific discussion, however, is situated within broader concerns of populist leaders’ perceived legitimacy and authenticity (Hahl, Kim, and Zuckerman Sivan 2018, 1), and therefore has application beyond this narrower concern.
- 6 I take “erstwhile outsiders” in their formulation in a qualitative sense, as referring to all out-groups vis-à-vis the populist people, including those who share state citizenship with those recognized as members of the “real” populist people.
- 7 An obvious illustration of this point is the governance of Apartheid South Africa. Between 1946 and 1990, the percentage of Black population increased from about 69 percent to 76 percent, while the White population percentage decreased from 20 percent to 13 percent (Chimere-dan 1992). Yet the governance and authority still reflected the logic of extreme majoritarianism.
- 8 This is why I disagree with analyses such as that offered by Benjamin De Cleen (2017), who argues that populism is defined solely by the “down/up” antagonism between “the people” and “the elites” (346, 352).
- 9 “Stateless” here refers to the situation of living beyond any state’s geographical borders, a very different sense from that in which those who *do* live within a state’s borders are denied the rights and status of citizenship, a very real phenomenon that is all too common.
- 10 As Philpott (2001) suggests, the Treaty of Westphalia represented a decisive consolidation of developments in European statehood that had been going on for centuries (77). While it does not represent a sole source of the international sovereign state system, Philpott nevertheless makes a strong case that, had it not been for the Treaty, which formally ended the Thirty Years’ War, the emergence of a sovereign state system in Europe would have occurred much later if at all (see 75–96). At any rate, Westphalia is commonly noted as the event that formalized the emergence of Europe’s sovereign state system, effectively inaugurating the common international sovereign state system (see Diener and Hagan 2012, 3; Thomas 54; Steger 2013, 61–63). For a full discussion of Westphalia’s significance for the constitution of the international sovereign state system, including its global expansion, as well as the Protestant Reformation’s political significance, see Philpott 2001.
- 11 I describe these as “idealized” presentations because there is little basis to support a universally shared sense of “Frenchness” or “Americanness” in either respective state. For the U.S. case, see Kaufmann 2000 and Theiss-Morse 2009; for the French case, see Scott 2007.

- 12 I am not presupposing, with this illustration, that only those granted citizenship should share in full equality or legal civic identity. But, as Bellamy (2008) suggests, citizenship grants “the right to have rights” (15), so that even those would deny civic equality to legal permanent residents, undocumented immigrants, asylum seekers, and so on would in principle recognize citizens’ civic identity.

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5

AMERICAN DYSPHORIA I

Christian Nationalism

Introduction

Whereas the previous chapter provided a general discussion of populism and nationalism's contemporary conjunction, this chapter will consider the most significant populist-nationalist expression in the contemporary US, Christian nationalism. To be sure, the nature of American national identity is contested, marked by competing conceptions (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016). As suggested in the previous chapter, virtually universal appeal to the descriptor "American" should not lead us to overlook that signifier's contested nature, which is to say, the fact that different groups "fill in" the meaning of "American" in diverse and competing ways (Schildkraut 2014, 446). While contemporary Christian nationalism represents only one articulation of American identity, it represents arguably the most socially and politically significant at present.

Expressing a potent articulation of populism and nationalism, it is also inherently anti-democratic, representing a socially dysphoric response to the queer social body that takes shape through queerly democratic action. As a populist movement, Christian nationalism is concerned to preserve the authentic populist people's social and political authority, while its distinctly nationalist dimension is given in response to the question that logically follows from this: who *are* the authentic populist people? The nationalist answer to this question is, "*real Americans*."¹ That is, the populist people does not include everyone with a shared civic or political status, such as US citizenship, but only a subset of that larger population who are not only US citizens, but who are also members of the authentic American nation.

As we shall see, this sense of authentic American national identity is defined by an idealized conception of the prototypical American as White, cisgender, heterosexual, Protestant, English-speaking, US-born, of northern European descent,

and affirmative of patriarchy (if not male). Reflecting populism and nationalism's narrative dimension, Christian nationalism is also grounded in a nostalgic narrative of American identity and the US state, from its founding up to the present time. This broad narrative tells the story of the US as a prosperous nation, founded and advanced by prototypical Americans. But this is also what Lorenzo Veracini (2010) refers to as a "declensionist" narrative, a narrative of decline (101): over time, and particularly since the 1960s, the US has been marked by decline, coinciding with economic and demographic changes that have produced a pluralistic and multicultural state in which prototypical real Americans have lost their socially and politically authoritative position (see Jones 2016a, 82–88; 2016b; Cox and Jones 2017; Cilluffo and D'Vera 2019). American Christian nationalism therefore expresses a desire for a return to a mythologized social and political order. Stated in terms of the social-as-body metaphor, it expresses a desire to (re)impose the Christian-national body's normative, hierarchical morphology, in which real Americans occupy positions of social and political authority while all other, merely nominal, Americans properly occupy subordinate places within it.

As experienced from within the Christian nationalist imaginary, the increasing pluralism and multiculturalism of the US, marked by democratic demands and social gains on the part of diverse constituencies who are not recognized in the idealized real-American prototype, represents the American social body's monstrous and grotesque transmogrification. Christian nationalism therefore represents a socially dysphoric effort to preserve or reinstate real Americans' position atop the American national hierarchy. Whiteness and patriarchy loom large in the discussion that follows, and with them the idea that Whites, particularly White men, have been the historical beneficiaries of the Christian-national body's hierarchical structuring.

It is important to head off, from the outset, a potential misunderstanding arising out of this focus. To suggest that White, Christian men who can be identified as Christian nationalists are responding to a loss of privileged status is not to claim, naively, that all White, Christian men are personally or individually doing well economically or politically. That is, the claim that this demographic has historically experienced privilege is not inconsistent with the recognition that many White, Christian men in the US are currently experiencing economic strain or political alienation (see Hochschild 2016, 140–143).

The decline in economic status, in particular, for White Americans in recent decades is real. Since 1980, with the supercharged imposition of neoliberal economic policies under Ronald Reagan, real income has risen for only the most affluent Americans (as opposed to rising in all social sectors from 1947–1979), leaving others, including the vast majority of Whites, behind (De La Torre 2019, 54). Neoliberal economic policies have also led to income inequality's exploding levels, so that "by 2012, during the first full year of the so-called recovery from the 2008 Great Recession, 93 percent of income gains went to the top 1 percent, while 7 percent went to the remaining 99 percent" (55). Miguel De La Torre powerfully sums up the economic realities reflected in such developments:

Neoliberalism is colorblind. White, Black, brown, red, and yellow shed blood of the same color when they are cut by the same global economy. Skin color—White, Black, brown, red, and yellow—makes no difference to those who extract the green from the pockets of the dispossessed. White, Black, brown, red, and yellow share the same disenfranchised space but are separated and divided from each other to ensure financial security for the privileged few.

(53)

Summing up the significance of such experiences, De La Torre writes,

poor Whites living paycheck-to-paycheck, fearing their jobs might be shipped south of the border, probably wonder, where is this power and privilege we supposedly possess? How does White privilege ... privilege Whites when their children are destined to be financially worse off than they are?

(52)

The key to answering this question lies in the narrative with which Christian nationalists identify. The economic facts negatively impacting millions of White Americans (and a much higher percentage of US minorities) are real. But contemporary Christian nationalism takes shape in the identification with a particular narrative *about* current economic realities. We noted in the previous chapter that political or economic interests are not objectively or empirically determined but are a matter of group identification. Applied to the context of many White Americans, it is true, from a factual or empirical perspective, that “Whites excluded from the space occupied by the uber-wealthy have more in common with poor and middle-class communities of color than with their better-off White counterparts” (De La Torre 2019, 57). But instead of standing *with* these communities, White Americans drawn to Christian nationalism become “fierce defenders of those profiting off their losses” (55). Whites lacking economic privilege identify with a narrative encouraging them to “dream up and blame down” (57). That is, failing to actualize the mythical “American dream,” Whites

neither blame themselves nor the 1 percent for their economic collapse. Instead, they pass the blame downward, accusing those who are marginalized of stealing their jobs and depressing wages and preventing the true heirs of the American dream from achieving their rightful place in society.

(58)

The same national out-groups, groups that are not *really* American and who bear responsibility for America’s long decline, are scapegoated as having unmade the social body, displacing White men, in particular, from their proper place within the Christian-national body.

Christian nationalists identify with what Arlie Russell Hochschild (2016) calls a “feels-as-if story” (135). It does not feel as if the (almost exclusively White) economically privileged have disenfranchised economically depressed White Americans. Rather, these are the real Americans, and what threatens them are those, within the US and standing at its borders, who are *not* real Americans. Identifying with this narrative, millions of White Americans not only defend, explicitly or implicitly, the American national body’s hierarchical ordering, but register their entitlement to occupy their rightful or natural place above those who do not number among the real Americans, including people of color. This narrative of hierarchical entitlement and blame for dispossession has not arisen organically but has been carefully cultivated by political conservatives (many of them the same economic elites disenfranchising the very Whites who vote for them in huge numbers) over the course of recent decades, first in Richard Nixon’s “Southern Strategy” and later with what Robert P. Jones (2016a) terms the “White Christian Strategy” (88–105). It is not happenstance that, as noted below, the overwhelming majority of Christian nationalists are political conservatives.

Grounded in narratives of American decline and real Americans’ political and social dispossession, Christian nationalism is a dysphoric response to a queer social body. It is a visceral, negative reaction to queer democracy and the *demos*’s expansion, to the social and political demands and gains of all those who do not match the idealized real-American prototype. Liberty and equality’s expansion to increasingly broad social sectors and the Christian-national body’s concomitant unmaking can only come at a cost to those whose social identity depends upon the existing social body’s active maintenance. The queer social body’s emergence, with no fixed morphology and defined by the *demos*’s ongoing transfiguration, provokes the Christian nationalist effort to (re)impose the morphologically normative Christian-national social body imagined within its nostalgic appeals to the American nation’s past greatness. Within the Christian nationalist imaginary, a social body marked by (un)becoming (Sullivan 2006, 560) is pathologically disfigured and grotesque, and must be set right, put back into proper order.

American Christian Nationalism

Illustrating the importance of populist and nationalist identity’s narrative dimension, Delehanty et al. (2019) suggest that Christian nationalism is rooted in “a discourse about the religious roots of citizenship and national identity” in the US, which they term “secularized evangelical discourse” (1284). Taking shape in religious and national identity’s coalescence (Davis 2018, 301), Christian nationalism seeks to merge the religious and political spheres (Braunstein and Taylor 2017, 39). The “America-as-Christian-Nation” narrative cannot withstand historical scrutiny (see Seidel 2019), but this is effectively irrelevant with regard to its constitutive force for contemporary Christian nationalism. As we saw in the previous chapter, the existence of the populist people or true

nation is an effect of individuals' or groups' identification with that nation or people, so that the narrative's factual accuracy matters less than individual's identification with it.

As we have seen, the social-as-body metaphor, as expressed within populism, is grounded in the natural attitude of embodiment (Bettcher 2009, 103), according to which the supposed naturalness of the body's morphology lends it normative shape. The effect of the America-as-Christian-nation narrative is to effectively naturalize the traditionally hierarchical and inegalitarian structure of the American social body, thereby lending it normative force. The historical privileging of those recognized as embodying the idealized real-American prototype is presented as a natural (i.e., socially and politically neutral) occurrence, giving the American national body its "natural" shape, so that contemporary departures from its normative contours can only be "unnatural" and, therefore, pathological.

This narrative, of course, ignores the reality that there has been nothing natural about the traditional structuring of the American national body, which has been structured through practices and discourses of violence and exclusion from its inception. From the openly racist liberal ideologies underlying the nation's founding (Mills 1997), to the founding of the state through the exercise of settler colonialism (Hixson 2013; Dahl 2018; Horne 2018; Miller et al. 2010), to the setting of its economic foundations on chattel slavery and misogyny (Painter 2010; Kendi 2016; Manne 2018; Jones 2020;), to more than two centuries of legal, cultural, institutional, and religious legitimization of the active oppression and marginalization of all those not recognized as fully American, the normative American social body has been consistently imposed and maintained by force.

The America-as-Christian-nation narrative's naturalization has not been accidental but depends on processes of active disavowal and historical denial (Hixson 2013, 11; Dahl 2018, 4). In the place of factual historical appeal, the America-as-Christian-nation narrative represents a "screen memory," an "inaccurate reconstruction that obscures what really happened" in the country's founding (Veracini 2010, 90). This screen memory involves a "peculiar inversion mechanism" (89) in which White European settlers are "indigenized" (78; Hixson 2013, 11), so that displaced indigenous peoples are viewed as having improperly entered settler space (Veracini 2010, 86), with the effect that "the indigene becomes the force of evil pitted against the good of the colonizing project" (Hixson 2013, 22). These dynamics all facilitate the ongoing development of a construction of pan-European White identity (Horne 2018, 13; Hixson 2013, 10) grounded (right up to the present) in a White "epistemology of ignorance" masking these operations (Mills 1997, 18) and allowing full identification with the screen memory expressed in the America-as-Christian-nation narrative.²

To fully appreciate the significance of this identification, it is crucial to recognize that it is not primarily directed to the past but expresses essential convictions about contemporary social and political life. Delehanty et al. (2019) identify four particularly relevant convictions: "that religious identity is important for good

citizenship, that religious belief is a criterion for strong political leadership, that society's rules should be based on divine will, and that public institutions should broadly accommodate religious belief and practice" (1286).

Predominant understandings about the nature of American national identity have shifted in recent decades. Referencing Gunnar Myrdal's (1944) well-known account, Deborah J. Schildkraut notes the long-held "conventional wisdom" that American national identity was based on a collection of political ideals that has come to be termed the "American Creed" (2014, 442; Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 435). This conventional wisdom meant that American national identity was traditionally envisioned as taking shape around a form of civic nationalism, based on shared social and political values and ideals, rather than ascribed attributes such as ethnicity, gender, national origin, class, religion, preferred language, and so on (Schildkraut 2014, 442; Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 2).³ Increasing theoretical and historical attention to national identity's contested nature, however, has led to greater recognition that "more than one version of nationalist thought organizes Americans' relationship to their nation" (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 3), lending credence to a "multiple-traditions thesis" of American nationalism (Smith 1997, 6, 18; Schildkraut 2014, 447). While civic nationalist expressions certainly number among these multiple conceptions of American national identity, numerous others find expression as well (Schildkraut 2014, 447), highlighting the "cultural cleavages" around which national identity's divergent senses take shape (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 428, 435). There is great overlap in the research findings of those informed by the multiple-traditions thesis: Edgell et al. (2019), for example, identify three distinct ways of "packaging" American national identity (2), while Delehanty et al. (2019) identify four nationalist orientations (1292), as do Bart Bonikowski and Paul DiMaggio (2016, 3) and Andrew L. Whitehead and Samuel L. Perry (2020, 10, 25).

Within this broadly shared perspective, Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016, 10) and Whitehead and Perry (2020, 25) each uncover a spectrum of orientations around American national identity with two extreme positions on the ends and two positions in the middle. Importantly, the middle positions on this spectrum, however, do not represent a shared "moderate middle" vis-à-vis the extreme positions (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 14, 17; Delehanty et al. 2019, 1295). Rather, individuals occupying the middle positions on the continuum tend to lean toward the more extreme positions at its ends, leading to the social's overall bifurcation through the expression of two broadly competing American nationalist identities (see Delehanty et al. 2019, 1292; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 29–38).

As a focus on *Christian* nationalism suggests, Christianity's experienced significance for American identity is a central axis around which these competing conceptions of American national identity take shape (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 4). As Whitehead and Perry (2020), whose research into contemporary Christian nationalism in America is the most recent and in-depth, suggest, "'Christian nationalism' is not a single idea that can be measured solely by

agreement with a founding myth, but rather a more dynamic ideology incorporating a number of beliefs and values” (7). Thus, Christian nationalism is a normative position about what America *ought to be* as a nation and what kinds of people *ought* to count as real Americans, not simply an appeal to its Christian founding (7).

Whitehead and Perry’s (2020) detailed measure of Christian nationalism deserves particular mention, given the degree to which it informs the discussion that follows. Drawing primarily on Baylor Religion Survey data from 2007 and 2017, they develop a composite measure of Christian nationalism by plotting individuals’ position on a 24-point scale, based on their responses to six statements (7–8).⁴ This scale reveals a four-position Christian nationalist continuum, with “Rejecters” and “Ambassadors” on the ends and “Resisters” and “Accommodators” in between these extremes (10). Rejecters (those scoring from 0–5 points on the scale) account for 21.5 percent of the population; Resisters (6–11 points) account for 27 percent; Accommodators (12–17 points) account for 32.1 percent; and Ambassadors (18–24) account for 19.8 percent (25–26).⁵ Rejecters and Ambassadors represent the most extreme positions, marked by strong opposition to Christian nationalism and strong support for it, respectively (26, 35). Illustrating the social’s bifurcation with regard to Christian nationalism, Rejecters “lean toward opposing Christian nationalism” (31), while Accommodators “lean toward accepting it” (33).⁶ As these findings reveal, a majority of Americans either actively support or are sympathetic to Christian nationalism.

Real Americans

As Whitehead and Perry (2020) suggest, Christian nationalism can be described as “Christian nation-ism,” defined by “a commitment to a vision of American civic life and polity as closely intertwined with an identitarian, politically conservative strain of Christianity” (x–xi). Representing a comprehensive cultural framework and understanding of national identity (10), Christian nationalism is marked by a “culturally specific vision of American belonging” (Edgell et al. 2019, 10) that vividly highlights the importance of the virtual/nominal identity distinction, as well as that between nation and state, as outlined in the previous chapter.⁷ From a Christian nationalist orientation, all US citizens may be nominally American, but citizenship is not sufficient to number them among real Americans. Christian nationalism therefore expresses “a cultural vision of whose country the United States *really* is” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 63). Real Americans, as one respondent succinctly states the issue, “stand at the flag and ... kneel at the cross” (80). Those who do *not* identify, or who are not identified, with this understanding of the American nation, by way of contrast, are not *fully* American (4). Rather, a discourse about “the religious roots of citizenship and national identity” is “a primary locus of political and cultural boundary work” within Christian nationalism (Delehanty et al. 2019, 1284). Thus, as Joshua Davis (2018) suggests, “in the

case of Christian nationalism, an individual may know that not all Americans are Christian and still contend that real Americans are” (303). Christian nationalist identity therefore expresses the deeply felt conviction that national belonging is spiritually grounded (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 164).

Within the Christian nationalist imaginary, real Americans “maintain control over access to society’s social, cultural, and political institutions, and ‘others’ remain in their proper place” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 118). Drawing on our earlier discussion of Elizabeth Theiss-Morse’s (2009) concept of prototypicality (72–73), we can see that this vision of the social body draws on deeply felt and viscerally affective conceptions of the prototypical American. Thus, Christian nationalism takes shape around a clear delimitation of the boundaries of real Americans’ social body, together with a concomitant, equally clear “otherizing [of] out-groups” perceived as threats to its homogeneity (Davis 2018, 313).

A notable consistency in idealized prototypical American attributes emerges across a range of studies in Christian nationalism and American identity. Christian nationalism is not only about religious identity, narrowly conceived, but is also wrapped up with other identity dimensions (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 5). In Schildkraut’s words (2014), Christian nationalism represents a form of “ethnocultural or ascriptive Americanism” that “sets rigid boundaries on group membership” so that, to be numbered among the real Americans, one must be “a White, English-speaking Protestant of northern European ancestry” (Schildkraut 2014, 447; see also Kaufmann 2000, 9, 17–18; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 118). Christian nationalist conceptions of authentic American identity also reflect Grosby’s (2005) dual elements of kinship (ancestral and territorial) (44). Thus, “*true Americans are those who were born here, lived here their whole lives, are able to speak English, and have American ancestry*” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 99; emphases added).

Another defining feature of the prototypical American is explicit identification *as American*. Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016), for instance, identify “feeling American” as a component of true or authentic American identity (6), while Schildkraut (2014) notes that those who consider themselves “typical” Americans are “more likely than others to identify strongly with the country, which in turn makes them more likely to define American identity in an ascriptive manner” (449, see also 452; Theiss-Morse 2009, 52). As this latter point suggests, there is a strong racial dimension to the perceived importance of explicit American identification. American identity is associated with Whiteness by many Americans (Devos and Banaji 2005; Jardina 2019, 118–154), and Whites who perceive Whiteness as essential to American identity oppose changes in racial or ethnic demography that challenge White hegemony (Jardina 2019, 155–186). Illustrating this point, Pew Research Center data shows that almost half of White Americans say that a majority non-White US population will weaken American culture (Parker et al. 2019). Whites, who have historically been counted as real Americans (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 59), are also more likely than Blacks to consider themselves typical Americans, and therefore to

identify authentic American identity with an explicit sense of American identification (Schildkraut 2014, 449, 451, 452).

While often not explicitly noted, political conservative identity is another feature of the prototypical real American. The strongest predictor of Christian nationalist identification is political conservatism (13; see also Davis 2018, 309): 44 percent of Accommodators identify as conservative (only 12 percent identify as liberal), while 69 percent of Ambassadors identify as conservative (only 4 percent identify as liberal), and 88 percent of Republicans identify as Christian nationalists (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 35, 38). Reinforcing these findings, Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016) find that “ardent nationalists” are most likely to identify as strong Republicans and least likely to identify as Democrats (12), while Ruth Braunstein and Malaena Taylor (2017) find that Christian nationalism is more closely tied to conservative political views than to religious affiliation, orthodoxy, or personal religious commitment (52).⁸ As Delehanty et al. (2019) suggest, while some of the ideas underlying Christian nationalism are not inherently politically conservative, they were articulated as such throughout the 20th century, taking on “exclusionary meanings through the cultural work of Republican elites, who identified religious conservatives as a potentially powerful political constituency” (1284). The social order Christian nationalists aim to protect is therefore intimately connected with political conservatism (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 153).⁹

As we have seen, national identity involves not only a sense of who is part of the nation, but a sense of who is not. Nationalist identity construction around idealized conceptions of the prototypical American is therefore concomitant with the construction of out-groups who are *not* real Americans. As we would expect, a concrete consequence of this is that Christian nationalists express broadly decreased out-group tolerance (Davis 2018, 312), encouraging “antipathy and mistrust toward those who do not meet the membership requirements of *native-born, Christian, and white*” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 16). The list of those excluded from membership among real Americans is long, including, but certainly not limited to, racial minorities, immigrants who are not recognized as White, naturalized citizens, Muslims, Jews, atheists and agnostics, members of the LGBTQ+ community, and the “undeserving” poor (see Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 11; Delehanty et al. 2019, 1285; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 16).

Preserving the American Social Body

Although Christian nationalism is structured around idealized conceptions of those groups who are and are not real Americans, there can be no practical question of limiting US citizenship to the former. Rather, the US population will always be an admixture of real Americans and those whose American identity is only nominal (e.g., those who have US citizenship but who are nevertheless not recognized as real Americans).¹⁰ Christian nationalism takes shape as the concrete

expression of the disposition to properly structure and order such a mixed society, a disposition which is captured in the social-as-body metaphor.

As outlined in the first chapter, the social-as-body metaphor effectively articulates a set of social and political dispositions even if it is not expressed explicitly. While we do not tend to find explicit discursive invocations to the Christian-national social body within Christian nationalism, then, the metaphor nevertheless renders explicit the political and social dispositions expressed within Christian nationalism. These dispositions are directed toward maintaining the social body's hierarchical order and structure (i.e., its normative morphology) and are accompanied by the visceral sense that an American social body that is not structured in accordance with that morphological ideal is pathologically malformed, literally dis-ordered.

Within the Christian nationalist imaginary, the morphologically normative social body, the American *Volkskörper* (Krämer 2017, 412), is the Christian-national body, one in which, again, real Americans “maintain control over access to society's social, cultural, and political institutions” while all others “remain in their proper [subordinate] place” (Whitehead and Perry, 2020, 118). The real-American prototype therefore legitimizes the maintenance of a social hierarchy (Edgell et al. 2019, 1), serving as a mechanism for the enforcement of the Christian-national social body's normative morphology. Christian nationalism therefore involves the reinforcement of real Americans' hegemonic power as a means for maintaining social order and the elimination of its perceived threats (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 145). Any challenge to the normative, hierarchical social order by those who are only recognized as nominally American threatens to unmake the normative Christian-national body, rendering it monstrous and grotesque and provoking socially and politically dysphoric responses.

To fully appreciate these dynamics of social body maintenance, it is important to recognize Christian nationalism's scope within American society. Unsurprisingly, White Christians are the largest single demographic within Christian nationalism's ranks (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 83; see also Edgell et al. 2019, 15). Within this overall demographic, Accommodators comprise the largest group (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 43), while White evangelicals account for almost 50 percent of the more militant Ambassadors (58). Consistent with this latter point, White evangelicals, compared to mainline Protestants, are more likely to express American identity in both civic and ascriptive terms (Schildkraut 2014, 449).

While it is perhaps unsurprising that we can identify a majority of White Christians as Christian nationalists, it is perhaps more surprising that the dispositions expressed in Christian nationalism are not limited to professing Christians, theologically conservative or otherwise. Whitehead and Perry (2020) find that over half of the US population broadly supports Christian nationalism (160), while Delehanty, Edgell, and Stewart (2019) find that approximately 58 percent of the US population at least moderately supports the discourse informing it (1292). These findings are significant because they indicate broader support for

Christian nationalism than can be explained by narrow conceptions of Christian identity (Delehanty et al. 2019, 1294) understood in terms of individual belief, practice, or other traditional religiosity measures (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 114, 145, 153).

Braunstein and Taylor (2017) demonstrate Christian nationalism's appeal in their consideration of the Tea Party Movement (TPM). They note that, despite popular associations of the TPM with the Religious Right, the TPM is actually marked by a "relatively religiously heterogeneous membership" (35). Thus, while about half of TPM members also identify with the Religious Right, "the other half of this movement reported significantly lower levels of religious orthodoxy and commitment and included a relatively large number of individuals who identify as nonreligious" (35). Were adherence to Christian nationalism limited to those with strong Christian identity narrowly conceived, we would expect to find strong support for Christian nationalism among Religious Right-affiliated TPM members, but not among TPM members with lower or no personal religious identification.

Braunstein and Taylor (2017) find, however, that a majority of *all* TPM members identify with Christian nationalism, including "disproportionately high numbers of nonreligious members" (35). That is, even TPM members demonstrating low religious identification levels still identify with Christian nationalism and its aims. The TPM's religious demographics are revealing in this regard: 17 percent of non-Religious Right-affiliated TPM members identify as atheist, agnostic, or "none," a percentage close to that among the general US population, which stands at about 20 percent (47).¹¹ Only a quarter of non-Religious Right-affiliated TPM members identify as evangelical Protestants, compared to two thirds of Religious Right-affiliated members, while more than a third (35 percent) of non-Religious Right-affiliated TPM members claim a non-religious identity, almost twice the percentage (20 percent) of non-religious individuals within the general US population (50–52). TPM membership is not only religiously heterogeneous, then, but TPM members who are not affiliated with the Religious Right tend to be *more* secular than the general US public.

Their study's most telling finding, given these considerations, is that "similar and substantial proportions of both movements' [the Religious Right's and the TPM's] members agree that America is currently and has always been a Christian nation" (Braunstein and Taylor 2017, 47). The numbers in this regard are overwhelming: "more than half of both subgroups agree that America is currently a Christian nation, and more than 90 percent of both groups agree that America is currently or used to be a Christian nation" (52, emphasis added). Further, Braunstein and Taylor also find that the percentage of TPM members holding this view is 13 points higher than that of the general population, while the RR's is only 7 points higher (47). It would be difficult to overstate this finding's significance for understanding Christian nationalism's broad appeal: members of the more secular TPM are significantly *more likely* to espouse Christian nationalist

views than members of the Religious Right. Religious Right-affiliated and non-Religious Right-affiliated TPM members are united, then, by a common commitment to Christian nationalism (52). Indeed, while affiliation with the Religious Right is driven by “religious orthodoxy and commitment,” affiliation with the TPM is driven by Christian nationalism (49). Summing up these findings, Braunstein and Taylor note that “religious nationalism is not necessarily associated with religious affiliation, orthodoxy, or commitment, at least among political conservatives” (52).¹²

Though limited to a particular socio-political movement, Braunstein and Taylor’s findings nevertheless lend credence to Whitehead and Perry’s (2020) suggestion that “Christian nationalism has thoroughly permeated American society and culture,” providing “a lens through which all Americans experience and interpret the social world” (18, see also 152). Thus, as Delehanty et al. (2019) suggest, “while its demographic preeminence has evaporated, White Christian America’s cultural influence remains profound, furnishing symbolic boundaries that appeal to many whose religious identities do not reflect the symbols’ religious roots” (1295). While these symbolic boundaries have become more porous over time, they nevertheless continue to function implicitly (1295), a point reflected in public opinion and policy debates, where Christian nationalist conceptions of American identity continue to be influential, despite having been “increasingly discredited in popular and political discourse” (Schildkraut 2014, 448).

American Christian nationalism’s cultural and political visibility also requires some additional comment. Even on Whitehead and Perry’s (2020) analysis there are almost as many Americans who *do not* identify with Christian nationalism as there are those who do (25), and they note that the past 30 years have been marked by decreasing overall identification with Christian nationalism, a trend they predict will continue (48–51). Given such considerations, it seems remarkable that Christian nationalism is arguably as, or more, visible within American social and political life at present than at any time in recent decades. What accounts for this increased visibility, given Christian nationalists’ numerical decline?

The answer to this question is straightforward: Christian nationalism is intensely visible socially and politically precisely *because* it is under strain. Social identities generally, and national identity in particular, can be intensified when confronted with perceived threats (Schildkraut 2014, 443), a dynamic evident in the finding that “Christian nationalism ... may wax and wane in response to certain societal tensions” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 51), becoming more salient in times of “societal unrest” (124). As Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016) note in a related vein, “nationalism may crystallize, and thus become more readily observable, in the aftermath of exogenous shocks to the nation or during protracted conflicts in the public sphere” (429).

The “protracted conflicts” and “exogenous shocks” confronting Christian nationalism are the social and political developments outlined in the introduction above which, taken cumulatively, signal the kind of power-devaluation crisis outlined in the previous chapter. We can think about Christian nationalism’s

emergent power-devaluation in historical terms. The image of prototypical, real Americans as White, English-speaking Protestants of northern European ancestry was broadly accepted in the US founding period (Kaufmann 2000, 9), a pattern which persisted throughout much of US history, with the consequence that US civic identity and American national identity were conflated. Thus, in the US's founding period, it was explicit that holding US citizenship did not, in and of itself, entitle one to full social or political equality (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 43) and in practice "citizenship in the United States reflected the racial hierarchy" common to the time (44). These sentiments were not limited to informal norms, but were codified in the 1790 Naturalization Act, which limited naturalization to "free White person[s]" of "good moral [i.e., Protestant] character" (44; see Jardina 2019, 9). Such formulations codified the coincidence of American civic and national identity—to be a full civic member of the US state, one also had to be recognized as an authentic member of the American nation.

While the earliest waves of immigration to the US followed a pattern of "Anglo-conformity," according to which "immigrants were to made into Americans...by absorbing American English, American liberty, American Protestantism and, ultimately, by intermarrying with Americans" (Kaufmann 2000, 13), subsequent immigration waves threatened to call prototypical American identity into question (Kaufmann 2000, 25–28; Masuoka and Junn 2013, 47; Jardina 2019, 9–10). Responses to such threats to national identity included the notorious 1911 Dillingham Commission and the 1924 Johnson-Reed Act, which established numeric quotas based on national origin, "advantage[ing] immigrants arriving from countries of the 'native stock,' or those persons with the same origination of the American population at the founding" (49; see Kaufmann 2000, 28–30; Jardina 2019, 10–11). Such laws and the nativist movements energizing them reflect ongoing practices aimed at maintaining the coincidence of US civic identity with American national identity. While national identity's racial dimension is at the forefront, highlighting "the country's long history of racial exclusion reflect[ing] the national vision of its identity embedded in a racial hierarchy" (50), it also implied other dimensions, such as gender identity, sexuality, and religion, which were taken for granted to such an extent that they did not even require explicit acknowledgment (44).

Since the latter half of the 20th century, however, it has become more difficult to maintain the coincidence of US civic identity and American national identity as the latter's taken-for-granted prototypicality has been challenged in various ways. The 1965 Hart-Celler Act's passage represents one of the most significant of these challenges. Reflecting the civil rights movement's impact and increasing social, political, and judicial recognition of prior immigration law's inherently discriminatory nature, the Act removed national origin quotas and "created a shift in the racial and ethnic makeup of the nation" (56; see Jardina 2019, 11). Over time, moving up to the present moment, this has resulted in a more explicitly multicultural and pluralistic state, effectively cleaving US civic identity from

prototypical national identity as an increasing percentage of the US population has come *not* to resemble the idealized real-American prototype. Other social and cultural developments (e.g., social and political gains of women, the LGBTQ+ community, disabled individuals, etc.) have combined with the country's changing racial demographics to further erode the idealized real-American prototype's normativity.

As experienced from within the Christian nationalist imaginary, these disruptive events all result from the social body's properly subordinate (or formerly invisible) members straying beyond their proper places within the Christian-national body, unmaking its normative hierarchical morphology. This transmogrification represents the kind of power-devaluation crisis outlined in the previous chapter. Those who identify, and are identified, as real Americans begin to see "their" country disappear (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 16), a perceived loss that can manifest itself in a sense of "aggrieved victimization" (Stanley 2018, 101). Liberty and equality's expansion to increasingly broad social spheres that marks queer democracy can appear as a source of injustice to those who have benefitted from the Christian-national social body's subordinate/superordinate morphology (89) so that out-groups' demands for inclusion in the *demos* are perceived as "masks for power grabs" (90).

Those who are displaced from their properly authoritative, privileged positions within the Christian-national body therefore react dysphorically to the American social body's increasingly evident queerness and fluidity in an attempt to reimpose its normative hierarchical morphology. Thus, within contemporary American Christian nationalism, "those who have historically benefitted from the status quo not only marshal justifications for the old order, but rally a coordinated response among those who stand to lose the most if that old order topples" (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 151). Christian nationalists' appeals to victimhood represent a crucial mechanism in such responses, providing the means of "cover[ing] up structural inequality by attempting to invert, misrepresent, and subvert the long hard effort to address it" (Stanley 2018, 99). Christian nationalists' deployment of rights language offers a subtle but telling illustration of this point. Political and religious conservatives have traditionally eschewed rights appeals in legal and social arguments, appealing instead to "common morality, personal responsibility, and civic republicanism" (Lewis 2017, 2) in opposition to minority groups appealing to rights. One of the defining features of contemporary Christian nationalist responses to the queer social body involves this schema's inversion, whereby "conservatives, particularly religious conservatives, have come to share the mantle of rights-based advocacy with liberals" (3–4). This shift in strategy is telling for at least two reasons. First, insofar as it represents a shift from a majoritarian to a minoritarian argument style (173), it highlights the power-devaluation crisis confronting Christian nationalists. Second, insofar as it aims to preserve the Christian-national body's normative morphology (162), it highlights Christian nationalists' dysphoric response to the queer social body.

Rethinking “Christian” Identity

Christian nationalism is a socially dysphoric reaction to the queerness of the American social body revealed in recent decades’ cultural and demographic shifts. As such, it expresses the desire to reassert a normative morphology on that body, to ensure that all the social body’s members are in their proper places, as imagined from within Christian nationalism. We have also seen that identification with Christian nationalism is not limited to those who narrowly identify as Christian. This raises an important question: if support for Christian nationalism is not limited to confessing Christians, in what sense is it “Christian”? What work does this qualifier accomplish?

One response to this question is historical. As we have seen, Delehanty et al. (2019) term the broader discourse underlying Christian nationalism “secularized evangelical discourse,” which they define as “a repertoire of political statements that are phrased in religiously nonparticularistic terms, but have roots in evangelical Christian history and epistemologies and have been politicized through social movements and party politics” (1283). Taken in this sense, the “Christian” of Christian nationalism alerts us to the historical origins of many of the key ideas and intuitions that inform the movement, including appeals to an “America-as-Christian-nation” founding narrative. This is one discernible sense of Christian-national identity evident in the Tea Party Movement, for example (see Braunstein and Taylor 2017, 52).

While Christian nationalism’s historical roots are not trivial, a second, more nuanced response to this question also presents itself. This response requires rethinking the concept of religious identity, particularly in relation to its political or social expression, and questions some of the common assumptions behind religiosity measures. The social-as-body metaphor’s theoretical utility is evident in this regard. As we have seen, Christian nationalism, the visceral sense that America is fundamentally a *Christian* nation, is more an expression of a deeply and affectively felt sense of *social order* than of doctrinal belief or practice, or of individual pietistic expression. As a dysphoric response to a visibly queer social body that is increasingly experienced as misshapen, monstrous, or grotesque, it expresses dispositions, what Braunstein and Taylor (2017) usefully describe as “religiopolitical sentiments” (40), about the American national body’s proper structure and shape.

As an expression of a disposition to social order aimed at the national body’s regulation and ordering, Christian nationalism is necessarily public in nature. In focusing on individual beliefs and practices, traditional religiosity measures, by way of contrast, tacitly presuppose that religion is inherently private. This presumption sets up a schema according to which “religion,” insofar as it is an inherently individual, private enterprise, and “politics,” as an inherently public phenomenon, represent two necessarily distinct social domains. This presumption, which is conceptually and historically problematic (see Miller 2016, 1–20), is

reflected in Davis's (2018) suggestion that Christian nationalism represents a "converged identity" that conflates individuals' religious and political identities (303). The clear presumption in such a formulation is that religious identity and political identity are, in fact, inherently distinct, so that their combination is in some sense abnormal. If one accepts this tacit schema, then support for Christian nationalism, with its inherently public interest, cannot meaningfully be described as "Christian" if individual Christian nationalists do not also register high marks on personal religiosity measures, or if those who do register high marks on such measures do not affirm Christian nationalism (which is actually the case—see Davis 2018, 307; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 84–86). For all the strengths of their analysis, this is a point of weakness in Whitehead and Perry's (2020) work. They routinely juxtapose inherently religious interests from Christian nationalists' social and political interests (e.g., 59, 152, 153), distinguishing Christian nationalism as a "cultural framework" from "religion per se," which seems to reduce to personal religiosity (see 155). These normative understandings of religion and politics, public and private, social and individual, produce analyses according to which Christian nationalism is "really" political, rather than religious.

There is no compelling reason to accept these normative premises. Rather than revealing a movement that is "really" political and "not really" religious, studies of Christian nationalism reveal a conception of Christian identity that *is not reducible to the private and individual*. As Braunstein and Taylor (2017) note, narrow conceptions of religious identity conflate "a number of analytically *distinct dimensions* of religiosity and religiopolitical sentiment" (40, emphasis added). As their research suggests, support for Christian nationalism among those who do not register high levels of personal religiosity do not indicate a movement that is "really" political, rather than religious, but instead "sheds light on new connections between religion and conservative political action in a religiously diverse society" (37). Within this shifted perspective, Christian nationalism should be understood as an expression of religiosity that is inherently public and social, as opposed to private and individual, in nature, but as an expression of religiosity nevertheless.

An expanded conception of religiosity can accommodate the fact that the typical Christian nationalist would likely not accept the assertion that their support for socially and politically conservative positions and policies reflects something *other than* "religiosity," regardless of measures of their personal beliefs or practices. On the contrary, they are likely to suggest that such support is a fundamental *expression* of their religiosity (see Wolterstorff 1996, 105; Miller 2019, 5). Going further, they would likely reject the notion that they could maintain an authentic Christian identity (as they experience it) and *not* support such policies and positions. If an affirmation of Christian nationalism *is itself* experienced as a *public* form of religiosity, if the desire for the morphologically normative Christian-American social body is itself a *religious* desire, then many Christian nationalists' potentially low levels of individual religiosity do not tell us that Christian nationalism is not really Christian, but instead highlights a particularly public and social expression of Christian identity.

This conception of public religiosity or religious identity helps to explain otherwise confounding information. For example, Edgell et al. (2019) identify increasing diversity and multiculturalism and the embrace (or rejection) of a “Judeo-Christian cultural core” as the central “cultural fault lines” energizing contemporary Christian nationalism (4) and Delehanty et al. (2019) suggest that the discourse powering Christian nationalism “undergirds a desire to protect a public sphere dominated by Christian values and traditions” (1300), while Whitehead and Perry (2020) note that Christian nationalists aim at “the political reinforcement of godly order” (149). If one assumes that religious identity can be reduced to individual beliefs and acts of personal piety, then it is difficult to explain why these views are shared by those for whom such religiosity measures are low. But if religious identity can take the form of a disposition to social order, as expressed in the social-as-body metaphor, there need be no contradiction on this point. A Christian nation, as Christian nationalists imagine it, is not defined solely by individuals with high levels of personal piety or religious belief but is also a nation in which prototypical real Americans maintain their proper social and political authority over others. Christian nationalists may seek the “*political* reinforcement of godly order” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 149, emphasis added), then, but they also seek political reinforcement of *godly* order, as they experience it. Within the Christian nationalist imaginary, a social body that is not hierarchically ordered, with real Americans occupying the positions at the top of the hierarchy, *cannot be* a Christian social body.

Christian nationalism therefore represents a form of Christian identification structured around the rejection of commonly held boundaries between religion and politics, public and private, social and individual. Put simply, within the Christian nationalist imaginary what it means to be Christian involves more than traditional measures of religiosity or personal piety. So, for example, when Whitehead and Perry (2020) find that high personal religiosity measures “often induce American political views *in the exact opposite direction*” from Christian nationalism (84), this is *not* an indication that Christian nationalists are “not really” religious after all. Rather, it indicates that Christian nationalism represents an alternative articulation of religiosity from what social scientists like Whitehead and Perry include under that term. The issue at play is not religious commitment or its absence, but alternative (and competing) conceptions of religious commitment. Rethinking religious identity along these lines allows us to recognize Christian nationalism’s substantively *Christian* nature even among Christian nationalists with low or non-existent levels of personal religiosity.

The Christian-National Social Body’s Normative Morphology

As we have seen, Christian nationalist identity is structured around a conception of prototypical real Americans as White, cisgender, heteronormative, Protestant, English-speaking, US-born, of northern European descent, affirmative of

patriarchy (if not male), and politically conservative. As we also saw, this “cultural packaging” (Edgell et al. 2019, 2) of authentic American identity is accompanied by a sense of those who are *not* real Americans. As Edgell et al. (2019) put it, Christian nationalists “draw symbolic boundaries excluding particular groups they perceive to violate a vision of American national identity” (3). Crucially, these boundaries are not merely symbolic, but achieve a social reality in the form of support for exclusionary real-world policies and practices based on distinctions between those who are recognized as real Americans and those who are not, illustrating the fact that “symbolic distinctions can codify into social boundaries, resulting in unequal access to material resources or political rights” (1; see also Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 18). Thus, as Whitehead and Perry (2020) sum up the issue, “Americans who embrace Christian nationalism are much more likely to create, support, and maintain symbolic *and* social boundaries that exclude non-Christians from full inclusion into American civic life” (161, emphasis added).

Symbolic distinctions’ translation into real-world exclusion and marginalization is directly connected to Christian nationalism’s dysphoric nature. Christian nationalism aims to reimpose or reinforce the Christian-national social body’s normative morphology, and we have seen that one of this body’s key morphological elements is its proper hierarchical ordering. Within the Christian nationalist context, this means that a properly ordered social body is one in which real Americans occupy superordinate positions of social and political authority, while all others occupy properly subordinate positions. Reflecting the fact that Christian nationalism involves real-world policies and practices, Christian nationalist efforts to restructure the social body invariably play out in concrete attitudes and policies aimed at subordinating, or legitimizing the ongoing subordination of, those who are counted among the real Americans. As a complex phenomenon seeking to renew and preserve an entire normative social order, the axes of subordination around which the morphologically normative Christian-national social body takes shape are multiple. While we could examine Christian nationalists’ efforts to impose super- and subordination structures in multiple social domains, then, we are focusing our discussion primarily on the issues of race and patriarchy.

The Christian Nationalist Racial Hierarchy

The normative Christian-national social body is a White body. That is, it is a body in which those who are identified as White hold positions of social and political authority, while the proper place of those who are not identified as White is one of subordination within the social body. As Whitehead and Perry (2020) starkly state the issue, with Whiteness “we are dealing with something very near the core of Christian nationalism itself” (91–92), so much so that Christian identity must be understood in “almost ethnic” terms (11). Many White Americans perceive the US’s impending “majority-minority” demographics as a threat to political and social authority (Craig, Rucker, and Richeson 2018, 206)

because they fear they will no longer fit the real-American prototype (207; see also Stanley 2018, 88), anxieties reflected in the finding that “White Americans exposed to the racial shift information ... express greater preference for racial homophily in their social settings and interpersonal interactions, and have more negative evaluations of racial minority groups in both self-report and reaction-time measures” (Craig et al. 2018, 206). Thus, Whitehead and Perry (2020) note that “some scholars believe endorsing Christian nationalism—again, particularly for White Americans—is *essentially* about White (Christian) supremacy and ethno-religious exclusion” (92).¹³ In the same vein, Delehanty et al. (2019) suggest that within secularized evangelical discourse, Christian identity “is as much a racial identity as a religious one” (1299).

Religious identity marks one of the most obvious social domains in which Christian nationalism manifests the desire for the subordination those who are not recognized as real Americans, and it also illustrates the “ethno-religious” dimension of exclusion highlighted by Whitehead and Perry. Christian nationalists seek, particularly in their renewed appeals to “religious liberty,” the ongoing privileging of Christian beliefs, values, and institutions, while perceiving other religions, or the increasing lack of a religious orientation, as inherently threatening to the social body’s normative morphology (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 109). Following from this, they draw strong group boundaries excluding those perceived as threats to the nation’s Christian identity (Edgell et al. 2019, 17–18). Indeed, Whitehead and Perry (2020) find that Christian nationalist identity is the strongest predictor of Americans’ attitudes toward non-Christian religious groups (112).

Given Whiteness and Protestant Christianity’s historical linkage within the idealized real-American prototype, these religious exclusions are also racial exclusions, evident in the fact that in earlier historical periods Jewish people, for example, were not considered White (e.g. Rattansi 2007, 7, 42; Painter 2010, 77–78, 225; Masuoka and Junn 2013, 17) and Irish and Italian immigrants, a majority of whom were Catholic, were considered un-American due to the fact that they were neither Protestant nor White (see Rattansi 2007, 7, 39, 42), while in the present US context, the racialized conception of Muslims as “Mid-Eastern” effectively defines all Muslims as non-White (Love 2017, 7–10). The equivalence of Christian and White identity within Christian nationalism allows for appeals to the “Christian nation” to operate effectively as racially coded language, applying equally to racial identity in isolation from purported religious identity. Thus, “White Americans’ claims to be preserving Christian order, America’s Christian heritage, or even ‘religious freedom’ have long served as cover for what has amounted to the exclusion of non-White and especially Black Americans” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 100). Such coded language allows for the expression of racial identity preferences and exclusions without specific appeal to racial categories (16).

Braunstein and Taylor’s (2017) study of religious identification and the Tea Party Movement powerfully illustrates White identity’s significance within Christian nationalism. As we have seen, even the significant minority of TPM

members who do not identify as Christian are overwhelmingly likely to identify with Christian nationalism. This raises a significant question: “What of the non-religious and non-Christian Tea Partiers who expressed this view [that America is a Christian nation], despite the fact that in a Christian America they would technically be part of the national out-group” (Braunstein and Taylor 2017, 55)? The answer, in such cases, is that their White identity, the fact that they are perceived to embody one of the real-American prototype’s central features, “inoculates them” from exclusion due to their lack of religious identification (55). The reverse of this point also applies: a high level of religiosity among minorities is not sufficient to qualify them as real Americans, even if they are Christian (Schildkraut 2014, 449). Given that religious affiliation and White identity are both linked to racial homogeneity/homophily (Craig, Rucker, and Richeson 2018, 206; Davis 2018, 302), such findings should come as no surprise in the case of Christian nationalism. Simply stated, when it comes to the real-American prototype, one can receive a pass for not being a practicing Christian if they are White.

There is significant historical consonance in Christian nationalists’ according Whiteness a privileged within the real-American prototype. As Natalie Masuoka and Jane Junn (2013) note, “the American state has since its inception classified and ranked people by race for political purposes” (17). This has produced a racial hierarchy that has remained in place and remarkably consistent over time. They picture this hierarchy as a diamond with “Whites ... at the top, Blacks at the bottom, and Latinos and Asian Americans ... between African Americans and Whites” (19). Groups’ placements on this hierarchy are “indicative of desirability for entrance and full membership in the American polity” (19). Occupying the hierarchical position atop the diamond, “Whites have the benefit of default-category status as the racial insider and as superior,” automatically counted among the real Americans.¹⁴ African Americans, on the other hand, “have a long history of being systematically shut out” of membership as ‘real’ Americans” (20), while Asian and Latinx Americans’ experiences have fluctuated between these two extremes (21). The result is that “African Americans, Latinos, and Asian Americans experience conditional [i.e., merely nominal] membership in the nation as a function of their racial categorization” (27).

As Stanley (2018) suggests, nationalists appeal to “natural” hierarchies, such as the racial hierarchy enforced over the course of US history, to legitimize ongoing concrete hierarchies’ imposition within social order (79). The naturalization of hierarchical racial conceptions is visceral, affective, and dispositional in nature, structuring perceptions, feelings, and practices aimed at all those not identified as White. Thus, Edgell et al. (2019) note, “for Whites, distinctly Christian religious conceptions associate with anti-Black affect” (18), Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016) find that restrictive views of national belonging are associated with (among other attitudes) “stronger anti-immigrant attitudes” and “hostility toward immigrants,” as well as “negative sentiments” and prejudice against ethnic minorities, (438, 439), and Craig et al. (2018) find that Whites express more negative

evaluations of racial minority groups after being made aware of the racial and ethnic demographic shifts taking place in the US (206). Negative affect toward non-Whites, in turn, structures Christian nationalists' very perceptions of social reality, as when they radically misperceive structures of racial inequality in the US (Stanley 2018, 93–94; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 99–106).

The hierarchical Christian-American body imagined by Christian nationalists therefore both reflects and reinforces negative dispositions directed at all those not identified as White, so that any unmaking of the hierarchical social order through demands for greater liberty and equality can only be experienced as an unjustified, and so unjust, threat to proper social order, a “Trojan Horse” aimed at the social body's transmogrification (Stanley 2018, 88). This sense of injustice motivates socially dysphoric responses aimed at moving from symbolic boundary construction to the hierarchical social body's concrete, real-world constitution. Negative prototypes of those who are *not* real Americans represent a primary mechanism underlying this movement. That is, Christian nationalism not only takes shape around a real-American idealization as White, but around counter-idealizations of those who are not identified as White.

Racial stereotypes, the dynamics of which were outlined in the previous chapter, play a central role in the articulation of negative prototypes and efforts to enact the morphologically normative Christian-national social body. Christian nationalism is therefore structured not only through the identification of Whites as real Americans and non-Whites as only nominally American, but through the presumption of what it *means to be* White and non-White, respectively. The racial stereotypes that operate within Christian nationalism are grounded in the racial hierarchy that already conditions the sense of American national identity, reflected in the finding that Americans share a broad agreement about, and awareness of, the stereotypes attached to different racial categories (even if they do not accept their accuracy) (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 65). Clearly illustrating the correlation between stereotype content and groups' locations on racial hierarchies, “Americans have come to associate those classified as White as the most privileged and desirable members of society” (65) because they occupy the top position in the American racial hierarchy. Thus, Whites are least likely to be associated with negative stereotypes, African Americans are the most likely, and Latinx and Asian Americans occupy a middle position (65).

Reflecting this general ordering, Christian nationalists associate African Americans with a wide range of social problems (Edgell et al. 2019, 15) and associate them with having character deficiencies (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 105). Stereotypes attached to African American identity “emphasize ‘deviant’ behaviors such as laziness, preference for being on welfare, and tendency toward crime and violence” (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 66), associations White Americans generally are prone to accept (74–79). These stereotypes draw sharp contrasts between African Americans and prototypical real Americans, positioning African Americans as outsiders (Edgell et al. 2019, 18; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 99–100). Racial

stereotypes' universalizing dimension, outlined in the previous chapter, highlights their fantastical character: in their universal application to an entire category of individuals, they express the desired "truth" about all that category's members, rather than any empirically or historically demonstrable facts about them. They direct social and political desire toward the drawing of normative distinctions between groups that legitimize and naturalize their hierarchical ordering. This legitimizing and naturalizing role of stereotypes is such that, once affect and perception are structured in these ways, it becomes "only natural" that Blacks should be socially subordinate to Whites within the Christian-national body.

These stereotypes and the normative, hierarchical image of the social body they legitimize find very concrete expression. For example, the Christian-national social body's normative morphology requires, literally, the policing of bodies of color. Appeals to "law and order," demands for unquestioning obedience to police commands, efforts to counter "troublemakers," all reveal an attempt to bring racial minorities, particularly African Americans, back into line, into their proper, subordinate place within the American national body. As Whitehead and Perry (2020) note, in the context of Franklin Graham's response to publicized police shootings of men of color, "in Graham's view, backed with a biblical injunction to 'submit to your leaders,' police have unquestionable, divinely granted authority of their [people of color's] bodies" (103–104).¹⁵

Christian nationalists' concrete efforts to impose the Christian-national body's normative hierarchical morphology are not limited to any single racial out-group. Thus, Christian nationalists are less likely than other Americans to emphasize equal treatment of all under the law or to affirm racial diversity as an important aspect of American life, they are more likely to support curtailing the rights of people with which they disagree to present their views publicly, and they are more likely to support defunding the social safety net (Edgell et al. 2019, 15). They are also more likely to support punitive actions toward criminals (Davis 2018, 310) which, given the disparities in the American criminal justice system, is effectively to support punitive actions aimed primarily at communities and individuals of color.

Christian nationalists also deploy negative stereotypes of immigrants, resulting in concrete xenophobic expressions (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 92–93). Indeed, Christian nationalists are significantly more likely to hold anti-immigrant attitudes than are other Americans (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 20; Braunstein and Taylor 2017, 48, 53) and to promote restrictive immigration policies as a result (Schildkraut 2014, 449; Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 25; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 93). Given Christian nationalists' focus on immigration at the southern US border, immigrants are subject to many of the negative stereotypes that attach to Latinx populations, and include the perception of poor abilities in speaking English and holding different cultural values from "real" Americans (Masuoka and Junn 2013, 66).¹⁶ White Americans are also more likely than Latinx Americans, Asian Americans, or African Americans to believe that members of the Latinx community "often end up on welfare," "significantly increase

crime,” “threaten national security,” “keep to themselves and don’t try to fit in,” and “are mostly illegal immigrants” (81). Thus, immigrants are thought to take away jobs that rightfully belong to real Americans, increase crime rates, and consume a disproportionate share of government spending (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 20). Xenophobic stereotypes also attach particularly to immigrants who are perceived to be Muslim, who become subject to the “Middle Eastern terrorist” stereotype (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 71, 84).

Given Christian nationalists’ dispositional linkage of Whiteness and Christianity, it is also no surprise that Christian nationalist appeals to religious freedom are meant to apply to prototypical White Christians narrowly (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 114), whereas “the religious beliefs of non-Christian Americans are presumed to hinder their ability to fulfill their duties as American citizens” (161). Such appeals, then, are ultimately concerned with “subordinating groups who are not native-born, White Christians” (119). Muslims, in particular, are perceived as a threat to the social body’s order and integrity, and so must be subordinated through the limitation of their political freedoms and civil liberties (72).

Christian Nationalism and Patriarchy

The Christian-national body’s normative morphology also requires a proper social order in relation to gender and sexuality. Indeed, “Christian nationalism is *the* strongest predictor of more traditionalist attitudes toward gender roles” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 130). “Traditionalist gender roles” here refers not only to relations between women and men (tacitly presumed to be cisgender), but attitudes toward lesbian, gay, bisexual, and TGNC people.¹⁷ With the increasing social visibility of LGBTQ+ people, “traditional gender roles” has become code not only for traditional relations between cis-identified men and women, but for supporting a thoroughly patriarchal social order more broadly construed. As Allan J. Lichtman (2008) suggests, the Christian-American national body is one that is properly “morally ordered,” requiring “a morally ordered family, with clear lines of divinely ordained masculine authority and the containment within it of women’s erotic allure” (3). Thus (again highlighting the connection between Christian nationalism and politically conservative identity) “control over women’s allegedly dangerous sexuality and autonomy is at the center of conservative politics” (3). The significance of the Christian-American social body’s hetero- and cis-normativity is given in the fact that these dimensions of gender and sexual identity often do not even warrant explicit reference in the Christian nationalist vision of the social body.

Kate Manne (2018) provides an analysis of the three related issues of patriarchy, sexism, and misogyny that are particularly illuminating for understanding this dimension of Christian nationalism and the multiple social domains it structures. She begins her examination of misogyny by dismissing what she terms the “naïve conception,” according to which misogyny is “primarily a property of individual

agents ... who are prone to feel hatred, hostility, or other similar emotions toward any and every woman, or at least women generally, *simply because they are women*" (32). In contrast to such a perspective, which reduces misogyny to an individual psychological quirk (67) or an issue of a few social "bad apples" (74), she suggests that misogyny reflects a patriarchal social order, inherently hierarchical and imposed on the basis of gender, marked by the proliferation and broad support of institutions that position "all or most women ... as subordinate in relation to some man or men therein," while men are superordinate over women (45). This hierarchical structure is compatible with examples of women in positions of authority over men, social norms that change in the direction of gender equality, and so on, insofar as the gender subordination in view involves "social pressures that *tend* to relegate women to this position but may not 'succeed' in doing so" (46).

Insofar as it transcends individual psychology, misogyny is "an inherently *political* phenomenon" and, as such, is "dependent on there being norms and expectations [i.e., dispositions] of a patriarchal nature" (Manne 2018, 67). Within a patriarchal milieu, misogyny acts as "the 'law enforcement' branch" policing and enforcing patriarchy as the "governing ideology" (63). In this role, misogynistic social forces "target girls and women ... for actual, perceived, or representative challenges to or violations of applicable patriarchal norms and expectations" (63). Misogynistic law enforcement mechanisms are various, and include

(a) distinctively gendered *contents*, which reflect and help to regulate or restore patriarchal order; or (b) particularly harsh *enforcement mechanisms* for girls and women (in the relevant class) as compared with boys and men (in this class, i.e., male counterparts); or (c) particularly intense and/or invasive forms of policing (for example, surveillance, scrutiny, and suspicion) for girls and women ... as compared with male counterparts.

(63–64)

Within the context of patriarchy, Manne (2018) also highlights sexism's complementary, but not equivalent, role vis-à-vis misogyny (78). Whereas misogyny represents patriarchy's "law enforcement" dimension, sexism is its "justificatory branch," consisting of "ideology that has the overall function of *rationalizing* and *justifying* patriarchal social relations" by naturalizing sex differences (79). Sexist ideology, then, consists

in assumptions, beliefs, theories, stereotypes, and broader cultural narratives that represent men and women as importantly different in ways that, if true and known to be true, or at least likely, would make rational people inclined to support and participate in patriarchal social arrangements.

(79)

Summing up sexism and misogyny's distinct but complementary roles within patriarchy, then, sexist ideology "will tend to discriminate *between* men and women," while misogyny "will typically differentiate between good women and *bad* ones, and punished the latter" (79, 80).

Patriarchal society, bolstered by sexism and misogyny, does not only affect cis-identified men and women, but TGNC individuals as well. And while sex, gender, and sexuality are not equivalent concepts, misogynist policing targets all three, as Heath Fogg Davis's (2017) conception of "sex-identity discrimination" (10–11) makes clear. As a "subcategory of sexism," sex-identity discrimination refers to "judgements about who does and does not belong in the sex categories of male or female" (11; see also 32). This concept's relevance lies in the fact that, as he goes on to note, gender stereotyping is a constitutive feature of sex-identity discrimination (11). Thus,

the durable elasticity of binary sex categories tells us that sex-identity discrimination entails something else in addition to the sex-role stereotyping that generates sex-based disadvantage. Sex-identity discrimination involves the judgment that a person has stretched the elastic bands of binary sex "too far," to the point of breaking free of one sex category and trying to join its opposite.

(47–48)

This clearly highlights the negative judgments applied to TGNC individuals, but it also encompasses sexuality, insofar as homophobia reflects, in significant part, the judgment that even cis-identified LGB+ people are failing to properly embody their "natural" (and therefore normative) gender (i.e., "real" men are properly attracted to women, while "real" women are properly attracted to men, etc.). While sexism, transphobia, and homophobia do not overlap completely, then, they all presuppose a patriarchal social order. Equally, while Manne's (2018) specific focus is the relation of men and women, it is clear that sexuality and gender identity are among the "intersecting systems of domination" involved in patriarchy (63). Sexism implies cis-normativity, so that the "bad women" targeted by misogyny would include transwomen, lesbian, bi-, poly-, pan-, and so on, cis-identified women, and, arguably, gay men as well.

The recognition of misogyny as "a property of social environments" (Manne 2018, 66), rather than individual psychology, means that it is the "climate" in which social agents are formed (74). Misogyny is therefore a "structuring structure" of the kind outlined in the first chapter (see Bourdieu 1990, 53; 1977, 72), shaping dispositions so that individual misogynists are "people who have been heavily *influenced* in their beliefs, desires, actions, values, allegiances, expectations, rhetoric, and so on, by a misogynist social atmosphere" (Manne 2018, 74). Like other dispositions, then, misogyny is better understood as a visceral, affective orientation structuring and expressing social and political perceptions, feelings,

and practices than as a set of consciously held or explicable discursive beliefs (71). In its structuring role, misogyny is “often quite invisible to the people whose privileged social positions ... [it] serve[s] to uphold and buttress” (156–157), so that “what gets taught to—or, better, *learned* or internalized by—individual agents are ... the various patriarchal norms and expectations that govern women’s [and others’] social roles in service of dominant men’s interests, together with a potent sense of personal entitlement” (76). When misogyny and sexism are both operating effectively, when all is “going to plan,” as Manne aptly puts it, “patriarchal social relations are supposed to be amicable and seamless” (76).

Within a patriarchal order, women are not targeted because they are universally hated by individual misogynists, but “because they are women in a [cis-, hetero-] *man’s world*” (Manne 2018, 64). Misogyny represents a dysphoric response to women, members of the LGB+ community, and TGNC individuals who are “out of place” within the social body, transmogrifying it and revealing its queer character. It is a reaction provoked by these diverse “others” who go “off-script” (169–170), who seem to have “ideas beyond their station” (69), aimed at restoring the social body’s normative morphology by putting them “in their place” (69, 77, 149) via any means “suitable to serve a punitive, deterrent, or warning function” (68). This highlights misogyny’s fantastical nature, insofar as it ultimately expresses (again recalling Žižek’s theorization of political fantasy’s operation) “desires and other similar states of mind that ask the world be kept or brought back in line with a patriarchal order,” rather than individual beliefs (69). Misogyny expresses a fundamental disposition to the social body’s proper ordering.

One of the most pervasive Christian nationalist mechanisms for (re)enforcing the Christian-national body’s normative patriarchy is the deployment of normative discourses on the family, which are supported by the twin mechanisms of sexism and misogyny. As Whitehead and Perry (2020) put it, “Christian nationalism is intimately intertwined with Americans’ definitions of the family and the proper roles for men and women within the family” (127). The family’s defining contours, as imagined within Christian nationalism, are so taken for granted they often go without explicit mention. The family is fundamentally defined by the limitation of sexual activity within the bounds of heterosexual, monogamous marriage between one cisgender man and one cisgender woman. Within this framework, the nuclear family holds pride of place and is idealized as patriarchally structured (Hoover and Coats 2015, 35–40), providing the model for the rest of society.¹⁸ Changing social views on gender and gender roles, gender identity, and sexuality challenge the “traditional” American family’s normativity, threatening to unmake the Christian-national social body. Christian nationalists’ appeal to “traditional family values” represents a socially dysphoric response to this unmaking, intended to reassert the Christian-national body’s normative patriarchy.

Two manifestos, the 2009 “Manhattan Declaration” (George et al. 2009) and the 2017 “Nashville Statement” (Council for Biblical Manhood and

Womanhood (CBMW) 2019), vividly illustrate these points, giving explicit expression to the Christian nationalist desire for the patriarchal social body. The sexist nature of both is explicit in their shared legitimization of the patriarchal order through the naturalization of sex differences, established by appeal to divine creation, biological function, and societal well-being. Both affirm cisgender identity as natural and divinely ordained, though the Nashville Statement, reflecting its production almost a decade later than the Manhattan Declaration, is more explicit in this regard. Within this sexist framework, both insist on the heterosexual, monogamous marriage's normativity, rejecting all other alternatives (same-sex marriage, polyamorous relationships, etc.) as unnatural and inevitably leading to pathological biological and social consequences. TGNC identity, which also figures more prominently in the later Statement, is also rejected as unnatural and sinful, as is intersex identity.

While the Declaration and Statement both serve patriarchy's cause by legitimizing sex differences as natural (and therefore normative), they also play the misogynist role of enforcing patriarchy through the threat of sanction. In its misogynistic dimension, responsibility for social disorder and dissolution lies with all those who embody or affirm expressions of gender and sexuality not sanctioned within the normative patriarchal order. Both statements also enforce patriarchy with the promise of divine sanction: whether intentional or not, and no matter how seemingly benign or well-intentioned, those expressing or condoning the normatively patriarchal social order's transfiguration are "sinning," run afoul of divine intent, and will suffer the consequences for this. Significantly, these consequences not only include theological conceptions of divine punishment, but expulsion from the Christian community. The Nashville Statement (CBMW 2019) says that expression or approval of TGNC identity or same-sex desire "constitutes an essential departure from Christian faithfulness and witness" and denies "that the approval of homosexuality or transgenderism [*sic*] is a matter of moral indifference about which otherwise faithful Christians should agree to disagree" (Art. 10). The Statement thereby threatens any who would simultaneously claim a Christian identity while also expressing or condoning support for non-patriarchal expressions of gender or sexuality with non-recognition as legitimate members of the Christian community. Those who express or condone the disruption of patriarchy are, then, neither real Christians nor real Americans.

The Manhattan Declaration and the Nashville Statement both represent socially dysphoric responses to the queer social body, expressing the social-as-body metaphor's fundamental logic as directed by the natural attitude of embodiment (Bettcher 2009, 103), according to which a social body whose members cease to play their natural, and therefore proper, sexual and gendered roles is pathologically disfigured. To be sure, both statements are articulated in a way intended to mask their dysphoric, reactionary nature, instead projecting confidence in their moral and cultural authority. Such bold assertions, however, belie their fantastical nature and the cultural insecurity at their heart. The fantastical basis of the sexist legitimization

offered in these Christian nationalist expressions is evident in the “nature” in which they ground their arguments. The biological and social bases for their arguments are decades out of date, particularly in the case of the more recent Nashville Statement. They completely ignore empirical and theoretical evidence against the existence of “biological sex,” its coincidence with gender, and the resulting concept of normative “biological gender” (e.g., Butler 1989, 2004; Fausto-Sterling 2000; Glover and Kaplan 2008, 1–25; Salamon 2010; Serano 2016; Rippon 2019). They also advance positions that contradict care guidelines, treatment protocols, and best practices outlined by major health and mental health organizations relevant to issues of gender and sexuality (see AAP “LGBT Resources”; AMA “Advocating”; AMA “Policies”; American Psychological Association “Practice Guidelines”; American Psychological Association 2015a, 2015b; Cabaj, “Working with LGBTQ Patients” n.d.; Miller 2017; Murchison 2016; Rafferty 2018; World Professional Association for Transgender Health (WPATH) 2012). Echoing Stryker (2006) once again, we can say that the nature with which they “bedevil” us is a lie (247): they are not statements based in natural facts, but “world-directing” (Manne 2018, 69n15) expressions of the fantastical desire for a natural order that never existed.

Despite the bravado of their presentation, the fact that Christian nationalists *need* to produce these manifestos also highlights that all is not “going to plan” with patriarchy, but that the patriarchal system is under strain. If the gains of women and the LGB and TGNC communities were not successfully unmaking the normative patriarchal order and revealing the American social body’s inherent queerness, such manifestos would be unnecessary. There is perhaps no clearer evidence of this than changing American views on LGB rights and marriage equality. The increasing cultural acceptance of marriage equality stands as a particularly notable and socially visible illustration of this: in the decade from 2004 to 2014, public support for marriage equality increased by 22 percentage points, an increase which was 43 percentage points higher than in the late 1980s (Jones 2016a, 124). Within the frame of these cultural shifts, the 2015 Supreme Court *Obergefell v. Hodges* decision, which found all bans on same-sex marriage to be unconstitutional, represents Christian nationalists’ decisive defeat on this front of the LGBTQ+ culture wars.

Christian nationalists’ cultural and political losses related to marriage equality help to explain why they have recently shifted to a more focused and sustained attack on TGNC rights, opposition to which Christian nationalist identity is the strongest predictor (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 137). Significant examples include the advancement of so-called “bathroom bills,” meaning “legislation that would restrict access to multiuser restrooms, locker rooms, and other sex-segregated facilities on the basis of a definition of sex or gender consistent with sex assigned at birth or ‘biological sex’” (Kralik 2019) and recent legislative efforts to prevent and criminalize the provision of medical treatment related to TGNC children’s and teens’ gender transitions (e.g., so-called “hormone blockers,” hormone replacement therapies (HRT), gender confirmation surgery, etc.), with both parents and medical providers in view (Riviera et al. 2019; Burns 2020; Hope 2020; Lam 2020; Murib 2020;).

These efforts represent yet another front in the battle to reinforce and maintain a normatively patriarchal social body, once again marked by the deployment of both sexist and misogynist mechanisms. Like the Manhattan Declaration and the Nashville Statement, they appeal, both explicitly and more tacitly, to biological sex as the determinant of gender and of these together as normative gender identity determinants. Opposition to these legislative and social efforts and affirmation of gender identities that diverge from “biological sex” are presented as, at best, a nonsensical denial of the natural (and therefore not only normative, but obvious) order. Within this sexist framework, vulnerable populations’ health and safety are also offered as the rationale for both kinds of measures, which are put forward with the stated aim of protecting women and children from predatory men dressed as women, in the case of so-called bathroom bills (see Currah 2016; Lhamon and Gupta 2016; Kralik 2019), and to protect minors from undergoing “medical changes they may regret as adults” (Lam 2020), in the case of opposition to medically supporting gender transition.

Such reasoning’s sexism is evident in its “common sense” presentation: given assigned gender’s obvious naturalness, how could one possibly support such clearly unnatural and dangerous practices as requiring public accommodations for TGNC individuals and medically supporting TGNC minors? But beyond the sexist role of legitimation, such rationales also play misogyny’s law enforcement role. In the case of support for public accommodations, the clear implication is that those who support such measures, whether or not they personally identify as TGNC, actively endanger women and children, and therefore represent a danger to society. Threats to criminalize TGNC minors’ gender transitions render literal misogyny’s law enforcement role.

The farcical sexist legitimations of these attempts to reinforce patriarchy highlights their fantastical and dysphoric nature. As with the Manhattan Declaration and the Nashville Statement, the biological basis of gender to which they appeal has long been discredited. With more specific reference to the supposed factual basis for bathroom bills, their supporters willfully disregard the fact that “there have not been any reported incidents whereby a transgender woman has sexually assaulted another woman in a women’s bathroom” (Davis 2017, 73), as well as findings that requirements to allow public accommodations to TGNC individuals have not led to an increase of violent assaults (Hasenbush et al. 2019). Those opposing medical support for TGNC minors’ gender transitions, in turn, do so in opposition to advice from major medical and mental health organizations (as noted above), and also overlook that medical transition for minors involves a measured, careful, and deliberative process (Murchison 2016, 8–17; Burns 2020).

The animus motivating both kinds of effort, by way of contrast, is readily evident in their active endangerment the TGNC community. While there is no evidence, for example, that cisgender children and women are endangered by requiring public accommodations access for TGNC individuals, the fact is that TGNC individuals are much more likely to be victims of sexual and violent

assault than cis-identified individuals (Office for Victims of Crime (OVC) 2014; Human Rights Campaign (HRC) 2020;), and requiring them to use the bathroom corresponding to their gender assigned at birth actively *increases* their risk for assault (Brady 2016; Wang et al. 2016; Rapaport 2019). Preventing TGNC youth from accessing medical treatments such as hormone blockers, on the other hand, leads to increased suicide and other mental health risks (in addition to the discussion of gender dysphoria in Chapter 1, see American Psychiatric Association (APA 2013, 454, 458–459; Dhejne et al. 2016; Murchison 2016, 15; Fitzsimons 2020; Miller, “Transgender Kids” n.d.).

The disconnect between the claims of those advancing such legislative and policy agendas and the actual facts reveals that we are once again confronting an expression of fantasy, of “world-directing” desire, as opposed to “world-directed” belief (Manne 2018, 69n15). The sexist appeals to biology and nature, backed up by misogynist threats to TGNC individuals and allies, are not appeals to facts, but expressions of the desire to erase queer people from public social space altogether (Currah 2016; Hope 2020), dysphoric responses to queer people who reveal the social body’s queerness. They are expressions of desire for a patriarchal social body grounded in a “nature” that never existed.

Injustice and Entitlement

The Christian nationalist desire for a morphologically normative, hierarchically ordered social body is evident in efforts to preserve and enforce patriarchal and racial hierarchies. We have seen that both hierarchical forms operate to naturalize differences between those who are recognized as real Americans and those who are not, thereby legitimizing an American social body with an inherently unequal and anti-democratic morphology. Our consideration of these hierarchical social and political dispositions also sheds further light on Christian nationalists’ visceral and affective opposition to all efforts to unmake these hierarchies. As we have seen, within the Christian nationalist imaginary, dispositionally shaped as it is by a proper, hierarchical social order’s naturalization, the social body’s transmogrification that follows from the expansion of liberty and equality among racial minorities, women, the LGBTQ+ community, and any others not recognized as real Americans can only represent something unnatural and grotesque. But, crucially, for Christian nationalists the social body’s transmogrification is also fundamentally unjust. As Whitehead and Perry (2020) sum up this issue, “Christian nationalism is fundamentally about *preserving* or *returning* to a mythic society in which traditional hierarchical relationships (e.g., between men and women, Whites and Blacks) are upheld, and *authority structures are biblical and just*” (105, emphasis added).

It is crucial to understand this point if we are to fully appreciate contemporary Christian nationalism’s force. Christian nationalists’ socially dysphoric reaction to the queer social body is also a reaction to a social body experienced as fundamentally unjust. This is why the *demos*’s expansion and the Christian-national

social body's concomitant unmaking triggers a power-devaluation crisis for Christian nationalists, producing a sense of aggrieved victimhood (Stanley 2018, 99, 105). Manne (2018) provides a discussion of entitlement which is instructive for thinking through this dimension of Christian nationalism. As she suggests, the contestation of patriarchal norms is experienced on the part of those who benefit from them "not only ... [as] a *comedown*, but also [as] an *injustice*" (157). As she argues, the desire embodied in misogynistic social structures is expressed by individual agents as a sense of entitlement, of "being *owed* by women" and other targets of misogyny (106). This conception of entitlement is instructive for thinking not just about patriarchy, but other hierarchical forms as well. Thus, the unmaking of Whites' normative social and political authority results in perceptions of discrimination against Whites (Schildkraut 2014, 453), of rightful obligations denied. Expressing this sense of entitlement, Christian nationalists viscerally experience the Christian-nation social body's trans-mogrification and the unmaking of its normative hierarchies as the loss of a country that is *theirs* by right (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 160).

The sense of victimization on the part of those at the top of the hierarchies structuring the Christian-American body is also expressed in their perceptions of discrimination *aimed at* them and others' obligation to express sympathy *for* them. In her discussion of misogyny, Manne (2018) coins the term "himpathy," the "mirror image of misogyny," to capture a patriarchal sense of aggrievement and entitlement that is so common it represents "a problem with no name" (197). Himpathy names the sense of sympathy, empathy, or support owed to cis-het men whose privilege within patriarchal social structures is contested.¹⁹ But this sense of aggrieved entitlement is also evident in other dimensions of Christian nationalism. So, for example, the Manhattan Declaration appeals to a sense of aggrieved victimization, positioning the gains of LGB and TGNC individuals as inherently violating Christian nationalists' religious liberty (George et al. 2009). Likewise, White Americans, the group most likely to benefit *from* racial discrimination against minorities, express a sense of aggrieved entitlement in their perceptions that they themselves are victims of discrimination.²⁰

Such claims and experiences perfectly illustrate the point, outlined in the previous chapter, that identification with populist and nationalist narratives is more important than their factual or historical veracity. So, for example, victimization claims on Christian nationalists' part are not typically empirically supported (see Payne 2019) but are expressed in "fable-like" stories and personal anecdotes defined by a lack of specificity or appeal to confirmable data (Bonilla-Silva 2018, 96–119). Hochschild (2016) argues that such positions, typically running counter to empirical evidence, reflect affective perceptions grounded in "deep stories," "feels-as-if" stories, that help to explain Whites' sense of social, economic, and political displacement (135, 281–287).²¹ Reflecting the dual logics of populism and nationalism, these stories reflect the structure of White entitlement in their articulation of the intuition that minorities' social gains simply *must* reflect unfair advantages granted by political and social elites at the expense of more deserving Whites (136–151).

American Christian Nationalism in Power: Brief Reflections on the Trump Administration

In May of 2017, the streaming service Hulu released the first trailer for its upcoming streaming TV series *The Handmaid's Tale* (Schwartz 2017; Scot 2017), provoking an almost instant backlash among supporters of a newly elected Donald Trump, who decried it as an obvious example of liberal ideology aimed at undermining his presidency. The problem with this accusation, of course, is that the series is based on the novel of the same title by Canadian author Margaret Atwood, originally published in 1985 (Atwood 1998), a point about which Atwood herself sought to add clarity, tweeting, “(Sigh) First published in 1985” (Scot 2017). As one commentator wrote, “Dear Trump supporters. This is based off a dystopian novel called *The Handmaid's Tale*. Any similarity between the Trump administration and the oppressive government in this fiction is entirely coincidental” (Scot 2017). Indeed, Hulu ordered the series before Trump even won the Republican nomination for president (Schwartz 2017). The obvious and telling point is that many Trump supporters recognized the Trump administration in a fictionalized account of an authoritarian patriarchal regime.

Just as Hulu's series was not about Trump, he and his administration are not the focus of our discussion of Christian nationalism. Christian nationalism pre-dates Trump's candidacy and subsequent election, having increasingly shaped American conservatism and Republican social and political appeals for decades. In this sense, Trump is an expression of an already potent American Christian nationalism. Following from this, Christian nationalism will not disappear now that Trump's presidency has ended. While Jones (2016a) is likely correct in his assessment that “Trump's unlikely victory is better understood as the death rattle of White Christian America ... than its resuscitation” (242), this should not be taken as a prediction of the immediate end of Christian nationalism as a potent social and political force in America. Delehanty et al. (2019) are almost certainly correct in their suggestion that the discourse informing Christian nationalism will continue to have an abiding cultural influence, even as Christian nationalists' overall numbers continue to decline (1289–1290). While Christian nationalists represent a decreasing percentage of the US population, then, they will likely maintain or increase their social and political intensity long after Trump (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 49).

Nevertheless, Trump and his administration serve as an almost textbook-perfect illustration of virtually every point made about populism and nationalism in the previous chapter, and about Christian nationalism in this chapter. Indeed, this is so much the case that the postulation of such a perfect embodiment of American Christian nationalism at the highest levels of the US government would be dismissed as a farcical caricature had it not become a political reality. All of this is to say that, while Trump and his administration are not the focus of this chapter, they nevertheless require comment.

Trump very effectively tapped into Christian nationalists' power-devaluation crisis and sense of aggrievement, as reflected in the finding that, even after controlling for race and religious affiliation, Christian nationalism strongly predicted voting for Trump, with his support coming overwhelmingly from Ambassadors and Accommodators (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 67).²² Christian nationalism provided a powerful narrative for Trump (156), who effectively and repeatedly "cast himself as the last chance for Republicans and conservative White Christians to step back from the cliff, to preserve their power and way of life" (241; Delehanty et al. 2019, 1287). As Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016) sum up Trump's populist strategy,

Trump's campaign has used a particular vision of the nation that emphasizes the superiority of the American people, the moral corruption of the elites, and dire threats posed by immigrants and ethnic, racial, and religious minorities, all while drawing a sharp distinction between the primordial nation and its political institutions.

(26)

Trump's candidacy, 2016 Electoral College win, and 2020 Electoral College loss all reflected and intensified a socially dysphoric, Christian nationalist response to the queer American social body. He channeled and amplified this social dysphoria with his promise to "make America great again," code for the reinstitution of a morphologically normative, properly ordered Christian-national social body. But while the social dysphoria energizing American Christian nationalism provided fertile soil for his populist nationalism, he did not produce it. He capitalized on an existing expression of Christian nationalism that was already entwined with Islamophobia, political conservatism, and gender traditionalism (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 154). His xenophobic and racist candidacy resonated with a Christian nationalist electorate that was already anxious about widespread demographic shifts in the US population (Craig, Rucker, and Richeson 2018, 205), expressing an anti-immigrant animus that already energized the pre-existing Tea Party Movement (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016, 27), motivating its members to support his candidacy (Craig, Rucker, and Richeson 2018, 208). The result was enough Christian nationalist support in just the right parts of the US to propel him into office in 2016 (Jones 2016a, 242–243).²³

The dysphoric nature of Trump's candidacy and the support for it is evident in its expression of the Christian-national social body's defining features. While these are public, for the most part, and too numerous to catalogue here, it is worth noting a few of them. Trump's patriarchal dispositions are evident, in both his open disdain for women in positions of power—for example his labeling Hillary Clinton as "a nasty woman" in their presidential debate (Berenson 2016), his public snubbing of Speaker of the House Nancy Pelosi at his 2020 State of the Union address (LeBlanc 2020),²⁴ and his dismissive reference to Michigan governor Gretchen Whitmer as "the woman in Michigan" (Smith 2020)—and his

more generally sexist and misogynistic views, memorably displayed in his boasting about sexual assault (Nelson 2016) and mocking “blood coming from her wherever,” in reference to Fox News host Megyn Kelly, in the run-up to the 2016 election (Yan 2015). His administration effectively granted “himpathy” the force of law with its reworking of Title IX regulations regarding campus sexual assault (see Ortiz and Kingkade 2020), an affect that is also on display in Trump’s consistent dismissals of women’s charges of sexual assault against powerful men as “unfair,” with the example of Supreme Court nominee, and now Justice, Brett Kavanaugh being the most well-known (see BBC News 2019a). The patriarchal disposition embodied in the Trump administration was also evident in its efforts to roll back TGNC individuals’ rights, banning them from military service (see Jackson and Kube 2019; Moreau 2020), arguing that LGBTQ+ individuals are not protected by federal anti-discrimination law (De La Garza 2019; Sopelsa and Moreau 2019; Whitehead and Perry 2020, 138) and, related to this, his Department of Education’s insistence that Title IX protections do not extend to TGNC individuals (see Lhamon and Gupta 2016; Somashekhar et al. 2017).²⁵

Trump’s proposals and actions in office also capitalized on the xenophobia that defines Christian Nationalism. Islamophobia was the third-leading predictor of support for Trump’s 2016 election (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 109), a fact which Trump turned to political advantage by calling for a ban of all Muslims entering the US (Pilkington 2015; Diamond 2018) and later implementing restrictions on entry into the US from a number of Muslim-majority countries (Trump 2017; BBC News 2018; see also Bier 2017). Such policy proposals and actions also reinforce the Christian nationalist privileging of Christianity over other religious traditions (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 106–107), evident in his executive order’s exceptions for Christians from Muslim-majority countries (BBC News 2017). He appealed to his supporter’s anti-immigration animus with his infamous insinuation that most undocumented Latinx immigrants were “rapists” and “drug dealers” (Lee 2015; see also Reilly 2016) and his lack of support for the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) program and so-called “dreamers” (see BBC News 2019b). As with his travel ban, Trump sought to turn rhetoric into policy with his administration’s implementation of his draconian family separation policy (Rhodan 2018; Southern Poverty Law Center (SPLC) 2019) and his extraordinary efforts to fund construction of a wall on the southern US border (Taylor and Naylor 2019; Booker 2020; Rogers 2020). Such examples, combined with his consistent refusal to unambiguously condemn White nationalism, most memorably on display in his insistence that “very fine people” were involved on “both sides” of the August, 2017 White nationalist rally in Charlottesville, VA (Jacobs 2017; Scherer and Altman 2017), his purported dismay that too many people from “shithole countries” (Vitali, Hunt, and Thorp 2018) and not enough from Scandinavian countries want to enter the US (Aizenman 2018), his use of tried-and-true racist dog whistles about urban crime and blight (see Peterson 2017;

Olorunnipa 2019), and his video message telling those attacking the US Capitol building in January 2021 “we love you, you’re very special” (Caldwell 2021), combined to produce a clear image of what people did and did not represent real Americans for the his administration (and for its enthusiastic supporters) and nostalgically hearken back to an earlier period in American history when immigration policy reflected this awareness.

The foregoing examples illustrate Trump’s concerted efforts to appeal to and reassert the fantastical, morphologically normative Christian-American social body. But Trump and his administration also employed populist governance’s concrete mechanisms, outlined in the previous chapter. Of particular note, the administration vividly illustrates populism’s typical personalization, verticalization, and majoritarianism.

To reiterate, populist governance proceeds on a *pars-pro-toto* logic (Urbinati 2018, 573), with the effect that the leader is presented and experienced (at least on their supporters’ part) as the authentic people’s embodiment, rather than their mere representation (Arditi 2007, 65). The leader’s “personalization” (Urbinati 2018, 153) reflects the populist sense of political immediacy, according to which the leader instantiates the authentic will of the people without institutional or structural mediation, so that the latter lose any normative value within the populist imaginary (Urbinati 2014, 159). Trump’s presumed immediacy to the populist people, to the *real* Americans who support him, was evident in his extensive claims to unprecedented degrees of executive power and rejection of oversight, highlighting the authoritarian tendency within populist governance (see Yen and Woodward 2020; Perez 2020; Olorunnipa and Marimow 2019). With these emphases, Trump gave ample evidence of his actions’ presumed *a priori* legitimacy, on the grounds that he is the incarnation of the people’s will (see Arditi 2007, 83).

The presumption of immediacy was also evident in Trump’s rejection of the typical means of communication with the American public, largely eschewing press conferences and formal communication channels (e.g., press secretaries, etc.) in favor of “direct” communication via social media and mass rallies. This shift intensifies the “audience democracy” that defines contemporary electoral democracy generally. As Arditi (2007) suggests, audience democracy’s mechanisms serve to mask the distance between leaders and the populace (63), so that the presumed immediacy with the leader is only “virtual” (51). Trump’s eschewal of accepted contemporary media and communications practices heightened the sense of immediacy only by occluding the fact that the one-way communication strategies he imposed enact a highly mediated and carefully controlled presentation of himself as leader. This presentation intensified his personalized politics’ authoritarian dimension, producing a “reactive mass of followers” (Urbinati 2014, 157) unwilling or unable to question anything he said or did, all appeals to their activism notwithstanding. Applying Urbinati’s observations to Trump’s case, then, governance becomes a matter of the leader’s acclamation, rather than selection (160). Her description of elections as “a plebiscite for celebrating the leader”

(Urbinati 2018, 577) are aptly applied to both Trump's continual celebration of his 2016 electoral victory and his extensive efforts to overturn the outcome of the 2020 presidential election, culminating in his incitement of his followers' attack on the US Capitol, while this acclamation's presumed normativity is also evident in his consistent (and typically populist) denunciation of "the media" as "fake news" and "unfair" whenever his statements or positions have been called into question.

Such examples also illustrate the typical populist verticalization of power, which operates in conjunction with and reinforces an "extreme majoritarianism" (Urbinati 2018, 272). As Urbinati (2014) suggests, populism transforms the principle of majority rule into the "rule of the majority" that renders political opposition meaningless (139). In populist terms, this means that only those recognized as real Americans had a share in governance or interests to be served by the administration, while the personalization of Trump's governance is such that personal loyalty and support for him have been the bases for recognition as a real American. This extreme majoritarianism projects the anti-pluralism inherent in the idea of the populist people onto the political plane, reinforcing the polarization populism fosters and on which it depends (131). In Trump's articulation and practice, these dynamics were expressed in the language of "winners" and "losers," with the clear implication that those who "lost" (i.e., who did not vote for Trump and who do not participate in his ongoing acclamation) the 2016 election had no part in determining the country's direction and are not real Americans at all. Trump articulated all of these dynamics in an even more personalizing fashion by conflating political support for him and his administration, both domestic and international, as a matter of whether or not people, indeed, entire countries, "like" him, are "friends" with him, are "nice to" him, and so on.

These considerations all serve to highlight the fundamentally anti-democratic nature of Trump's governance, very much in keeping with populism's anti-democratic nature, outlined in the previous chapter. While Trump is not the cause of populist Christian nationalism in the US, then, his administration represented a textbook embodiment of populist nationalism. Just as the Trump administration's policies vividly illustrated (on his followers' own accounting) a dystopian social vision first articulated more than 30 years before, so his administration's governance perfectly illustrated populism, consistent with analyses offered before he ever came to political prominence.

Conclusion

Christian nationalism represents a socially dysphoric response to a queer social body. A social body that is not hierarchically ordered, in which liberty and equality extend to those who do not fit the idealized real-American prototype, one in which those who identify with novel social identities demand their place within the *demos*, is one defined by a queer, fluid morphology. Christian nationalism is a visceral, negative reaction to this provocation, seeking to (re)impose the Christian-national social body's hierarchically normative morphology.

In its dysphoria, Christian nationalism is both fundamentally anti-democratic and fantastical. What we have called queer democracy takes shape around the embrace of the *demos*'s constitutive incompleteness, constantly seeking its expansion through the active extension of liberty and equality to increasingly broad social sectors. Queerly democratic action actively unmakes the social body's enforced morphological normativity. With specific regard to the American scene, queer democracy breaks with the patriarchal and racial hierarchies that normatively define the Christian-national social body and displaces the idealized real-American prototype. Queer democracy is, then, fundamentally incompatible with Christian nationalism. By the same token, Christian nationalism is also fundamentally incompatible with queer democracy, and can only take shape in active opposition to the expansive and constitutively incomplete *demos*. Christian nationalism is not only incompatible with representative democracy's procedures and institutions, as Urbinati so effectively outlines, but is anti-democratic in an even more basic and fundamental sense.

As substantively anti-democratic, Christian nationalism is also fantastical. We suggested in the previous chapter that populism and nationalism express a desire for a fantastical social body, a social body that is impossible because it has never existed, a description that certainly applies to contemporary Christian nationalism. Queer democracy does not create the queer social body but reveals its fundamental queerness. In its embrace of the *demos*'s constitutive incompleteness, queer democracy registers the recognition that *there is no* normative morphology to the social body. Rather, the social body is always fluid and shifting, expressing a fundamentally queer morphology. In its nostalgia for the Christian-national social body's lost normative morphology and its opposition to the queer social body, then, Christian nationalism expresses a desire that can never be fulfilled, insofar as it is a desire for an impossible object. This desire's fantastical nature is what, more than anything, defines Christian nationalism as fundamentally dysphoric in nature.

Notes

- 1 Moving forward, I will not always mark references to "real Americans" by placing it in quotation marks. All such occurrences of the phrase, however, refer to Christian nationalist conceptions of American identity.
- 2 These dynamics, and particularly the active nature of the historical disavowal involved, were on clear display in the Trump administration's response to the *New York Times*' "1619 Project," which aims to "reframe American history by considering what it would mean to regard 1619 as our nation's birth year," with the recognition that "doing so requires us to place the consequences of slavery and the contributions of black Americans at the very center of the story we tell ourselves about who we are as a country" (Silverstein 2019). In response, Trump championed the creation of a "1776 Commission" that would "restore patriotic education to our schools" and counter the "far-left" view that "America is a wicked and racist nation." In contrast, through the teaching of the 1776 Commission, American "youth will be taught to love America" (Crowley 2020).
- 3 We will consider an expression of civic nationalism in the next chapter.
- 4 The six statements are: 1.) "The federal government should declare the United States a Christian nation," 2.) "The federal government should advocate Christian values," 3.)

- “The federal government should enforce strict separation of church and state,” 4.) “The federal government should allow the display of religious symbols in public spaces,” 5.) “The success of the United States is part of God’s plan,” and 6.) “The federal government should allow prayer in public schools” (Whitehead and Perry 2020, 17–18). Respondents were asked to identify their level of agreement with these statements on a five-step, 0–4 scale (question three was reverse coded) and then assigned a position on a spectrum of relations to Christian nationalism as a result of their total score out of 24 possible points (169). Joshua Davis (2018) also utilizes the scale developed by Whitehead and Perry in his own analysis (305).
- 5 In their study of American nationalism, Delehanty et al. (2019) identify a scale of four orientations to what they term “secularized evangelical discourse” (SED) that is similar to Whitehead and Perry’s typology at several points. On their scale, 17 percent of Americans are “ardent opponents,” 25 percent are “moderate opponents,” 34 percent are “moderate supporters,” and 24 percent are “ardent supporters” (2020, 1292).
 - 6 Delehanty et al. (2019) reflect similar findings in their typology, with ardent and moderate opponents lining up on one side in opposition to moderate and ardent supporters of SED (1292).
 - 7 “Cultural preservationists,” rather than Christian nationalists *per se*, are Edgell et al.’s focus. Nevertheless, Christian identification’s significance for the cultural preservationist position is such that it overlaps significantly with Christian nationalism.
 - 8 As with Edgell et al.’s (2019) analysis, there is significant conceptual overlap between Bonikowski and DiMaggio’s “ardent nationalists” and Christian nationalists, even given their alternative nomenclature.
 - 9 While I agree with Whitehead and Perry’s general point, I disagree with their framing the issue as Christian nationalism’s “coopting” of “Christian language” to “cloak particular political or social ends in moral and religious symbolism” (153). This formulation implies that “religion” and “politics,” or religious identification and political identification, are essentially different things, when this is precisely what is put in question in Christian nationalism’s articulation (see Miller 2019). We will consider these and related concerns more fully later in the chapter.
 - 10 As I noted in the previous chapter, I am not presupposing that only those possessing US citizenship should share in full equality or legal civic identity in the US. Rather, I choose the example of citizenship to highlight that Christian nationalists would effectively deny the authentic American identity even of those with the most robust implicit claim to full American-national belonging without corresponding to the real-American prototype.
 - 11 As we would expect, none of the Religious Right-affiliated TPM members identified as secular.
 - 12 The common denominator for the overwhelming majority of TPM members is, of course, conservative political identity, reinforcing the point that political conservatism is the strongest predictor of Christian nationalist identification.
 - 13 They go on to note that their view is that Christian nationalism is broader than such a perspective allows.
 - 14 Nothing in this discussion should occlude the fact that the requirements for identification as “White” have themselves been historically variable. See Painter 2010.
 - 15 As Whitehead and Perry (2020) go on to note, “we would be remiss if we failed to point out how Black men like Philando Castile and Charles Kinsey complied with Graham’s suggestions about obeying authorities and were *still* shot by police” (104). At the time this is being written, this observation is even more pertinent, as the US is currently experiencing widespread protests in the immediate aftermath of George Floyd’s execution at the hands of the Minneapolis police. Floyd, while unarmed, handcuffed, and lying prone on the ground, was asphyxiated as a result of a chokehold administered at the hands of a White police officer.
 - 16 It is obviously not the case that all Latinx individuals are immigrants, nor that all immigrants are Latinx. But, as debates about immigration policy make clear, the

- presumed issue is immigration from Mexico and Latin America, so much so that, for most Americans, to speak of “immigrants” is effectively to speak of Latinx individuals—hence the focus here on negative racial stereotypes that attach to them.
- 17 Whitehead and Perry (2020) note that *all* Americans, including Christian nationalists became less traditional regarding gender roles from 2007–2017. They go on to postulate that “as more egalitarian gender roles in the family have become more widely accepted, Christian nationalism has seized upon other threats to the stability of traditional, patriarchal order, like homosexuality and transgender people” (130), a supposition I share.
 - 18 Hoover and Coates (2015) highlight a tension that exists within evangelical conceptions of patriarchy. While evangelical men tend to affirm an ideal of “hard patriarchy” in principle (35), the concrete egalitarian gains of women, as well as economic necessity, have forced an acceptance of “soft patriarchy” in actual practice (39).
 - 19 Manne’s (2018) specific focus in developing the concept is the lenient sentence and sympathetic attitudes expressed toward convicted rapist Brock Turner in 2016 (196–197). But the concept is not limited to such egregious examples.
 - 20 While a majority of White Americans (55 percent) believe they experience racial discrimination (NPR et al. 2017, 5), this is a position held by almost three quarters (74 percent) of White Republicans and only 28 percent of White Democrats (a significant political distribution, given that politically conservative identification is the strongest predictor of Christian nationalist identification) (7; see also Jones 2019, Sheffield 2019).
 - 21 Hochschild’s specific focus are Tea Party-affiliated Whites in Louisiana. Given Tea Party members’ overwhelming identification with Christian nationalism, his findings are informative for understanding Christian nationalism more broadly.
 - 22 By the same token, those who identified as Resisters or Rejecters, whether they identified as Christians or not, tended not to vote for Trump, reinforcing the finding that religious identification narrowly construed is not the primary issue at play within Christian nationalism or support for the Trump administration.
 - 23 Trump’s 2020 election loss should not minimize this point. While he lost the 2020 presidential election, he still received more votes than any presidential candidate in history, with the exception of Joe Biden, clearly highlighting the deep resonance of his populism with broad segments of the US population.
 - 24 It is worth highlighting that this very public snub went unremarked among Republican lawmakers, despite their vehement denunciation of Pelosi’s “breach of decorum” in tearing up her copy of Trump’s State of the Union speech following his public delivery (Wu 2020), prompting some Republicans to go so far as to propose a resolution of disapproval for Pelosi’s actions in the US House (which was subsequently tabled by the Democratic majority) (Byrd and LeBlanc 2020).
 - 25 After writing this chapter, in June 2020, the US Supreme Court released its surprise (given the conservative majority among its justices) 6–3 decision in *Bostock v. Clayton County, GA*, finding that LGBTQ+ individuals are protected from employment discrimination under Title VII of the 1964 Civil Rights Act. Writing for the majority, conservative justice Neil Gorsuch argued, “an employer who fires an individual for being homosexual or transgender fires that person for traits or actions it would not have questioned in members of a different sex. Sex plays a necessary and undisguisable role in the decision, exactly what Title VII forbids.” See *Bostock v. Clayton County*, 590 U.S. ____ (2020).

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6

AMERICAN DYSPHORIA II

Civic Nationalism

Introduction

The previous chapter considered contemporary American Christian nationalism as a dysphoric response to the queer social body and an anti-democratic response to the queerly democratic practice that reveals it. In its expression of the fantastical desire for the morphologically normative social body, Christian nationalism expresses a desire for an impossible object, which is to say, for a body that has never been. But this fantasy, and the visceral, dysphoric responses it energizes, is not solely the political right's domain, nor does Christian nationalism have a monopoly on nationalist expression within the US. As we suggested in the previous chapter, at any given time there are multiple competing conceptions of American national identity (Bonikowski and DiMaggio 2016). While I argued that Christian nationalism represents the most pressing and significant articulation of American nationalism at present, I also noted that the competing conceptions of American national identity include expressions of civic nationalism. In this chapter, we will consider an expression of civic nationalism through a close examination of historian Mark Lilla's *The Once and Future Liberal: After Identity Politics* (2017b).

I focus on Lilla's text for several reasons. First, Lilla expresses his civic nationalism through a critique of "identity" or "movement" politics, which plays the role of foil to his own position. Considering such a critique is informative, insofar as critiques of identity politics can be found across the political spectrum, not only within rarefied academic discourse, but also as a widespread popular attitude (Alcoff 2006, 20). The second reason for considering Lilla's text is related to this: as his title makes clear, he articulates his civic nationalism as a politically liberal, rather than conservative, position, representing an important reminder that nationalist expression within the contemporary US is not limited to the political right.

Within this liberal framework, Lilla's text also bridges the gap between academic or theoretical critiques of identity politics and more popular expressions. While liberal critics have targeted identity politics for decades, the issue seemed to gain new urgency in the aftermath of the 2016 presidential election in the US, after which it became fashionable in many liberal circles to blame Hillary Clinton's loss on the Democratic Party's undue focus on identity politics (see Daum 2016; Altschuler 2017; Frum 2017; Harrop 2017; Mitchell 2017; Koppman 2018;).¹ As Professor of Humanities in the Department of History at Columbia University, Lilla obviously represents an example of an "academic elite." But his text is written in a non-specialist form (an issue I also note below) and he has also presented his basic thesis in a number of more popular venues, including the *New York Times*, the *New Yorker*, interviews on NPR, and so on (Lilla 2016a, 2016b, 2017a, 2017c). Linda Martín Alcoff (2006) also highlights three primary political arguments leveled against identity politics, together with three corresponding assumptions, which are also clear in Lilla's text. The first assumption is that "strongly felt identity is necessarily exclusivist," which leads those involved in identity politics to advocate divisions and identifications that foreclose on the possibility of shared political projects. The second concern is that identity politics enforces conformity and identitarian authenticity in such a manner that individuality and freedom are stifled. The third assumption is that identities are constituted around particularistic interests, values, beliefs, and so on, which foreclose on rational deliberation, which is supposed to involve the transcendence of precisely such particularities (36–38). Stated in terms of the social-as-body metaphor, these critiques operate on the assumption that identity politics leads to division within the social body, undermining its normative morphology and the unity it provides. While liberal expressions of civic nationalism, with their accompanying critiques of identity politics, do not speak univocally, Lilla's argument is nevertheless representative in many regards.

The third reason for considering Lilla's text is that, in its critique of identity politics, it clearly demonstrates civic nationalism's socially dysphoric nature. Civic nationalism, no less than contemporary Christian nationalism, express a disposition to proper social order and structure, a disposition effectively expressed in the social-as-body metaphor. Civic nationalism takes shape as an expression of the desire for the morphologically normative national body, representing a visceral reaction against disruptive queer democratic practice that transmogrifies that body. While these liberal articulations fill out the fantastical desire for the normative social body differently than Christian nationalism, that desire nevertheless remains. While people have critiqued Lilla's proposal from several different perspectives (e.g., Flaherty 2016; Illing 2017; Mehta 2017; Zeitz 2017), then, we will be considering Lilla's proposal as a dysphoric reaction to the queer social body. While his politics clearly differ from Christian nationalism, it is telling, as we shall see, that many of his social dysphoria triggers are the same as those triggering Christian nationalism.

We will begin our discussion with an overview of Lilla's civic nationalism and its critique of identity politics. We will then turn to a necessarily brief, but

nevertheless telling, consideration of some of the factual historical difficulties that plague his account. These difficulties are significant insofar as they highlight the specifically fantastical dimension of Lilla's proposal, demonstrating that his civic nationalism, like the Christian nationalism of the previous chapter, expresses a nostalgic desire for a return to a morphologically normative social body that has never existed. The chapter's final portion presents an alternative account, arguing that identity politics is an expression of queerly democratic practice and the American-national body's constructive unmaking.

Civic Nationalism and the Critique of Identity Politics

In Chapter 4, we highlighted the conceptual differences between nation and state as a means of thinking through the difference between a general sense of civic identity and a more robust sense of national identity. To reiterate a key point of that distinction, we suggested that common residence within geographical political borders and subjection to common sovereign authority is the only necessary commonality shared by those within the state. Compared to this, national identity is marked by a deeper, more robust sense of commonality, representing "a society whose members are linked by sentiments of solidarity and self-conscious identity based on a number of other bonds (e.g. history, territory, culture, race, 'ethnicity,' language, religion, customs)" (Morris 2004, 205). As we saw in our nationalism discussion, these shared bonds are not only a matter of identification, but of recognition and ascription. That is, it is not enough for one to identify oneself with the nation's common society—inclusion within the nation also requires one to be recognized as a legitimate member and, in this sense, national membership features must be ascribed. This is the conception of national identity operative within the Christian nationalist real-American prototype, which represents a form of "ascriptive Americanism" (Schildkraut 2014, 447). Within the context of the political state, any such national identity ascription necessarily enacts a distinction between those who technically have a place within the state but are nevertheless excluded from a more robust sense of national belonging. In the US case, this plays out as a distinction between those who possess only nominal American identity on the basis of something like citizenship, and those "real" Americans who are full-fledged members of the authentic American nation.

It is possible, however, to articulate a non-ascriptive sense of national belonging based solely on membership within the state, thereby bridging the conceptual gap between national and state identification. As Steve Fenton (2006) suggests, this "state-level universalism expresses the idea that states are capable of being primary bearers of a civic morality which bestows rights and dignity on all individuals, irrespective of [ascriptive] particularities" (193). We will refer to this "universalist (civic) paradigm of nation" (201) as civic nationalism.

From within a civic nationalist frame, in contrast to ascriptive Americanism, American national identity is a function of shared *political* identity, shorn of all

ascribed characteristics. Historian Philip Gleason (1982) clearly articulates this position when he suggests that, from the founding period, American national identity has had nothing to do with “any particular national, linguistic, religious, or ethnic background,” but has been based on committing oneself “to the political ideology centered on the abstract ideals of liberty, equality, and republicanism” so that “the universalist ideological character of American nationality meant that it was open to anyone who willed to become an American” (62–63). Rogers M. Smith (1997) locates this civic nationalist conception in a historical interpretive trajectory running from Alexis de Tocqueville (1960) through influential figures such as Gunnar Myrdal (1975), Louis Hartz (1955), and Michael Walzer (1990), and up to the present (14–30; see also Schildkraut 2014, 442).

Myrdal (1975) offers what has become the classic statement of this “American Creed,” representing an affirmation of “the ideals of the essential dignity of the individual human being, of the fundamental equality of all men [*sic*], and of certain inalienable rights to freedom, justice, and a fair opportunity” (4). This common creed, which also represents a shared “social ethos,” uniting all Americans, regardless of “national origins, classes, regions, creeds, and colors” (3). It is “the cement in the structure of this great and disparate nation” (3), giving “the common American his [*sic*] feeling of the historical mission of America in the world” (5). To be sure, Myrdal suggests, “the political creed of America is not very satisfactorily effectuated in actual social life,” such that “America is continuously struggling for its soul,” but, nevertheless, “as principles which *ought* to rule, the Creed has been made conscious to everyone in American society” (3, 4).²

Lilla’s civic nationalism and his critique of identity politics clearly fit into this long Tocquevillean trajectory. Indeed, as we shall see, Lilla’s own elaboration of American civic-national identity bears striking formal similarities to Myrdal’s own. Additionally, his aim in appealing to American civic-national identity is essentially the same, appealing to what are purported to be America’s core democratic and egalitarian values to argue for ongoing social and political reforms as their perfecting or ratification (see Smith 1997, 26).

Lilla presents identity or movement politics as an existential threat to the American national body’s morphological integrity, owing to the fact that they represent its pathological transmogrification. By way of contrast, he advances what he views as a non-identitarian liberalism, periodizing the last century of US history into two contrasting “dispensations”: the “Roosevelt Dispensation,” stretching from the New Deal through the civil rights movement, but which “then exhausted itself in the 1970s,” and the “Reagan Dispensation,” which began in 1980 and is now “being brought to a close by an opportunistic, unprincipled populism” (Lilla 2017b, 7–8).

Lilla’s appeal to historical dispensationalism (our focus will be on the Roosevelt Dispensation) is telling. As Cyrus Scofield (1982) (of *Scofield Study Bible* fame) suggested in his discussion of Christian dispensationalism, “dispensations” name discreet historical periods or “ages” defined by “some change in God’s method of

dealing with mankind [*sic*] ...” (295). This essential logic applies to Lilla’s secular dispensationalism: dispensations are teleologically directed by the unique logics according to which they operate.³ Insofar as the defining essence of the period in question relates social parts to whole, it dictates the American national body’s normative morphology and members’ proper places within it.

Within this framework, Lilla expounds his Roosevelt Dispensation with prophetic aplomb, presenting it as a golden socio-political age which has been forfeited through the dual sin of identity politics and rampant individualism (which amount to the same thing in his estimation) (Lilla 2017b, 99).⁴ Echoing Myrdal’s creedal language, Lilla argues that the Roosevelt Dispensation was defined by a “catechism of doctrines that set the terms of the political debate,” the “watchwords” of which were “solidarity, opportunity, and public duty,” with the aim of participation in “a collective enterprise to guard one another against risk, hardship, and the denial of fundamental rights” (8). The Reagan Dispensation, by way of contrast, “pictured a more individualist America” whose “watchwords were self-reliance and minimal government.” (8).

The Roosevelt Dispensation’s *esprit de corps* can be stated in a single word: citizenship. Lilla (2017b) understands citizenship as the one commonality shared by all Americans, regardless of background (15). Shared citizenship represents “a vision of our common destiny” that has nothing to do with a diversity of social identities (120; see also 123). Reflecting the logic of state universalism underlying civic nationalism, national identity, for Lilla, cannot be based on identity elements that are not universally shared. Citizenship serves this universalizing goal, providing a shared sense of “us” (119) and serving as the “bond linking all members of a political society over time, regardless of their individual characteristics” (88). Again, in agreement with Myrdal, Lilla argues that the Roosevelt Dispensation’s civic “catechism” was universally shared, among both liberals and conservatives, so that it provided the shared normative basis for preserving the American national body’s unity (33; cf. Myrdal 1975, 3).

Like all salvation histories, Lilla’s civic nationalist narrative recounts a fall from this Edenic historical paradise, the cause of which is nothing other than identity politics. The 1970s (more properly, the post-1960s) mark the period of this fall, during which “the New Left was torn apart by all the intellectual and personal dynamics that plague every left, plus a new one: identity” (Lilla 2017b, 75). As a result, the “healthy politics,” marked by shared citizenship’s “centripetal” force, was torn asunder by the “centrifugal” forces of social identity (77). Thus, while the New Left “spawned issue-based movements that helped to bring about progressive change in a number of areas,” thereby making the country “more tolerant, more just, and more inclusive,” it also failed to “contribute to the unification of the Democratic Party and the development of a liberal vision of Americans’ shared future” (Lilla 2017b, 77–78). The social-as-normative-body metaphor effectively captures the socio-political dispositions at the heart of this account. The presumption of the social body’s normative morphology is primarily given

negative expression: identity politics' social threat lies in its unmaking of the American national body. Identity politics arises from members of the social body who are out of place, transmogrifying the national body and threatening its very existence. Expressing the same logic as Christian nationalism, within the civic nationalist imaginary, a transmogrified social body is a pathologically disfigured social body.

Questioning the Roosevelt Dispensation's Coherence

Lilla's account of the Roosevelt Dispensation is open to both theoretical and empirical critique on multiple levels. Here, I want to focus attention on some of his proposal's empirical failings, insofar as they will set the stage for more theoretical critiques. From this perspective, the most glaring critique of Lilla's proposal is that the historical period he describes was never marked by the social unity he ascribes to it. Shared US citizenship did not result in the unified American national body Lilla imagines. Roosevelt's election provides a straightforward illustration of this. His economic and social proposals were hugely popular, leading to a groundswell of voter participation in his election, the formation of a diverse coalition of supporters, and a landslide victory, earning him a massive 88 percent of the Electoral College vote (472 of 531 total votes, carrying all but six states) and approximately 57 percent of the popular vote (Peters and Woolley; see also Painter 2010, 347). Yet this does not represent the degree of social unity Lilla imagines. While the electoral victory was massive, it nevertheless remains the case that more than four of every ten voters did *not* vote for him or his programs (Peters and Woolley), hardly evidence of a universally shared national identity.

But electoral statistics only begin to hint at the grave difficulties confronting Lilla's easy appeal to a universally shared sense of national identity grounded in common citizenship. The most obvious and pressing challenges to his account come from those groups who seem not to have had the place at the New Deal table suggested by Lilla's account: Native Americans, women, African Americans, and sexual and gender minorities, to name just a few obvious examples. Like other Tocquevillean accounts, Lilla's presentation of the ideologically and socially unified Roosevelt Dispensation requires the systematic elision of all such groups who were *not* counted as real Americans during the period in question (e.g., Smith 1997, 22). While a consideration of any of these examples would serve as an illustration of his account's inadequacy, a consideration of African Americans' experience and the Black civil rights movement, though necessarily brief, is particularly telling, particularly in light of Lilla's approach to these topics.

In the Preface to her excellent study of the civil rights movement, Jeanne Theoharis (2018) offers an account of the mythology of the Black civil rights movement that reads as if drawn directly from Lilla's text. Introducing themes she develops in detail throughout the remainder of her book, it illustrates just how typical Lilla's account is, and also why it is simply not credible. As she suggests,

the story of Black civil rights has been cast as one of “progress and national redemption” (x), transformed into a national “fable” with the idea that the movement “crossed party and ideology” and that “simply everyone was doing it” (xiv). The resulting narratives “flatter us as a country, minimizing our failings and marking our progress as inexorable as opposed to deeply contested and often eroded” (xvi). As she sums up the issue, “US democracy, in this version, is a self-cleaning oven, powerful, strong, and constantly self-improving; injustice is aberrational and once revealed is eliminated in a country built to move past its own mistakes” (xxi).

These elements are all prominent in Lilla’s account. While he does acknowledge that “racism, xenophobia, misogyny, and homophobia” have always played a role in American politics and that “Anglo-Protestant cultural dominance” has been evident (Lilla 2017b, 62, 63), he also presents these realities as essentially vestigial in nature, reminders of liberalism’s ongoing, teleological evolution toward its perfection of a fully inclusive society. This presumption once again situates Lilla in the Tocquevillean interpretive tradition, according to which ascriptive Americanism’s ongoing force represents only a historically vestigial artifact at odds with American national identity’s essentially egalitarian and democratic nature (see Smith 1997, 16, 26). Thus, Lilla effectively dismisses the failure to empirically enact the principles of the Roosevelt social catechism as irrelevant in much the same fashion as Myrdal almost three quarters of a century earlier (see Myrdal 1975, 3).

Lilla (2017b) anticipates the obvious rejoinder that many African Americans do, in fact, share a sense of common identity that does not simply reduce to citizenship, allowing that African Americans did develop a “strong identification within the African-American community itself” (64). Obviously, the existence of shared African American identity within the Roosevelt Dispensation threatens his narrative that shared citizenship, in opposition to diverse identity expression, was the period’s defining feature. His rhetorical strategy for mitigating these considerations’ force is to situate this shared identity outside the Roosevelt Dispensation itself. Illustrating the logic of the “historical artifact,” he suggests that African Americans’ shared identity stems from the imposition of the invented racial identity of “the Negro,” an identity that was “used as a criterion to exclude their progeny from political citizenship and from full membership in civil society” (64). By insisting that this identity was “imposed on slaves by their enslavers” (64), he delegitimizes African American identity, presenting it as a vestige from a prior historical period. In so doing, he also situates the injustice he perceives at the heart of African American identity safely outside the Roosevelt Dispensation. Thus, while the Roosevelt Dispensation’s inauguration in the New Deal is accompanied by the disenfranchisement of African Americans (34), this exclusion is presented as epiphenomenal in nature, in no way calling into question the common national identity shared by all Americans.

Insofar as it was foisted upon African Americans by their persecutors, shared identity is a symptom of social dysfunction, not a resource for addressing it.⁵ As evidence of this, Lilla asserts that shared identification in common citizenship is so

strong that it overcomes the legacy of this pre-dispensational crime. Thus, we are assured, African Americans were never really excluded from the shared sense of national or civic identification at all: while “it is hard to imagine how the victims of the racial crime could ever identify as citizens of the country that had committed and justified it for centuries,” it turns out that many African American intellectuals were able to “discover that they were Americans after all” (Lilla 2017b, 65).

Of course, this account is historically untenable. For example, Lilla’s presentation occludes the fact that Jim Crow segregation was not simply an epiphenomenon of American slavery, but a significant cultural and legal institution in its own right (see Lewis and Lewis 2009, xiii–xix; Lavelle 2015, 125–126). Nor was this legal system limited to the American south, as Lilla implies when he attributes African Americans’ exclusion from New Deal policies to Roosevelt’s need to placate the so-called “Dixiecrats” (see Lilla 2017b, 34). As Theoharis (2018) points out, many northern Whites were happy to frame institutional racism as a specifically southern problem when, in fact, racism was endemic throughout the US (31–61; see also Katznelson 2005; Lewis and Lewis 2009, xii; Rothstein 2017). The ongoing invention and application of new crimes against African Americans in the period extending into the Roosevelt Dispensation itself (and, of course, continuing through the present) makes it clear that legally sanctioned racism directed at African Americans cannot be reduced to an epiphenomenal manifestation of the past. In attempting such a reduction, Lilla again stands in a long tradition of Tocquevillian American nationalist interpretation, expressing the same explanatory Lacuna as Hartz’s (1955) well-known analysis (see Smith 1997, 26).

Lilla’s historical whitewashing is not limited to the New Deal period, but also runs through the modern Black civil rights movement. Presenting the historical Black civil rights movement in a manner consistent with his broader dispensational approach, he then uses that presentation to highlight the damage enacted on the contemporary American national body by the Black Lives Matter (BLM) movement, which he presents as a negative exemplar of identity politics. In this way, the Black civil rights movement stands as a telling illustration of the morphologically normative American-national body in the Roosevelt Dispensation, serving as a stark foil to the social body’s transmutation enacted by contemporary movements such as BLM.

In a scathing critique, Lilla (2017b) writes that BLM represents “a textbook example of how not to build solidarity” (129). Despite the movement’s legitimate role in mobilizing supporters and “deliver[ing] a wake-up call to every American with a conscience” by drawing attention to “police mistreatment” of African Americans, the movement goes too far, becoming counter-productive precisely to the extent that it becomes socially disruptive. Thus, he insists,

there is ... no denying that the movement’s decision to use this mistreatment to build a general indictment of American society, and its law enforcement institutions, and to use Mau-Mau tactics to put down dissent and demand a

confession of sins and public penitence (most spectacularly in a public confrontation with Hillary Clinton, of all people), played into the hands of the Republican right.

(129)⁶

This statement represents a viscerally dysphoric response to the social body's members who are clearly, on Lilla's view, out of their proper place. Political or social action that awakens Americans to their purportedly shared ideals is legitimate (setting aside the question of precisely how widely shared such ideals can be if they require social "awakening" to begin with), but only to the degree that it does not transmogrify the American national body in the process. To suggest that many, even most, Americans *do not* share the same ideals (as in, for example, a wide-ranging critique of American law enforcement institutions and practices) or that US citizenship *is not* enough to guarantee equality, threatens to unmake the American-national body, and must be opposed. The transmogrification enacted in queerly democratic movements such as BLM threatens to reveal the national body's fundamental queerness. Such movements represent a social malady that must be expunged if their advocates will not fall into line, taking up their properly appointed places within the morphologically normative American-national body.

The specifically dysphoric nature of Lilla's response is brought into clearer relief in the distinctions he draws between BLM and the earlier Black civil rights movement. For Lilla (2017b), BLM stands in stark contrast to the Black civil rights movement, which did not call into question the American national body's normative morphology, but actually reaffirmed it, offering "a constructive way of serving both the African-American community and the country as a whole" (65). Members of the Black civil rights movement, on this account, were not out of place within the American-national body, threatening to transmogrify it, but served it by operating within its normative parameters without departing from their assigned positions within it.

And what, precisely, was the service rendered to broader society? Expressing the logic of the fully inclusive *demos* teleologically unfolding its essence within the social (outlined in Chapter 2), the service of the Black civil rights movement consisted of "working to force America to live up to its principles" (Lilla 2017b, 65). The Black civil rights movement, then, in no way reveals the queerness of the American-national body by unmaking its normative morphology; on the contrary, it reaffirms it. Even further, as an expression of the *demos*'s essence, the morphologically normative American-national body actually serves the condition of possibility for the Black civil rights movement itself. On Lilla's account, then, the Black civil rights movement in no way calls into question the Roosevelt Dispensation's historical integrity, but instead serves as evidence of its teleologically constituted unity.

Lilla's (2017b) deployment of this logic is not limited to considerations of the Black civil rights movement. Rather, a range of earlier social movements, such as those "against slavery, for women's rights, for workers' protection," were

qualitatively different from contemporary expressions of identity politics insofar as they operated within the morphologically normative American-national body's bounds; they "did not question the legitimacy of the American system; they just wanted it to live up to its principles and respect its procedures" (109). For Lilla, all these movements express the legitimacy of the normatively structured American-national body, neither transmogriying it nor expressing the *demos's* constitutive incompleteness. Insofar as these movements "worked with parties and through institutions to achieve their ends" (109), they preserved and ratified the social body's normative morphology and, ultimately, their places within it.

In specific contrast to BLM, then, the Black civil rights movement is exemplary in this regard: "the leaders of the civil rights movement chose to take the concept of universal, equal citizenship more seriously than White America ever had" (Lilla 2017b, 65–66), and in so doing it did not "idealize or deny difference," but "render [ed] it politically impotent" (66). Understood in these terms, the Black civil rights movement didn't "just" serve African Americans' interests, but the interest of "the country as a whole" (65) precisely because it did *not* transmogriy the American-national body. On this point, Lilla's appeal to dispensationalism is not merely illustrative or metaphorical, but substantive: the Roosevelt Dispensation's conceptual integrity is grounded in the American-national body's essential morphological integrity. The civic-national body may require growth to bring its normative morphology to full maturation, but that growth will be teleologically determined by the inner truth of what it already is in all its fullness, while any shortcomings in the institution of liberal polity are merely contingent and will be overcome naturally and in due course. Social and political movements' legitimacy, on Lilla's account, can therefore be evaluated in direct measure to their ultimate affirmation of the American-national body's normative morphology. Any who transmogriy that body, thereby revealing its fundamentally queer nature, are illegitimate by default.

As Theoharis (2018) notes, the same myths Lilla propounds about the Black civil rights movement have routinely been used to delegitimize BLM. But these myths traffic in "an 'epistemology of ignorance'" (xvi), participating in what Charles Mills (1997) describes as "White misunderstanding, misrepresentation, evasion, and self-deception on matters of race" (19). In marked contrast to Lilla's whitewashed account, the fact of the matter is that the very same criticisms he levels against BLM were routinely leveled against the Black civil rights movement as well (Theoharis 2018, xvi). While numerous historical examples would serve to make these points, a brief example from Martin Luther King, Jr.'s life will have to suffice. King is a particularly fitting example in this regard, insofar as he has become "Exhibit A" in accounts of the Black civil rights movement like Lilla's.⁷ Indeed, while Lilla doesn't list any particular civil rights leaders in his discussions, referring only generically to "leaders," there can be little doubt that MLK figures in the background in his account.

King's "Letter from a Birmingham Jail" (1992) perfectly illustrates these points. Having helped organize a series of demonstrations in Birmingham, AL, King,

together with Reverend Ralph Abernathy, was arrested on Good Friday (April 12), 1963, for openly defying a court order against marching. Eight White anti-segregationist members of the Alabama clergy subsequently signed an open letter arguing against civil disobedience in contravention of standing court orders, decrying the fact that “we are now confronted by a series of demonstrations by some of our Negro citizens, directed and led by outsiders,” and arguing that, while “we recognize the natural impatience of the people who feel that their hopes are slow in being realized ... we are convinced that these demonstrations are unwise and untimely” (Carpenter et al. 1992, 109–110; see also Kendi 2016, 374). The letter continues,

we agree rather with certain local Negro leadership which has called for honest and open negotiation Just as we formerly pointed out that “hatred and violence have no sanction in our religious and political traditions,” we also point out that such actions as incite hatred and violence, however technically peaceful those actions may be, have not contributed to the resolution of our local problems. We do not believe that these days of new hope are days when extreme measures are justified in Birmingham.

(*Carpenter et al. 1992, 110*)

The letter clearly illustrates that those writing it, White clergy *opposed to* segregation, are critical of King because he is *not* working through established parties and institutional procedures. They also do not perceive King, particularly in his employment of direct-action tactics, as simply calling American society to “live up to its principles.” In sharp contrast with Lilla’s anodyne presentation, they view King’s methods, if not his message (it is, after all, “technically peaceful”), as a necessarily disruptive unmaking of the American-national body; King and his co-dissenters are members out of place within the social body, pathologically disfiguring it.

Thus, King’s critics express the same dysphoric response to the American social body’s transfiguration as Lilla. King is censured for failing to operate within the framework of established political and legal institutions, instead participating in queerly democratic actions that actively challenge them; with sowing division and discord within the social body, rather than working to build consensus; and for undertaking extreme measures that work only to alienate others, including the broader White-majority community. King is censured, in other words, for constructively unmaking the American-national body. The writers of the letter essentially level the same charge against King that Lilla reserves for BLM: his is a textbook example of how *not* to build solidarity, which is to say, of how not to accept the morphologically normative American body’s legitimacy.

King is so incensed by the letter that he responds directly, which was rare (Kendi 2016, 374), and his response is telling. He dismisses their concerns regarding “outside agitators” as “narrow” and “provincial,” defending the breaking of “unjust” laws and the use of disruptive direct-action methods, writing, “I

have yet to engage in a direct-action campaign that was ‘well-timed’ in the view of those who have not suffered unduly from the disease of segregation” (King 1992, 111, 112). He also writes, “you deplore the demonstrations that are presently taking place in Birmingham. But I am sorry that your statement did not express a similar concern for the conditions that brought the demonstrations into being,” continuing, “I am sure that each of you would want to go beyond the superficial social analyst who looks merely at effects, and does not grapple with underlying causes” (111). Far from affirming the American-national body’s normative morphology, King here refers to that body as “diseased,” implicitly presenting his own actions as an effort to unmake the social body so that it can take on a new shape. In this way, he is actively and intentionally involved in the social body’s transmutation, directly contradicting Lilla’s interpretation of his actions vis-à-vis those of BLM.⁸

Further disrupting Lilla’s narrative, King also shows very little concern with building (White) solidarity. In a formulation that certainly sounds like both an appeal to identity and a refutation of the claim to a universally shared sense of American national identity, he writes, “we know through painful experience that freedom is never voluntarily given up by the oppressor; it must be demanded by the oppressed” (King 1992, 111). Most pointedly, he continues,

I must confess that over the last few years I have been gravely disappointed with the White moderate. I have almost reached the regrettable conclusion that the Negroes’ great stumbling block in the stride toward freedom is not the White Citizens’ “Councilor” or the Ku Klux Klaner [*sic*], but the White moderate who is more devoted to “order” than to justice; who prefers a negative peace which is the absence of tension to a positive peace which is the presence of justice; who constantly says “I agree with you in the goal you seek, but I can’t agree with your methods of action”; who paternalistically feels that he [*sic*] can set the timetable for another man’s [*sic*] freedom; who lives by the myth of time and who constantly advises the Negro to wait until a “more convenient season.” Shallow understanding from people of good will is more frustrating than absolute misunderstanding from people of ill will.

(112–113)

King’s pointed comments are directly relevant for us on a number of levels. The first is that he explicitly decries the disposition to “order” opposing a disruptive institution of justice. Translating this into the language of the social body, King rejects the argument that the morphologically normative social body must be maintained at all costs, and that its transmutation is the danger to be avoided. He rejects “solidarity” if it requires maintaining the social body in its currently existing form, and his rejection highlights the vacuity of Lilla’s appeal to a universally shared sense of citizenship. More pointedly, he suggests that the “moderate” positions advanced by those like Lilla are in fact more pernicious than the openly oppressive and racist positions advanced by White supremacists.

King's Birmingham letter and the events that occasioned it illustrate the point that the American social body has never possessed the morphologically normativity Lilla ascribes to it. This is evident if we pose the question (which Lilla never considers) of why, if they are nothing more than the morphologically normative American-national body's teleologically oriented expressions, social movements like the Black civil rights movement were ever necessary at all. The response to such considerations is simple: the morphologically normative American-national body to which Lilla appeals *never existed*. There is no credible way to claim that King's Birmingham episode (to say nothing of other events in his life and career) expresses a universally shared "catechism" of values. It is most certainly not the case that they experienced *themselves* as sharing such values, as evident in the open letter to King and his response.

Moving beyond the events of Birmingham, this latter point is also evident in the fact that King's popularity plummeted (by 1966 only about a third of Americans had a favorable opinion of him) as he shifted his focus from combatting segregation in the American South to the North (Dupuy 2018). As Clayborne Carson, director of the Stanford Martin Luther King Jr. Institute, puts it, "it is one thing to talk about the desegregation of the University of Alabama. It's quite another think to talk about the desegregation of neighborhoods in Chicago" (Dupuy 2018). Looking more broadly than divergent attitudes toward King, Black and White Americans' very different recollections and assessments of the Jim Crow era and the Black civil rights movement also show that not all Americans shared the same values (Lavelle 2015). Indeed, even language of *the* Black civil rights movement is misleading, insofar as the fight for Black civil rights was never expressed a single, homogenous movement. If it is not possible to fit figures like King into a comforting civic nationalist narrative of the harmonious, morphologically normative American-national body, this is even truer of figures like Malcolm X and Stokely Carmichael, various Black Nationalist movements, and organizations such as the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC) (e.g., Carson 1981; Joseph 2006; Kendi 2016; Theoharis 2018).

Such considerations fundamentally contradict Lilla's dispensational account. The formal similarities between the criticisms leveled against King and Lilla's criticisms of BLM reveal that the social body's transmogrified, queer character is not new, nor does it represent a fall away from a socially harmonious period marked by a morphologically normative social body and universally shared sense of American identity. The social body's consistent queerness undermines the qualitative distinction Lilla draws between the Roosevelt Dispensation and what has come after it. Likewise, it indicates that there never was a shared catechism or civic creed uniting all Americans together in a shared sense of American citizenship and its significance.

Whatever plausibility such an account might have owes only to the highly abstract quality of Lilla's proposal. His appeal to shared citizenship is particularly instructive in this regard. In making his appeal, he explicitly sidesteps the most contentious issues related to citizenship itself. Thus, he writes,

It is a sign of how polluted our discourse has become that any mention of the term *citizen* leads people to think of the hypocritical and racist demagoguery that passes for our “debate” on immigration and refugees today. I will not be discussing such matters here, and what I have to say about citizenship implies nothing about who should be granted citizenship or how noncitizens should be treated.

(Lilla 2017b, 15)

He later repeats this point, adding, “I am interested here only in what citizenship *is*” (Lilla 2017b, 121).

This is, of course, fundamentally question-begging: there can be no account of what citizenship “is” without attending to questions concerning who should be counted as a citizen, processes for attaining citizenship, rights and duties pertaining to citizenship, citizens’ relationships to non-citizens, and so on. We cannot sidestep citizenship’s meaning if it is to serve as the basis of shared national identity. As Richard Bellamy (2008) suggests, citizenship grants “the right to have rights” (15); without addressing the questions Lilla sidesteps, appeals to citizenship are vacuous. Lilla’s easy reliance on citizenship’s seemingly transparent meaning also overlooks the opacity that has actually defined the concept in US history. As Smith (1997) notes, US law has historically “been shot through with forms of second-class citizenship, denying personal liberties and opportunities for political participation to most of the adult population on the basis of race, ethnicity, gender, and even religion” (2). Citizenship in the US has often defined what rights individuals *do not* possess as much as it has defined what rights they do possess. Thus, courts and executive officials have often employed different citizenship categories,

including not just birthright and naturalized citizens and state and US citizens but also nonvoting citizens, “jurisdictional” citizens, “commercial” citizens, citizens subject to incarceration or deportation without due process owing to their race, denizens, US nationals, and even colonial subjects.

(14)

Any appeal to citizenship absent explicit consideration of its meaning is essentially vacuous.

Instead of attending to necessary and complex definitional issues, Lilla (2017b) appeals to the watchwords of “solidarity, opportunity, and public duty” (8). He makes no effort to define what a “watchword” is or how it operates socially or politically. But even setting aside the question of whether or not these watchwords have the universal appeal he ascribes to them (we have significant reason to doubt this), he clearly assumes that universal appeal represents the expression of a shared set of substantive values or meanings. That is, he assumes that universal appeal to “solidarity,” “opportunity,” and “public duty” is evidence of universally

shared understandings of these terms' meaning or significance—that all people invoking these terms intend the same thing in doing so. We can describe this understanding of universality as substantive or conceptual universality, contrasting it with a notion of *contingent* universality (introduced in Chapter 3, see also Miller 2016, 185–186, 2019a, 4–5). Assuming, for the sake of argument, that such words are universal in the sense that everyone appeals to them, this does not imply that everyone making such appeals understands or intends them in the same way. Rather, these terms are essentially “empty,” lacking any universally shared meaning or significance, which allows the diverse groups and individuals appealing to them to “fill” them in different ways. They may be universal in their social and political appeal, but they are contingent in the diverse meanings with which they are invested. Indeed, their universality is a function of their conceptual emptiness: if they are, indeed, the subject of universal appeal, this is *because* they do not have fixed, determinate, or universally shared meanings. Lilla's invocation of shared “watchwords,” then, does little to lend cogency to the idea of the unified Roosevelt Dispensation.

Lilla's Political Fantasy

Universal appeal to shared watchwords is not, as Lilla supposes, evidence of a shared social order constituting the American-national body's morphological normativity. On the contrary, appreciation of such watchwords' contingent universality would be evidence of the American social body's fundamental queerness. It reveals that the American social body *has no* normative shape, but is always a transmogrified assemblage of diverse identities, interests, and meaning-making investments, as even a cursory historical examination illustrates. Yet this point only heightens a theoretically significant question: given its historical and factual untenability, why does Lilla's proposal have the force and appeal that it does? Why does an account like Lilla's resonate so deeply with so many?

The answer is that Lilla's proposal is not a matter of political or social fact, but an expression of political fantasy. Once again taking up Žižek's (1989) notion of fantasy as “a screen masking a void” (126), we find political fantasy operating to occlude the fact that *there is no* morphologically normative American social body. Political fantasy masks the fact that the American social body is fundamentally queer or transmogrified, shaped and re-shaped by continual processes of (un)becoming (Sullivan 2006, 560), directing political desire instead to the social and political attainment of the morphologically normative American-national body as an impossible object (Žižek 1989, 118). Lilla's account of the American-national body, no less than that of contemporary American Christian nationalism, is fantastically structured by the social-as-body metaphor.

The fantastical nature of Lilla's proposal accounts for the vitriol, bordering on abject rage, that drips from the pages of his text as he expresses such distain for any and all social movements that would disrupt the social body's normativity as

he imagines it, threatening to reveal his political fantasy for what it is. It also explains the paucity of detailed historical investigation and critical engagement with other thinkers in his text.⁹ The fantasy of the morphologically normative social body fundamentally directs what limited appeal to facts Lilla makes and accounts for his text's obvious contradictions, which are otherwise difficult to explain. So, for example, he cautions against any nostalgic appeal to the past, describing such nostalgia as "suicidal" (Lilla 2017b, 23), insisting that "there is no *again* in politics, just the future" (16), while nevertheless structuring his entire proposal around an appeal to a past dispensation that is every bit as nostalgic as it is fantastical. Likewise, in a rationalistic vein defending the priority of rational deliberation as democratic practice's central feature, Lilla castigates "identity" liberals for being "mesmerized by symbols" (14), closing off the possibility of reasoned dialogue (90), and emphasizing "aimless self-expression" over "the priority of democratic persuasion" (104), contrasting them to liberals of the past who "received a relatively nonpartisan education in an environment that encouraged debates over ideas" (140). Yet, at the same time, he chides contemporary liberals for failing to "inspire" others and win over Americans' "imagination" (6–7), and credits Reagan's success to his ability to transform ideas in an "epiphany" that would seem to operate on an entirely different register from that of debate and dialogue (22). And this is to say nothing of his appeal to inspiring political leaders' "messianic" nature (100).

Such contradictions are inevitable given the fantastical nature of Lilla's discourse. Precisely because the morphologically normative American-national body is a fantasy, presupposing the "natural attitude" of normative embodiment (Bettcher 2009, 103), he is led into contradictions to support it. The fact that he overlooks such obvious tensions and contradictions further highlights that his discourse operates on the level of political desire, not the rationality for which he otherwise argues. Just as American Christian nationalism's fantastical character allows it to thrive in the face of factual disconfirmation, Lilla's liberal fantasy of the morphologically normative American-national body takes shape in the wake of obvious factual and historical shortcomings.

Fantasy, Democracy, Identity

Lilla's opposition to contemporary identity politics represents a dysphoric response to a transmogrified social body, expressing the political fantasy of a well-ordered, morphologically normative American-national body. Like contemporary American Christian nationalism, Lilla's civic nationalist critique of identity politics is fundamentally anti-democratic. This may appear to be a counter-intuitive claim, given his explicit appeal to a notion of democracy in opposition to what he sees as identity politics' depoliticizing threats. However, if we understand democracy in its queer expression, as a form of dissensual social practice that transmogrifies the morphologically normative social body, then any effort to foreclose on such practice is necessarily anti-democratic in nature.

While Lilla (2017b) does not explicitly define either democracy or politics, it is clear throughout his discussion that he understands both in statist, procedural, and institutional terms. Consistent with his insistence on “the priority of institutional over movement politics” (104), he equates being “political” with involvement in government (40) and limits democratic action to participation in elections and town halls and to judicial appeal (12, 41). Thus, democratic participation is explicitly focused on formal institutions (104), is fundamentally a matter of rational political persuasion (117), and is practiced only within formal legislative processes (113), with government representing the *sine qua non* of American democracy (106). Finally, he consistently reduces progressive politics to membership within the American Democratic Party (e.g., 76–78).

Lilla’s understanding of the *demos* is also unclear, requiring us to tease out his views. Striking a populist tone, he implicitly equates the authentic people with “non-elites,” noting their abandonment by elitist Democrats (thereby rhetorically linking identity politics with “elitism”). In a populist formulation indistinguishable from that of Christian nationalism, he identifies the authentic people as those who live “between the coasts” (60) in the “vast middle of the country” about which Democrats have no concern (84), having abandoned them in favor of “social movements” (60). While the Roosevelt Dispensation’s Democratic Party served the interests of real Americans, they have since been abandoned in the period of identity politics, with the obvious implication that those who understand themselves in anything other than civic nationalist terms are not part of the authentic people.

Lilla’s populist “middle-America-versus-liberal-coastal-elites” narrative simply cannot be factually sustained. It is certainly not the case that all Americans living on either coast are liberal or elite, nor are all coastal states reliably “blue” (Florida, Georgia, South Carolina, and North Carolina are prime examples of this). African Americans, who (obviously) live all over the US, overwhelmingly vote with the Democratic Party. Many reliably “red” states have “blue” metro areas within them (e.g., Austin, TX, Charlotte, NC), while many reliably “blue” states are marked by significant internal regional cultural and political differences (e.g., Washington, Oregon, California). Whether one accepts the thesis that American politics is divided on the basis of urban vs. rural populations (see Kron 2012; Bump 2014) or that divisions in voting behavior are more regional in nature (see Woodward 2012, 2017), the language of “coastal elites” vs. “real Americans” is simply indefensible on any empirical analysis. In deploying such tropes, Lilla’s civic nationalism is rhetorically indistinguishable from that of American Christian nationalists, opening his positions to many of the same empirical challenges.

His proposal’s fantastical nature once again allows Lilla to ignore these and other empirical observations. By reducing democracy to participation in institutions and political parties and presenting such participation as the Roosevelt Dispensation’s defining feature, Lilla presents the Roosevelt Dispensation as the period of authentic democracy, in contrast to the contemporary political moment.

Democracy's smooth functioning is thereby rendered contingent on the morphologically normative American-national body's maintenance. On this formulation, any unmaking of the social body is inherently anti-democratic, effectively ruling out any dissent directed toward existing political practices or institutions. To act democratically just is to play one's proper role within the American-national body: to participate in existing political parties, to cast votes in regularly scheduled elections, to enter into civil and rational debate in approved venues and forms.

Just as Lilla's whitewashed, anodyne presentation of the civil rights movement serves to ensure that it supports, rather than unmakes, the morphologically normative American-national body, legitimate democratic participation supports that same normative body. And this is not accidental, in Lilla's view: he projects his institutionalized vision of democratic participation to the founding of the US, so that socially disruptive dissensual practice represents a departure from the founders' very ideals. Thus, he writes that the "main focal point of American democratic politics" has always been "government" (Lilla 2017b, 106) and argues that the aim of the founders was to "canalize political energy into institutions, while making them as transparent and participatory as possible" (107).

Lilla's projection of Roosevelt Dispensation norms into the past once again highlights his Tocquevillean proclivities in identifying an inclusive civic nationalism as American-national identity's founding principle (see Smith 1997, 14–20). Unsurprisingly, however, with this projection Lilla uncritically recirculates another common American nationalist myth that cannot be historically supported. While it is certainly true that the American founders did not look fondly on socially disruptive political practice, this is not true for the reasons Lilla supposes. The American founders did not intend to make government institutions either as transparent or as participatory as possible. On the contrary, the system they envisioned was intended to guard *against* widespread popular participation and democratic fervor. As Patrick J. Deneen (2018) sums up the issue, "both classical and progressive liberals are dominated by thinkers who praise the rule of the electorate even as they seek to promote systemic governmental features that will *minimize electoral influence* in the name of good policy outcomes" (162, emphasis added). Sheldon Wolin (2008) writes that

The main hope of the framers of the Constitution was to establish a strong central government, not one hobbled at every turn by an intrusive citizenry or challenged by the several "sovereign" states ... The new system, with its emphasis upon a strong executive, an indirectly elected Senate composed (it was hoped) of the educated and wealthy, and an appointed Supreme Court also represented the fears of the Founders. Theirs was a counterrevolution against not only the system of politics that had led the revolution against Britain but against the democratic tendencies and populist outbreaks that had persisted from the end of the seventeenth century through the eighteenth.

(225; see also 225–230; Dunn 2005, 71–84; Deneen 2018, 161–173)

Regarding the liberal principles underlying the American Creed, Kaufmann (2000) suggests that the founders' liberal espousals had much more to do with the establishment of cultural identity than with actual political practice, distinguishing the nascent American state "from illiberal ethnicities both on its southern and northern border and in Europe" (3). And all of these points also hold against the backdrop of American settler colonialism, slavery, and misogyny, outlined in the previous chapter, which ensured that only men of White European descent could legitimately or realistically participate in formal political institutions or processes. Once again, the fantastical nature of Lilla's argument inoculates it against the force of such stubborn historical realities.

Identity Politics

Identity and Identification

It would be instructive to carry out a point-by-point contrast of Lilla's understanding of democracy with that of queer democracy outlined in Chapter 2, given their stark differences. Insofar as it can allow no place for dissensual practice and the American-national body's unmaking, Lilla's reduction to democracy to existing parties, mechanisms, and procedures is fundamentally anti-democratic, his own claims notwithstanding. Indeed, his blithe acceptance of America's institutional/procedural political status quo provides no obvious resources for countering neoliberal managed democracy's pernicious effects. Rather than developing these points further, however, I want to focus the remaining discussion in this chapter on the concepts of identity and identity politics. We have already given some consideration to the notion of identification in previous chapters, examining its role in the constitution of nationalism and populism. Here, we will consider identity and identification from a different perspective, examining the essential role they play in queer democracy and the social body's constructive unmaking.

A civic nationalist critique of identity politics raises at least two overarching issues: first, what is meant by "identity" and, second, do appeals to identity have the fragmentary effect on the American-national body critics fear? We can already see the answer to the second question is negative, at least in the sense that the social body has never been the unified, morphologically normative object presupposed by such a concern. Opposition to identity politics on the grounds that it fragments the social body is fantastical in nature, expressing the desire for an impossible national body that has never existed.

As the more fundamental for a consideration of identity politics, the first issue deserves sustained attention. As with other key concepts in his civic nationalist proposal, Lilla does not provide a unified or clearly articulated account of what, precisely, "identity" and "identity politics" are, though it is possible to tease out key elements of his understanding. In his most robust attempt at a definition, he

suggests that “the term *identity* ... did not enter American political discourse until the late 1960s,” suggesting that in its contemporary sense, the term refers (as noted above) to “an inner thing, a homunculus that needs tending to” (Lilla 2017b, 62). Informed by this perspective, identity politics is a form of radical individualism, while the academy is its primary generative cultural source, granting it an “intellectual patina” (87).¹⁰ This occurs as students learn that “the aim of education is not to progressively become a self through engagement with the wider world,” but that, in contrast, “one engages with the world and particularly politics for the limited aim of understanding and affirming what one already is” (84). The end result is “the Facebook model of identity,” according to which “the self [is] a homepage I construct like a personal brand, linked to others through associations I can ‘like’ and ‘unlike’ at will” (87).

Trading on a very traditional distinction between the political as public and the self as inherently private, then, Lilla’s objection to identity politics is that, as an expression of radical individualism bordering on narcissism, it is fundamentally depoliticizing. His scathing dismissal of the well-known feminist slogan “the personal is political” vividly illustrates this understanding. While he allows that the slogan may once have meant that “everything that seems personal is in fact political, that there are no spheres of life exempt from the struggle for power,” he suggests that it has devolved to the point where it now means “that what we think of as political action is in fact nothing but personal activity, an expression of me and how I define myself” (Lilla 2017b, 75). Identity politics, on this view, reduces “political” action to an expression of personal preference, a “romantic” and “adolescent” appeal to the authenticity of one’s inner identity (67). Such appeals enact, at best, only the appearance of “superficial diversity” (14), their real effect being to unmake the American-national body. Identity politics undermines any shared vision of the common good (10) with an emphasis on “disuniting rhetoric” (59) and on difference that has torn the “New Left” apart (75). The end result is that, in contrast to the Roosevelt Dispensation, when differences were recognized but rendered “politically impotent” (66), the present moment is, for the left, one in which there is no shared sense of “we” (30).¹¹ In a statement that perfectly summarizes his overall position, Lilla writes, “every advance of liberal *identity* consciousness has marked a retreat of liberal *political* consciousness” (10).

Lilla gives voice to the common liberal concerns with appeals to identity Alcott highlights (2006), most notably the concern that such appeals lead to social fragmentation by advancing such narrow and particularistic interests that the individuals involved cannot transcend their own individual perspective to the degree required for common political action (36–37). This is why Lilla contrasts individualistic and narcissistic appeals to *identity* with shared *identification* in citizenship. Drawing his own distinction between identity and identification, then, he envisions citizenship not as a form of identity, but as that which, as a form of identification, overcomes or transcends individual or particularistic identity (Lilla 2017b, 66). Thus, identity is strictly individual, while

identification is corporate or collective; identity is the source of social fragmentation, while common citizenship identification is the source of political and social commonality; identity relegates the political to the realm of private individualist expression, while common citizenship identification allows for the articulation of shared political, which is to say properly public, projects.

Lilla's concept of identity is fundamentally flawed. The distinction he draws between identity and identification is a fitting point at which to take up this consideration, given our previous discussion of identity and identification in Chapter 4. In differentiating identity from identification, Lilla tacitly presupposes a distinction between that which is static and that which is fluid or dynamic. Thus, identity, insofar as it expresses what someone "already is," is an essentially fixed category. To the limited degree that identity gives any evidence of flexibility or fluidity, this owes entirely to the caprice of the individuals in question, therefore reflecting their individuality and further reifying their identity. By way of contrast, insofar as identification transcends individuals' capricious identity of individuals, it permits the requisite flexibility and fluidity for the sense of group belonging required for meaningful participation in public political practices and institutions.

As we saw in our discussion in Chapter 4, however, identity and identification are not two contrasting concepts. Rather, identity is better understood in terms of identification. As Steph Lawler (2014) suggests, "identity itself is a social and collective *process* and *not*, as Western traditions would have it, a unique and individual possession" (2, emphases added).¹² This understanding of identity-as-process collapses the distinction between identity and identification on which Lilla constructs his analysis. Lawler explicitly makes this point, defining "identity-making" in terms of "processes of *identification*" (10), while Richard Jenkins (2014) advances similar arguments, suggesting that "instead of 'identity,' we should only talk about ongoing and open-ended processes of 'identification'" (10; see also Rattansi 2007, 116). What is at issue in any discussion of identity is therefore "a process—*identification*—not a 'thing'; it is not something that one can *have*, or not, it is something that one *does*" (Jenkins 2014, 6). Armed with these insights, we see that the static, "homuncular" identity with which Lilla contrasts his own concept of identification is another impossible object that does not exist, revealing an additional fantastical dimension to his account: his civic nationalism is cogent only when opposed to an impossible form of identity. Identity is not, as Lilla supposes, an object possessed by individuals, but is itself *always* a dynamic social process, a "practical accomplishment" (48). Shifting from language of identity to that of identification has the advantage of sidestepping the dangers of reification that often attend the language of identity (15–16), evident in Lilla's account.

As Jenkins (2014) suggests, "identity and identification are ubiquitous, generic aspects of human life" (204). This understanding undermines Lilla's simplistic insistence that identity is a novel social phenomenon, taking shape only since the 1960s. Jenkins highlights identification's significance for categorization, as it

facilitates the possibility of “know[ing] ‘who’s who’ (hence what’s what),” of “knowing who we are, knowing who others are, them knowing who we are, us knowing who they think we are and so on” (6). Lilla’s reductive view of identification occludes a more nuanced appreciation of the changed social and political dynamics that *are* expressed in identity politics. While identity’s role in social life is not new, the “power of categorization—the subjugation of the internal moment of identification by the external” has increased significantly in the modern period (205). In a related vein, Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe (2001) suggest that the proliferation of subject positions within the social is decisively modern, facilitated by what they, following Claude Lefort, refer to as the “democratic revolution,” symbolically inaugurated in the French Revolution (152–159). Awareness of identity’s dynamic nature allows for the simultaneous recognition that identity has always been an irreducible social category *and* that it plays a role in the modern and contemporary period that is different from prior historical periods, a nuanced position that cannot be accommodated in an account such as Lilla’s.

This more complex and nuanced account of identity also highlights the incoherence of the notion that identity is purely individual in nature. As Lawler (2014) suggests, it is a mistake to think of individual identity or selfhood as a “core which is outside the social world” (15). On the contrary, individual identity takes shape “*between* rather than *within* persons Selfhood and identity are produced through social relations that people then take up and use as resources for self-understanding” (17). Along the same lines, Jenkins (2014) suggests that identification “is the basic cognitive mechanism that humans use to sort out themselves and their fellows, individuality and collectivity” (14), so that “all human identities are, by definition, *social* identities,” insofar as this sorting involves the application of categories of similarity and difference (18). Allison Weir (2013) highlights a corollary of such considerations, noting that identity necessarily involves “shaping and creating a ‘we’” (71), recognition of which directly contradicts Lilla’s (2017b) insistence that appeals to identity necessarily call into question any shared sense of “we” (30).

None of this is to deny individual identities’ visceral, affective, deeply felt reality. But it is to deny that such identities could somehow be theorized or understood in abstraction or isolation from the processes of social life or dynamics of *habitus* (Bourdieu 1990, 53; 1977, 72) that give rise to them. As Jenkins (2014) states the issue, “individual identity—embodied in selfhood—is not a meaningful proposition in isolation from the human world of other people” (42). Identity, he suggests, “is never unilateral,” so that, contrary to Lilla’s “Facebook” conception, “it is not enough simply to assert an identity; that assertion must also be validated, or not, by those with whom we have dealings” (44).

Jenkins (2014) provides two pairs of critical concepts for expressing the dynamics of the “internal-external dialectics of identification” (42–43), or the interplay of individual and group as it relates to identity. The first is the pairing of “category” and “group,” two ways of understanding collectivities,

representing “different ways of looking at interaction, at ‘individuals in co-activity’” (105–106). Categorization represents “collective external definition,” while group identity is the product of “collective internal definition” (107). That is, a category is a collectivity as defined from the “outside” (i.e., by those who are not part of the social group in question) while a group is a collectivity as defined from the “inside” (i.e., by those who recognize themselves as part of the social group in question). Groups therefore name collectivities in which “members ... can identify themselves as such: they know who (and what) they are,” while categories name collectivities in which “members may be ignorant of their membership or even of the collectivity’s existence” (106).

Groups and categories may relate to each other in a variety of ways, which could be mapped on a spectrum. At one end would be a perfect coincidence of group and categorical identification: all members of an externally defined collectivity would have a shared sense of belonging to, and identifying with, that collectivity. A simple example of such a collectivity might be the paying members of a country club, insofar as the categorical list of members includes only those who have willingly chosen to belong to the club. The other end of the spectrum would be marked by a total non-coincidence of group and categorical definition. Common examples here might include any number of categorizations used for analytical or social-scientific purposes, which might not correspond to the self-understanding of any individual members (e.g., the majority of White Americans who would likely reject their categorization as Christian nationalists). Most typically, of course, groups and categories would be marked by varying degrees of coincidence, lying between these extremes. One significant element of identification’s internal-external dynamic is that categorical identifications can also serve as the basis for emergent group identifications: “given appropriate circumstances, groups may come to identify themselves as such because of their initial categorization by others” (Jenkins 2014, 112). That is, externally imposed identities may come, over time and through complex processes, to represent the self-understanding and identity of those so categorized, so that the category comes to represent a group.

The result is that collective identities invariably take shape in the interplay between categorization and group identification. As Lawler (2014) suggests, individuals’ ways of living and understanding their own lives are given in terms of the socially constructed identity categories available to them (9). Emphasizing the effect of categorization on individual identity, then, she goes on to note that “people take up notions of ‘identity’ ... and view themselves through the lens of what is socially said and thought about ‘identity,’” so that “knowing something of the group to which we belong, we know ourselves through that knowledge” (18). Drawing again on her notion of self-impersonation (introduced in Chapter 4), this knowledge becomes the basis for individual “impersonation” of group identity (118).

We briefly considered Jenkins’s (2014) second pair of critical concepts, “nominal” and “virtual” identity, in Chapter 4. Nominal identity and virtual identity refer to the distinction between “the *name* and the *experience* of an identity,”

respectively (46). Roughly corresponding to the conceptual dyad of category and group, nominal identity refers to “the label with which the individual *is identified*” (101, emphasis added), while virtual identification “is what a nominal identification means experientially and practically over time, to its bearer” (101), therefore having to do with how an individual *identifies*.¹³ As we saw in our earlier discussion of nationalism, then, the nominal/virtual distinction highlights that individuals and groups may well share the same nominal identification while nevertheless embodying different, even radically divergent, virtual identities. Thus, as Jenkins suggests, “the nominal may be associated with a *plurality of virtualities*,” so that “the same nominal identity produces very different virtual identifications and very different experiences” (Jenkins 2014, 102, 103).¹⁴

When he insists that shared citizenship provided all Americans with a common identification during the Roosevelt Dispensation, Lilla registers his ignorance of the distinction between nominal and virtual identity. His governing presumption throughout the discussion is that specifying shared American citizenship identification tells us all we need to know about the identification of individuals and groups existing under that nominal category. As we have seen, however, there *never was* a universally shared, universally experienced sense of “American-ness” held in common by all US citizens. As we have also seen over the course of the previous two chapters, “American” might have provided a common nominal identification, but radically divergent felt experiences of what it means to be “American” reveal a plurality of virtual American identities.

Lilla’s ideological fantasy of a universally shared sense of American-ness is sustained only through abstraction from all details of concrete historical context and experience. As Jenkins (2014) notes, “the consequences or meaning of any specific nominal identification can vary from context to context over time” (102), and it is therefore only by ignoring such contextual and historical questions that Lilla is able to project a sense of shared citizenship identification onto society as a whole, thereby conflating categorization with group identification and nominal identity with virtual identity. This is why his evasion of definitional issues regarding citizenship, the relationship between citizenship and non-citizenship, and so on are so significant. Such considerations’ insertion into the discussion would immediately reveal the gaps and fissures that exist between nominal citizenship identity and citizenship identification’s diverse virtual expressions and experiences, which political fantasy masks.

Identity and Social Fragmentation

Identity is not the inner homunculus Lilla suggests it is, nor does it operate as the individualistic, Facebook concept he supposes. On the contrary, identity is a necessarily and inherently social concept. Following from this, Lilla’s insistence that appeals to identity foreclose on any shared sense of “we” is also misplaced, which brings us to fuller a consideration of the second issue raised by a civic nationalist critique of identity politics, its purportedly fragmentary effects.

Given the morphologically normative American-national body's fantastical nature, it is clear that identity does not have the fragmentary effects often attributed to it. Yet a significant question remains: if identity is a ubiquitous feature of social life, why does it nevertheless *seem* as if claims to identity do, in fact, unmake an otherwise more unified social body? Given social fantasy's role in veiling the (un)becoming and transmogrification that inherently defines the social body, this amounts to a question concerning the social and political mechanisms sustaining this fantasy. If political fantasy explains why "specific practices and regimes 'grip' subjects" (Glynos and Howarth 2007, 145), we also need to consider the social and political mechanisms through which this is achieved.

The answer to this question lies in the concept of hegemonic articulation.¹⁵ A hegemonic social identity is one in which a *particular*, virtual identification comes to represent a *universal*, nominal identification as such (as when a particular, virtual identification as citizen takes on the social role of representing citizenship as such, without qualification). A hegemonic social identity serves as the norm according to which other virtual identities are measured and evaluated. The concept of normativity is central in this regard, harboring both a "benign" and an "ideological" sense, both of which are at work in the institution and maintenance of a hegemonic social articulation. Expressing this dual sense,

the normal stands differently for what is typical, the unenthusiastic objective average, but it also stands for what has been, good health, and for what shall be, our chosen destiny. That is why the benign and sterile-sounding word 'normal' has become one of the most powerful ideological tools of the twentieth century.

(Jenkins 2014, 199–200)

Social identities' normativity is established and maintained through consequence allocation, whether positive or negative, for ongoing identification with (or contestation of) them (201–203). Because social consequences follow from identification's expression or performance, differences between identities are not simply articulated as neutral, but are invested with differing degrees of value, so that the greater the degree to which an identity expression is experienced as diverging from a hegemonically normative identity expression, the greater the imposition of negative consequences, and vice-versa. As Jenkins suggests, "allocation of consequences is part of the process that generates identification: being deprived of or given access to particular resources is likely to color the sense of what it means to be an X or a Y" (202).

This initiates a process that reinforces hegemonic identities' normativity. As Jenkins (2014) writes, "groups are real if people think they are: they then behave in ways that assume that groups are real and, in so doing, construct that reality: They *realize* it" (13). The leveling of social consequences and the allocation of resources is such as to repeatedly realize the hegemonic identity as socially

normative.¹⁶ Normative identities thereby take on the role of “structuring structures,” to use Bourdieu’s language (1990, 53), predisposing individuals to act in accordance with their experienced normative force, thereby reinforcing their status as normative. Normative identifications therefore act dispositionally in such a way that they are constituted as “a past which survives in the present and tends to perpetuate itself into the future by making itself present in practices structured according to its principles” (Bourdieu 1977, 82). This process describes the social mechanisms through which civic nationalist political fantasy operates. A dispositional sense of the American-national body’s normative shape is thereby enacted and naturalized to such an extent that any departure from that norm unmaking that body is experienced as an existential threat, evoking visceral, dysphoric responses.

In the previous chapter, we suggested that the prototypical real American imagined within Christian nationalism is White, cisgender, heterosexual, supportive of patriarchy (if not actually male), Protestant, English-speaking, and born in the US. We also suggested that most of US history has been defined by a coincidence of American national and civic identity, reflecting the widespread social acceptance their coincidence, as demonstrated in its common legal codification. The result has been a society in which social and political authority is wielded over those who are not perceived to fully embody prototypical American identity by those who are. Christian nationalism emerges as a socially dysphoric attempt to reinforce or reimpose this hierarchically ordered, morphologically normative Christian-national body with prototypical real Americans continuing to wield such political and social authority, while all others rightfully occupy subordinate positions within the national body.

We are now able to see that Lilla’s civic nationalism also represents a dysphoric response to the transmogrified social body. His facile acceptance of the American Creed and projection of liberal, democratic, and egalitarian principles to the origins of the US founding masks the inegalitarian and hierarchically ordered reigning conception of national identity operative not just then, but through much of US history. His historical elisions mask the reality that the social and political gains made by ethnic minorities, the LGBTQ+ community, women, the disabled, and others do not reflect the natural unfolding of American founding principles and the American-national body’s maturation but are the hard-won effects of the American-national body’s constructive unmaking over time. They are the effects of countless queerly democratic actions, expanding the *demos* and revealing the social body’s fundamental queerness.

Despite his liberal pretensions, Lilla’s civic nationalism parallels Christian nationalism in expressing the fantastical, nostalgic desire for a return to a morphologically normative national body that has never existed. To be sure, the American-national body’s imagined morphology is, in Lilla’s civic nationalism, different than within Christian nationalism. But the dysphoric effects are largely the same. Lilla’s fantastical appeal to the Roosevelt Dispensation, to a national body teleologically and naturally maturing into an empirical reflection of

universally held egalitarian principles, actually normalizes the existing, highly unequalitarian social body. The teleology and abstraction of Lilla's civic nationalism amounts to an idealist denial of the actually existing, highly unequalitarian social body's reality. No matter how unequalitarian or hierarchical the existing national body may be, no matter how dominant ascriptive Americanism's role, the existing social body represents only a passing stage of the authentic American-national body's teleological unfolding. This is the inner logic of a civic nationalism insisting that America is *really*, in its essence or at its core, egalitarian, and is only failing to "live up to its principles" or, to repeat Myrdal's (1975) formulation, "struggling for its soul" (4).¹⁷ The civic nationalist's morphologically normative body is, then, never empirically present, but always stands in the future, at a utopian moment when the American Creed's promise will find full empirical embodiment. This future operates like an Aristotelian final cause, drawing the American social body toward its natural fulfilment. Lilla's civic nationalism expresses the same fundamental logic presupposed by the vision of the fully inclusive *demos*, outlined in the second chapter: given enough time, the egalitarian social body will come to be through its natural, organic development.

Herein lies the specifically dysphoric nature of Lilla's civic nationalism: any unmaking of the existing American social body can only interrupt its teleological unfolding and must therefore be countered and opposed. Acts of unmaking threaten to reveal the fantasy underlying civic nationalism—they threaten to reveal the social body's fundamental queerness, to reveal that its existing morphology is merely a contingent historical fact, rather than a stage in its teleological unfolding. The ironic effect is that the egalitarian civic nationalist ideology can be maintained only by opposing the acts of queer democracy that aim to expand the *demos* in the here-and-now. Every bit as much as Christian nationalism, then, Lilla's civic nationalism represents a dysphoric reaction to the queer social body.

In this regard, it is almost impossible to overstate the significance that the targets of Lilla's purportedly progressive civic nationalism—feminists, BLM, queer activism, to name just a few—are indistinguishable from Christian nationalism's targets. Despite their purportedly divergent political aims, Christian nationalism and Lilla's civic nationalism represent dysphoric responses triggered by the same social and political efforts to unmake the currently existing social body. Both are responses articulated in opposition to queer democracy, the *demos*'s expansion, and a morphologically fluid social body. If theoretical and historical considerations were not sufficient to disqualify Lilla's civic nationalism, the fact that it is, in actual practice, virtually indistinguishable from Christian nationalism would be.

Identity Politics as Queer Democracy

Lilla advances the liberal civic nationalist critique that identity and identity politics fragment the social body. As we have seen, this is incorrect (or, more properly, nonsensical) insofar as the question of identity politics' socially fragmentary effects

is based on the fantastical premise of the morphologically normative social body. Indeed, the socially dysphoric nature of Lilla's entire proposal owes to his adherence to this fantasy.

But Lilla also argues that identity is inherently depoliticizing, so that "identity politics" would be something of a misnomer. Lilla dismisses identity politics as a depoliticizing retreat from the public sphere of meaningful political engagement and argument into the citadel of private (or, at most, group) preference. On this account, identity politics represents a political abdication. But, as we have seen, this dismissal is only convincing if one accepts Lilla's institutional and procedural reduction of politics and his individualistic, homuncular conception of identity. We have seen that the latter of these assumption does not hold: identity may be vitally personal, but it is never private or individual in nature. It is, rather, an inherently social phenomenon.

In Chapter 2 we considered a conception of queer democracy, naming dissensual political and social practice that takes shape around the *demos's* active (un)becoming as novel social identities take shape within the social body. Here, I want to consider identity politics as an expression of queer democracy. Far from a depoliticizing retreat into the merely personal, identity politics is an irreducibly and viscerally political development, representing the social body's hyper-politicization. To say that identity's social constitution is achieved and maintained through consequence assignment and resource allocation is also to say that identification is an irreducibly political process (Rattansi 2007, 116; Jenkins 2014, 45). Consistent with our previous discussion of queer democracy, this involves a conception of politics as a much more visceral, ubiquitous social dimension than allowed by Lilla and liberal critics of identity politics more generally. Viewed from this perspective, identity politics cannot be apolitical, insofar as the political represents the basis for the social body's constitution (see Mouffe 2005, 8–9).

To understand the dynamics of identity politics and its significance as a queerly democratic expression, it is helpful to revisit the notion of group identity. Awareness that group identity, like individual identity, is best understood as an ongoing process, rather than a static "object" or possession (Lawler 2014, 2) provides a guard against group identity's "spatialization." That is, rather than understanding groups' reality or objectivity as lying in their occupation of social "spaces," their "objectivity" is provided by members' shared sense of "groupness" (Jenkins 2014, 9–10), which is an effect of identification dynamics. The same points we have highlighted with regard to nations and the populist people apply to group identities more broadly: social groups *are*, or exist, only insofar as members continue to identify with them and recognize themselves as members. This is why identity must be understood as processual: identification can never be static or fixed because "indeterminacy, ambiguity and paradox are part of the normal pattern of everyday life" (10), requiring ongoing, active renewals or reconfigurations of identification.

Identification is driven by perceptions of similarity and difference: groups are defined by their individual members' perceived similarities, on the one hand, and

the perceived differences/similarities between their group (with its individual members) and other groups (with their individual members), on the other (Jenkins 2014, 19).¹⁸ This interplay of similarity and difference highlights the co-constitution of individual and group identity. Individuals' senses of self develop in relation to their perceived similarity with individuals with whom they share a group identity, and in relation to their perceived differences from others (Jenkins 2014, 39–40). Thus, groups provide the “public-images” (44) which individuals then “impersonate” in their articulation of their individual identities (Lawler 2014, 118). In terms of identity, individuals and groups are therefore co-constituting: without shared perceptions of similarity on the part of individuals, there would be no basis for shared group identity, but without a sense of group identity, providing public-images available for “impersonation” by individuals, there would be no similarities to perceive on the part of individuals.

The dynamics of co-constitution once again highlight identity's irreducibly social nature. This reinforces Jenkins (2014) point that identity “is never unilateral.” Rather, “we identify others and are identified by them in turn,” “seek [ing] to be—and to be ‘seen to be’— ‘something’ or ‘somebody’” (44). The dynamics of our “seeking to be ‘seen to be’” by others and our own, reciprocal “seeing to be” of them reveal the full significance of consequences and resource allocation in relation to identification. There are social costs and benefits, for both individuals and groups, of individuals' identification or disidentification with groups and for groups' recognition or non-recognition of individuals (Lawler 2014, 11–12). Identity is never a matter of difference or similarity abstractly considered, but of differences or similarities *that matter*, which is to say, of difference or similarities expressing a defining salience for relevant identities' maintenance and experience.

The consequences attending different identifications are a crucial component in the structuring of this salience. Thus, similarities or differences that seem natural or innate are often the product of “discriminatory processes that establish some identities as more or less valuable than others” (Lawler 2014, 13). The distinctions that define different identities are therefore “not simply ‘there’; they are not ‘given in nature’ but need to be *made*” (12). Following from this, “not only ... are all identities relational, but all are produced within systems of inequality” (14), which is to say, within systems of differential resource and consequence allocation. Extending this critical point further, Lawler later suggests that “social differences ... become social *divisions* only because of power relations in which groups marked by these differences exist in relations of inequality” (161). Individual and group identifications, then, are never neutral acts, but are invested with differing degrees of social value. As Jenkins (2014) suggests, “it is the capacity to generate those consequences” that determines which identifications “stick” (45).

These considerations highlight how simplistic and reductive Lilla's presentation of identity is. Contrary to his individualized and depoliticized understanding of identity, the social nature identity and the dynamics of consequence and resource

allocation reveal identity to be irreducibly political in nature. “Political,” in the sense I am using it here, is not a reference to the state, political parties, explicit political ideologies, and the like. Rather, the political has to do with questions of the institution and ordering of society as such (Laclau 1990, 34; Glynos and Howarth 2007, 117). Taken in this sense, as Chantal Mouffe (2000) suggests, “any social objectivity [e.g., an individual or group identity] is ultimately political,” insofar as it is constituted by “acts of exclusion” (21). To suggest that identity is political in this sense is to situate it as a fundamental category in social ontology (see Glynos and Howarth 2007, 114), meaning that identity is a fundamental social structure.

But identity is also “political” in the more colloquial, everyday sense of this term. That is, the dynamics structuring identity are also operative at the level of political states, parties, institutions, procedures, and so on, where issues of differential consequence and resource allocation are integrally related to questions of social categorization. Legal protections, legislation, government policies, and so forth, at all governmental levels, have fundamentally to do with the allocation of consequences and resources on the basis of externally imposed, categorical identifications. Indeed, given the saturation of human life by the contemporary state, the list of resources and consequences involved is pervasive (see Critchley 2007, 113; Wolin 2008, 88–90).¹⁹ Who will be allowed to vote? Who will be taxed, and to what extent? How will the government allocate those tax revenues? Who will be allowed to marry? Are there such things as “public goods” and, if so, who is entitled to them? Should workers be protected from dangerous or excessive working conditions? If so, *which* workers and *what* conditions will be included? And on and on and on. Concrete answers to these questions (and concrete answers to these questions *are* given) necessarily involve social and political categorization practices of and procedures. Indeed, there would be no modern administrative state apart from the processes and mechanisms necessary for such categorization and its resulting consequence and resource allocation. Further, insofar as a wide range of these issues have fundamentally to do with citizenship status, together with questions of the obligations and entitlements that attend it, these considerations highlight yet another reason why Lilla’s abstract appeal to citizenship is evasive and simplistic.²⁰

Consequence and resource allocation dynamics bring us back to the complex interplay between categorical and group identifications, introduced above. Frequently, those categorized in some way by the state recognize themselves in that categorization, in which case there is a coincidence of categorical and group identity. Consequences represent a significance basis for such coincidence: positively stated, individuals are more likely to identify with the externally imposed categorization if it is in their interests to do so. This point is key, insofar as a common critique of identity politics is that it leads individuals to act “against their interests.” Such a critique, however, reflects a misunderstanding of the relation of interests and identity. As suggested in Chapter 4, interests and identity are

integrally related. As Jenkins (2014) suggests: “how I identify myself has a bearing on how I identify my interests” (8). To speak of interests is, necessarily, even if only implicitly, to speak of identity.

Thus, the allocation of concrete consequences and resources attending political and social categorization creates interests on the part of those categorized which, in turn, incentivize identification with the resulting categories: perceived positive consequence and resource allocation create an interest in identifying with the categorization, and this identification, in turn, gives rise to a group identity coincident with that category. Ongoing interest and identity co-constitution is therefore centrally important. While individuals identify with external categorization on the basis of perceived consequence and resource allocation, ongoing acts of identification, in turn, constitute those allocation patterns as being “in the interest of” the individuals in question, thereby reinforcing identification patterns. Categorization consequences only operate as interests if they are perceived to be, *felt* to be, interests by those subject to categorization. In this sense, appeal to “objective interests” absent individuals’ identification with those interests is nonsensical.

But group identification also takes a negative or privative form, arising from *negative* consequence assignment or the withholding of resources based on categorization. Every politically or socially consequential categorization not only defines which individuals are recognized as belonging within a political/social/legal category, but also defines, whether implicitly or explicitly, which individuals are *excluded from* that category, and every decision to allocate resources on a categorical basis is also a decision *not* to allocate those resources to those who are not categorized as legitimate recipients, producing a system of inequality. This is the concrete expression of Lawler’s point that “differences ... establish some identities as more or less valuable than others” (2014, 13). This dynamic yields an oppositional sense of group identity, according to which it is *not* perceived as being in group members’ interests to identify with other social groups, with governing authorities who regulate consequence and resource allocation, and so on. This is the social site for the emergence of identity politics as conventionally understood.

While identities are always shaped, at least in part, in response to inequalities in resource/consequence allocation, however, this fact alone does not account for the emergence of the politically salient identities expressed in identity politics. Laclau and Mouffe’s (2001) distinction between relations of subordination and relations of oppression provides a crucial missing element in this regard. A relation of subordination is one in which “an agent is subjected to the decisions of another,” while a relation of oppression is one in which relations of subordination have “transformed themselves into sites of antagonisms” (153–154). While the social, at any given time, takes shape around a plethora of identifications which are differentially valued (i.e., unequally structured), most do not result in antagonism or political contestation, insofar as such inequalities are constituted as natural, valid, or otherwise legitimate.

Identities emerge as salient political forces, on the other hand, when these inequalities *cease to be* experienced as natural or legitimate. This shift transforms merely subordinate relations into relations of oppression, as experienced by the social groups in question. It is then, as Lawler (2014) suggests, that identity politics takes shape as a demand on the part of one group for parity in consequence and resource allocation (164). Identity politics takes shape as group members participate in dissensual practices, demanding the equality presently denied them. Contrary to Lilla's claims, there is nothing depoliticizing about such identities' emergence within the social. On the contrary, identity politics is hyper-politicizing, insofar as it embodies the desire to extend liberty and equality more and more broadly within the social body. Understood in these terms, identity politics is queer democracy in action. Reflecting back on Lilla's dismissal of the slogan that "the personal is political," we can see that identity politics is not politics' reduction to self-expression, but is, rather, a contestation of the line between personal and political, public and private and the categorical exclusions it legitimizes. The phrase means precisely what Lilla (2017b) suggests it originally meant: "everything that seems personal is in fact political [and] ... there are no spheres of life exempt from the struggle for power" (75). Identity politics represents the social body's constructive unmaking, revealing its morphology's contingency, fluidity, and fundamental queerness, allowing for novel social identities' emergence and the *demos's* expansion.

Expressing identification's inherently social nature, identity politics virtually always takes shape in the context of externally imposed categorizations. Rather than expressing individualistic preferences or desires, then, the identities expressed in identity politics take shape as a reaction to categorical marginalization. As queer democratic practice, identity politics, in its diverse forms, represents the reaction of the marginalized who demand a place within the *demos*, which necessarily involves the social body's unmaking. As such, they represent social body members who refuse to remain within their appointed places, provoking the dysphoric response evident in Lilla's civic nationalism.

BLM offers a vivid illustration of these points. As we have seen, Lilla (2017b) castigates the movement as a hindrance to solidarity (129). In sharp contrast to this dismissive evaluation, however, we can see that BLM emerged as it became increasingly clear, most acutely due to the concrete actions of police officers on multiple occasions, that different social and political consequences, as well as the denial of key social and political resources, accrue to Black, most specifically Black male, identification. That is, it became clear that unarmed Black men, as a category, do not experience the same concrete consequence or resource allocation (for example, to use Lilla's example, equal protection under the law) as members of other social categories, most notably unarmed White men. It is due to such very concrete, very social categorization consequences that BLM emerged.

It is not difficult to identify additional illustrations of this process. TGNC identity affirmation, far from representing a contemporary "totem," as Lilla

(2017b) suggests (91), takes shape as a potent political force only as a response to TGNC individuals' treatment as an externally imposed category (see Chapters 1 and 4 for examples of this). Had TGNC people simply been included under Title IX protection (a positive consequence of categorical identification), for example, the TGNC community would not have taken shape as the political force it has increasingly become; indeed, the widely shared group consciousness of a TGNC "community" might not have arisen at all. Had women in multiple walks of life, to give another example, not experienced routine sexual assault and discrimination, therefore being denied the resources and protections afforded to those who abused them with impunity, there would be no #MeToo movement.²¹

Examples such as these make clear why so many contemporary identitarian social and political movements have their origins in marginalizing racial (e.g., various racial or ethnic identifications), misogynistic (e.g., various articulations of feminist identifications), or medical and mental health (e.g., various LGBTQ+ identifications) categorizations. Such movements are not, as Lilla's civic nationalism tacitly presumes, expressions of the liberal essence of the American-national body's teleological unfolding. Rather, they emerge as a result of context and myriad contingent historical and political circumstances. This is why, as we saw in the second chapter, such movement emerge unforeseeably within the social, expressing the *demos's* constitutive incompleteness and the social body's transmodification. To the degree that some of these movements achieve significant political and social gains, effectively reshaping the social body, they can retroactively achieve a misleading sense of inevitability or necessity. These dynamics are what lead Lilla to suppose, mistakenly, that such movements represent the morphologically normative civic nationalist body's affirmation, when in fact they are expressions of the social body's fundamental queerness.

Conclusion

On the face of it, Lilla's civic nationalist account would seem to diverge radically from the Christian nationalism we considered in the previous chapter. Indeed, the 2016 election of Donald Trump as president, driven in large measure by Christian nationalist support, was one of the primary motivations for Lilla's publication of *The Once and Future Liberal*. And, to be sure, the implicit real-American prototype to which each nationalist expression appeals are decidedly different. Within the Christian nationalist imaginary, the prototypical American is White, cisgender, heterosexual, supportive of patriarchy (if not actually male), Protestant, English-speaking, and born in the US. Within Lilla's civic nationalist imaginary, there is *no* prototypical American, insofar as prototypicality has to do with such ascriptive identifying markers. Rather, shared American identity is not constituted by ascriptive features, but by shared civic identity: "real" Americans are nothing other than US citizens. Civic and national identity merge in a form that is, in

principle, universally accessible to all, irrespective of any particular or ascriptive identity markers. The basis for common American identity is a shared creed or “catechism” in core civic and political values.

And yet, despite these differences, Lilla’s civic nationalism is, in crucial and defining ways, formally indistinguishable from Christian nationalism. Most notably, his civic nationalism mirrors Christian nationalism in its expression of a disposition to proper social order and structure. This disposition is effectively captured by the social-as-body metaphor, making it a productive resource for analyzing Lilla’s civic nationalism, even if he does not explicitly appeal to the notion of the social body or the “body politic.” As Žižek (1989) suggests, the social-as-body metaphor, which is to say, “the corporatist vision of Society as an organic Whole, a social Body in which the different classes are like extremities, members each contributing to the Whole according to its function,” remains the “fundamental ideological fantasy” operative today (126). Lilla’s visceral reaction against social and political movements that disrupt social order reveals Lilla’s civic nationalism to be structured around precisely this “ideological fantasy,” the same ideological fantasy that structures Christian nationalism.

Understood in these terms, Lilla’s civic nationalism expresses a desire for a morphologically normative American-national body, the normative contours of which are achieved as its members remain in their proper places, playing their proper roles in its teleological maturation. It is as a dysphoric reaction to the queer social body that Lilla’s civic nationalism reveals itself to be formally indistinguishable from Christian nationalism. Not only do both of these nationalisms express the desire for the morphologically normative American-national body, and not only do both emerge as dysphoric responses to the queer American social body, but both dysphoric responses are triggered by many of the same social body members. In their common opposition to feminists, to contemporary Black activism, to demands for equality on the part of the LGBTQ+ community, civic and Christian nationalism express a shared opposition to the unmaking of an American social body, the normative morphology of which requires the subordination of members of these and other groups.

Insofar as dissensual political practice on the part of those who identify with such groups represents queer democracy in action, Lilla’s civic nationalism, in its opposition to them, is no less anti-democratic than Christian nationalism. This anti-democratic orientation is even more pernicious in the case of Lilla’s civic nationalism precisely because he expressly advances it in the name of democracy, rather than advocating the majoritarianism we find in Christian nationalism. If the theoretical and historical reasons for rejecting Lilla’s civic nationalism were not compelling, the anti-democratic orientation it shares with Christian nationalism, their common targeting of those who are marginalized and subordinated within the American social body, would still represent reason enough to reject it.

Notes

- 1 It is, of course, worth noting that many have advocated precisely the opposite position since the 2016 presidential election as well. For a small sampling, see Goldberg 2016; Johnson 2016; Yglesias 2016; Bailey 2017; McElwee 2018.
- 2 Smith (1997) suggests that, over the course of his historical analysis, Myrdal's own findings systematically undermined his argument's opening assertions (23–24).
- 3 The notion of progress plays a contradictory role in Lilla's text. On the one hand, he chides liberals for what he sees as a naïve faith in progress, which has blinded them to their political peril (Lilla 2017b, 106). On the other hand, however, he tacitly appeals to liberalism's progressive nature throughout his presentation of the "Roosevelt Dispensation," as we shall see.
- 4 The prophetic tone of Lilla's text is unmistakable. The text has no notes, references, or bibliography. Despite his repeated criticism of liberal identity-theorists' failure to engage in reasoned or sustained dialogue with alternative viewpoints or interlocutors (e.g., Lilla 2017b, 90, 91), Lilla does not engage any other thinkers or positions in his text. Rather, the text as a whole is presented as coming from one of absolute authority, descending from his (academic) mountain to deliver the truth to the masses (or at least readers of the *New York Times* and NPR listeners). With the adoption of this approach, of course, Lilla enacts precisely the elitism of which he is otherwise so critical.
- 5 We will revisit this issue of identities that are first imposed externally, but which become the basis of a social group's self-understanding, later in the chapter. It is worth noting that this account will undermine the tacit and simplistic opposition between authentic and imposed identity on which Lilla's account relies here.
- 6 In this criticism of BLM, Lilla echoes the earlier criticisms leveled at appeals to ethnicity by Arthur Schlesinger. In the Foreword to the enlarged edition of his *Disuniting of America*, Schlesinger (1998) also gives voice to the "some good came from the movement, but they took it too far" logic deployed by Lilla. Thus, "the eruption of ethnicity had many good consequences," but "pressed too far, the cult of ethnicity has had bad consequences too. The new ethnic gospel rejects the unifying vision of individuals from all nations melted into a new race" (20). Like Lilla, he views "multiculturalism" as threat to the integrity of organic social body: "The militants of ethnicity contend that a main objective of public education should be the protection, strengthening, celebration, and perpetuation of ethnic origins and identities. Separatism, however, nourishes prejudices, magnifies differences, and stirs antagonisms" (22). All such responses (and in this form Lilla's statements are effectively indistinguishable from those leveled on the political right) follow a strategy effectively outlined by Theoharis (2018): "Excessive behavior (anger and recklessness, and refusal to behave respectably or to use proper methods for expressing grievances) by a new generation of Black people is ... cast as the cause of many current problems, and such behavior must be checked and challenged to maintain this noble [liberal] progress" (xxi). Lilla's suggestion that BLM "puts down dissent" is more than ironic, given the origins of the movement and the backlash against it. In addition, in presenting the movement as simply socially divisive, he overlooks the diversity within the movement, which includes an array of Black identities (Bonilla-Silva 2018, 233). As Bonilla-Silva also notes, "the phrase 'Black Lives Matter' was coined by three Black women, all of whom identify as queer, and the three other most prominent figures have been two Black women and a gay Black man" (234). Here, as elsewhere, Lilla projects homogeneity onto a diverse movement, all in the service of accusing that movement of enforcing conformity and homogeneity.
- 7 Theoharis notes that figures like Rosa Parks and Martin Luther King, Jr. "have been turned into Thanksgiving parade balloons—floating above us larger than life; unthreatening, happy patriots" (Theoharis 2018, xix).

- 8 The superficiality, condescension, and trivializing nature of Lilla's treatment of BLM is also worth noting in this regard and is on clear display in his reference to their concern for countering "police mistreatment" of African Americans. "Mistreatment" seems a particularly anodyne descriptor for the all-too-common extra-judicial killing of unarmed Black men by White police officers, the vast majority of whom never face criminal charges, let alone convictions, for their actions.
- 9 This feature is determinative of Lilla's text. He offers no concrete historical evidence to support his points, he does not engage with other thinkers, and he provides no critical apparatus for his book. The book is a manifesto, resting only on Lilla's own implicit claims to authority.
- 10 As with so many points in his book, there is a deep ambivalence in Lilla's presentation of the academy. On the one hand, it is the ideological breeding ground of the liberal, coastal elites who are out of touch with the vast majority of Americans. At the same time, however, given the pervasive and pernicious effects Lilla ascribed to identity politics, the academy seems to have an outsized, disproportionate influence. Additionally, Lilla's condemnation of the academy as the site of identity production does not account for the political expression of movements like BLM, one of his favorite targets, which *did not* originate in the academy or flow from rarefied academic discourse.
- 11 It is worth noting that despite his nostalgic appeal to shared national identity's supposed universality within the Roosevelt Dispensation, Lilla's concern here seems only to be the liberal left's unity, a particular segment of the US population, implicitly undermining his own appeal to the American-national body's unity.
- 12 This emphasis on identity as a process or activity has also become influential within social psychology. See Halloran and Kashima 2006, 140; Moghaddam 2006, 167; Postmes et al. 2006, 230.
- 13 It is important to note here that "virtual" in no way implies that experienced identifications are somehow unreal or illusory. On the contrary, Jenkins notes that he applies "virtual" in its most literal, dictionary definition as "something that exists for practical purposes rather than in name or by definition" (Jenkins 2014, 101).
- 14 This point also relates to the notion of contingent universality, discussed above and in Chapter 3.
- 15 The discussion that follows draws heavily on the political ontology I develop in Miller 2016, particularly Ch. 4. In political-theoretical terms, that discussion is most influenced by Ernesto Laclau's theory of hegemony, developed in collaboration with Chantal Mouffe. See Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe 1987 and 2001; Ernesto Laclau 1990, 1996, 2000a, 2000b, 2000c.
- 16 Because resource allocation is, to my mind, one of the most significant dimensions of consequence assignation, I couple resources and consequences in the discussion that follows, though the latter is a broader category than the former.
- 17 This civic nationalist logic finds popular expression when, in response regressive social or political policies and practices (e.g., implementation of the Trump administration's "family separation" policy), individuals claim that "this is not who we are" as a country. While perhaps well-intentioned, such statement tacitly presupposes an essential inner logic teleologically expressing itself in the American-national body's ongoing development.
- 18 Jenkins offers a significant critique of what he terms the "difference paradigm," according to which identity represents only "sameness," so that any meaningful assertion of difference must be a *rejection* of identity. While I would take issue with some of the finer points of his analysis, it is convincing overall, and he raises several important points (Jenkins 2014, 20–22). For similar points see Alcoff 2006, 47–49 and Weir 2013, 5–11.
- 19 Consequence and resource allocation obviously extends to social spheres beyond the state and its attendant actors and institutions, taking on myriad additional forms. Examples, which are often less tangible and more difficult to quantify, include such things as hiring practices, "discomfort" with members of out-groups, etc.

- 20 While we have considered this point with regard to Lilla's treatment of citizenship, his appeal to the concept of equal protection under the law provides another vivid illustration. He suggests that the principle, apart from any further conception of identity, is sufficient to guarantee citizens' rights. He writes, "equal protection under the law is not a hard principle to convince Americans of. The difficulty comes in persuading them that it has been violated in particular cases ..." (Lilla 2017b, 128). But Lilla, again, misses the crucial issue: everyone can agree on the value of the equal protection principle is precisely *because* it remains abstract and ill-defined. Disagreement about equal protection's scope cuts deeper than Lilla suggests. Those who oppose the political demands made by groups in the name of "equal protection" do not do so by denying the principle. Rather, they deny the standing of those leveling the claims. This, in turn, is an issue that has fundamentally to do with identity. In denying standing, a group in power (or a court) is denying the legitimacy of the collectivity in question. They are categorizing political dissenters or legal claimants as *not* a part of the collectivity protected under the law. This amounts to the hegemonic social identity's reinforcement through the exclusion of alternative identities which are performatively defined, through this very exclusion, as non-normative. And, to repeat this crucial point, all of this takes place *without a denial of the equal protection principle*. In suggesting that simple appeal to the principle is sufficient or socially unitive, then, Lilla overlooks such concepts' actual social and political functioning and their integral relation to questions of identity and social categorization.
- 21 This is not, of course, to suggest that there are not further shortcomings to be addressed with the #MeToo movement. There are significant questions regarding whether or not the movement can or will have an effect for women who are not wealthy, powerful, White, cisgender celebrities (see Fagin 2017; Dastagir 2018). The cause of such concerns was on poignant display, for example, when actress Rose McGowan, speaking at an event about her own #MeToo experience, dismissed concerns raised by a trans woman, who correctly noted that trans women are statistically at much higher risk for experiencing sexual assault than are cisgender women. McGowan's dismissive response was that "we are the same. My point was, we are the same. There is an entire show called ID channel, a network, dedicated to women getting abused, murdered, sexualized, violated, and you're a part of that, too, sister. It's the same" (Harrison 2018). It is possible to affirm the experience of all women represented within the #MeToo movement *while at the same time* recognizing that not all women are at equal risk for sexual assault, and that not all women have the same social capacity to bring sexual abuse to light. McGowan's transphobic rant following the encounter vividly illustrates the ways in which hegemonically privileged identities are maintained through the exclusion of marginalized identities, as a follow-up interview with the woman who confronted McGowan makes clear (Burns 2018; see also Valens 2018). McGowan's appeals to "sameness" further marginalizes trans women, thereby reinforcing cisgender women's normalization as "real" or "authentic" women. Trans women's negative reaction to such acts cannot be reduced, as Lilla suggests, to expressions of mere personal identity or preference.

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CONCLUSION

As we saw in Chapter 1, Valerio Fabbrizi (2018) argues that the “liberal theory of democratic representative sovereignty” has replaced the idea of the body politic (17). As I suggested there, this assertion may be correct if we think in terms of explicit invocations of the social-as-body metaphor. However, if we understand the metaphor in dispositional terms, as effectively expressing the desire for proper social order, for the maintenance of the social body’s normative morphology, Fabbrizi is incorrect. Understood in dispositional terms, the social-as-body metaphor remains, as Slavoj Žižek (1989) suggests, “the fundamental ideological fantasy” (126).

The discussion of the preceding chapters has borne this out. Even within the context of contemporary American nationalism and populism, the social-as-body metaphor effectively brings into view the disposition to proper social order these phenomena express. One of the most striking patterns emerging from the foregoing discussion is the historical continuity of the political disposition expressed in the social-as-body metaphor. From the metaphor’s Western origins in the concord speeches of the pre-Christian Stoics, to the medieval emphasis on *tranquilitas*, through the social contract theories of Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau, up to contemporary American neoliberal managed democracy, populism, and nationalism, the social-as-body metaphor has consistently expressed the social and political disposition to proper, almost inevitably hierarchical, social order. Within the social and political imaginary structured by this dispositional logic, a body with members out of their proper places is a body pathologically disfigured, evoking visceral efforts to reimpose proper order. The specific members of the social body and the specifics of its normative morphology vary with context, of course, but the fundamental logic remains consistent.

The social and political effects also remain consistent: the suppression of any action on the part of individuals or groups within the social body threatening to unmake its normative morphology. Across its expressions, the social order imagined within the logic of the social-as-body metaphor is fundamentally anti-democratic. Proper social order cannot accommodate the unmaking of the social body that inevitably accompanies democratic social and political action. Squaring the circle of affirming democracy and ensuring proper social order can only be achieved by reducing democracy to its institutional or procedural dimensions, to what Margaret Canovan (1999) describes as its “pragmatic face” (11), a reduction that easily devolves into neoliberal managed democracy or populist/nationalist majoritarianism, as we have seen.

But, as Žižek (1989) suggests, and our consideration of trans-theoretical considerations of embodiment confirm, the morphologically normative body presupposed in the traditional social-as-body metaphor is a fantasy, a body that has never existed. The social body, like all bodies, is queer, morphologically fluid, with no fixed shape. This is the sense in which Žižek is correct when he argues that the social is a “void” and that masking this reality is fantasy’s ideological function (126). I have described the political practice that flows out of an affirmation of the queer social body, expressing a disposition toward the emergence of a social body with novel morphological forms, rather than the imposition of social order, as “queer democracy.” Rather than representing threats to be overcome, the queer social body and the accompanying incompleteness of the *demos* are the conditions of possibility for expanding the *demos* through the extension of liberty and equality to broader and broader social domains. Such expansion evokes socially and politically dysphoric responses precisely because it unmakes the existing social order, revealing the productive void at its heart, traversing the fantasy of the morphologically normative social body.

These considerations highlight a vital question: given the historical continuity of the desire for social order expressed in the social-as-body metaphor, what are the prospects for queer democracy? It is clear that queer democracy highlights the tensive, even paradoxical, nature of democracy. Drawing again on Canovan’s (1999) typology, queer democracy represents an expression of the “redemptive face” of democracy (11). Its productive force and energy cannot be reduced to a fixed and regulated set of institutions and procedures, even if these are necessary for both its emergence and sustenance. This is the sense in which, as we saw in Chapter 2, the emergent *demos* has no “place” within the formally democratic state: in both its constitutive incompleteness and ongoing expansion, it necessarily unmakes and overflows the bounds of proceduralism and institutionalization.

At the same time, however, queer democracy is always threatened by its own success. The redemptive expression of democracy, if it is to have lasting concrete effects, necessarily requires a measure of the very institutionalization and proceduralism it resists. Every expansion of the *demos*, every remaking of the social body to give a place to those formerly excluded from it or marginalized within it

comes with the temptation to take that new, morphologically emergent social body as normative. Queer democracy is therefore threatened, as Wolin (2004) suggests, with the reduction of politics to process (601). Queer democracy's success is necessarily accompanied by the threat of its own disappearance.

Applying Wolin's (2004) phrasing to queer democracy, we can say that it is "an ephemeral phenomenon rather than a settled system" (602): it can never represent a structured program or policy, and it often disappears by the time we can register our recognition of it. Queer democracy is "necessarily episodic and circumstantial" (604); it is a "fugitive" phenomenon (see Wolin 1996). Like the political agents who give expression to it, then, queer democracy takes shape in unforeseeable and unanticipated ways. But queer democracy *does* emerge in its ephemeral, fugitive way, reshaping the social body and the pragmatic institutions and procedures that also structure democracy. Widespread and long-lasting protests against police brutality and the murder and mistreatment of people of color in 2020, which provided the backdrop for the completion of much of this project, represent one potent expression of queer democracy. While it remains unclear what the end results of this will be or what changes of lasting significance might follow from them, it is clear that there is greater, and more diverse, social buy-in to these protests and direct actions than there has been in the past. These protests have been accompanied by a related renewal of efforts to acknowledge America's racist founding on the related foundations of settler colonialism, slavery, and emergent global capitalism. As with the protests, we see greater popular support for such efforts, as evidenced by increasing popular support for the removal of Confederate monuments and increasing recognition of the realities of American racial history. Such shifts represent the expansion of the *demos*, holding the promise that such democratic action can, in fact, reshape the social body. Such shifts also occur in more institutional, formalized contexts. To this point, I again note the 2020 Supreme Court decision (*Bostock v. Clayton*) determining that Title VII of the 1964 Civil Rights Act protects LGBTQ+ individuals from employment discrimination. Standing behind this decision, which renders numerous existing institutions and procedures more democratic, are generations of activists fighting for the inclusion of LGBTQ+ individuals' place within the *demos*, expressions "queer democracy" in a dual sense. And while these represent highly visible examples of queer democracy in practice, queer democracy is also emergent in the practices of ordinary people acting in myriad ways across diverse contexts every day.

The affirmation of the queer social body does not inaugurate utopia. Queer democracy brings with it no guarantees. And it plays against the stacked deck of the disposition to social order, expressed in the complex institutional, procedural, and economic force of neoliberal managed democracy, in contemporary Christian nationalism, and in liberal civic nationalism. The socially dysphoric response to queer democracy has been all too evident in the law enforcement response to social justice protests and, in early 2021, in the insurrection of thousands who

stormed the US Capitol in an effort to deny the legitimacy of the outcome of the world's most visible democratic election. Yet, despite such reactions, queer democracy resolutely emerges within the social, stubbornly continuing to unmake the social body and expressing the promise that continues to resonate within democracy. And looking back over American history, we can see that, despite all efforts to impose proper order and maintain the presumptively "natural," and therefore normative, social order, queer democracy has had profound effects, transmogrifying the social body. Viewed from the nostalgic disposition to a normative social order grounded in the mythical American past, queer democracy continues to render the social body monstrous or grotesque. Informed by the recognition of the queer social body, however, we see that the monstrous is beautiful, expressing the fluidity of the continually emergent *demos*.

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INDEX

- Alcoff, Linda Martín 213, 214, 231, 248
 Althusser, Louis 28, 136
 American Creed 9, 171, 216, 231, 238, 239; *see also* civic nationalism
amour de soi 118; *see also* Rousseau, Jean-Jacques
amour propre 118, 120, 129; *see also* Rousseau, Jean-Jacques
 anti-elitism 135, 137, 138, 139, 140, 142, 145; *see also* populist people, the
 anti-pluralism 8, 79, 137, 138, 139, 141, 142, 143, 148, 149, 159, 161, 201; *see also* pluralism; populist people, the
 apophaticism 75, 76, 77, 80
 Ardit, Benjamin 79n15, 135, 140, 142, 143, 144, 145, 147, 149, 200
 Arbery, Ahmaud 2
 Atwood, Margaret 197
- bathroom bills 193, 194; *see also* trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC) bodies
 Bettcher, Talia Mae 6, 33, 34, 35, 45, 46, 67, 94, 149, 170, 192, 228
 Bodin, Jean 25
 Bonilla-Silva, Eduardo 196, 247
 Bourdieu, Pierre 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 37, 44, 46, 54, 60, 65, 68, 115, 122, 190, 234, 238 *see also* dispositions; *habitus*
 Black Lives Matter 76, 220, 221, 222, 223, 224, 225, 239, 244, 247, 248
 Black Nationalism 225; *see also* civil rights movement
- Body of Christ 16, 19, 20: Church as 15, 17, 18, 19, 20; Eucharist as 19; Jesus of Nazareth as 19; as metaphor 20; and social body 20; *see also* *Corpus Mysticum*; Paul (apostle); Stoics
 body politic 15, 20, 21, 24, 26, 33, 44, 53, 60, 67, 83, 85, 89, 91, 94, 101, 246, 255; *see also* social-as-body metaphor
 Braunstein, Ruth 169, 174, 176, 177, 180, 181, 184, 185, 187; *see also* Tea Party movement
 Brown, Wendy 55, 56, 57, 58, 59, 60, 61, 62, 63, 64, 68, 69, 71, 78; *see also* democracy: neoliberal/managed; governmentality; *homo oeconomicus*
 Butler, Judith 38, 40, 43, 45, 70, 71, 193
- Canovan, Margaret 70, 79, 117, 123, 135, 136, 137, 139, 140–141, 142, 146, 256; *see also* democracy: pragmatic dimension of; democracy: redemptive dimension of
 Carmichael, Stokely 225; *see also* civil rights movement
 Christian nationalism 8, 9, 166–212, 213, 214, 215, 218, 227, 228, 229, 238, 239, 245, 246, 257; appeals to nature within 169, 170, 185, 187, 190, 192, 193, 194, 195; and democracy 166, 167, 169, 179, 195, 200, 201, 202; as dysphoric reaction 166, 167, 169, 175, 179, 180, 183, 186, 191, 191, 194, 195, 198, 201, 202; fantastical nature of 192, 193, 195, 200,

- 202; identity of “real” Americans within 166, 167, 168, 169, 170, 172–174, 175, 178, 179, 182, 183, 184, 185, 186, 187, 188, 192, 195, 200, 201, 202, 203; injustice and entitlement within 195–196; narrative dimension of 167, 168, 169, 170, 180, 189, 195, 196, 198; and natural attitude of embodiment 170; nature of Christian identity within 167, 171, 172–173, 174, 175, 176, 180–182, 183, 184, 185, 188, 192, 199, 203; patriarchal structure of 188–195; racial hierarchy within 183–188; and the social body 167, 168, 169, 174–179, 182–183, 186, 187, 188, 191, 195–196, 198, 200, 201, 202; and social-as-body metaphor 167, 170, 175, 180, 182, 192; Trump administration and 197–201; and understandings of family 188, 191, 204; *see also* civic nationalism; nationalism; populism citizenship 8, 143, 157, 162, 163, 166, 169, 171, 172, 174, 178, 188, 203, 215, 217, 218, 219, 220, 221, 222, 224, 225, 226, 232, 233, 236, 237, 242, 245, 249
- civic nationalism 9, 153, 171, 202, 213–254, 257; and the African American civil rights movement 218–227; and democracy 228–231, 239–245; as dysphoric reaction 213, 214, 221, 223, 228, 238, 239, 240, 244, 246; fantastical nature of 213, 214, 215, 227–228, 229, 231, 233, 235, 237, 238, 239, 240, 246; and identification with the state 215; and identity politics 215–218, 231–245; and the social body 214, 215, 216, 217, 218, 220, 221, 222, 223, 224, 225, 227, 230, 231, 232, 237, 238, 239, 240, 244, 245, 246, 247, 248; and the social-as-body metaphor 214, 246; *see also* American Creed; Christian nationalism; identity politics; identity/identification; Lilla, Mark; nationalism; populism
- Civil Rights Act (1965) 204, 257
- civil rights movement 178, 216, 218, 220, 221, 222, 225, 230; *see also* Black Nationalism; Carmichael, Stokely; civic nationalism; Jim Crow; King, Martin Luther, Jr.; Malcolm X; Parks, Rosa; Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee; Theoharis, Jeanne
- colonialism 127, 152, 226; *see also* settler colonialism
- Connolly, William 31, 61, 127, 137; *see also* visceral register
- contingent universality 114, 115, 227, 248
- Cooper, Christian 2
- corporatism 20, 24, 26, 246; *see also* *corpus mysticum*; social-as-body metaphor
- corpus mysticum* 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 32; and as corporation 21; *corpus Christi* 19; as political metaphor 21; secularization of 20; social extension of 22; *see also* corporatism; mystical; *mysterium*; *sacramentum*; social-as-body metaphor
- Council for Biblical Manhood and Womanhood 191–192
- Covid-19 1, 2, 78
- Critchley, Simon 73, 74, 242,
- Dahl, Adam 128, 128, 170
- Dahl, Robert 55, 69; *see also* democracy: substantive versus procedural/institutional theories of
- De Lubac, Henri 18, 19, 20, 21,
- De La Torre, Miguel A. 62–63, 167–168
- democracy: audience 144, 145, 146, 200; and empty place of power 54, 55; fugitive 257; and inverted totalitarianism 56, 57, 58, 64, 124, ; liberal 7, 56, 67, 139; and majority rule 55, 64, 73, 139, 141; neoliberal/managed 7, 55–59, 60, 61, 63, 64, 65, 66, 67, 68, 70, 74, 75, 76, 77, 79, 121, 124, 138, 140, 141, 142, 146, 147, 147, 231, 255, 256, 257; and political fantasy 67; pragmatic dimension of 70, 79, 117, 121, 123, 140, 141, 142, 147, 256, 257; queer 6, 7, 8, 9, 15, 43, 55, 67–77, 78, 79, 80, 84, 100, 116, 117, 120, 127, 134, 139, 140, 141, 142, 146, 147, 149, 150, 162, 169, 179, 202, 228, 231, 239, 240, 244, 246, 256, 257, 258; redemptive dimension of 70, 79, 140–141, 147, 256; representative 141, 142, 143, 149, 202; shareholder 63; as society without a body 54, 78; substantive versus procedural/institutional theories of 55, 58, 68, 69; to come 69, 70, 125; and totalitarianism 55, 78, 100, 103, 105, 107; as unnatural 74; *see also* *demos*; Canovan, Margaret; Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; Derrida, Jacques; Laclau, Ernesto; Mouffé, Chantal; nationalism; populism; queerly democratic practice; Rancière, Jacques;

- representation; social contract tradition; Wolin, Sheldon; inverted totalitarianism; totalitarianism
- democratic revolution 53, 54, 234
- demos* (people) 7, 43, 77, 78, 179, 229:
 changing identity of 116; coextensive with social 71; constitutively
 incompleteness of 7, 55, 71, 72, 73, 75, 79, 101, 116, 117, 119, 124, 149, 150, 202, 222, 245, 256; as distinct from the populist people 79, 139–140, 162; emergent 76, 117, 118, 119, 123, 258; and empty place of power 150; essentialist conception of 71–72, 79, 221, 239; expansion of 9, 75, 76, 79, 84, 117, 123, 148, 149, 150, 169, 195, 238, 239, 244, 256, 257; free participation within 118, 119; as heterogeneous principle 74; management of 56, 67, 68, 77, 124, 141; morphologically fluid 8, 72, 73, 77, 119; no place for 73, 74, 256; as nonsensical 76; and political recognition 71–72, 116; as process/achievement/event 70, 72, 75; queer 73, 74, 75–76, 77, 117, 124, 127, 139, 140, 148, 148, 150; rule of 54, 69, 70, 71, 73, 80, 116, 124, 149, 150; as sovereign 57, 117, 118, 125, 150; transmogrification of 71, 73, 125, 169; unmaking of 72, 73, 77, 118, 149, 240, 244; will of 117, 124; *see also* democracy; representation
- Derrida, Jacques 45, 69, 70, 73, 75, 78, 96, 125; *see also* apophaticism; democracy: to come
- desire 36, 38, 39, 43, 61, 86, 110, 118, 145, 190, 191, 192, 196, 228, 244; directed by bodies 33; and fantasy 36, 37, 67, 134, 150, 161, 193, 202, 213; for impossible object 15, 37, 46, 67, 126, 150, 161, 202, 213, 231; for morphologically normative body 15, 42, 77, 78, 150, 161, 167, 180, 181, 195, 214, 215, 227, 238, 246; for order 9, 77, 125, 159, 184, 192, 195; 255, 256; queer 119; religious 181, 182; and representation 143; and stereotypes 187; world-directing 19; *see also* fantasy
- Dillingham Commission 178
- Discrimination: and federal anti-discrimination law 199, 204, 257; and identity/identification 241, 245; immigration law and 178; and sexism 190; White perceptions of 196, 204
- dispositions 4, 5, 6, 7, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 42, 45, 54, 60, 61, 63, 65, 74, 77; alternative 5, 15, 43, 69, 74, 76, 77, 101, 116, 118, 149, 224, 256; within Christian nationalism 175, 180, 182, 185, 186, 188, 189, 190, 191, 195, 198, 199; within civic nationalism 214, 238, 246; within nationalism/populism 133, 134, 137, 149, 150, 157, 158, 159, 161; within the social contract tradition 84, 90, 91, 95, 100, 117, 118, 119, 120, 123, 124, 128, 127; to social order 4, 5, 8, 13, 14, 35, 42, 54, 67, 77, 78, 255, 257, 258; *see also* Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; democracy: neoliberal/managed; nationalism; populism; social contract tradition; social-as-body metaphor
- dysphoria: non-rational nature of 44; as social phenomenon 6, 39, 40, 41, 42, 256, 257; *see also* Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; democracy: managed/neoliberal; gender dysphoria; social contract tradition
- embodiment: morphologically normative 6, 7, 13, 14, 15, 34, 35, 40, 41, 42, 43, 45; natural attitude of 6, 33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 39, 41, 42, 45, 67, 68, 69, 74, 77, 94, 107, 120, 126, 149, 170, 192, 228; queer 6, 7, 15, 33, 35, 36, 41, 42, 43, 46, 68, 69, 77, 161, 256; social nature of 38; *see also* Bettcher, Talia Mae; Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; social body; social contract tradition; nationalism; populism; social-as-body metaphor; trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC) bodies
- Fabrizi, Valerio 25, 26, 28, 53, 54, 255
- family *see* Manhattan Declaration; Nashville Statement
- Floyd, George 1, 2, 5, 203
- Fogg, Heath Davis 46, 190
- Foucault, Michel 60
- French Revolution 25, 53, 78, 234,
- gender dysphoria 7, 15, 38–40, 47, 48, 195, *see also* gender dysphoria in children; gender identity disorder; gender identity disorder of childhood; homosexuality
- gender dysphoria in children 38, 39; *see also* gender dysphoria; gender identity

- disorder; gender identity disorder of childhood; homosexuality
 gender identity disorder 38, 39, 40, 46, 48;
see also gender dysphoria; gender dysphoria in children; gender identity disorder of childhood; homosexuality
 gender identity disorder of childhood 38, 39, 40, 48; *see also* gender dysphoria; gender dysphoria in children; gender identity disorder; gender identity disorder of childhood; homosexuality
 general will 101, 103, 104, 105, 106, 107, 108, 112, 113, 115, 116, 117, 118, 119, 120, 121, 122, 123, 125, 128
 governmentality 59–67; and democracy 60, 64, 65, 66, 67; as dysphoric response 62, 63, 65, 67; human capital within 61, 62, 63, 64; as neoliberal administrative form 60; and political rationality 59–60, 61, 65; political subjects within 60, 61, 62, 64, 65; responsabilization 62, 63; and social-as-body metaphor 59, 60, 61, 64, 65; state/corporate hybrid 64; and stratification 62, 64, 65, 67; structures normative social morphology 59, 61, 62, 63, 64, 65, 66, 67; and Whiteness 62, 63; *see also* Brown, Wendy; democracy: neoliberal/managed; *homo oeconomicus*; subjectivity/subjectivation; Wolin, Sheldon
- Habermas, Jürgen 78, 79, 129
habitus 28, 29, 30, 31, 37, 44, 46, 122, 124, 234
 Halberstam, Judith 35, 46
 Hart-Cellar Act (1965) 178
 Hayek, Friedrich 56
 Heidegger, Martin 30, 122
 hierarchy 8, 13, 16, 17, 22, 23, 24, 32, 42, 43, 46, 54, 60, 64, 68, 69, 77, 134, 149, 150, 154, 156, 161, 167, 169, 170, 175, 178, 179, 182, 183, 185, 186, 187, 189, 195, 196, 201, 202, 238, 239, 255
 Hobbes, Thomas 7, 8, 9, 25, 26, 53, 83, 84–90, 91, 92, 94, 95, 96, 97, 98, 100, 101, 102, 103, 104, 105, 107, 109, 120, 125, 126, 127, 128, 162, 252; dissent and the social body 89–90; dysphoria in 90; and social-as-body metaphor 84–86; racialized theory of 128; sovereignty and unity of social body 87–89; state of nature and origin of social body 86–87; *see also* social contract tradition
- homo oeconomicus* 56, 57, 61, 64, 56, 57, 61
 homophobia 34, 40, 190, 219
 homosexuality 39, 40, 192, 204; *see also* gender dysphoria; gender dysphoria in children; gender identity disorder; gender identity disorder of childhood
 Honig, Bonnie 71, 73, 80, 127, 129
- identity/identification 135–137, 147, 213, 231–239, 248; nominal/virtual distinction 157; *see also* identity politics
 identity politics 9, 214, 215, 216, 217, 218, 220, 222, 228, 229, 231, 232, 234, 236, 239, 240, 242, 243, 244, 248; as queer democracy 239–245; *see also* identity/identification
 Inston, Kevin 103, 108, 109, 110, 111, 112, 113, 114, 115, 116, 117, 118, 119, 125
 inverted totalitarianism 56, 57, 58, 59, 64, 124; *see also* democracy: neoliberal/managed; totalitarianism
 Islamophobia 198, 199
- Jenkins, Richard 44, 136, 137, 147, 157, 233, 234, 235, 236, 237, 240, 241, 243, 248, 248
 Jim Crow 220, 225; *see also* civil rights movement
 Johnson, Mark 26, 27, 28, 31, 33, 77; *see also* metaphor
 Johnson-Reed Act (1924) 178
 Jones, Robert P. 167, 169, 193, 197, 198, 204
 Junn, Jane 155, 156, 173, 178, 184, 185, 186, 188
- Kaltwasser, Cristóbal Rovira 103, 135, 139, 140, 147; *see also* populism
 Kant, Immanuel 113, 129
 Kantorowicz, Ernst H. 18, 19, 20, 21
 Kavanaugh, Brett 199
 Kendi, Ibram X. 170, 223, 225
A Kid Like Jake 41
 King, Martin Luther, Jr. 222, 247; *see also* civil rights movement
 Krämer, Benjamin 137, 138, 139, 144, 147, 149, 150, 151, 175
- Laclau, Ernesto 45, 80, 113, 114, 115, 128, 143, 145, 234, 242, 243, 248
 Lakoff, George 26, 27, 28, 31, 33, 77; *see also* metaphor

- Lawler, Steph 136, 233, 234, 235, 240, 241, 243, 244
- Lefort, Claude 53, 54, 55, 56, 59, 68, 69, 78, 78, 78, 140, 145, 149, 150, 162, 234; *see also* democracy: and empty place of power; democratic revolution; totalitarianism
- LGBTQ+ community 69, 76, 174, 179, 193, 195, 199, 204, 238, 245, 246, 257; *see also* Supreme Court: *Bostock v. Clayton*; trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC) bodies
- Lilla, Mark 9, 78, 213–246; *see also* civic nationalism
- Locke, John: 7, 8, 9, 53, 83, 84, 90–100, 101, 102, 103, 104, 105, 107, 108, 109, 110, 120, 125, 126, 127, 128, 129, 162, 255: consent and legislative authority 91–94; dispositions determined by social body 100; dysphoria in 100; and political fantasy 91, 94, 97; natural law in 97–100; political theory's queer impulses 100; and race 128; social body, majority rule, and constitution of the *demos* 94–97; *see also* social contract tradition
- Luther, Martin 24, 25
- majoritarianism 8, 133, 141, 142, 143, 145, 148, 161, 162, 179, 200, 201, 246, 256
- Malcolm X 225; *see also* civil rights movement
- Manne, Kate 170, 188, 189, 190, 191, 193, 195, 196, 204; *see also* misogyny; patriarchy; sexism
- Manhattan Declaration 191, 192, 194, 196; *see also* Nashville Statement
- marriage 191, 192, 193
- Masuoka, Natalie 155, 156, 173, 178, 184, 185, 186, 188
- minorities 3, 142, 159, 168, 185, 196; gender 218; racial 69, 159, 174, 184, 185, 187, 195, 198, 238; religious 5, 69, 174, 198; *see also* Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; Islamophobia; LGBTQ+ community; racism; nationalism; populism; trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC) bodies; xenophobia
- media 2, 3, 4, 58, 66, 138, 139, 144, 146, 147, 200, 201
- metaphor 25–28, 31, 33, 54, 77, 85; *see also* social-as-body metaphor
- #MeToo 76, 245, 249
- Miller, Daniel 44, 46, 72, 78, 80, 114, 115, 125, 147, 180, 181, 203, 227, 248
- Mills, Charles W. 10, 76, 77, 84, 127, 128, 129, 170, 222; *see also* racial contract
- misogyny 170, 188, 189, 190, 191, 194, 196, 219, 231; as dysphoric response 191; fantastical nature of 191; *see also* sexism
- Montesquieu, Charles de Secondat, baron de 92
- Mouffe, Chantal 80, 113, 115, 234, 240, 242, 243, 248
- Mudde, Kas 103, 135, 139, 140, 147; *see also* populism
- Müller, Jan-Werner 103, 135, 137, 139, 145; *see also* anti-pluralism; populism
- Muslims: as racial category 184; *see also* Islamophobia
- Myrdal, Gunnar 171, 216, 217, 219, 239, 247; American Creed
- mysterium 19; *see also* corpus mysticum; mystical; sacramentum
- mystical 19, 20; *see also* corpus mysticum; mysterium; sacramentum
- Nashville Statement 191, 192, 193, 194; *see also* Manhattan Declaration
- nationalism 6, 8, 9, 10, 78, 133, 134, 151–161, 166, 167, 256; body morphology in 133, 134, 161; and democracy 161; as dysphoric reaction 134, 161; as ethnonationalism 154–155; multiple-tradition thesis of 171; and nationalist identification 157–160; as political fantasy 134; and social body 133, 134, 160–161, 255; and social-as-body metaphor 134; and *Volkskörper* 161; *see also* anti-pluralism; Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; nation; populism; populist people, the; power-devaluation crisis; state
- nation 151–153, 158, 159; as cultural community 152, 153; as distinct from state 153, 156, 157, 159, 172, 215; and “people” 154–157, 160, 161; and race 154–155, 157; and sense of shared origins 123, 133, 152, 154; and social-as-body metaphor 161; true or authentic 8, 134, 160; *see also* nationalism; state; territoriality
- Naturalization Act (1790) 178
- neoliberalism 56, 57, 58, 59, 60, 61, 65, 78, 168; *see also* democracy: neoliberal/managed

- Noble, Bobby 36, 67, 74; *see also* transing
- Painter, Nell Irvin 170, 184, 203, 218; *see also* Whiteness
- Parks, Rosa 247; *see also* civil rights movement
- patriarchy 8, 17, 167, 183, 196, 197, 198, 199, 202, 204, 238, 245; and Christian nationalism 188–195; *see also* misogyny; sexism
- Paul (apostle) 18, 19, 21; Body of Christ in 16–18; *see also* Body of Christ
- Pearle, Daniel 41; *see also* *A Kid Like Jake*
- Perry Samuel L. 171, 172, 173, 174, 175, 176, 177, 179, 181, 182, 183, 184, 186, 187, 188, 191, 193, 195, 196, 197, 198, 199, 203, 204; *see also* Christian nationalism
- Philpott, Daniel 23, 24, 25, 44, 83, 151, 153, 162
- pluralism 44, 70, 133, 138, 140, 141, 142, 143, 157, 161, 167, 178; *see also* anti-pluralism
- political fantasy 15, 26, 36, 38, 42, 46, 126: as ideological 32; masks impossibility 37, 40; of morphologically normative body 7, 15, 33, 36, 37, 38, 40, 41, 42, 43, 67, 70, 77; and political recognition 73; shapes and directs desire 36, 37, 42, 67; and totalitarianism 55; traversal of 40, 41, 42, 43, 73, 74; *see also* Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; nationalism; populism; social contract tradition; Žižek, Slavoj
- political personalization 144, 145, 146, 161, 200, 201; *see also* political verticalization
- political verticalization 142, 144, 145, 160, 200, 201; *see also* political personalization
- populism 6, 8, 78, 133, 134–150, 161, 166, 167, 256; as anti-liberal 139, 141; body morphology in 133, 134, 149–150; conditions for emergence of 146–148; and democracy 133, 134, 138, 139, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 147, 148, 149, 150; as dysphoric reaction 134, 149, 150; narrative dimension of 133, 147; as political fantasy 134, 135, 145, 149–150; political leader within 135, 136, 139, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 147, 148; and populist governance 140–146; and social body 133, 134, 135, 148, 149, 150, 160–161, 255; and social-as-body metaphor 134; and *Volkskörper* 150; *see also* anti-elitism; anti-pluralism; Christian nationalism; civic nationalism; majoritarianism; nationalism; political personalization; populist people, the; power-devaluation crisis; nationalism; political verticalization; representation
- populist people, the 135–140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 147, 149, 150, 151, 154, 155, 158, 160, 161, 162, 166, 169, 200, 201, 240; racial dimension of 154, 157; *see also* populism; prototype/prototypicality
- power-devaluation crisis 148, 250, 159, 160, 161, 177, 178, 179, 196, 198; *see also* populism
- proper 4, 13, 14; *see also* property; propriety
- property 3, 14; John Locke and 91, 92, 93, 128; *see also* proper; propriety
- propriety 14, 63, 94; *see also* proper, property
- prototype/prototypicality 8, 136, 137, 138, 139, 144, 146, 155, 159, 160, 167, 169, 170, 173, 174, 175, 178, 179, 182, 184, 185, 186, 188, 201, 202, 203, 215, 238, 245; *see also* Christian nationalism; nationalism; populist people, the
- queerly democratic practice 71, 72, 73, 74, 75, 76, 77, 79, 84, 91, 95, 101, 104, 114, 117, 118, 119, 123, 124, 134, 141, 147, 148, 149, 166, 202, 213, 214, 215, 221, 223, 238, 239, 240, 244; *see also* democracy; queer
- race 5, 9, 32, 65, 66, 152, 154, 155, 156, 157, 183, 185, 186, 198, 215, 216, 222, 226, 245, 247; biological conception of 154, 155; and cultural identity 155; and nation 154–155; and stereotypes 155–156; *see also* racism; stereotypes
- racial contract 77, 84, 127
- racism 3, 4, 219; cultural 155, 156; framed as “southern” problem 220; “new” 156; “strong” 154; *see also* race; stereotypes
- Rancière, Jacques 66, 72, 74, 75, 79
- Rawls, John 129
- recognition 71, 72, 73, 74, 78–79, 118, 136, 137, 146, 154, 157, 192, 201, 215, 241; *see also* identity/identification
- representation 26, 53, 54, 66, 78, 88, 89, 92, 95, 96, 101, 102, 117, 124, 133, 136, 137, 143, 144, 145, 146, 147, 150, 162, 200, 235, 255; crisis of 147, 148;

- logical structure of 143–144, 145–146;
metaphorical 27, 28; paradox of 97, 101,
127; of sex and gender 34; *see also* social
contract tradition; nationalism; populism;
populist people, the
- Rousseau, Jean-Jacques 7, 9, 25, 53, 80, 83,
84, 100–125, 126, 127, 128, 129, 162,
255: appeals to queer social body 101;
dysphoria in 120, 124, 125; critique of
natural law 107–112; denaturalizing will
112–120; and political fantasy 102, 120;
and populism 103, 119; queerly
sovereign *demos* in 120–125; racializing
tendencies in 128; and totalitarian
democracy 101–107; *see also amour de soi*;
amour propre; general will; social contract
tradition
- rule (Gr. *kratos*): *see demos*: rule of
- sacramentum 19; *see also corpus mysticum*;
mystical; *sacramentum*
- Salamon, Gayle 33, 34, 36, 38, 193
- Schlesinger, Arthur 247
- Scofield, Cyrus I. 216
- sexism 189, 190, 191, 194; and appeals to
biology 195; fantastical nature of 192,
194; *see also* misogyny; patriarchy
- social body: normative morphology of 5, 6,
7, 13, 14, 15, 18, 21, 22, 25, 26, 28, 32,
33, 37, 42, 43, 54, 56, 59, 61, 62, 63,
64, 65, 66, 67, 68, 72, 77, 78, 255, 256;
queer 7, 15, 42, 43, 54, 55, 67, 69, 70,
71, 73, 74, 76, 77, 78, 84, 91, 94, 100,
101, 107, 117, 118, 120, 125, 126, 127,
134, 149, 150, 161, 166, 169, 179, 180,
191, 192, 193, 195, 198, 201, 202, 213,
214, 221, 222, 225, 227, 238, 239, 244,
245, 246, 256, 257, 258; unmaking of 7,
15, 55, 72, 74, 75, 76, 77, 114, 116,
118, 119, 124, 148, 161, 169, 179, 186,
191, 193, 196, 215, 218, 221, 223, 230,
231, 238, 239, 244, 246, 256; *see also*
embodiment; Christian nationalism; civic
nationalism; nationalism; populism;
social contract tradition; social-as-body
metaphor
- social contract tradition 7, 83–132, 252;
body morphology in 84, 85, 86, 90, 91,
94, 95, 97, 100, 101, 102, 104, 107,
116, 118, 120, 124, 125, 126, 127; as
dysphoric response 127; and political
fantasy 126, 127; racial dimensions of
127; *see also* Hobbes, Thomas; Locke,
John; natural law; Rousseau,
Jean-Jacques; Rawls, John
- social-as-body metaphor 5, 6, 7, 8, 13, 14,
33, 35, 36, 42, 44, 53, 54, 56, 59, 60,
61, 64, 65, 67, 68, 72, 74, 77, 255, 256:
in Christian nationalism 167, 170, 175,
180, 182, 192; in civic nationalism 214,
227, 246; dispositional nature of 14,
25–33, 37, 42, 43, 54, 56, 59, 60, 64,
65, 67, 68, 72, 84, 91, 100, 134, 175,
214, 217, 246, 255; historical
development of 15–25; in nationalism/
populism 134; and political fantasy 32,
37, 42, 43, 256; reimagining/queering of
5, 6, 7, 38, 43, 69, 77; in the social
contract tradition 83, 84, 85, 90, 91, 94,
95, 100, 101, 125, 126; *see also* Paul
(apostle); Body of Christ; *corpus mysticum*;
social body; Stoics
- settler colonialism 127, 128, 170, 231, 257;
as mechanism of US founding 170; *see
also* colonialism
- state 8, 55, 100, 127, 151–153, 242; and
democracy 66, 67, 69, 70, 73, 74, 75,
76, 80, 117, 123, 124, 256; and exercise
of sovereignty 23, 24, 25, 44, 83, 101,
102, 126, 152, 160; as distinct from
nation 156, 157, 159, 172, 215; and
modern state system 23, 24, 44, 129,
151, 162; as political community
151–152, 215; populist governance and
135, 141, 160, 161; and social-as-body
metaphor 16, 17, 18, 20, 21, 23–25, 53,
55, 83, 101, 124, 125, 161; and
statelessness 162; and unity with
commercial and economic interests 57,
58, 61, 64; *see also* nation; territoriality;
Treaty of Westphalia
- state of nature 86, 87, 90, 92, 93,
95, 98, 101, 106, 109, 110, 111,
114, 115, 128; *see also* social contract
tradition
- Steinbock, Anthony 29, 44
- stereotypes 136, 155, 156, 186, 187, 188,
189, 204; fantastical nature of 187; *see
also* race
- Stoics 6, 16, 17, 23, 255; *see also* Paul
(apostle); social-as-body metaphor
- Stryker, Susan 35, 36, 74, 120, 126,
150, 193
- Student Nonviolent Coordinating
Committee 225; *see also* civil rights
movement

- subjectivity/subjectivation 37, 46, 60, 61, 62, 64, 65, 71, 72, 73, 108, 114, 115, 123, 128, 138, 234, 237
 Sullivan, Nikki 15, 35, 36, 43, 54, 62, 74, 120, 169, 227; *see also* (un)becoming
 Supreme Court 199, 230; *Bostock v. Clayton* 204, 257; *Obergefell v. Hodges* 193; *see also* Kavanaugh, Brett
 Taylor, Breonna 2
 Taylor, Malaena 169, 174, 176, 177, 180, 181, 184, 185, 187; *see also* Tea Party movement
 Tea Party movement 176, 180, 184, 198, 204
 territoriality 23, 151, 152; *see also* nation, state
 Theiss-Morse, Elizabeth 136, 137, 155, 158, 159, 162, 173; *see also* prototype/prototypicality
 Theoharis, Jeanne 218, 220, 222, 225, 247; *see also* civil rights movement
 Thirty Years' War 23, 162
 totalitarianism 55, 56, 59, 78, 150; *see also* democracy; inverted totalitarianism
 trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC)
 bodies 35, 36, 41, 42, 43, 45, 46, 47, 48, 68, 74, 188, 190, 191, 192, 193, 194, 195, 196, 199, 244, 245; as challenge to normative body morphology 33; as out of place 35; as revelatory 35, 36; as transgressive 34, 35; as untrue 35; *see also* *A Kid Like Jake*;
 bathroom bills; dysphoria; embodiment: queer; gender dysphoria; LGBTQ+ community; Manhattan Declaration; minorities: gender; Nashville Statement; Supreme Court: *Bostock v. Clayton*;
 transphobia
 transphobia 34, 46, 190, 249; *see also* trans and gender nonconforming (TGNC) bodies
tranquilitas 23, 26, 42, 43, 64, 255; *see also* social-as-body metaphor
 transing 36, 67
 Treaty of Westphalia 24, 44, 152, 162; *see also* state; territoriality
 Trump administration 9, 10, 197–201, 202, 204, 248
 (un)becoming 15, 35, 43, 54, 62, 65, 67, 69, 71, 73, 75, 76, 77, 120, 125, 127, 169, 227, 237, 240
 Urbinati, Nadia 79, 135, 137, 138, 139, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 147, 148, 149, 150, 160, 200, 201, 202; *see also* majoritarianism; political personalization; political verticalization
 visceral register 31, 60, 137
 Weheliye, Alexander 76, 84, 137, 138, 139, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 148, 149, 150, 160, 200, 201, 202,
 Whitehead, Andrew L. 171, 172, 173, 174, 175, 176, 177, 179, 181, 182, 183, 184, 186, 187, 188, 191, 193, 195, 196, 197, 198, 199, 203, 204; *see also* Christian nationalism
 Whiteness 9, 10, 62, 63, 167, 173, 183, 184, 185, 188; emergence as racial category 127–128, 170
 Wolin, Sheldon 56, 57, 58, 59, 60, 63, 64, 66, 68, 73, 78, 230, 242, 257 *see also* democracy: fugitive; democracy: neoliberal/managed; inverted totalitarianism
 Wolterstorff, Nicholas 181
 xenophobia 159, 187, 188, 198, 199, 219; *see also* Christian nationalism; minorities; nationalism; populism; populist people, the
 Žižek, Slavoj 46; *see* political fantasy
 Zucker, Kenneth 47; *see also* *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual* (DSM)